

By Just for Tonight

Look for **EDIT LINE** to find our place

core group N A

Review current essays on December 11, page 363

Don't worry about the times you can't make the Thursday night workshop, just feel good about the times you can. Remember our free for all polity: we can all get to this work in progress and knock off a daily meditation of two when we have the time. Anonymity and open access frees us. Whatever we write will be taken into consideration when we have a face-to-face get together to take the writing of Just for Tonight to the next level.!

“They say a picture is worth a thousand words. But what if it reflects not reality but an agenda? In this age of airbrushed magazine covers, computer-generated image words lost meaning? Or have they become more important than ever?”

“Dear God, Please protect and provide for me. Guide and illuminate the path of my pilgrimage. Grant me courage, commitment and strength. Teach me to care and give without reservation. Remind me of gratitude and principle. Please allow me to recognize your presence in me and around me and allow my life to be a reflection of your love.” From Greg Pierce

*“Nothing blinds a person like fanaticism
which is just an outward expression of obsession.”*

“That we can all come together for the good of the Fellowship.”

Bo - We are discussing going to PUBLIC DOMAIN with this piece only. Probably the least expensive way to protect the integrity of the material. May open a new door for anonymous writings. Items discussed:

1. copyright is meaningless unless those involved are willing to defend in court at their expense . . . how much money do you have in the bank?
2. Public domain means the “public’ owns the material. Can’t be undone. Non-reversible.
3. Without study, learning and painful experience, we remain ‘uninformed’ and our opinion is worthless except perhaps emotional attachment.
4. Our objective is to focus on the spiritual rather than the financial. We only keep what we have by giving it away. Each word choice is important!
5. Look up spirituality vs legalism.

QUOTES FROM GREY BOOK WITH INPUT FOR ESSAYS

“God, as we endeavor to complete this work, we know that You are with us. We know that without Your strength and inspiration we are not capable of the task before us. We know that this work is not our work, but Yours. Each of us, in our own way, humbly petition You to use us as Your tools; according to Your will. We offer ourselves to You in this way knowing that You are a Loving God and have all power. In this work and in our lives--Thy will be done.”

Thoughts that may help -

Daily Meditations can help us reconsider some of our values and goals. Old habit patterns may no longer give us the joy and energy of accomplishment. Locating and chasing down information on opportunities that may be just under the skin of our daily routines may suddenly take shape and form new paths we are free to take without damage to the rest of our lives. Go for it.

Winter is the time of the year when weather sometimes drives us indoors and gives us time to think things through. Many people review their lives and make resolutions to do better in the coming year.

Spring is full of new things coming up, along with the flowers! Might be a good time to make a list of things that have been put off.

Summer means vacations and extra time in the yard for many people. Shaking off dull routines without ignoring our commitments can do a lot to raise our energy and move towards being the person we see in our dreams.

Fall is the time when it is good to take inventory and be grateful for the positive changes that have come to us whether by hard work or serendipity.

Narcotics Anonymous has special days. Our Book began in earnest at Memphis, Tennessee February 15, 1981. The writing was completed and the White Approval Form was dated sometime in November of that year. Someone find us the date. Other significant days relating to our history and achievements as a Fellowship should be honored. Nothing should take away from the importance of "This Day" keeping first things first.

Idea From YellowEyes

Titled: Just For Tonight
More Will Be Revealed

We can point this book towards an evening Meditation reading. Reading this book before bed rather than waking up to it.

Just for Tonight

Based on the Grey Form written at Memphis

Preface
where this book came from

Forward “The full fruit of a labor of love lives in the harvest,
and that always comes in its right season...”

A labor of love, just think, a labor of love. Our Grey Book and our Basic Text were written as labors of love. This meditation book is written as a labor of love. Love by members of this Fellowship for this lifesaving program that has given us new lives, lives we are proud of. The full fruit describes how we grow and change as we work the Steps and start living the Program. Doing this work is labor, hard labor, but it becomes labor we love. We were barely little buds of hope when we came into the rooms, we were nurtured and fed by the love of our predecessors. We were pruned and encouraged by the love of our sponsors and grew abundantly by the light of our Higher Power as we came to understand Him. We bloom and become ripe fruit in our proper seasons as our lives are shaped by spiritual principles and our relationship with our Higher Power grows. Then we start new little buds of hope in the hearts of newcomers just as our buds were encouraged when we arrived. The ongoing process of birth, growth and maturation continues and will continue as long as we hold true to our Program, our Steps and our Traditions. Our right season is ever now as we strive to live by spiritual principles in the here and now. We are proud to be members of Narcotics Anonymous.

Introduction

How to use this book

To locate quotations, we show the page number followed by the line number.

The Memphis Review Form was produced by members in service at the Memphis Literature Conference held at Memphis State College in February, 1981.

The entire Basic Text, Narcotics Anonymous, was written that year based on input from the general membership to the review form. Three conferences accomplished this writing:

WLC 4 - Santa Monica, California

WLC 5 - Niles, Ohio and

WLC 6 - Miami, Florida.

The Memphis Review Form had a grey cover and has since picked up the nickname "The Grey Book."

The Stories came from WLC-7 held in Bucks County just north of Philadelphia, Pennsylvania in February, 1982.

January 1

Who is an Addict. “We use to live and live to use. Very simply an addict is a man or woman whose life is controlled by drugs.”

Memphis Review Form - page 1, first paragraph

We become responsible members of society with integrity, freedom, joy and serenity as we work our 12 Steps. The Steps give us the creative freedom to become the very best people we want to be: respected, responsible, productive members of society. **People we** are proud to be recovering addicts living clean and free.

We are all the same, victims of the disease of addiction. We all want the same thing, an end to pain and recovery from our disease. Although our stories may be different, the feelings and difficulties brought about by this disease are the same: worthlessness, abject misery, regret, hopelessness, remorse, resentment, fear, anger, grief, shame and self-pity. We have all done things we would take back if we could. Some things we may never want to admit. By the same token, if we have a deep enough desire and we are willing to make the effort, we can be given hope. We can use the principles of honesty, willingness and open-mindedness. We develop our own acceptance, courage, strength and perseverance. By working Step Three, we are blessed with power and wisdom by the God of our understanding.

Just saying no is not an option for addicts who are hooked. The drugs control our actions. Until we have the NA program, the disease is driving the bus. We just hang on for dear life while we watch ourselves going down. Surrender is the way out. Through surrender, we starve our addiction. We may feel like using but just bide our time as the desire to use is replaced by the desire for recovery.

[bs/jf]

January 2

“We regretted the past; we feared the future.”

Memphis Review Form - page 2, 15

This is the way we lived in our addiction. We fretted over the past or projected possible futures. We were never focused in the present instead we were using to escape our feelings. Perhaps we mistakenly thought our using made our present bearable. In reality, we were obliterating our present, then we could regret it in the future! We were slaves to our addiction. Very few of us were able to live in the present - except perhaps when calamity or disaster overcame us. Then, of course, we had to use again. Through working the Steps, we begin to live in the present. The present is the only time we can change the future.

Active addiction made us slaves. Developing a deep sense of self-honesty is essential to our recovery. Giving ourselves progressively to the program of Narcotics Anonymous by working the Steps, we begin to live by spiritual principles. As we progress through the Steps we clean up our past and acquire the skills necessary to live in the present. We begin doing the right thing for the right reason. This brings us the great freedom of being able to focus our attention on the present, right here, right now. When we can live in the present, we become aware of the great joy and beauty surrounding us. We see how much we have missed in the past. Our lives are much richer now. We are grateful to live in the present.

January 3

“Drugs could no longer hide the pain. We just wanted an easy way out. Suicide was on many of our minds.”

Memphis Review Form - page 2, 22

We used to mask our pain from our consciousness. With or without drugs, we lost the ability to remember what was making us feel so badly. It was all we could do just to get through the day! People yelling at us or putting pressure on us kept us even more distracted. Is it any wonder we became isolated? Eventually we became so dysfunctional even other addicts couldn't stand our company.

We seek personality change for the better through the N A 12 Steps. Spiritual growth replaces the broken parts of our personality with things that work for us. A day at a time recovery gives us a brand new life without all the self-inflicted wounds and unnecessary habits. While recovery takes place on a day by day basis, the changes are at a level so fundamental that they touch every part of our lives.

Frequently we had to force ourselves to endure feeling good. Many of us were afraid to get our hopes up. Helping others put us in situations where we forget ourselves while seeing very clearly where someone else is going wrong. Then we apply the lessons we learn to our own lives.

January 4

"We can die from untreated addiction. But before we die, the disease takes from us our pride, our self-esteem, our families and loved ones. And finally, it takes our very will to live."

Memphis Review Form - page 14, 19

The pain and confusion of active addiction makes it hard to realize we are slipping into a hole until it is too late. Actually, there is no such thing as 'too late.' Most of us arrive to a N A meeting feeling hopeless and expecting things to get worse. The lessening of despair and the early glimmers of hope come as a surprise! Listening to other members share, we slowly realize we are not alone. Eventually we hear someone share an experience that seems to apply to what we are going through. We try out what worked for them and find it working for us.

In our recovery program, we do not dwell on the horrors of active addiction but rather share and emphasize the processes of recovery. We surrender, and this allows us to end the struggle to deny our addiction but we may persist in our efforts to control our lives. When we discover our unmanageability, we can work the second half of the First Step. We find just by not using, going to meetings and reading N A literature we become focused on a new way to live. Hope is given to us and therefore grows in us.

We hear others share their pain. At other times, they share the joy of being liberated from active addiction. One day we look up and realize the `12 Steps are working for us. Our identification with the members in the rooms of NA allows us to rejoin the human race. Recovery becomes an adventure!

January 5

“After attending a few meetings, we began to feel like we were finally getting somewhere. It was in these meetings that we were first introduced to the Twelve Steps of NA.”

Memphis Review Form - page 30, 11

Surrender seems like the last thing that would help us dispel the negative feelings and emptiness we feel inside. But if we are powerless, we get instant relief when we stop fighting. Life is not our adversary; addiction is our problem. We find ways to substitute real life and solutions instead of using drugs and their parallel behaviours. We deal with things as they come up.

Sometimes, when we are listening to someone share about what happened when they stopped fighting and began looking for new answers, we have a flash of insight. We identify with the speaker. An idea catches hold and suddenly we change our minds. Through the miracle of identification, we no longer see change as a threat. It is a jump ahead! We become winners when we can accept life as it is. At last we can learn ways that were blocked by our ego and self-will.

In the Second Step, we go looking for a belief we can trust. We enjoy great freedom in N A because we are free to find our own path, the life of the spirit. We read, discuss and study whatever written materials we can find and if we are dissatisfied we can move on to another belief until we are satisfied and feel ourselves being restored to sanity. This is usually called a peaceful, easy feeling.

The Third Step completes our entry into a new way of life. We find it natural to turn our will and our lives over to the God of our understanding. Many just call their God “Higher Power.” It is the word ‘care’ that is important in this Step. Only a loving H P can restore us to sanity by helping us through the next six Steps!

January 6

“Go off by yourself and say silently, ‘God, I’ve made a mess of my life. I can’t solve my problems and I ask you to take care of me and show me how to live.’”

Memphis Review Form - page 38, 27

This simple prayer has changed countless lives for the better. These few words show self-awareness, surrender, acceptance, humility, willingness to change, honesty, hope, trust, faith, simplicity, dedication and devotion. When said with sincerity from the heart, we are no longer spiritually bankrupt.

As we grow in recovery, we acquire the personal resources that paint a beautiful picture of spiritual growth and insight. This is true for all addicts who follow our way of life. Rich or poor, educated or not, skilled or rough labor - all take on a spiritual quality. No matter what our social standing, we all seem to shine when filled with the spiritual light! Our growing interest in the well being of others has many positive side effects.

Helping others helps us overcome our selfishness. We see people struggling and want to help. Our sincere desire to help suggests solutions which might not have occurred to us on our own. This insight shows the way we might change ourselves! These solutions may ‘fly in under the radar’ because our ego is out of the way.

January 7

"We became capable of depravity--of betrayal to ourselves and to others. Temporarily clean, we ran around trying to get it all squared away before our next spree."

Memphis Review Form - page 2, 4

Waking up can be a painful process when we recall what we did last night or in the recent past. Befuddled and cloudy from mood and mind altering drugs, we suspended good sense and found misbehavior funny. Angry or resentful, we felt liberated when released from unwanted pressure from authority figures whom we did not respect. Sometimes our friends egged us on. Our whole way of thinking became "us" and "them."

Depravity involves immoral and unacceptable behavior that can create shame and guilt. We know we will feel badly about what we are doing. We find it impossible to stop. Subjecting others to embarrassing treatment can be exciting or titillating. Bad behavior raises questions of correctness and propriety. Our misbehavior becomes worse as we continue.

With the clarity and the focus that comes with recovery, we can see what is happening is not right, and stop it before it goes any further. We can also see other ways to do things that are even more exciting and choose to do them instead, bypassing the wrongdoings. Loving and caring behavior replaces doing what will embarrass us later on. We want to hurry up and clean up the mess because we do not have much time to set things straight

January 8

“Our program is in fact a way of life. We learn the value of principles such as humility, surrender, and service. The idea that we have to do it alone is obsolete.”

Memphis Review Form - page 21, 8

As a way of life, we enjoy the company of others who are in the same process we are engaged in ourselves. We become so closely associated with fellow members, we really enjoy the type of closeness otherwise found only in families. This is a very natural way to obtain feedback that is simple and honest. Many times their answers turn out to be our answers.

Humility is simply honestly setting aside our egotistical ideas and being open to the experience and thoughts of others. Surrender gets us out of ourselves and frees us to shake off many of the chains that used to bind us. Service involves extending ourselves for others. We can practice projecting our feelings onto those in need and help them find solutions.

The energy and power we get from others bring alternatives into view. We find different ways of looking at things and develop approaches that never occurred to us before. What we do leads to other positive moves and doorways swing open for us.

For example, my first sponsor would say “Ask yourself, what can I do to improve my situation.” I had never thought of looking at things this way before.

Another member told me when we were in the midst of a car problem, “I don’t see these things as problems, I see them as experiences”. This really helped me to avoid the negative when situations went bad for me.”

Old ideas got us into trouble and crippled us to a low standard of behavior. You can’t get a new life with old ideas. As we grow in recovery, we find others sharing about the very problems that plague (plaguing) our lives! Their answers may become our answers. This successful pattern of growing takes hold of us and creates a momentum that feels good while getting good results. Getting to know other addicts seeking recovery gives us answers, identification and a joyous spirit long missing in our lives!
[jf/bs]

January 9

“When we admit our powerlessness and inability to manage our own lives, we open the door to a power greater than ourselves.”

Memphis Review Form - Page 30, 20

Belief is about our relationship with a power greater than ourselves. Our belief clarifies our lives because at last we find a pathway to something bigger, smarter and lovingly powerful that has the answers we need. The belief a higher power exists and can help us get results where we used to have this naked, lost feeling. It is a powerful bringer of hope. Praying for guidance, reading, listening to others share their experience and feelings gives us courage to approach our goals. Even our wildest goals can awaken dreams long lost to the insanity of active addiction.

Clinging to the notion we can manage our lives is a control game. By the time we reach the N A program, control is something we choose to leave behind. “If it isn’t practical, it isn’t spiritual.” reminds us to keep our feet on the ground and use spiritual principles to get what we want or need.

This higher power is an endless source of alternative viewpoints and ideas. The energy flows into us as soon as we are open to it. Conscious contact reveals an endless supply of suggestions and approaches that were out of reach before we started working the NA Twelve Steps! It is so powerful some members get carried away on a pink cloud. This is why we talk about working our Steps on a ‘daily basis.’ Yesterday is forever gone and tomorrow never quite gets here. Today is the only day we can make a difference, one tiny act of faith at a time.

[j/f/bs]

January 10

“Part of ourselves could see what was happening; another part would not accept it. We were caught in an illusion of ‘what if,’ ‘if only’ and ‘just one more try.’”

Memphis Review Form - page 2, 25

During our using, the part of us that could see what was happening got ignored or discounted so often, we stopped believing it. Our illusion of “what if,” “if only” and “just one more try” got us building walls of denial so thick, the truth could not be seen (experienced fully). The Steps and the Program gives us (offers) the tools to break down our walls of denial (DENIAL - Don’t Even Notice I Am Lying) with honesty, open-mindedness and willingness. Our insane illusions are replaced with sanity. Sanity is living in harmony with reality. We learn to be fully focused in the present, observing all the joy and beauty that we used to miss in our search for “just one more.”

Not thinking clearly, we sought easy answers that turned out to be substitutes for real action. We were bumping into walls without really getting anywhere. Even in recovery we can find ourselves coasting without thinking things through. It helps to review our goals and methods every once in awhile. The drug induced fog can become so familiar that we live there. Snapping out of habitual ways of doing things gives us a break from our insanity. Going easy on ourselves and developing a watchful attitude towards our inventory gives us time to prepare for the changes ahead.

[jf/bs]

January 11

“In the Third Step, we simply recognize that there is a force for good in the world and we cooperate with that force. We let good things happen to us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 38, 35

This incredibly beautiful and inclusive observation opens the doorway to a spiritual life. In N A, we need to get on a good footing with the God of our understanding. To get out of the ditch, we have to have more power and this involves finding a belief we can live with. G-O-D is good, orderly direction. Like many things in life, it doesn't matter where we are, it matters where we're going. One Step at a time, we find ourselves setting new goals. The road never ends and each break-through leads to another.

Putting what we learn into practice turns up new items to think about and leads us to even brighter horizons of discovery and application. Even dead-ends and apparent failures will often lead us to solutions we could find no other way. Life becomes full of learning experiences. Our goal is not to become perfect. Recovery is ongoing discovery. We just want happiness of the sort we can live with.

Spirituality involves states and experiences that go beyond what words can easily express. Persons going through spiritual growth have trouble sharing with someone just starting out. “When we feel far from God, God seems to be our greatest enemy. The closer we get to God, the more we realize God was our only true friend all along.” Meditation can seem a big waste of time until we realize we are noticing things that have slipped our minds. The original meaning of the Summerian word for prayer was ‘to work for.’

[jf/bs]

January 12

“All of us have this one thing in common -- we put the disease that kills us and, one way or another, we usually pay for it, a bag at a time, a few pills at a time, or a bottle at a time until we die.”

Memphis Review Form - page 34, 7

One of the benefits of recovery is choice. We can see better, hear better and process information better. This gives our choices the power to draw better conclusions and pick better ways to go forward in our lives. We find better ways to express ourselves and so present more accurately who we are and what we care about. This way we attract people into our lives and we grow in the process. Our living reflects our truth and our feelings.

Putting our energy into the things we really care about or blindly following the obsession of the moment without considering the cost is a choice we have today. Taking life a day at a time helps us reach escape velocity from our old habits and preferences we developed when we were out of our minds. Being in the present is an important tool for finding a new way of living.

Stopping now and then to make a written list of all we have to be grateful for is a good way to improve our mood and raise our energy for the day to come. Saying “thank you” and asking permission before forcing an issue or getting someone’s help smooths out our relations with everyone we encounter.

We may stop and wonder that this way of simply living according to our inner beliefs and genuine desires was not taught to us in early life. The dysfunctions we grew up in confused the better part of us and generates all the problems that come with active addiction. The NA 12 Steps guide us gently into a whole new way of living.

[bs]

January 13

"If we have come this far in the N.A. program, we have already noticed some change in our lives. However, the change may not be as fast nor as dramatic as we wish."

Memphis Review Form - page 39, line 6

One of the things about recovery we have to learn is we see the world through damaged equipment. Our associations are messed up; we jump to conclusions too quickly. We cobble together a few facts and in our hurry we have yet to establish a habit of calming our minds and bodies so as to achieve a clear state of attention. This is like the need for putting on goggles to see underwater. Without the goggles, we get blurs and debris instead of a clear vision. We move from desperation to inspiration.

Getting in a hurry, we miss things and leave things out. Slow down! Be careful! Build your life up on a firm foundation. You're not in danger like it used to be. Really, the clean life is based on achieving and practicing good mental habits. We learn to look at things as they really are. If what we are hearing is unclear, we ask questions and don't let ourselves go off half cocked. That's what our NA friends are for.

Astonishingly, almost everyone of us is surprised to find out that gratitude is an internal resource instead of an exterior force. We exercise gratitude and find we are often more able to become consciously grateful. This brings us back to consider our need to adjust to positive changes without getting in a hurry! If we want the changes to stick, we give them time to replace old habits and ways of doing things. Again and again, we surrender to our Higher Power.

[bs]

January 14

"We find that we will continue to have living problems."

Memphis Review Form - page 39, 13

In time we may see where these 'problems' are part of our learning curve and lead us to understandings we could get no other way. We may even reach the point where they are no longer problems but simply challenges we take in stride as we continue to practice living in the solution. Our attitude is to see problems in a different light. If we slow down and do things more carefully, many skills come to us naturally. If we re-read the directions of ask for help from those who have experience with what we are doing, it makes all the difference in the world!

Many times, what we see as problems are just doing things that were impossible or out of reach in active addiction. Many are not that hard, they are just new. Sometimes our members tell us they develop a habit of immediately looking for a solution rather than getting stymied. New things require us to stare at the 'problem' area until we notice things that might go together and make connections that lead to a solution.

Assuming we will fail before we even try may be based on our former failures. Calming down, taking a deep breath, making a prayer for our HP to help us, we may find ourselves getting curious and seeing differently. I knew a diesel mechanic who worked for years with a buddy and when one of them was having trouble, they would stop and ask one another for help. The 'asking' put them in a state of finding the solution. For one thing, they weren't alone. Later when his friend got a job in another state, even though he was working alone, when faced with a problem, he would ask himself what would Charlie do about this. Frequently, a solution jumped into his mind out of thin air!

In recovery, we learn that what used to block our way often turns out to be a doorway to a new understanding. When we move from fear-based living to faith-based living we are living in a new existence where every 'problem' is just a new doorway about to open.

[bs]

January 15

“We examine in depth our relationships with people, places and situations asking ourselves what we have demanded of these relationships. Often the answers will show that we are placing unreasonable demands on reality. WE find that we are demanding other people to stop being who they are.”

Memphis Review Form - page 42, 26

As our minds and bodies settle down in recovery, our perceptions become more clear. When we hear, see and think better, much of the world around us becomes clearer. We lose our anger and frustration, one piece at a time. Resolving our lives around our true feelings and accurate conclusions enable us to live with fewer contradictions, so we are not at odds with ourselves.

We find using past behavior as a guide may not contain a skill set that fits our new way of living life. Patience, tolerance and humility get better results because they have worked for many others. Patience gives us time to wait for another person to finish what they have already committed to doing. It is their competence makes them popular.

Tolerance cushions personal interaction where we have to give respect to get respect. People are often willing to match us if we are considerate. Humility diminishes the blockage set in place by our pride and ego. Even if we get someone to do what we want them to do, they will remember being poorly treated and seek to ‘get even’ with us!

What we demand of others, we need to be willing to give ourselves. Setting ourselves above those we claim to care for is not only bad manners, it angers people because it shows they are not being honest. You can’t treat someone badly if we care for them. Giving opens the doorway to receiving and as our demands lessen, our happiness increases.

(bs)

January 16

"It doesn't matter whether we just took a few pills, fixed eight times a day, suck on a pipe, drink bottles of cough remedy behind drug stores, or have one tranquilizer with our first martini each day..... we have certain things in common, no matter to what degree or what kind of addict we are."

Memphis Review Form - page 30, 23

The obsession and compulsion were two things we had in common. We were also all familiar with the feelings: guilt, remorse, fear, self-loathing, anger, desperation, self-pity, inadequacy. The twin attributes of obsession and compulsion just didn't work. It is like an animal stuck in a laboratory that keeps mashing a button without getting the food. Obsession is losing control of our minds. Compulsion is losing control of our actions. Between bouts of using, we begin to realize it just gets worse and there seems to be no way out. That's why NA is called "The Last House on the Block."

Pain is our common denominator. It can actually be a comfort to find there are others who hurt like we do. Just going to meetings with fellow addicts we slowly discover what works for them, works for us. When we find ourselves passing along what we have found to others, the spiritual Program of NA really wakes up for us. We realize there is a network of love, peace and understanding worldwide.

Many members believe when we act as a conduit of love and gratitude the energy that passes through us energizes us in passing. As recovering addicts, the good feelings we enjoy are part of what keeps us coming back. It seems like all people take a moment to reflect on how their lives are going. If you are clean and working the NA 12 Steps, the answer is generally the same: we are steadily getting better.

(bs)

January 17

"We quit fighting. We accept our addiction and life the way it is."

Memphis Review Form - page 33, 20

When we forget to work our recovery Steps, we find ourselves slipping back into our old habit patterns. After all, those habit patterns were formed over months or years of active addiction and dysfunctional thinking. When we quit fighting recovery, we can start our days on a whole new platform.

We can learn to start our days being grateful and surrendered. Praying for our HP to help us stay in touch with our surrender, faith and active gratitude, everything in our live's changes. It is funny how we find ways to get along with others when we are mindful of our release from our addictive prisons. Pain can make us real open-minded! Gratitude can make us more open to what others are saying or going through. When we pay attention, we get attention.

Our disease tells us we can never win and no one really understands or cares. We sink into the old grooves of our past behavior. We catch ourselves sinking and suddenly we reach up, practicing what we have learned in recovery. As we learn to live clean, we fail less and discover more. We begin to see the principles work together: honesty, open-mindedness and the willingness to try. If we are willing, we frequently don't have to!

Honesty puts us in touch with reality. It feels spooky. Being open, we are free to entertain notions without feeling trapped. We have a choice. The willingness to try often frees us from having to do something. All three of these may seem illogical at times because we realize they are rooted in a higher realm. They are uplifting us into a new life.

(bs)

January 18

“This Fourth Step can be a wonderful adventure, reviewing our past performance and our present behavior to see what we want to keep and what we want to be rid of.”

Memphis Review Form - page 43, 2

The ‘rubber hits the road’ when we work our Fourth Step. Steps Four through Nine make real the personality changes we have been seeking. The journey of a thousand miles begins with that one simple step forward. Steps Four, Six and Eight prepare us to move forward. Steps Five, Seven and Nine are when we actually make our move!

The cost of freedom is getting used to living without our chains. The old boundaries no longer apply in our new lives. As clear headed-ness and good karma work together, new rules apply. When we stop using drugs, we can go to a family picnic without getting beat up when we got angry when people didn’t agree with us. We find many family members really like us when we drop some of our old habits. Playing mind games to distract family members from our past behavior doesn’t really work, does it?

Instead of stewing in the past with negative expectations for the future, we can pick and choose what our life experiences will become. We find we can have almost any good thing if we are willing to pay the price and make a little effort.

(bs)

January 19

“The thing that will make us better is to clean up our lives by relieving ourselves of guilt. The Eighth Step is a mighty stride away from a lie dominated by guilt and remorse.”

Memphis Review Form - page 51, 13

The willingness to admit fault releases the chains that have held us back from re-experiencing painful guilt and shame. Life no longer has to be the way it has been. It is one thing to think about freedom and it is quite another to walk down new roads in our lives. Keeping our wits about us and staying with the ‘one day at a time’ approach to the new life is a real good idea. If we move too fast, we make it easy to take a fall. Slower is quicker.

Looking at our lives in a new light, we realize some of the things that bothered us were not real. Others we skipped over had to be resolved and dealt with. Recovery has a way of changing our pasts and present. That’s how we get a new future! Frequently when we review things that bother us from back when, it occurs that it was the situation that was so painful. There is almost no mean or hurtful thing that could have done worse or more often.

One of the things that may surprise us is when we visit past events and feelings with our current resources: *we are not afraid and can see what really took place*. As reality sets in, amends become a way out of the endless pain and punishment of guilt. Many times we find our future has been blocked by our lack of understanding and inability to see or hear clearly. Why do so many of us call it ‘messed up?’

(bs)

January 20

“We had used all sorts of drugs over the years and experienced numerous living problems as the result of our using and yet did not consider ourselves addicted.”

Memphis Review Form - page 2, 31

It usually takes a total catastrophe or disaster to penetrate our walls of denial. Denial is so all pervasive, we actually come to believe our own lies. The acronym “Don’t Even Notice I Am Lying” is such a wonderful description of D-E-N-I-A-L. Spinning stories and then believing them is an ability we have all become so skilled at, we often are not aware we are doing it we exaggerate how bad we are to keep from surfacing what’s really bothering us. If something has been bothering us a long time, we may be surprised with we open up and write about it. It is like another hand is writing the truth from our inner being, without the hedges and blocks held in our minds.

When we hit our bottoms, when our lives are so unmanageable and out of control that we can’t believe our own lies anymore, our addiction becomes apparent. Even then, it often takes a long time before we are ready to do anything about it. Fortunately, recovery gives us that time! Our NA Program is designed by fellow addicts who love and understand what we are going through.

When we finally, truly, accept that we are addicts and can’t live this life of addiction anymore, we can make the admission and surrender required by Step One. Then we begin to recover. We must start developing a relationship with honesty, not just cash register honesty, but the deeper level of self-honesty required to look at ourselves. It takes courage and faith to take a deep look inside and see all the mistakes we have made over the years. Often our loving God releases this information to us over a long period of time. It seems God takes us through some preparation inside before it comes up in our conscious minds.

We need to realize that we are not evil, malicious horrible monsters, but we are simply human beings who made mistakes and poor choices. It a way it is to our credit that we experience guilt and shame. Often situations had more control over what happened than we did. We are capable of learning to make better choices and fewer mistakes. This is where the Fellowship, the Program, a Sponsor and a strong relationship with our Higher Power can help us. There is indeed hope for all of us. We can learn to love ourselves, have lives filled with joy and happiness and become people we are proud to be.

(bs)

January 21

"We have surrendered our will and our lives to the care of a power greater than ourselves. We are now a part of the Ultimate Reality which has brought Order out of Chaos."

Memphis Review Form - page 39, 22

As long as your belief works for you, we are happy for you. We are serious about finding a loving Higher Power. There are many equal and lower powers.

Our Program only asks that this Power being loving, caring and greater than we are. Ascribing the characteristics of loving and caring is not difficult for us because we certainly had surrendered our lives to a vengeful harmful, even killing, power greater than we are in our active addiction. Surrendering to our growing understanding of a Higher Power is easy. Holding on to the pain and indecision is hard. Our HP will not only do us no harm but actually help us to relieve our pain.

As the drug induced fog lifts, we discover how many of the parts fit in an order that can only be called divine. We advise members to 'take it easy' so the changes stick and the broken parts can be replaced or restructured. Clean, time is on our side.

(bs)

January 22

“Upon working Step One, we affirmed our surrender to the principles of N.A, only then did we overcome the alienation of addiction.”

Memphis Review Form - page 31, 1

From the very beginning, we are members of NA. For many of us this is our first experience with the life saving principle of vulnerability. Our unconditional surrender is the key that will unlock the door and allow others into our lives and us a way out! This provides the help we need and helps us avert our tendency to continue in self will.

The pain of being clean and having the realization that we cannot successfully use drugs, not use others, and control situations through manipulation and control. When we find that we are unable to control life and see how our lives are unmanageable, we can free ourselves through surrender. Surrender becomes a positive move away from things that no longer work for us. We find it helps to bring ourselves to full consciousness whenever we need to make a new surrender.

Hope for something better helps us surrender and we find there are many like us. We are never alone. Identification lets us see up close how many of our defects are on the surface and it doesn't take much to pull them out by the roots! Sometimes there is a moment of fear when we do this but it always results in feeling better almost right away.

(bs)

January 23

“We look at our actions during the day and we practice the art of looking at where we were wrong, considering what we could have done differently, and the amends we need to make.”

Memphis Review Form - page 56, 2

Step Ten helps us keep recovery new and fresh by sweeping the debris of our life before we can trip over it. It is also vital to our ongoing recovery because it keeps us from making up things under the guise of prayer and meditation. The old phrase, “if it ain’t practical, it ain’t spiritual” has served many a member well in recovery. A spiritual life requires cleaning and grooming to stay in adjustment with reality.

Jimmy K, one of our early members, called NA the self-adjusting program. Every member cleans their own spot. If we see someone else making a mistake, we learn to be gentle and respectful just as we find it works better if we are gentle and respectful with our own faults and errors. Life happens and we go along with it, doing our best as we go, making amends as needed and helping others wherever we can.

Amends are not as bad as trying to leave them undone. After we can clearly see what went wrong, our personal sense of right and wrong will give us all the prompting we need. If we really care about people, we don’t want to be hurting them in any way. Ongoing inventory is also a vital part of the prayer and meditation in Step Eleven. Without spiritual inventory, we are subject to mistaking strength and guidance for wishful thinking and self-service!

One of the reasons we, as a Fellowship, settled on the words ‘clean’ and ‘clean time.’ is that it suggests getting rid accumulated dirt and debris as we go forward. It is said that big airliners are off course 90% of the time and have self-correcting electronics to keep them on course. Recovering addicts also need self-correction to stay on course!

(bs)

January 24

“We are not going to be perfect. If we were perfect, we would not be human.”

Memphis Review Form - page 43, 11

Perfection may simply be a fear-based notion on the mental plane. Our intuition and spiritual sensitivity go way beyond the mental plane! There is no one grading our papers! Recovery is rejoining a process begun millions of years ago. It's all about being a human being. In recovery, we regain our humanness. Humans make mistakes, correct the mistakes and learn from them as we go. Our learning spreads to address all aspects of a subject. When our understanding contains most of the pertinent aspects of a subject, we are said to be informed. Slowing down and developing the habit of thinking through our understanding is part of the 12 Step recovery process.

In the states of confusion associated with using drugs, we are too busy, to hurried. We don't feel we have time to think things through clearly. The Buddha said, “May who lives in house that is burning down is always in a hurry.” This results in about ninety percent of our problems! Proceeding without fully seeing the landscape before us, we can only stumble blindly ahead. Surrendering and connecting with a power greater than ourselves, we find the time to do things once, instead of doing them a dozen times. There is always time to do it over but there is never time to do it right in the first place.

Spending time with clean addicts gives us a chance to review our mental habits and our ways of communicating. Going to meetings and spending time with members is essential to recovery. Otherwise, we begin to float off on our own cloud. Reading recovery literature written by addicts, for addicts also helps put us in a ‘recovery state of mind.’

Perfection may be approached gradually. At any point, there is much to be done! Many of us had to just go to meetings and not use drugs for a while until we began to clear up. Keeping a recovery journal is another good approach for some members. The point is we have to keep varying our approach until we get the results we want. Sometimes all we have to do is just turn up the volume by going to more meetings, reading more material and listening more attentively to our fellow members share their experience, strength and hope.

(jf/bs)

January 25

“Day by day we discover the magnitude of the Third Step.”

Memphis Review Form - page 39, 28

If we put pennies in a jar every day we are clean, the jar would fill to overflowing, we would have to get another jar! After some time, we would have a row of jars. We have countless opportunities to make bad choices and regrettable decisions each and every day. Not making these poor choices becomes a tidal wave of goodness touching every current and ripple of our lives. Recovery gives us back our losses while eliminating new mistakes as we go.

If we are really surrendered to being an addict and if we have found a belief in a higher power, turning our life and will over should be easy. The test will be seeing how things work out with our HP in charge! We will always be learning more about the God of our understanding. Again and again we remind ourselves our HP is not a lesser or equal source of strength and guidance, it is on a higher plane of reality! When we share in meetings, many times we voice things that were going on inside that may not have yet surfaced in our minds. When we listen to others share, we often find clues and hints that apply in our own lives. In this way, we find answers popping up on a daily basis. It is important that we have the time and desire for recovery to bring these resources into our daily practices.

Usually, every recovery speaker I listen to there is one “sound bite” that really hits home. One example is a lady I heard say, “I have seem better people than me relapse.” At the time, that really got me! It’s not about subjugating others, it is about subjugating our own egos.

(jf/bs)

January 26

“We needed proof. In that N.A. meeting we found people like ourselves with the same, or worse patterns of of drug dependency and failure, yet they were clean. They smiled. Their eyes were clear. They cared for each other.”

Memphis Review Form - page 31, 7

Patterning after happy people seems to be an innate quality in human beings. Before we had the NA program in our lives, we had a real shortage of ‘happy people.’ We can pick up good vibes and without much preparation, find ourselves looking, feeling and sounding better. As our internal state changes from a fear-based outlook over to a positive setting where good things not only possible, they are common. Spiritual growth is practicing being happy, being fulfilled. Before we got into the 12 Steps, spirituality seemed like something distant and well out of reach. Recovery brings it into our day to day lives. We see and hear what works for others and try out their solutions for ourselves!

Some members use the phrase, ‘acquired learnings’ to refer to things that may not yet be part of our personal experience. As more and more is added to our internal resources, we find ourselves repeating the things we have heard from other members to newcomers and we get to see simple ideas and phrases help jar a person out of a negative view.

The NA program is full of people who had no hope and no way out of their addiction. Bit by bit our habits and mental processes are reformed into working parts of our lives. We may find ourselves thinking, “Gee, if this is what works for me, why didn’t someone tell me?” Miracles are so commonplace in NA, that we soon take them for granted. This is where recalling past pain can help us continue up recovery road!

The old saying, “Everything we needed to learn to get clean, we learned in the first ninety days.” We keep forgetting and often remind ourselves by helping others. A visitor said in a meeting, “If I’m not happy, I’m not working my program!”

(jf/bs)

January 27

“We make our list, or take it from our Fourth Step and add to it any more people we can think of and we face that list honestly and openly and examine our fault.”

Memphis Review Form - page 51, 27

In working our program, we make lists so that our goals are attainable and not insurmountable. There is a simple way to look at Step Nine. There are stories like the one about a princess who could feel a pea beneath a bunch of mattresses. Another phrase refers to a burr under the saddle that gives your horse the jitters. If these things didn't bother us, they probably wouldn't be on our Eighth Step list! When we reach way down and wiggle them loose, we have settled old issues and are free to find different ways to spend our time and energy. Otherwise, they each drain tiny bits on a daily basis until we are empty.

Putting closure on things from the past frees up time and attention for our future. Clean is not only measured in time, it is also the freed up energy. We are sometimes surprised to find new ways to live without endlessly repeating what doesn't work for us! We need to remind ourselves that working the 12 Steps is how we crawl up out of the endless pit of addictive pain and confusion. It is not something we do for our spouses, parents or other family members and friends. We are the first beneficiaries of our recovery.

When it's the proper time for the amends, the means appears. People we have wronged show up. Money suddenly appears to settle past accounts. Our willingness surprisingly rises up to the occasion. The Ninth Step is a gift we give to ourselves like no other.

One of the bonuses of recovery is we realize how useless it is to lie to ourselves! Honestly looking at our inventory is the only way it will work for us! The whole idea is self-betterment. Our happiness depends on it!

(jf/bs)

January 28

“A problem many of us seem to have with the Eighth Step and the admission of the harm we did is the belief we were victims, not victimizers, in our addiction.”

Memphis Review Form - page 52, 6

The endless quest to look good and sound innocent avails us nothing here. Getting real and finding the source of our pain is worth the tiny jet of honesty it takes to really look at what we have been up to in active addiction and early recovery. But instead of increasing our feelings of doom, we experience relief and joy. Whatever it was, the main thing is to stop feeding the thinking and habits that produce such results.

When we stagger out of a drug induced fog, we often get things turned around and fail to realize how much of a part we played in painful memories of the past. After all, we are the main actors in our own movie! If we felt good about the things we said and did, we wouldn't need the NA program. That quiet little voice down inside us is available to help as needed. When we ask for God's help, surprising answers occur out of thin air!

The Fourth Step can be fodder for the items on the Eighth Step. The people we harmed, the money we owe, the loose ends to be dealt with. Facing these things with a good attitude and appropriate action, we become free to enjoy today and look forward to tomorrow.

We put ourselves on the list as being harmed. When I was new, one oldtimer told me “As an addict, you have a right to be angry at what happened to you out there”. I remember one newcomer who was straight but let guys have sex with him in caskets for money for his habit and caused him to get aids. He had a right to be angry at what happened to him out there. In recovery, he asked himself, “Was he running from his situation or compromising on a daily basis.” In recovery we slowly learn to not compromise.

(bs/jf)

January 29

“We think of love as a shield against the attacks of other people, and as a weapon to blast through walls of hate, and to open closed hearts and closed minds. We feel protected by our love, through adversity, discouragement, anger, and insecurity.”

Memphis Review Form - page 72, 13

Love is a word that takes on many new meanings in recovery. We find that we even use love to justify anger or jealousy. We never had time to think through our feelings before. We were too busy making others happy! Maybe we thought we did but the ‘drug induced fog’ scrambled what happened and why it upset us. The love and caring in Step 12 has to do with something more soulful. We not only mean we appreciate and want to see someone we love happy and doing well, recovery furnishes us ways to help make that difference in their lives. Unconditional love also means we don’t put expectations or make deals like, “I love you so you have to satisfy my needs and wishes!” That’s not love at all, it is a justification for manipulation and control! Subjugation of others is not a worthwhile goal. Participation gives us a voice without the need to control.

Love becomes an active principle for living in a new way. Real love is healing and goes way beyond ‘intending’ goodness, it can provide that goodness. When we spend part of our time thinking about how we can be of service to others, we have less time to be mean and selfish. The activities of loving and caring enrich our lives. We often find we have more after giving than we had before!

When others are unfair or deceitful, we begin to realize how understand the anger raised by others we tried to dominate in the past.

(jf/bs)

January 30

"We forgive more easily, anger more slowly, expect less, and give more to our brothers and sisters."

Memphis Review Form - page 72, 22

My Father's sister once told me, "You never get back all you put out, so if you want a lot, you have to give more than you want to get." While there are other famous beliefs, I never forgot this one from my Aunt. When I become a 'giver', my 'getting' goes up. It takes time and energy away from my 'selfishness.'

Life is not for 'getting' things, life is for 'giving' to others. Following the NA 12 Steps, I reconcile the parts of me that thwart each other and settle down to my real self. From this 'seat of power' I am less easily knocked off balance and less threatened by what others say, think and do.

These aspects of recovery are not to be forgotten or pushed aside. They are a few of the aspects of recovering addicts different from the way we were before. We find ourselves giving real love and caring and feeling ok about it. Since we learn to not put strings on our love, we don't have to go through the expectations that complicate a simple act of kindness. As we give this sort of love, we also discover we can accept love like this. Perhaps by giving it, we realize the feeling experienced by those who express a willingness to help us.

People are the most important things on the planet. Clear-headed and with no selfish goals in mind, we begin to see how each part affects the whole. So, cutting corners and forcing things into the narrow confines of our minds loses it power to hold us back.

(bs/ye)

January 31

“Often, when we get home, write out a resentment, explaining how we feel and how we became angry, and the part we played. We find out how to restrain ourselves later so we don’t repeat that action.”

Memphis Review Form - page 56.13

The freedom of surrender eliminates excuse making and dodging our responsibility. Things we could not see clearly jump out at us on closer examination. Having a clear head free from the issues brought up by fear of repeating past mistakes and situations not likely to occur now that we are clean. Having N A friends and a sponsor to talk over what’s happening with us makes a big difference. This is how human contact makes on the spot re-evaluations - the way they do in a healthy family. People close to us help us see ourselves through their eyes. The time and energy they take with us helps create a better future for us. The love of a brother or a sister creates space in our hearts that opens us to gives and receiving help in our future. This is one of the parts we have to discover if we grew up in a dysfunctional family. Gress, what? We all grew up in dysfunctional families.

We couldn’t see it and neither could our families since they probably reflect the world they grew up in. Optimize the goodness and minimize the downside. Pile up the good stuff until it overshadows the field of view and keep going, giving and learning every step of the way.

Many parts of our program of recovery consist of repairing mishaps resulting from simply taking things the wrong way or poor thinking. Emotions should not keep us from thinking clearly. Just because a feeling is strong does not make it real, right or justified! We addicts often get it wrong and recovery helps us reconsider before we regret what we say or do. Patience and understanding work better than being right or putting others at a disadvantage.

Making gratitude lists, recovery journals and the discoveries we experience in meetings all work towards actualizing the ‘real self’ within each of us. These home made tools help us get a grip on our recovery and accumulate a written record of what we learn in our own words.! Taking ideas and spiritual concepts and making them into real, working parts of our life helps our personal program grow from small seeds of desire into large trees of new experience!

(bs/ye)

FEBRUARY

February 1

“We do however, remember that God not us is responsible for our change.”

Memphis Review Form - page 56.17

If it were up to us, we would be able to have someone do it for us. In reality, we do have something else helping us change, God. When we finally decide to get clean, get involved in a home group, find a sponsor, and begin working the steps, we let go of our self-centered, self-righteous ways. We let go completely and find that we are being changed and many of us realize we are not doing it. We find that a power greater than ourselves is taking hold and we are allowing ourselves to be transformed into the person we always wanted to be and never knew how. This is how surrender works to set us free!

The importance of this distinction lies down the timeline when we look back and realize how much we have changed. If we imagine it is we ourselves that accounts for the changes, it can easily lead us back into self-will. Attributing the changes to our Higher Power frees us from ego and gives us a path to continue the process of seeking recovery and freedom through inventory, prayer and meditation.

It may help to try conceiving of God as what is to come as well as what has already manifested. Of course, from God's Viewpoint, each part of reality is part of something whole and complete and we are like ant's making our way on a huge anthill of all there is! With the help of a loving God, we can slow down for the curves and speed up for the straight aways.

It is said, NA is a self-correcting program. We surrender, come to believe and turn our lives over to a loving Higher Power. The 'we' in the NA Twelve Steps is 'us.'

(bs)

February 2

“Ask anyone who has some time on the program and who has the kind of life you want for yourself, they will tell you that the Fourth Step was a turning point in their lives.”

Memphis Review Form - page 40, 21

In our early days, many members viewed the Fourth Step as upsetting and many felt pain and upset. The reality is that Step Four takes us out of our old habits and ways of dealing with life. We are free to examine and evaluate what we want to keep and what no longer fits our life. This is the mechanism of personality change where our surrender opens the way to escape our old ways of dealing with life.

When addicts let go of things of the past, they clear the way for future growth. What used to be habitual and we considered to be a genuine ‘part’ of our being, falls away and does not come back - so long as we stay on the 12 Step path. In some periods of confusion, not all members understand or learn to see recovery this way. Like an old timer said, “Nobody likes to admit complete defeat! “

The turning point can best be seen when we look back on it. Clean time gives us a wider view from which to see ourselves. When we look back, our minds and memories are more clear and accurate. Our willingness to make amends or just laugh at ourselves is greater. We are reminded to match up the changes we experience with our willingness to go along with our HP.

(bs)

February 3

"Many of us, before we take Step Five, fear that God will turn away from us, when we reveal ourselves to Him."

Memphis Review Form - page 43, 31

There are plenty of curves our disease will throw at us to keep us worried and fearful. We have to look to our old-timers to see what they have learned. They share that the process of spiritual growth is never ending. The higher we climb the mountain of spiritual growth and recovery the more mountain appears before us.

As soon as we think we are approaching the top of the mountain, we see a little more mountain appear before our very eyes! We see not only what's in front of us, we also see beyond! And this process teaches us to expect more to come into view as we rise step by step.

When we share our innermost feelings about the painful areas of our personal past, there is nothing left to fear. Taking Step Five requires us to put our Faith into action. Of course, we all have the lurking awareness that our Higher Power already knows this stuff but coming out in the open and sharing our Fourth Step with God, ourselves and another human being puts it all on the line, in black and white.

No longer fearing divine retribution over our past lives frees us to continue our journey on recovery road. It is like an athlete in training surpassing a goal that lets them know they can run in the race and have a chance of winning. It gives wings to our hope of ongoing recovery. Let it be said that the list of past wrongs is a list of what has been bothering us for so long - and upsetting us whenever we begin to get ahead in life. The peace this gives us doesn't go away.

(bs)

February 4

"We no longer wish to participate in the problem. We now serve God. In this manner of service, we renew our vow to turn our will and lives over to the care of God."

Memphis Review Form - page 61, 25

The brightness and pain of active addiction does more than make us say, "Ouch." Hey, it really hurts. With the pain comes the willingness. Most people realize there are ups and downs in life. If you have drifted away from the things that brought you freedom and relief in the beginning of recovery, you do not have to take a fall to get back with the program, just do what it says here: "Renew your vow to turn your will and life over to the care of God." That's all it takes. Just say the words to yourself a few times. Like a sticky light switch, keep flipping it until the light comes on!

It may help to put the Third Step prayer in terms of the First Step surrender. Giving up and taking back our ego and self-will is not going to work for us any better than it did before...

It was our ability to give up absolutely that empowered our recovery at the very beginning. It is a constant source of amazement to watch newer members surrender and begin their recovery the way many of us did: just accept our unmanageability and take recovery one day at a time.

Complicating things and trying to make recovery harder will not work! Simple surrender and faith works best.

Renewal gives us hope afresh. Positive expectation allows us to surface feelings of optimism and gratitude that we have made it this far. It is rational to think about how dependent recovery is on our desire and belief that it is possible and others have done what we are doing with good results. Actually terrific results in most cases. Some have trouble keeping their faith bright and taking the actions that give life to our daily adventure in the clean life!

(bs)

February 5

“Step One means that we don’t have to make excuses for the way we are, and that is a great freedom.”

Memphis Review Form - page 31, 30

Our freedom results in more energy and open-mindedness. This is the raft we ride into the Second Step where we find connections to a power that can help us. Surrender would not work out on the streets or places where we have all been. In the loving, caring circle of friends in an N A meeting we find a protected environment made just for us. As we grow in recovery, our need for and ability to surrender grows as well.

Along with our own experiences, we see the Program work for others. It is a funny thing, the people we may see as hopeless or least likely to stay clean and find recovery are often the ones who had really had enough.

The gifts of a good mind and many of the good things that so many take for granted often keep us from really giving up the process of rationalizing and minimizing our need for help! “Yeah, I messed up. I reached the point where I just couldn’t make excuses any more. That’s when I asked for help and meant it.” Painful as it may be to reach this level of despair and desolation, the joy that follows surrender is all the greater!

(bs)

February 6

“Trusting others doesn’t come naturally to us, but we must learn to trust because an addict alone is in bad company. The needed strength wasn’t there until we found N.A., which showed us how to make faith work for us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 62, 20

What a statement! Faith does work for us but we have to learn a little to get it right. Faith is real evidence of things unseen. The difference shows in how we make new choices and how we react to events and circumstances. Positive expectation may be a big part of it. Expecting good things to happen keeps our minds open to positive outcomes. If we let ourselves believe our situation is hopeless, it is hard to see good opportunities. Watching others get clean and stay clean, it is easy to see how the evidence of recovery working for us. Asking questions and responding to the answers opens many doors.

Reading recovery literature, sharing and listening in meetings, it feels right and many of the topics we learn more about are things we stumbled onto in the past but were unable to follow through on. Now we can read, listen in meetings and then ask questions to clarify our understanding.

Keeping a recovery journal lets us mark down breakthroughs in our understanding as they occur. It matters not if we ever go over them later, just the physical act of writing down things that are important seems to imbed it in our minds! Written affirmations embed positive images into our minds and helps lead us deeper into our faith and belief.

(bs)

February 7

“You may approach the Fourth Step in a number of ways. It is advisable that before you start, go over the first Three Steps with your sponsor.”

Memphis Review Form - page 41, 21

We need our surrender, belief and our decision to let our Higher Power care for us - lest we try to take control and work our Fourth Step on self-will! If this happens to you, just take a break and think about how it feels to push harder on something that is not working. Slow down and think about your HP until you get that ‘cared for feeling.’ Remember, we don’t want to lose our assets, just the attributes and habits of mind and action that make trouble for us.

Sharing our perceptions with a trusted friend or sponsor gives us a chance to catch ourselves so we don’t slip into the limitations that used to pin us down. The Third Step makes it clear our relationship with our Higher Power is positive, God will supply us with energy and ideas that open the way before us. Many members conclude that God, our High Power of choice, works the next six Steps for us.

We bring everything we have learned to the fore and turn our life and will over to the *care* of a loving God. Not the tyranny or the confinement but more of the good feelings that helped us get with the NA Program in the first place.

(bs)

February 8

“Surrender means not having to fight anymore. It took a while, for some of us, to realize how unmanageable our lives had become; for others, this was about the only thing of which we could be sure.”

Memphis Review Form - page 31, 31

Surrender becomes one of the most powerful weapons in our arsenal. As we truly accept our powerlessness over just about everything but ourselves, we find our power over ourselves is growing. We can change our attitudes, our beliefs, our feelings, our actions and our responses. We learn to take a moment to think about our actions in accordance with our growing belief system and then respond instead of just blindly going into action!

When we fight, we wear ourselves out! With our energy expended, we thrash about like an animal in a trap. Surrendered, we just stop and see what happens. Admitting our powerlessness helps put an end to futile attempts to keep up a good front while crashing and burning inside. Unmanageability is a good big word to cover what we are admitting to. When we were kids on the playground at school fighting with another kid, giving up meant the other child had to get off us and we could stand up and dust our cloths off. It gave us a chance to go on with our play!

Looking back over our past lives, we don't want to repeat the error of fighting only to find ourselves creating situations that trap us in situations that require even more surrenders in the future. So, instead of fighting, we surrender each day anew and always hope for the best. It is easier to do life once the right way than to do something a dozen times wrong.

(bs)

February 9

"In the old days we knew, deep down inside, that we were faking it whenever we indulged in our delusions of grandeur and self-importance. Now, because we were beginning to love ourselves unashamedly, we can love other people more completely, because we no longer feel like we have anything to hide from anyone."

Memphis Review Form - page 72, 34

These are priceless blessings that money cannot buy. Many people live out their lifetimes without activating these aspects from the list of available potentials. We each progress from one area of concern to the next one that comes into view as a result of our growth. Ongoing recovery, one day at a time, is ongoing growth and discovery.

Our membership in N A gives us a new social setting that allows for special people like us, people are living a spiritual recovery program on a daily basis. We can self-correct as we go because when we live spiritual principles, we don't have to fight life. Helping others gives us insight into how others feel when they are helping us. They're helping us, not hurting! Because of identification hurting one another in N A would not make sense.

As real talent and ability replace a sick need for egotism, we let go of our fear-based habits and attitudes. We see others floundering to hold on to their controlled lives and we no longer want to embarrass ourselves that way.

(bs)

February 10

“Without N A, few of us would have survived, and fewer still would have found recovery.”

Memphis Review Form - page 92, 12

We are still constructing N A as we know it. Our experienced members are often appalled at the members who seem to think we just make up things and do not realize we learned from those who have gone before.

Our written literature helps our members get in touch with the reality of passing on experience that has proven itself in the lives of many addicts. Those who have a vested interest in N A want to continue growing and better carry a message of recovery based on the actual experience of our members. The scars of our addiction and the host of ideas carried in the minds and hearts of our members in different stages of recovery make an interesting mix.

Keeping up appearances has to be balanced with the truth of inner experience. Financial issues and concerns need to balance with the love and concern we have for others. The things we gather in recovery should never take precedence over our need for our meetings and the others who walk our path.

People sort out at different levels of understanding and behavior. Nobody's perfect and no one is so knocked back they can't get better. We are always on our way up from who we were to something better. Spirituality stabilizes us at a certain point of clarity and it gets easier from there. But we have to keep surrendering and seeking help if we are to continue growing.

(bs)

February 11

“As long as we preserve our clean time we enjoy the greatest possible advantage over our disease. For this we are grateful. The first thing to do is get clean. This makes the other stages of recovery possible. Learn that addiction is a disease. Try to forgive past behavior and realize it was caused by our disease. Go to meetings and study the program for your own personal growth.”

Memphis Review Form - page 125, 28

This amazing paragraph is supremely important for it contains basic information that has worked for literally countless addicts all over the planet Earth. All faiths are welcome to N A ! All nationalities, languages, national historical settings fit in with us. Addicts are the same wherever they come from and so is recovery!

While there is no magical cure for addiction, it can be arrested. We stop the disease in its tracks when we stop using. Our using ways and character defects may roll on for a while but the root is cut.

Like a man said in a Southern California prison, “If I want to feel good, I have to stop doing the things that make me feel bad.” Like a shoe that fits all feet, N A seems to work for all types of people, all educational levels, etc. The principles are universal and work for all people regardless of their state, status or situation.

(bs)

February 12

“Obsessiveness is really common to all the addicts we have met or heard of. Our ego tells us we can do it on our own, then loneliness and paranoia return.”

Memphis Review Form - page 125, 35

Obsession is losing control of our thinking. We get afraid and rush ahead to regain control, at least in our imagination. Body drugs may fuel our desperation. Our ego is our false sense of self. It erects barriers that keep others out and keeps us lonely within.

Obsession on the physical level is compulsion, losing control of our our actions. Both work together in active addictions or the early stages of relapse. Spiritual principles start with surrender and getting help. Working on self-improvement and helping others keeps us out of trouble while we are getting with the program.

Isn't it funny that when we stop flopping around and acting out of desperation, our lives get better. Then when we think we are ready to take control again, we begin to have trouble again. That's why recovery is surrender on a daily basis!

(bs)

February 13

“Our egos used to control us in all kinds of subtle ways. For one thing, it seemed important for us to compete with others in almost all of our endeavors. Some of us even refused to try something that we might not be the best at. We watched other people closely , not with any concern for their wellbeing, but to check and see if we were measuring up to their standards.

“With all this negative expectation, when we did well, we were only confused. Everyone we met was sized up in terms of how they could be useful to us or a threat to our self-esteem.”

Memphis Review Form - page 73, 4

These are the old rules of our lives. It wasn't our fault, it is stuff we learned in our families, in our schools and among all the people we interacted with. You might call them, “The ways of the world.” When we get physically sick, we are put in a hospital where we can get well. In recovery, we find a need to be among clean addicts so we can get well. Fear-based thinking and acting only made us sick again. Many say, “We don't just work the Steps, we live the Steps.”

Finding NA literature and other clean addicts, we let the NA ways into our lives. Mimicry let us take in new ways of seeing life and doing things differently. At times it was scary but when something works, it is attractive!

(bs)

February 14

“Remember, we didn’t become addicted in one day. We can’t possibly solve all our problems at once, no matter how much energy we have. Take it easy! The only way we recover is to apply what we learn from each other, on a daily basis.”

Memphis Review Form - page 62, 30

When we get away from the simple, true, proven program of N A, we can drift into endless complication. Keep it simple is more than just a neat phrase! The N A Program is assembled out of the combined experiences of men and women who found answers in the 12 Steps and work within the boundaries and principles of the 12 Traditions. To let our minds get fuzzy and drift away from what works for us, oftentimes the only thing that works for us, is insanity rejoined!

Years ago, when N A started growing, it seemed to take a long time for people to get with the program. Nowadays, it seems we are adjusted to the deep changes required for spiritual growth and personality change. When you have a disease that can kill you, people seem more willing to take the time!

We are continuing to learn as breakthroughs in neuroscience, general medicine and individual recovery push back the relapse line. Oh, you can still relapse but there is much more information on recovery you have to avoid or push aside than we had back when N A started growing.

(bs)

February 15

“We pray for willingness and humility and finally get honest about our mistake in judgment or bad decision. We tell those who were hurt that we were to blame, ask them to forgive us and make whatever amends necessary. Now we’re in the solution again.”

Memphis Review Form - page 126, 27

When we are lonely and scared, we are full of negative expectation. Willingness can seem threaten because we are accustomed to failure. The amazing thing is that in many cases, the embarrassment and feeling of not being able to perform well evaporates and we don’t have to do much of anything hard. We often find ourselves slowly down and just doing the next right thing. This is the miracle of ‘willingness. When we are willing, we usually find we don’t have to...

When there are amends to be made, we experience joy being able to set things right. Usually, there are some people we owe amends that we can’t locate and so we have to give what we have, the willingness to make amends when we can. Often writing a letter to the person and filing it with our personal papers can help.

(bs)

February 16

“We think that the Tenth Step helps prevent relapse.”

Memphis Review Form - page 126, 32

Ongoing inventory allows us to see and react without all the confusion and fear that kept us from being able to deal with life on life's terms. Inventory gives us momentary pauses to look around and see what's happening while we are focused on a task at hand. Just doing this prevents minor problems growing whereas it only takes a moment to correct. When our life was confused and desperation prevented us from making a plan and working the plan, many of our efforts fell short of satisfaction. Now, we begin our life anew!

From the beginning, we are able to find new resources that come with membership starting when we surrender to our addiction and our need for help. Going slow and getting it right helps us break up old thinking habits and the messes we make when we get in a hurry. Resources refer to things that have worked for us in the past. They are also people we can turn to for help. Calmly thinking things through makes a big difference.

The Tenth Step readies us for what is to come next in our recovery. As we grow we need to inventory what comes through prayer and meditation. There is great energy in these two aspects of our Tenth Step. Through being clear headed and generally in better working order, we will spot items of inventory we missed in our Fourth Step. But how about when we want something on the spiritual level after we have learned how the spirit within controls what happens in our daily lives. Prayer lets us reach out and meditation lets us take in new perceptions and ideas that do not come to a careless person.

(bs)

February 17

“There is something in our self-destructive personality’s cries for failure. It permeates our total being – “You do not deserve to succeed.” We have all experienced this and without the knowledge that we finally have earned the right to be responsible, respectable members of society. The manner in which we returned to our addiction is not important. What is essential to each of us is that we have the choice not to continue.”

Memphis Review Form - page 126, 34

Written recovery presents assets found by members of N A who have gone the way before you and wrote down their thoughts and feelings to make your way easier. We did not come to the program with a great deal of self-worth and self-esteem. In fact, we felt lower than an ant’s belly before most of us became willing to try a new way of life. When we were beaten we became willing as the old saying goes. It is the deep inner sense of unworthiness that kept most of us In the downward spiral of active addiction as we used, made more messes In our lives then had to use some more to live with the guilt and anguish of what we did while on our last run.

We get off this merry-go-round by surrendering. We surrender control of our lives to the program of Narcotics Anonymous. For most of us this was a huge relief just to be able to let go of control of an unmanageable life, what a relief! Once we get even a little bit of clean time, we begin to see more clearly how the drugs had been managing our lives for quite some time now.

As we have small success in recovery like not using just for today or even for a whole month, we begin to see a glimmer of self-esteem, maybe for the first time, In a long time, In our own eyes. Our friends in the fellowship will give us the hope we no longer have as they applaud each new key tag we pick up, yes!

N.A. gives us hope. If it can work for some of these crazy lunatics, maybe, just maybe it can work for me. As we work steps with our sponsor, we begin to grow in recovery which as they say happens over time not overnight. As weeks turn into months and months to years, we begin to see a new vision of ourselves as basically happy responsible people. As our insides are healed, we tend to do much less self-destructive stuff because we feel worthy of much more We are recovering!

Just for tonight; I will trust the process of recovery and hold onto the new truth that more will be revealed and a new me is shining through.

(ko)

February 18

“When we pray and take action it always goes better for us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 42, 18

The difference between my will and God's will is results! When it's my will, the results are good for me and no one else. They are short-lived and only work for a little while, usually at someone else's expense. When it's God's will the results are good for me and everyone else! It's like a missing piece in a puzzle, it fits just right.

Turning one's will and life over to our Higher Power grants us access to great power and tremendous vision. In recovery we can use this Power to build our new lives. Every day is a new chance to practice our new life and do things differently knowing we are acting in the best interest of all and not just ourselves.

Just For Tonight: As we become more God-Centered and less Self-Centered people, we seek to do our Higher Power's will above our own. We have found that God's will is usually what we really want and need.

Ko March 15, 2016

February 19

“Attending meetings daily, living a day at a time, and reading the literature seems to send our mental attitude towards the positive. Willingness to try what has worked for others is vital.”

Memphis Review Form - page 128, 15

A sponsor shared a simple concept with his sponsee. “If you live in the problem, the problem gets bigger and if you live in the solution, the problem goes away” If we are wondering what the right thing to do is when life crashes in on us, we simply do the very things that got us clean. We call our sponsor, go to meetings regularly, raise our hand and share. We stick with the winners, pray and dive into Step work.

We are reminded that the very things we did to get clean will most certainly help us walk through the difficult and troubling times in our lives. By working a strong program, we most certainly are living in the solution and not the problem today. Just as it paid off when we were new by getting and keeping us clean, so too will our recovery effort keep us centered and grounded in times of woe.

Just for tonight; I will get out of the problem and get into the solution by working my program like I did when my ass was falling off in my first few weeks clean!

ko March 15, 2016

February 20

“We found that we could no longer control our using, nor could we manage our own lives. This surrender was the starting point of our recovery, and is a primary point of unity for the Fellowship.”

Memphis Review Form - page 91, 20

Without surrender we find it hard or impossible to admit our need for help or express our need to those who might have our answers. As one member put it; “First I surrendered to recovery and did not use for just one day. The next morning when I awoke, I surrendered to the 2nd half of step one... THAT MY LIFE WAS NONE OF MY BUSINESS!”

When we surrender, we surrender it all. If we have learned one thing in hitting bottom it was that our lives could not be managed by us. We managed to lose just about everything that was near and dear to us. For most we managed to live on the outskirts of life, either by choice or by necessity avoiding something we had screwed up royally. We may be wanted by the law, or hiding from angry creditors, in laws, outlaws.

We need to fully conceive in our inner most selves that we need direction and guidance by others who have been where we came from and have found a new way to live. In time we will learn to incorporate that new way of living by spiritual principles. Only then does our lives become manageable. But for now, it is suggested that we stop trying to run the show as all we end up doing is running it into the ground.

Just for tonight; I will let go of my life and trust that the fellowship can show me a new way to live. What have I got to lose?

[ko]

February 21

“Our purpose is to achieve freedom from the guilt we have carried so far, with so much pain, so that we can look the world in the eye with neither aggressiveness nor fear.”

Memphis Review Form - page 51, 4

In the 9th step in the Basic Text it clearly states the purpose of working the steps up to that point “we forgive others, possibly we are forgiven and eventually forgive ourselves.” This is the main purpose of working the 12 steps so we can finally, at long last, we can get to a place where we forgive ourselves. Once we reach this part of the steps we are truly a free and open channel to love others.

One of the questions a sponsor asked his sponsee about his past ways was.. “could the person you are today do all that negative selfish stuff to the ones you love?” The sponsee thought for just a second and then answered of course not! The sponsor suggested the principle of anonymity. Can’t you grant yourself your own anonymity, you give it to newcomers and other members freely. If we can let go of all we know about ourselves from the past and grant ourselves anonymity by seeing only the new person we have become, we surely know in our heart of hearts that we would not cheat on our spouses, leave our children with no food and use the money for drugs, or steal our children’s Christmas toys for just one more! Of course we would not today!

This type of thinking does not mean we don’t have to hold ourselves accountable for those past mistakes, it just means we need to give ourselves a break on the emotional level and stop drowning ourselves in self-pity for what rotten so-and-so we were. This type of self-abuse will not heal the situation nor move us closer to HP and recovery but keep us and other stuck in the pain of the past.

Just for tonight, I will grant myself some anonymity and free myself to become the person God wants me to be, clean and kind and courageous.

Mar 23, 2016 ko

February 22

“For years, we avoided seeing ourselves as we are.”

Memphis Review Form - page 44, 8

One member shared that he walked into his first N A meeting in blue hospital pajamas, skinny as a rail from years of heroin use, chipped teeth, matted hair, yellow skin, thinking; “These women must be checking me out” Our world became so crazy that we had to build a world around us that we could survive in! We had stopped looking in the mirror for real as we did not want to see who was looking back for all the stuff we had screwed up in our lives and the lives of those we once loved and for many of us lost to our addiction.

After years of masking our feelings, we begin the program scattered and hurting. Our beginnings are full of anxiety, fear and apprehension. We may search for a reason to continue staying clean at all. If we stay clean, we began hearing stories we can relate to. Seeing members looking healthier than we’ve have felt in many years, we start to believe in the hope we are starting to experience in the rooms of N A.

We learn to get out of ourselves by helping the next newcomer who walks in the door. We show him where the pamphlets are, we suggest that he take a seat next to us and offer them a cup of coffee. As we stay clean a day at a time, we begin to have small successes in our lives that give us just a bit of self-esteem and self-worth.

As one member shared, I came here with no self-esteem. I worked a few steps and stayed clean then I developed “low self-esteem” Smile.

Just for tonight: I am grateful for the self-esteem and self-worth I am developing through working the steps and participating in my recovery today.

Mar 23, 2016 ko

February 23

“Obviously our way did not work. In utter desperation, we looked for another way. In Narcotics Anonymous, we are told that we can turn our will and our lives over to a care of a God of our own understanding.”

Memphis Review Form - page 37. 27

A sponsor shared with his sponsee; “It’s your thinking that’s messed up” The sponsee asked his sponsor; “how much of my thinking?” The sponsor replied... “We usually start with all of it! If there’s any good, we will let you know!”

The one thing most of us grasp fairly easily when we truly surrender in our inner most selves that addiction has kicked our ass is that the only place our thinking got us was jails, institutions and a whole lot of trouble with any and all that loved us. For once in our lives we saw our big egos for what they truly where a bunch of hyped up phony lies to keep us from the truth of what a mess we had made of our lives and the lives of those we held dearest.

It is from this place of what appears to be weakness, comes our true strength, humility. We have learned that if we are not humble we are often humiliated. In recovery we choose to accept ourselves with all our flaws. Once we do so, they have no power over us anymore. We do this by working the steps so we can be freed from our self-made prisons and learn, over time, a simple way to live that works in harmony with God and others. We replace or old thinking with living by spiritual principles.

Just for tonight; I will replace the code of the street with the 12 steps so my life can be one of love and not hate.

Mar 23, 2016 ko

February 24

“Some of us sought spiritual guidance through churches, different religions, meditation and cultism. Some of us sought cure by geographical changes, blaming our surroundings and living situations for our problem. This attempt just gave us new people to take advantage of.”

Memphis Review Form - page 24, 25

What we failed to realize is that wherever we are, we bring the problem with us, ourselves. As the cartoon character Pogo Possum so aptly said; “We have met the enemy and they is us!”. We blamed people, places and situations for all our problems. We barely, if it all, took responsibility for most of the bad situations in our lives. If that cop had not been there, if she had only said yes, if they had not walked in on us when we had that needle in our arm, we would not have lost that job. The world is out to get us, we often moaned and groaned.

Solutions to our problems cannot come from outside sources, they must come from within. The Steps are the answer to our problems if we can find the courage, willingness and honesty to use the Steps to look inside, see who we are, accept ourselves and seek change. First we must come to a point of surrender. We give up trying to run the show. We let go and let recovery work in our lives as it has for so many before us.

Finding and developing a relationship with a Higher Power gives us the spiritual power to accomplish great changes we would otherwise be incapable of accomplishing on our own. We start to gain self-acceptance and self-love by realizing we are no longer the despicable depraved people we used to be. That we are becoming capable of giving hope and love to those coming in after us and most importantly to ourselves at long last.

Just for tonight; I will surrender to the truth that it was not the world that was after me. I was the maker of most all of my problems and with the help of others, I can be part of the solution today.

Mar 23, 2016 ko

February 25

“There is a spirit or an energy that can be felt in the meetings, and it is sometimes the newcomer’s first perception of God.”

Memphis Review Form - page 64, 13

Recalling our feelings and impressions from our initial contact with N A helps us keep our minds open to new ideas and target what we really want and expect from recovery. That little lift in the chest and sitting up straight expresses the openness and attention to learn more about the N A 12 Steps and Traditions. We may not even have words for it yet, but it is this desire for self-betterment that drives all our recovery.

One member who had just come in from his 3rd relapse in 2 years of trying to get clean, got to hear a story of a member who had tried to get clean 40 times! After the member shared their story at the treatment center H and I meeting the damnedest thing happened. They asked the speaker to come to the front of the room and they gave him his 1 year medallion! The newcomer thought to himself, if that crazy son of a bitch can stay clean a whole year so can I.

As one member shared; “N A gave me hope.” This was probably something that was sorely lacking in our lives for a long, long time. The only hope we had was that we hoped the dope was good this time. We hoped the dealer would get back soon so we could get the sick off. We hoped we wouldn’t get ripped off this time. But hope for freedom, for a better life, for an answer to why we kept sinking lower and lower with no hope of a way out. For many of us that was how we felt at the beginning, hopeless.

Just for tonight; I am grateful for the hope I have today and if I don’t have much hope today I will call my sponsor and get to a meeting to get some.

Mar 23, 2016 ko

February 25

"We convinced ourselves that we could make it alone and proceeded to live life on that basis. The results were disastrous, and, in the end, each of us had to admit that our self-sufficiency was a lie."

Memphis Review Form - page 91, 16

A sponsor told his sponsee; "I will tell you the one thing, that if it doesn't change, will keep you from getting everything God has intended for his children.. and that is... when you know, you know, you'll never know! But when you begin to understand that you don't understand, then you will have understanding. When you stop trying to understand, then you will enjoy life." The sponsee said back "Hell, I don't understand a word your saying!" The sponsor responded "and that's it and don't you ever forgot it!" The sponsee looked at him dumb-founded ... "hell you're crazy!" The sponsor replied "I know!"

The biggest problem most of us had when we got here was being know-it-alls. We were so smart we just knew we had a better grasp on life than just about anyone. For most of us at some very early age we were abused or abandoned or betrayed by our care-givers. We chose to do life all by ourselves, thank you very much. We lost faith in the world and knew in our heart-of-hearts that if we trusted others, eventually someone would screw us over.

Or we thought that we would never let anyone use us as the brunt of a joke so we became very wise in the ways of the world. We most certainly would not be made a fool of by others. We got real smart and in our people-pleasing obsession we constantly worked at out-smarting others first. The problem was that this became a full-time 24/7 job. It was exhausting. It may have brought us some notoriety. Some folks actually looked up to us but we traded off this small bit of ego boost by a life of always being on guard so we could be whoever you needed us to be to like us or at least tolerate our often bizarre behavior.

Just for tonight; I will find joy in not knowing it all so I can be opened minded enough to learn new things and grow.

[ko]

February 26

“Another desirable quality is love. We love the ambitious for they can inspire us; we love the failures for they can teach us; we love the kings for they are but human; we love the meek for they are divine. We love the poor for they are so many. We love the rich for they are lonely. We love the young for the faith they hold; we love the old for the wisdom they share. We love the beautiful for their eyes of sadness’ we love the ugly for their souls of peace.”

Memphis Review Form - page 72, 5

Love feels good whether we are giving love or receiving love. Learning to look for love changes the way we see, hear and feel life.

February 27

“Some of us had no idea who we were, or who we wanted to be. We only knew we didn’t want to be ourselves.”

Memphis Review Form - page 73, 11

For many of us, we did not surrender to recovery at first, we surrender to the truth that we could not live one more day in the hell of our active addiction! We did not know what this recovery stuff was all about but we had a glimmer of hope that it had to be better than the self-destructive life we had been living for so long.

Once we can surrender our old ways, it is a lot easier to live in the solution of recovery. We are firm believers in “being done”. We were sick and tired of being sick and tired as the literature says. For some it is not until we put it all down on paper in a thorough 1st step, that reality rings true as a bell. One member shared, I just could not use again once I had written about the last 15 years of failed drug usage and the devastation this had been to my wife, my son and those that I loved. If I knew anything for certain it was that I could not use successfully.

Just for tonight: If I have any reservations about being able to use safely I will share them in a meeting or with my sponsor and Higher-Power. I may even choose to write another 1st step so I don’t do something that I may regret for the rest of my life.

Mar 27, 2016 ko

February 28

"We were sick and tired of pain and trouble. We were frightened and ran from the fear, but no matter how far we ran, the fear followed us. We were hopeless, useless and lost. Feelings of worthlessness overcame us."

Memphis Review Form - page 25, 5

Nobody knows the trouble I've been. That was the song many of us would keep singing to our dying day if we had not found recovery in Narcotics Anonymous. Our self-esteem was in the toilet for many of us. There were no longer any "good" days, just tolerable ones. We had so much remorse, guilt and shame from the destruction we caused in our active addiction. Was there any help for addicts as bad as us?

As one sponsor told his sponsee: "If you always think what you always thought, then you will always feel what you always felt and if you always feel what you always felt, you will always do what you've always done and if you always do what you've always done, you will always get what you always got!"

We can get lost in our self-absorbed negative thoughts and never move forward in our lives. We get stuck in feeling sorry for ourselves or wallowing in how bad we are and never have a desire to move. We often find others who will feel sorry for us and this only feeds our desire to be sad or down. We get a pay-off for living in this negative self-destructive state.

For many of us we need to surrender to KISS, keep it simple, smile! If we write down 24 things we have to be grateful for, we can often move into a more positive mind frame and from there we can get back to our willingness to live in the solution today.

Just for tonight: I will remember that gratitude and self-pity are mutually exclusive. I know that I cannot be grateful and feel sorry for myself. I will write 24 things I have to be grateful for and share them with my sponsor.

March 27, 2016 ko

February 29

“Progression of recovery is a continuous journey uphill with loving effort. Without love or effort, we start the downhill run. The progression of the disease is an ongoing process, even during abstinence, no matter how long.”

Memphis Review Form - page 128, 30

We have learned, over time, that the road gets a lot less winding but it becomes a lot narrower! When we first come to recovery our feelings and mood go through huge swings, like a road that goes up and down steep hills and winds to and fro. As we work steps and get some time away from our last high, life becomes more peaceful. The road unwinds and the ups and downs aren't so drastic. We are recovering!

We come to understand that the peace we have found is from doing the right things for the right reasons as we begin to live a life of integrity. We are consistent in our actions and we have chosen to take 100% responsibility for lives. This takes discipline which, for most of us, is something we develop over time as we work the steps.

As one member shared; “I go to sleep at peace each night because I have taken care of all of my responsibilities that I could that day. I have returned the phone calls, shipped the packages, paid the bills or spoken with the creditors. I have spent time with my spouse, hugged my children etc etc etc. I would not feel comfortable going to bed any other way today. What a miracle from the person I was when I got here, wow!”

Just for tonight; I will stay on the path of recovery as I know that my life and peace of mind depend on it.

[March 27th, 2016 ko]

MARCH

March 1

“We had to feel better internally before we could even bear to think about whom we had harmed and how we had harmed them, and exactly what was the way we perceived ourselves.”

Memphis Review Form - page 50, 28

Newcomers want to do three steps, 1, 9 and 12... I surrender, I'm sorry, I'll help you! Not! Step 9 is at the end of the steps for a very sound reason. It takes a great deal of healing and insight to get to a place where we can make living amends and be consistent with them. It is one thing to say I'm sorry for not being there for you Dad and quite another to commit to be there for our parents for the rest of their days.

For many of us, we have not even a clue as to the exact nature of our wrongs. For many we just think stealing bad... but if we do a searching inventory we may come to the deeper truth that not only did we steal from our loved ones but we betrayed them and their trust over and over again. We took advantage of their kindnesses and saw them as weakness to be exploited. Or at worse, we did this with little or no remorse as the exact nature may have been our total self-centeredness and greed.

With so many levels of wrong to get to, it probably would work best for us first to find out how we deceived and cheated ourselves by continuing to use drugs when everything in our being and those around us kept telling us we were slowly committing suicide. It would probably serve us better in early recovery to find out why we hated ourselves so much that we would continue poisoning ourselves just to avoid feelings of guilt and shame.

There is a lot of love and sensitivity built into our N A Twelve Steps. They come in a given order that helps insure we are ready for the Step we are working at each step forward. It is very supportive and caring that along with each Step we can see how others have gone through the same things. So, as we progress, we are also woven into a Fellowship of men and women just like us, all on the road to a new life clean.

Just for tonight; I will trust my sponsor and the fellowship and work the steps in order knowing there is wise and sound reasons to do just that. I will trust that those who have come before me have learned the easiest softest way.

Mar 27, 2016 ko

March 2

“The Twelve Steps to recovery, that N.A. outlines for us, hold the answer for all of our ego-trips and insecurities. They seem to hold the only answers for us that we can really use. In living these Steps, we first begin to let go of old egotism. We then open up to a Higher Power, so that we will lose all fear of facing ourselves and of facing other people.”

Memphis Review Form - page 73, 15

For most of us, we have lived a life of people pleasing, at best and manipulating others at worst. We conned our fellows into thinking we really cared when inside we were merely plotting ways to get over or use them for funds for our next round. Maybe we just wanted folks to like us so we could get away with bloody murder and be forgiven for our transgressions as we continued to screw over our closest friends and family one more time.

We may have been or felt abandoned at a very early age when our caretakers were lost in their addiction or had turned on us by sexually abusing us or worse. We learned to make our caretakers happy at all cost as it would have meant we would be abandoned and die. This type of fear has run with us all our lives so we put up with people who abused us over and over and over again as we dreaded the thought of being abandoned one more time.

In recovery we find one good person to trust, a sponsor. With this small leap of faith, we begin to get honest with another human being, possible for the first time in decades. We share our innermost thoughts with our sponsor and we take direction from someone who has been where we were and has made it through ok. By opening up to this small bit of faith, which for many maybe a huge leap of faith, we can build an entire recovery on this simple step of surrender.

Just for tonight: As a sponsor said to his sponsee “If there isn’t a power greater than you, we are all in a world of trouble!”.

Just For Tonight; I will trust in just one person besides myself, I will trust my sponsor for they are fairly trustworthy folks.

Mar 27, 2016 ko

March 3

“When we came to the Fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous, we faced many disturbing realizations.”

Memphis Review Form - page 27, 4

We realized we had run from our feelings, we had lost control of our lives and become victims of the disease of addiction. The compulsion and obsession that had ruled our lives had forced us to take many actions that were against our will. We have lied, stolen, cheated, sold ourselves and many other vile things all in the name of getting one more. Now faced with the total unmanageability of our lives, we were filled with guilt, remorse, shame and sorrow. We couldn't see a way out. Going to meetings started to give us hope. We heard others share about how their lives got better. We started to learn there was a better way.

Learning is an ongoing process in recovery. Rethinking and sharing with others one on one or in meetings, we wake up to where we have been and what we have been doing! Living a day at a time frees us from repeating things we no longer approve of or care for. Each day is a blank slate. Hope and the freedom that comes from surrender and belief enables us to take a good look and review our lives as casually as we comb our hair. We can substitute actions and viewpoints until we are satisfied. Even then, when they stand for inspection, we are free to make other improvements. Our progress encourages us to continue the process.

Just for tonight: Instead of feeling lost when something negative comes to mind, we just think, “I'll share about this at the meetings tonight. Surely I am not the only one who has this problem.” No longer are we trapped and out of touch. With supportive people we can move forward as our lives are not stuck in concrete shoes!

March 27, 2016 ko

March 4

“We no longer blame God and others for our own problems, and see that our problems have been of our own making.”

Memphis Review Form - page 64, 19

As our notions about God and spirituality change in the light of a new understanding, most of our members see where God is in control but we are responsible for making our own choices. God takes care of the cosmos, the weather, politics and getting us out of our worse messes, when we ask for help. We are in charge of turning our life and will over to the care of a loving God who we have found in our 2nd Step! We also generally have fairly good sense and aren't afraid of admitting fault whenever we can, allowing that we find that relieves most of the tension and stress in our daily lives.

As we grow in recovery, we grow in internal resources, the tools and abilities to handle most day to day concerns and a few real upsets. Clean, real upsets don't occur that often but when they do, we are surprised how well honesty, openmindedness and the willingness to try eases the tension and gives us the ability to puzzle out what is going on and what needs to be done. If we remember to pray for help from our Higher Power, it can be like someone remembered to turn on a light!

The insanity mentioned in our 2nd Step is the root of most mishaps and once that is admitted, life is different. We relinquish fear and the need to find fault and lay blame on someone else's doorstep.

(bs)

March 5

“We must carefully choose the person who is to hear our Fifth Step.”

Of course it is most practical to share our 5th step with our sponsors as hopefully they both know us best and will be able to help us see the true nature of our defects in the upcoming steps once he or she hears our life story. We suggest that the person listening to our step know a good bit about us in advance whenever possible so they can listen for what we are not saying, as much as hearing clearly what we are saying.

Like all things spiritual, our Higher Power gives us lots of helpful guidance in this area. We pray for our HP to guide us to the right person! We want someone who cares about us and yet is able to be honest with us. We find someone we trust will keep our Fourth Step secrets confidential. Also, sharing with God, ourselves and another human being does not mean we give that person the right to judge us one way or the other.

It helps to have someone listen to our step who has worked all 12 of the steps themselves. The process of working the steps helps remove such defects as judgmentalness, ego, fear, jealousy etc.

We don't need that when opening our heart and our souls in a thorough Fifth Step. We needed someone who is non-judgmental, who will listen without passing pronouncements on our inappropriate behaviours with friends and loved ones. Usually another recovering addict who has worked through Step Five will certainly have empathy and compassion. They will have had their blinders opened and will have a clear idea of the kinds of denial we need to get past in this and the next few steps. They can share with us, gently, the areas we may need to expand our answers on or get honest about.

Just for tonight: I will trust the process and if I don't trust the person who is to hear my Fifth Step, I will take the time to choose someone I do so I can open up and free myself from my past once and for all.

March 31st ko

March 6

"In Step Ten we strive for genuine humility. In this humility we can better interact with others."

Memphis Review Form - page 56,25

A sponsor told his sponsee; "There are two truths that you need to surrender to... 1st, there is a God and 2nd you're not it!" When we make our Higher Power the center of our lives, we tend to live more in humility than not. We are filled with a deep sense of trust that the universe and our lives are playing out just the way they are supposed to at any given moment in time. We have no desire or need to fix things, make things go "our way", heal others, right some great wrongs. We have no white horse to ride off in the sunset today. We can be filled with gratitude and that is the best message we will ever be able to carry to the still suffering addict.

Humility let's us show our heart and inner being to other human beings. This open-heart calls forth the openness in others. It minimizes or eliminates the fear of being subjugated by others or the need to manipulate and control others. It let's us just 'be' ourselves. It lets us drop the games and be real. When we are open to others, they can relax and be open with us.

Just For Tonight: As the Basic Text reminds us: "Humility is as much a part of staying clean as food and water is to staying alive." We can take a moment and think where our lives would be if we had no food and water. This will give us some idea of just how vital living in humility is for a successful recovering life.

Apr 8th, 2016 ko

March 7

“There will be times, however, when we feel like getting off. We want to run, we feel lousy, we need to be reminded of where we came from and that it will be worse this time. This is when we need to Fellowship most.”

Memphis Review Form - page 126, 3

As the Text says; “Honest sharing is the antidote to our diseased thinking” We have learned that it is wise to “rat” on our disease. We tell others what we are thinking and the desire to use diminishes. This is one of the wonderful concepts of recovery. Just by seeking help from others by honestly sharing, our disease no longer has power over us just for today.

If we use during times of stress and hardship or even to celebrate some life event, we don’t learn anything and we often have a ton more problems when we come down. Distorted reality is not a good guide to living! If we reach out, follow direction and not use, just for today, we gain tools that we can use for the rest of our lives. We can ask ourselves, which do I want, more pain, misery, guilt and shame or a killer new recovery tool that will work over and over again in many problem areas of my life? If we can get honest, it’s not a hard choice.

Just for tonight; If I have a desire to act out in unhealthy ways, I will call my sponsor, share it with a recovery friend or take it to a meeting and leave it there. I know I will feel much better if I do that simple thing.

Apr 8th, 2016 k0

March 8

"We hate to be wrong. It is hard to believe that now in our recovery somehow self-will leads us to make decisions based on manipulation, ego, lust or false pride but it happens . . . often."

Memphis Review Form - page 126, 11

We never outgrow our need for personal inventory. One member shared, "Hell, I was willing to go to any lengths just to be right! Well, old Bob killed himself, yes but he was right." sigh. Sounds pretty stupid eh? But the sad part is most of us lived our lives with such thoughts and actions. For many of us, we were shamed a great deal in early adolescence. We told ourselves, once we found out how to be cool, that we would never let anyone get us like that ever again grrrr!

As the literature so aptly states: "We no longer need to stand up for non-existent virtues". When we came to recovery our insides were so raw from years of unhealthy living that we had to put up a huge front so at least "we" wouldn't feel the pain of being less-than everyone else. We had often destroyed all our relationships and pushed most all our loved ones out of our lives. Reality was not looking very pretty to us so we built a world in which we could feel comfortable in. We where Billy Bad-Ass, Mr. Handsome or the Princess. For some, we were just happy, as one member said it, to be "the man" who sits next to "The Man!" don't you know.

By the time we get to recovery, for most of us, we are just too tired to play anymore. We become willing to admit that we don't know it all and in fact we no longer have a desire to anymore. We are content with learning a new way of life that does not rely on what others think of us. We are set free. Many of us go looking for a new set of chains straight away! Humility, patience and tolerance are still important tools once we get on our feet!

Just for tonight; In the words of a spiritual leader of our times "free at last, free at last, thank God almighty we are free at last!"

Apr 8th, 2016 ko

March 9

"The Twelve Steps led us to a point of recovery that seemed to make the world change before our eyes, for the better."

Memphis Review Form - page 73, 30

As one member shared: "I stopped using and my family got better, imagine that?" As the literature states: "Everything we know is subject to revision, especially what we know about the truth!" One of the first persons to die from AIDS in our fellowship that we all knew wrote that now familiar line. She understood that it is not life that changes but our perceptions of life.

As we work the steps, we face our resentments in our Fourth Step and probably for the first time in our lives, get honest about our part in the messes we saw and felt that have weighed us down for so long. If we have a resentment, it is coloring our perception of that situation and probably our perception on life in general. If we have the courage to get honest and own our part, we will surely feel a great sense of relief as we let go of issues and positions that have kept us stuck, often for decades. What a relief to be able to face our issues, come clean and get past them to inner peace and true freedom. For most of us, after Step Five, we feel a freedom we had only dreamed possible before working the steps.

Our Twelve Steps have purpose and function after we think we are getting better. We always have room for growth. Deeper surrender and stronger belief will always work to our betterment. Our inventory process along with prayer and meditation will take us further into the world and life of the spirit. There is no end!

Just for tonight: As the old adage goes; "The truth will set you free but first it will piss you off!" I am willing to walk through my old angers and hurts so I can be set free.

Apr 8th, 2016 ko

March 11

"We are not readily angered, frightened, or maddened by greed or lust. "We remember our part in the divine partnership with God and we are more tolerant and patient with other people."

Memphis Review Form - page 56, 26

Once we find recovery and are no longer the center of our universe, we begin to understand that life is not out to get us. That no one is doing us wrong, so to speak. If we can grasp the concept that "life is hard" then we begin to understand that life takes work. As the text says "the sooner we accept our personal responsibilities, just that much faster do we become responsible, productive members of that society. If we stop coming from a place of being a victim, we quickly realize that taking responsibility in every area of our lives brings us the true freedom we always longed for but could never quite achieve.

As one member said: "I just wanted to shoot heroin and have respect." I always wondered why I felt less than and not good enough so I chose to hang with those who lived outside of respectability and called responsible people fools and idiots! I looked down my nose at all those I inwardly admired. Hell, I couldn't hold a job, get up on time each day, raise a family and so on. I told myself that was for squares.

Today we are perfectly ok with being a square. We find enjoyment at being a member of society, something we had dreaded just a few months or years ago. We no longer need to hide in plain site by wearing strange attire or acting like we had inside knowledge and push folks away with ugly stares and mean looks. All we really wanted was to feel a part of and not apart from others and society as a whole.

Just for tonight; I have learned that the road to recovery is paved with personal responsibility in every area of my life with the pay-off as being peace of mind and peace in my heart.

Apr 8th, 2016 ko

March 12

[“Freedom to change seems to come mainly after our acceptance of ourselves.”](#)

[Memphis Review Form - page 78, 18](#)

“Enforced morality lacks the power that comes from a spiritual awakening” as our literature says. For years, family members and loved ones have tried in vain to get us to grow up or to get clean or to stop the insanity once and for all. We even wanted to do these things ourselves but for some reason we lacked the power to do so. Our every attempt at getting our lives together once more was usually short-lived or a complete disaster when we picked up, often completely against our wills. We would scratch our heads in wonder as did those around us who had not completely given up on us like most sane people would after several failed attempts at helping the helpless. We were often just as baffled as they were as we did not understand the true nature of the disease of addiction and that we were caught in its grip.

When we found recovery and began to surrender to the simple suggestions the program has to offer, miracles began to happen in our lives. We began with simple successes like staying clean a day at a time. These days began to turn into months and we began to truly want recovery for ourselves and not just to please our spouses or significant others. One day we wake up and find that the promises of recovery have become realities in our lives. What a joy to wake one day and realize that we truly have stopped using, lost the desire to use and have found a new way of life, wow!

Just for tonight: I will trust the process and surrender my old ways as they got me nowhere. As one member said; “I threw out the code of the streets and exchanged the for the 12 steps and 12 traditions and my life got better!”

Apr 8th, 2016 ko

March 13

“By recognizing the defects in our characters, and letting go of them spiritually, we were ready to have sanity restored to us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 78, 22

Someone once said; “Hell is being separated from our Higher-Power and heaven is when we are connected”. For most of us, our insanity was not so much being out of our minds, it meant we thought the world revolved around us. That it all began and ended with us. We watched the whole world trying desperately in an instant to be what we thought everyone wanted us to be. Now that’s crazy.

What energy it took to be on guard 24/7 so “they” won’t get us. We knew who “they” were but hell we were ready, by God! A little old lady on a bus would sneer at us or even in our direction and we would have a bad day trying to figure out what we did wrong. As one member said: “When folks sneer at me, my first thought is “Heck, I must not know who you think you are, lol, lol, lol”; He is free from others needing to be superior. That is all that is about.

We need not buy into others ill feelings we are free to live in the here and now and don’t have to spend our days wishing we were someone else other than who we are. Once we become ok with ourselves, there are no more buttons for others to push for it is our guilt and shame that allow others to twist us to their liking's or needs.

Just for tonight; As an older member said; “you can’t please all of the people all of the time and if you are, you are probably doing something wrong!”

Apr 8th, 2016 ko

March 14

“After we accept that we created our own hell and that there is a God that wants to help us, we begin to make progress in solving our problems.”

Memphis Review Form - page 64, 22

An older member shared her favorite prayer “whatever is going on in my life, God has it already taken care of.” There is a Japanese Haiku which means a short meaningful poem which says “in the beginner’s mind there are many questions, in the Masters but few.” In other words; if God is the answer, what’s the question.

As we begin to rely on the God of our understanding to meet our needs each day, we begin to find true peace in our lives. When we hit a brick wall in our lives we don’t have to keep banging away at it trying in vain to move it as we are just sure the answer is right on the other side. In recovery we can surrender, knowing the God has a much better and easier solution to each situation. If we but let go of our notions of how things “ought” to be. We begin to see that God’s will most often is much better than the short sighted, short-lived, self-centered vision we are stuck on.

Just for tonight: As the text states in step 11; “God’s will for us becomes our own true will for ourselves. This happens in an intuitive manner that cannot be adequately explained in words”

Apr 8th, 2016 ko

March 15

“Personality change was what we really needed. Change from a self-destructing to a self-affirming pattern of living was imperative.”

Memphis Review Form - page 25, 18

When we were using, a change of any kind of personal nature was the farthest thing from our minds. We were getting and using every day, the only thing we wanted to change was the pain of living, that in many cases, we were unable to clearly see.

It wasn't until we were able to get clean, when it was said to us, that in order to stay clean, all we had to do was pray, go to meetings and not pick up, and change everything in our lives. This was almost too much to absorb at once. After we saw other addicts working the 12 Steps and living the program, we began to see things differently. As our patterns of thought and action began to reflect the values and behaviour of people in the meetings, we could see we too were changing. And you know, it wasn't all that bad. The more accustomed we became, the Program began to look better and better.

The reason we can adapt so quickly to the clean life is we have spent years in confusion and desperation. We experience something called the 'pink cloud' where the new freedom from our chaotic life style and the familiar routines support a good feeling inside. Learning to 'live the Program' gives us an edge that can't be beat. Sometimes we will find ourselves falling away from the new way of life and it may take some honest sharing to 'self-correct.'

(bs)

March 16

"We place our recovery first and our own petty desires and egos last."

Memphis Review Form - page 74, 4

Watching people achieve recovery while those who fought the principles and ideals of N A, we realized the addicts we could identify with were in serious trouble. Inevitably, some of our best friends in the N A program relapsed and died. That's when it all came into focus for us. What we thought was just having fun and cutting up, was seen in its real colors! "Hey, this addiction stuff can kill me!"

At this point we are beginning to see the seriousness of N A! While people come into the program at different levels, care is taken to word our recovery material so that members can understand and benefit regardless of clean time and where they are in working their 12 Steps.

This way, a person who is working the program can benefit from the writing. Personal preference is set to the side and writing groups read and discuss the material to insure it is going to help any addict seeking recovery. In recovery, we filter out ego based thinking and expression for the good of all. We include what each one of us has to say rather than exclude.

We begin to go to meetings daily as we start seeing that it puts our recovery into Turbo Mode. We start seeing even the smallest change in the meetings. We see people lightening us on their program and then we see them go out the door. We see others get more involved and blossom.

We see changes in the N A fellowship start and then spread like wildfire. We hear something for the very first time. Like a person ends their share with "And I am Frank and I am an addict."

Then we go across town the next day and hear the same thing, for the second time. Then we go to a different county and hear it there for the third time. We realize that there is some synergism in NA that cannot be explained. And this can work for the good or bad of N A. (JF/bs)

March 17

"If we keep what we have to share, we lose the meaning."

Memphis Review Form - page 80, 5

When members share in N A recovery meetings a strange thing happens. We recall what we have heard, read or shared in other meetings. This means the meeting, taken as a whole, is like a soup with many flavors! Sometimes our minds will seem to drift off but our ears take in everything. When we stop sharing our hearts and beliefs, the meetings stop working. When we are open to one another, we grow from what we find we have in common.

I was taught that I could say anything I wanted to in a meetings. The idea was that we talk it out instead of using over it. We had a crosstalk rule to insure our moment in the sun of getting it out. That way, we did not have to worry about saying it right, it could be garbled and see still had the safety to say it and thereby not have to use over it. We could complain about the neighbor being a jerk. We could talk about our frustration with the area. We could curse God for not hearing us. There was something very profound about this vocal freedom. It made us somebody in the fellowship. We had rights. We had respect. We had a place at the table.

When crosstalk creeps in, it makes the meeting unsafe to share in. When someone cuts in while we are sharing, we feel belittled and unappreciated. Ours is a strange disease. When people can't share at meetings, they may fall into relapse instead. That's why the rule is there in the first place. No crosstalk. Our predecessors hard won experience revealed this. Cross talk gives some members a chance to play doctor. If what they have to share is that good, perhaps they can say it to the member after the meeting. Some of these problems may carry over from treatment or therapy.

(jf/bs)

March 18

"Words mean nothing until we put them into action."

Memphis Review Form - page 80, 6

Well, maybe words mean something but the quote means that talk is cheap if not acted on. Many of us addicts dodge action because we are afraid it will look silly or subject us to some unkind attention. When we let our Higher Power guide us, we are free to put things that stand out to us into action. Sometimes they work, sometimes not. But the effort is instructive. Fear is a habit we don't let run our lives now that we have new resources to help us.

There was a famous book "I'll quit tomorrow". That says it all. Words mean nothing till we put them into action. In this case, action could be just going to a meeting.

One can never go wrong by going to a meeting. Part of this is because when we need a meeting more than anything else in the world, our brain tells us is that we have no time for meeting attendance, we need to get the laundry done or go look for a job. By knowing that going to a meeting is never a mistake, it gives us the green light to stop, go to a meeting and get centered. We gotta do this. Meeting are our lifeblood, our food and water.

When addicts call us, we must take the call and we must let them end the conversation when they are good and damn ready. They could be contemplating suicide and need us for that small window of human contact. God has given us cell phones, we need to keep them on and pickup. This is NA service work in this most direct form.

Meetings have to hold to a certain general criteria. Lots of times members who come in through treatment will find themselves slipping into what they do in the hospital. This is NA, we have our own ways of dealing with the things that come up in recovery.

(jf/bs)

March 19

"Facing problems is a necessary ability to stay clean"

Memphis Review Form - page 80, 14

Cash register honesty may be important to recovery but so many times we let fear keep us from asking for help. We call other members, that is why they gave us their number in the first place. We call our sponsor and tell them what's bothering us. We take it to a meeting and share honestly so the members in the room can get with us after the meeting. Direct responses are sometimes permitted but we don't want our meetings to turn into group therapy sessions. We also don't trap newer members into trying the 'help' someone with their great ideas. We share experience. We share our strength. And we share our hope.

Once while racing down a mountain road in an RV with no brakes, I yelled to my friend who was driving, "We got a problem". He responded to me, "I don't see these things as problems, I see these as experiences."

The next time I had a flat tire, I told myself, "This is not a problem, it is an experience." It was the experience of having a flat tire on the side of the road."

Someone stopped and helped me and it all turned out good. I learned from this. God did not take me this far to dump me. Things were going to turn out alright. I was favored in God's eyes as I was trying to deliver a clear message of recovery to his other suffering children. I was very, very sincere about this. I would crawl over broken glass to tell a using addict "You never have to use again."

(jf/bs)

March 20

“One way to develop our conscious contact with God is to make up a “gratitude list,” count our blessings and thank our Higher Power for them.”

Memphis Review Form - page 64, 28

This kind of applied spirituality may be new to us. Our discomfort and disease has blotted out our view of reality, selecting only for the negative and unpleasant. That’s why our newfound hope is so surprising. Active addiction removed our hope, bit by bit until there was nothing left.

Gratitude is being consciously thankful for what we have already achieved or secured. It feels good when we are grateful. Many addicts are so disconnected from their feelings, they have to sit up straight and pay attention to be grateful. After a while, it becomes a graceful state of mind for many of our members.

We never forget or minimize our goal of conscious contact with our Higher Power. Whatever spiritual path you follow, all our members are free to follow their own spirituality. Faith and active belief is the best way to keep our recovery moving in the right direction.

(bs)

March 21

"We have only to believe what we see with our own eyes in the transformed lives of other N.A. members. That's all it takes -- an open mind."

Memphis Review Form - page 38, 5

Seeing is believing! All our interaction with other clean addicts reinforces our knowledge and understanding of N A and our processes. Over time, surrender belief and doing away with the habits and peculiar living routines that had move to do with surviving than living make more and more sense to us. N A is a living program based on successful experience with recovery from addiction and extension into a new world of wonder and freedom.

The self-destructive nature of our illness makes it hard to accept good things into our lives. We have to force ourselves to be happy. What? Is this a surprise? Don't you know addiction is a disease of the shadows. It hides in many places. Our fears, our negative projections, our inability to step up to life and demand our share of happiness and goodwill. Getting over the duck and dodge of active addiction is what makes recovery fun!

If addiction runs in families, that means people who are unhappy and see no way out look normal to us. Many times newer members wonder if our happy members were ever lonely, fear-based and ever stuck on stupid? It takes remembering our pain to push us into honesty, open-mindedness and willingness.

March 22

“If we check to make sure that our actions are clearly within the bounds of our Traditions, if we don't represent anyone but ourselves, if we don't dictate to other groups or force anything upon them, and if we take the time to consider the consequences of our actions ahead of time, then all will be well.”

Memphis Review Form - page 102, 3

These three questions make it easy to double check group decisions. Abiding by our 12 Traditions is not an optional thing! We follow 12 Traditions in NA to protect our members and our NA existence. We, as groups of NA members, can find a way to deal with the issues that come up, often when there are changes in who is attending like, whether they are from treatment or members coming in off the street, for instance. Until a member has been clean and active in a group for a while, it may be hard to see the connection between following our Traditions and a trip to the cemetery.

Not one of us is perfect and the ability to make amends frees us to step out on faith and try something new or different. Still, anything new or untried. may or may not work out. In our daily lives, we make changes all the time. Before they put the curves at the end of aircraft wings, an airplane was said to be 'off course' over 90% of the time due to wind and turbulence! Self-correction is a real bonus that comes with our new freedom from the insanity of active addiction. Our lives find benefits from the principles of our 12 Steps and Traditions because principles are spiritual and universal. It takes time for all this to become a working part of our lives. When problems come up in our daily lives, we can think about our Program and sometimes find things we can do to help correct some situation that has gone wrong. There is no way to get 'recovery' without making mistakes and learning to apply the new tools in our lives.

March 23

“The 12 Step of our personal program also says that we should carry the message to the addict who still suffers. This is no coincidence.”

Memphis Review Form - page 102, 26

As we progress to the benefits of recovery, we recall how our surrender make such a big difference In our early recovery. Through helping others, we become a “human plus sign.’ We offer a life giving solution to our situation of pain and endless suffering. Helping others gives us a mental, spiritual and even physical lift right away. We can see ourselves in others. We realize that those who help us do not feel grandiose or .better than us. It is actually the other way around. We are comforted because some of the words we use helping others will apply to us as well.

We call carry the N A message when we meeting someone knew. Being conscious of this, many of us pray on the way or walking into the meeting. The first Step of N A triggers a mini spiritual awakening! In a short time we experience a different level of consciousness whenever we are in a meeting. We learn to be relaxed, active listeners who bring to bear everything they have read, seen or heard concerning N A. So, you have fifteen members in a meeting. Except for a few members who are new, group members have attended hundreds and sometimes thousands of meetings. You get used to caring and by extension, what you want for them is also what we want for ourselves, so this puts in a good position to follow our own advice!

March 24

“All Our groups can do is plant the seed for recovery and bring addicts together so that the magic of empathy, honesty, caring, sharing and service can do its thing.”

Memphis Review Form - page 102, 15

This quote reminds us that our recovery is a God-given blessing far beyond what the mind of mankind can do. Recovery is a miraculous event. Those who work their Steps like their lives depend on it, know what is meant by these words. The disease of addiction affects three levels: the physical, mental and spiritual. The physical is easy, we can feel it. We can feel the mental also but the idea that we are in control can become a serious roadblock. Spiritual knowledge is what grants us real recovery. Many, many members who work their program, go to meetings, read the literature and follow the proven N A Program in all ways but one miss out on the biggest blessing of all: relinquishment, freedom from our human frailty through a supernatural agency called God or Higher Power.

While our sensitivity to the assumptions and pain inflicted by people who think they have a patent on spirituality prohibits our openness to what others think, through our own experience, we know the Higher Power is real and loving. We share our light with others the way we can share light by lighting the candle of an addict seeking recovery in N A.

While the situations that go with empathy, honest, caring, sharing and service can be described, it is the human feeling experiences by an individual that cannot be put into words. The changes in someone bound by fear and negative expectation is indeed magical. It produces changes inside by appealing to something unseen and without physical description.

March 25

"In our past, we were usually irresponsible. After we face ourselves in the inventory Steps, and make amends to others in our amends steps, we can no longer allow other people the "pay our way" for us. We want to serve."

Memphis Review Form - page 74, 10

It is important to remind ourselves that we are making progress. We have been down so long we have to re-conditions ourselves to simple relief from pain or the joy of giving. We approach give and take relationships from a different place inside. Carrying and sharing makes us feel apart of and like we are doing our part to deserve the good things in life. Lack of stress and tension paints a new reality we couldn't reach before.

Working the Steps of N A recovery removes the clouds that limited our vision and restricted our movements! Freedom from active addiction is more than a state of mind, it is a physical, mental and spiritual reality. Sometimes when you've been walking in mud, you find there is still a little more to scrape off. On the road to freedom, we remember where we came from and show our gratitude for a new life clean by continuing to work our program to find out what lies ahead!

March 26

"We know that in doing God's will, our lives will be fulfilled."

Memphis Review Form - page 25, 35

It is one of the quietest yet strongest truths of N A what the Program takes us from insanity and futility to a spiritual awakening wherein we live by spiritual principles and look out for other people. Literally, our life overflows into goodness - not just for ourselves but for all who come in contact with us. There is a real basis for our sadness and despair when we come to N A seeking help. We have had plenty of failure and confusion. Gradually, as we work our Steps, go to meetings and hear others share, we are re-built into what we were meant to be.

It is our dreams, yours and mine, that come true for us. The new understanding of a loving God, freedom from defects and amends with those we have harmed that come from the change inside each one of us. When you take a car to the garage to be repaired, the outside looks the same, but now the car runs of runs better! We are the same. The changes inside our bodies and our minds change the way our parts work and our feelings reflect a new element called 'HOPE.'

With time, our hope may need to be shined up a bit by practicing feeling of gratitude for the many blessings we enjoy. Selfishness and ingratitude help us not at all!

March 27

“For us in Narcotics Anonymous autonomy is also creative freedom. It gives our groups the freedom to act on their own to establish their atmosphere of recovery, to serve their members, and to fulfill their primary purpose. It is this aspect of autonomy that makes it one of our most precious principles.”

Memphis Review Form - page 101, 12

This does not give a group license to violate the principles of the 12 Steps or Traditions. Among the important items of spiritual growth is the ability to sort out common sense. Almost all members visit other areas and travel to distant conventions or gatherings to see if members elsewhere work their Steps and practice the principles of N A the same way their members back home practice them. We call this visiting the ‘greater N A.

Like any freedom, we have boundaries that prevent breaking out in self-will by not considering the effects of our group changes may have on other groups and members. It can really get sticky when conflicting viewpoints resist thoughtful concern and discussion. Sometimes, it is best to just wait until folks settle down. One solution might be to just let the group supporting what may turn out to be ill considered do their thing. Deciding later if it works or now may teach something good to know of something to avoid. We all have time to correct our errors. We call this ‘clean time.’

Freedom always demands responsibility. Being short on freedom, we may have a lot to learn.

March 28

“Not preaching or judging but sharing the experience strength, and hope that comes to anyone who accepts our way of life.”

Memphis Review Form - page 80, 24

In recovery, a new light shines in our eyes. We begin to see the phonies all around us and this helps us in our struggle to get real. It also gives some help with compassion since we can see ourselves reflected in their misery. We have heard for a long time that the secrets are inside. Through N A we find a way to reach for what we lack and plug into a new life. We can't let mere comfort and peace of mind make us lazy and block our way forward. Experience is the past, strength is the present and hope is the future.

March 29

“Today we have feelings of love, joy, hope, excitement, sadness and friendship. Before we were either elated or depressed with very little in between.”

Memphis Review Form - page 25, 24

In recovery we find much of the color and beauty in life is found in the details we used to blow off as unimportant. Going more slowly and thinking things through gives is a chance to see what we have been missing. What breakthrough lies just ahead of us today if we take time to catch it on the fly?

Polynesians have over twenty words for love. They have time to think about it. The more clear our minds and the better our memory, we can find words to address fine variations of meanings to express our feelings. As we can hear and see others better, we can track our own internal dialogues. Recovery allows clarity and the absence of fear helps us understand what's going on around us.

March 30

“Rigorous honesty is the most important tool we have in learning to deal with the past and to live today.”

Memphis Review Form - page 65,9

Like sharpening a knife on a wet-stone, we ‘hone’ our daily habit patterns to re-route our lives into a form that we can live with without having to make amends later on. Honesty appears to have the same root word. The idea of honesty keeps us safe from buying into lies, our own or someone else’s. Even our memories lie because if we were loaded when it happened, how can we trust our shame or guilt based on things that happened when we were out of our minds?

We develop our internal resources as we grow forward in recovery. We learn from other clean addicts, from our literature, from our own experience. We can see trouble coming long before it arrives, in time to change things for the better.

The reactions of people around us when they realize we are being honest come as a surprise to many of us. Generally, even when we have made serious boo-boos, people are just glad to see the situation resolved, especially if they are among those who may be blamed for our wrong-doing!

March 31

"In our groups, we all need to open up first, selfishly, for our own recovery, and later candidly, for the inspiration of the newer members."

Memphis Review Form - page 74, 15

The truth has great power to overcome the phantoms of our minds. Consciousness can give us a clear picture of what is happening when we are not deluded by mind changing drugs. We don't want our new lives to be subject to our moods when we can see quite clearly since we are clean. Going to meetings helped us by being among people like us. We are also helped when we clear away the hypnosis of daily living and remember who we are, what we are and why we go to recovery meetings.

It is embarrassing to make up reasons for our insanity among other clean addicts who know our game. When we tell the truth, it strengthens our resolve to build our new lives on solid ground. Genuine concern for others gets us out of ourselves and into helping others in some way. This selflessness is good for us and helps us get in touch with our true feelings. Don't fake it till you make it. Make it and you don't have to fake it!

(bs)

APRIL

April 1

"The pain of working the program did not seem as great as the pain of addiction, so we surrendered."

Memphis Review Form - page 35, 5

We have often heard one member or another lamenting the hardships of recovery or life on life's terms in general, but how does this compare to the desperation of active addiction?

Perhaps each member might recall the fear, paranoia and degradation experienced while using. It took a monumental effort for most of us to maintain our addiction once our disease had progressed to the latter stages. The sheer number of lies we tried to remember to keep those we loved in the dark about our addiction could wear down even the strongest of wills.

The suggestions of the program seem simple, even easy by comparison. Going to meetings instead of to cop, calling our sponsor or talking with another recovering addict instead of a dealer are all very doable.

April 2

[“We don’t have to be religious. All that is required is a willingness to believe.”](#)

[Memphis Review Form - page 38, 1](#)

It is shocking how easy it is to get the spiritual life, once we are willing. The Narcotics Anonymous program is based upon one of the cornerstones found in Step Twelve that speaks of sharing experience, strength and hope rather than giving advice. We do not tell other members what to do, rather we share what it has been like for us and the hope we have found on our path of recovery. So when a new member first approaches Step Two and the process of coming to believe, rather than attempt to impress our own beliefs upon them, we share ESH and allow the person the respect, dignity, and compassion to come to their own understanding of a Power greater than ourselves, and in their own time.

This is a great leap of faith for the older member as well as the new. The newcomer stepping out, perhaps for the first time, with the initial willingness to be openminded, which leads to the hope that they too can recover, having the solid evidence of others on the recovery path before them. That hope eventually transcending into faith. Whatever our spiritual beliefs, if any, outside the program may be, we all learn to have faith in someone in N.A. that believes in us and wants to help us in our recovery.

Each member has the the right to believe in what works for them, to come to their own understanding of a Power greater than ourselves. Many of our member have various religious, philosophical, non religious views and beliefs. What we all have in common is the spiritual aspect of all beliefs, that we can do together what we could never do alone and that the therapeutic value of one addict helping another is truly without parallel when we focus on our similarities rather than our differences.

We are grateful that regardless of what we believe or do not believe, that we are accepted in Narcotics Anonymous and able to find recovery from the disease of addiction in the company of others like ourselves.

April 3

“Step Ten is worked while the days ups and downs are fresh in our heads.”

Memphis Review Form - page 56, 30

Daily inventory gives us freedom because we can clean up the problems before they expand and involve more people. Mostly, we forgive and forget in our minds - and pledge to not repeat the same mistake! If we have to make direct amends to someone, our fresh experience with surrender gives us internal resources we did not have before!

We sometimes feel relieved of the pressure error brings. Only very rarely does someone feel good about owing an amends. If we are not clear about what went wrong, it is best to talk to someone who knows your situations before jumping the gun and making things worse. .

Many times our inventory has to do with the future, envisioning things that haven't happened yet. This is the wonderful twilight of NA recovery! We can see the future in time to change it! If we are also working Steps 11 and 12, inventory can really help us maintain a reasonable reality setting. Prayer and meditation are powerful Steps and inventory helps us maintain the balance we all need.

April 4

“We become spiritually refreshed and are glad to be alive.”

Memphis Review Form - page 59, 5

We don't sugar coat reality or promise our members that there will be no problems along recovery road. What changes is the way we are inside and the way we react to the happenings in our lives. If you are not spiritually refreshed and glad to be alive, there is usually one or more of the basics that worked for you in the beginning that you have discontinued or forgotten to observe.

The spiritual life keeps us pointed in a direction that feeds us helpful information, a new attitude and people who are there for us when we need them. By not reading literature, going to meetings, calling your sponsor and, oh yeah, not using, we lay ourselves open to attack without warning. That's what a relapse is - an attack on our our new lives.

Hopelessness and despair are always there, waiting around the corner, and come out when we run out of spiritual food and the opportunities that the Program brings to us.

April 5

“Although our heads told us we would never make it, the people in the Fellowship gave us hope by insisting we could.”

Memphis Review Form - page 25, 29

We will find that our hopelessness and despair is always waiting to take over any time we slack up on our prayer and meditation. Spiritual maintenance is what we use to get clean, stay clean and grow spiritually. When we turn our attention to helping others, we change our whole situation. Our concern for others makes a big difference in the way we think and feel.

We can move from despairing and needful to sitting up straight and thinking up ways to encourage someone else. This change is crucial to our new lives. The important thing for us to remember today, is we have to make this change of situation every day and do what it takes to help it come naturally. Close contact with other members gives us a constant source of different ways to handle our approach to life. The change in us makes a change in the way we experience life.

The using life kept us spinning in a soup of circumstances beyond our control. Even if we were basically good people, we became capable of terrible things. We literally couldn't help it when our addiction was running our lives.

April 6

“It isn’t easy, but, if we want to live happily, we have to learn to live ethically, and within our means, facing what we have and what we have not, with honest acceptance and gratitude.”

Memphis Review Form - page 74, 21

Acceptance comes with seeing clearly where we are and what is expected of us. However much or little we have, we can always make ourselves miserable by wanting more. Gratitude is an emotional muscle that responds to exercise. Practicing gratitude gives us strength inside. Getting honest may be a problem.

One member was a working CPA. He was going to file his taxes and was thinking about cheating a bit. It would save him \$50. He ran it past someone in the program and his friend asked him if his integrity was worth \$50. It really put it all in a nutshell, the matter of ethics. Being ethical and moral is worth the price. He says he knows from experience that it doesn’t take much to trick himself into compromising his values!

Another member shared, “I was hanging with a guy with forty years clean, going to meetings and such. I asked him what his definition of honesty was. He replied, ‘Well, I will not perjure myself. I have not signed a court slip since that day, as the people would come in late and leave early and I was swearing under penalty of perjury that they were in attendance at the meeting, indicating, the entire meetings.’”

Nixon had a few minor league guys snoop around the Democratic Headquarters. A night watchman caught them. This destroyed Nixon’s presidency and caused him to resign in disgrace. The interesting part is that nothing would have been gained from their snooping. Do I leave myself hanging out to be arrested for minor activities? Something that would taint my record forever.

April 7

“There are those of us who tried to stay clean without the benefit of “having had a spiritual awakening as a result of those steps,” and they are no longer with us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 59, 11

The Program of Narcotics Anonymous is no joke. It is a set of principles we can live by with good results. Through the years we have seen many members put their program on hold while they took care of ‘more important things.’ Their relationship, their job, their passtimes and hobbies. They failed to realize for us addicts working the N A Program is a life and death matter. Recovery is what makes the rest of our lives possible!

When a close friend relapses, it may provide the kick in the ass we need to get real about recovery again! A spiritual awakening is an impossible goal for most of us. Our general culture does not credit everyday people with the ability to become spiritual adept.

Now, there are those who wind up the N A who are not addicts. A little controlled using convinced and made believers of them and they got back with the program. There are others who stuck with the Program and lived on to better things. The Program is designed to help those who suffer from the disease of addiction and want a new way of life. It is worth noting that the Program does work for non-addicts; it just works faster. The 12 Steps also work for some individuals who have other mental problems. How could be not be fine with that?

Surrendering, coming to believe and turning our life and will over to a Loving God is pretty strong for a good beginning. Going through the inventory process that deals with the things that have been bothering us is also very spiritual. When we have inventory, prayer and meditation in our experience, we really have walked a spiritual mile. Almost all of us have had the problem of assuming a spiritual awakening is some kind of impossible dream. But the real truth is that if you are reading this, it already qualifies you to pursue 12 Step recovery to the new continent of life on the clean side!

April 8

“None of the Steps work by magic. We do not just say the words of the Steps; we live them.”

Memphis Review Form - page 32, 10

Belief in magic was part of our illusions and delusions in our using days. We could convince ourselves of the most unbelievable things. In recovery we learn that we have to work for our achievements. First, we learn the words to the Steps. We hear them repeated in every meeting and their meaning starts to sink in. When we start to work them with a sponsor, they become real to us. They start to make sense and slowly become a part of our lives.

As we progress through the Steps, we learn spiritual principles and incorporate them into our lives because life becomes easier and makes more sense. The more we work the Steps and practice living by spiritual principles, we find ourselves living in the solution and finding self-value.

As we practice the spiritual principles taught by the Steps over and over, they become as natural as breathing to us. We master living in accordance with the will of our Higher Power and our lives become richer and more beautiful. Eventually, going against what we know to be the will of our Higher Power becomes difficult and the pain we get proves we have made a poor choice.

We start to have a light shining through us that is readily apparent to others. We become grateful for this new way of living and want to share it with others. The Steps are not come imaginary sequence that has no basis in reality or nature. The are realer than real and their depth and clarity can only be appreciated by those who live them.

April 9

“Those of us who are consciously working and using the Twelve Steps to recovery in our lives are seldom bothered by gossip. Our lives are lived like “open books,” and really don’t feel like hiding anything, or judging anyone. We no longer feel a need to put up a front, because we are doing the best we can.”

Memphis Review Form - page 74, 23

One member got into the habit of pumping other members for information. He would see a friend and just begin asking questions; what did he make, how much did he pay for his car, did he have a lot of debt. Then he would take this information and share it with other people.

He eventually found that when he approached people, they would pull out their cell phones and pretend to be talking to someone, thus cutting him out. Finally he had no friends. He never figured this out. Eventually he simply faded away from the fellowship.

I had told him I had the flu and it was bad. Later I went to a meeting across town and everyone was surprised to see me. They thought I was terminally ill. When I ask who they heard this from, they replied “Doc”. Then we all smiled as we realized it was just more of Doc’s gossip. He eventually lost all credibility.

As the people moved away from Doc, he simply turned up the volume and began gossiping even more. Finally he relapsed. He would come back around to the meetings loaded but never could get clean again. No one would help him. He had burned his bridges. Even now, there are those who would help him if they could but the first requirement of membership in NA is surrender. Membership doesn’t always come easy, but it is always worth it.

April 10

“The first way in which we carry the message is by staying clean with the help of God and the Fellowship. Our new way of living speaks for itself better than our words ever could.”

Memphis Review Form - page 59, 26

We don't have to sell NA. The pain and desperation of active addiction is enough to make people want a change. Maybe it is a question of values and motivation. If we had to coddle people, it would change our profile from stand up integrity over to slick commercialism. You can't get what we have to offer for any amount of money.

Self-evident recovery is a beautiful thing. The persons in NA have a glow about them. They attract addicts to recovery because the identification is there. Possibly some of our defects help work the miracle the way dirt produces flowers.

Our hope opens the doorway to recovery. Seeing others who remind us of ourselves, we imagine there may be a chance NA will work for us. We have to stop using and surrender to the fact of our addiction, at least on a daily basis. After a short time, we will notice a difference.

April 11

"A warning about rationalization is that it has killed more of us than anything else."

Memphis Review Form - page 57, 1

Many, many members are yet to realize that rationality alone is insufficient for the purposes of a spiritual life. Spiritual is on a higher level than mentality alone.

One member led meetings and when people brought a salad to the noon meeting, he would give them a hard time for not bringing enough for everyone. He thought it was kind of cool to give people a little shit and make them squirm. But there was nothing in the meeting reading about bringing food into the meeting and eventually people got tired of his "joking." See, it was joking to him and being attacked by the brown baggers who left work on their noon hour to come to a meeting. Eventually all the working people quit coming to his noon meeting and then it consisted of just brand new people without jobs.

He had rationalized his attacks as being very subtle humor designed to bring him closer to those he was attacking. The theory was, I suppose, that if he could make you squirm, it was ok cause you were such good buddies and that's what good buddies do. In Narcotics Anonymous, some members just love to excoriate others due to poor social skills. The tv show song goes "Welcome back Cotter. We love him a lot so we put him on the spot, welcome back, welcome back, welcome back". Theory being, if you are really really close to someone, then you have the right to insult them as no one else could do and it would be ok, you get a pass.

This happens in NA but the attacked sees it as just that, an attack. While the attacker sees it as some sort of strange bonding process enabling the hapless sap being attacked as some sort of long lost friend when they really never knew him that good in the first place. Maybe it just manifestation of poor social skills on an NA level. We must understand that we can never say please and thank you too often. We can never be too kind and considerate. We are all trying to bond and we need to send a message of friendship loud and clear.

A group of people used to congregate around the meeting hall entry way and heckle those arriving. But we do not know what state of mind the new arrivals are in. Think about it, when you get into the car and go to the meeting hall, it could be that you are in trouble and are looking for some support ASAP. The dog could have died, you got fired, Mom died or you got a letter from the IRS. We have no idea of what that person is going thru.

April 12

“ We read this book and attend N.A. meetings. We see for ourselves if the Fellowship has something to offer us. It is not where we are that counts, but where we are going!”

Memphis Review Form - page 32, 14

We start to realize we are on a journey of recovery that will be a life-long trek of discovery. Changing, growing and learning becomes pleasurable to us and we look forward to the next day's developments. The process of ongoing self-examination may begin to occur before we realize what is happening. It is a new thing, this being excited rather than worried as we start each new day.

Often others will notice changes in us before we do and surprise us with their insights. Upon reflection, we realize we are no longer who we were and we like who we are becoming. We are afforded glimpses of what we might become in our deepening friendships with long-timers who have infinite patience, humility and joy in their lives. This becomes our dreams and goals, to live happy, joyous and free. Serene in the love of our Higher Power and the new people in our lives.

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From the beginning we are encouraged to get in touch with our inner being, this is the being we lost touch with when addiction took over our lives. It put the answer out there, somewhere, not here where we are. Slow down, pay attention, practice being good to people until you learn to be good to yourself!

April 13

"Those of us who do service work are the luckiest people on God's earth!"

Memphis Review Form - page 61, 2

Service is an expression of gratitude. We are truly grateful for the wonderful gift of recovery. We consider it a privilege to give nameless, selfless service to Narcotics Anonymous. Whether we help a newcomer, make coffee, sponsor someone, bring a meeting to a shut-in, serve as chairperson for a meeting, become a trusted servant for area, region, H&I, phone lines or other positions, we consider ourselves lucky. By working the Steps have learned the joys of living in the present in accordance with spiritual principles.

Doing for others, we learn all we need to know to treat ourselves with affection and genuine respect. The world begins to lose its hold on us and we learn to pray as we go through life. We can admit fault and ask for help. We don't have to have all the answers. We fit in with others, we don't have to dominate. We can be a part of humanity.

Luck comes from being aware and awake. The answers are often printed large on billboards if we go slow enough to read them. While many believe totally in karma, what comes around, many find that God is ready when we are. If God is in all of us, surely God would want to be comfortable in our house!

April 14

"We often miss what we are looking for because it isn't hidden."

Memphis Review Form - page 80, 8

It may take us a while to surrender enough to get this, but lots of things in life are not hard. We make them hard by trying too hard. Relaxing and calming ourselves changes dramatically the way others see us. If we exhibit tension and fear of things going wrong, others pick up on that. They would much rather interact with someone who is straight up and carries no air of negative anticipation.

One of the discoveries we may stumble upon is we just pray for something with positive expectation and let it come to us. We still stay active and meet our obligations but if there are unforeseen obstacles, getting what we want may be out of order and create problems we cannot foresee. A truly loving God would not want this to happen. Our minds and mental habits are set in a pattern established before we got clean. If we continue to surrender, it sometimes makes it easier to accept and be grateful for what comes our way. It is ok to hold out for good things in the future and what we find ourselves doing on a daily basis may well lead to that pleasant outcome.

The oldtimers used to always tell us "Don't leave before the miracle happens." The self-destructiveness of our addiction perpetuates the idea that life is hard and the odds are rigged against us, like a casino. Real casinos are rigged by human beings for self-gain. Our lives are under our control but first we have to learn how to drive! The telephone polls and sidewalks are not out to get us. We learn to keep it between the curbs. Our thinking and expectation may play a larger role than we have been told by people who didn't know better!

April 15

“Our lack of fear and our new found faith serves as a firm foundation for courage in the future .”

Memphis Review Form - page 65, 13

One member owed the IRS \$800,000 and he found another member that owed them \$1,000,000. The two became friends and both eventually resolved their problems.

No matter what the problem, we can solve it with HP's help. How do we eat an elephant, “One bite at a time”.

And we need to take a break once in awhile. We go to the movies, camp out in meetings or go to our favorite healing places. This rejuvenation process can boost us into the project at hand with turbo charged energy and laser focus.

When we focus on one item, we are unstoppable. When we disperse our focus, we waste time and get little done.

April 16

“Those of us who have relapsed found the true progression the disease that plagues us. To know and come to understand that there is a Power greater than ourselves desiring to have a relationship with us, in spite of our faults, comforts us all.”

Memphis Review Form - page 127, 10

The disease of addiction sometimes paints pretty pictures of our using days. Relapse brings all that to a screeching halt. The insecurity, the distrust we have for our mental processes, confusion, uncertainty, physical symptoms, negative projections - we don't go through a grace period. Our active addiction cut deep grooves in us that further using quickly fills to the brim.

If we have had any relief from our addiction in recovery, we remember the calmness which began to fill each of our days and the feeling we got around the members who loved and understood us. The beauty of a day at a time. The feeling we had greeting a newcomer at their first meeting. Even if we were very new, we began to associate these feelings with a higher power.

In addiction, progression insures whatever is bothering us will get worse if we use. Usually, whatever is bothering us just dries up and goes away on its own! Conscious contact is better than having a genie in a bottle! Ask your Higher Power for help and it is amazing how things work out.

April 17

“The program doesn’t work when we adapt it to our life, we have to adapt our life to the program.”

Memphis Review Form - page 80, 34

The feeling that something isn’t right, that nothing we did turned out right was a very accurate feeling. Addicts often confess that they lie out of habit. That they expect things to go wrong for them. Well, honesty has to be learned and is one of the areas that turns up quick results in our new lives but goes on forever. The reason we fit into life so quickly when we get clean, is because we lose all the bumps that stick out from us and get us into trouble! They are like thorns that poke out and when others feel pain, they retaliate.

The world we see is not necessarily all there is. There are many things that don’t exist for us because we are conditioned not to see them. Sometimes, as our minds and personalities grow, we are surprised by opportunities and agreeable people all around us. Some of us think that we can’t see what we can’t accept inside. When we learn through a process of positive experiences that we can trust ourselves and rely on our ability to stand tall in situations where we used to fail all the time.

If the Program is honesty, openmindedness and the willingness to try, and that is how we learn to cope with things that come up in our lives, it becomes easier to see how adapting can benefit us. We are taught not to be too hard on ourselves because it takes time and application to adapt to the new life we have chosen.

April 18

32, 18 None of us stumbled into this Fellowship brimming with love, honesty or open-minded willingness. ”

Memphis Review Form - page

Most of us actually showed up at our doors brimming with degradation, isolation and loneliness. We probably covered up our feelings and considerate members didn't need to ask. We know what it takes to come to that first meeting!

With that fear, we needed to see how simple it could be using N A as a means of fulfillment. Instead of the shooting galleries we used to frequent, NA gives us choices. We go to meetings, call members, hang out together and realize we are never alone.. Not near as stressful in 'our' rooms, we begin seeing a little more clearly. We see members laugh, have fun and genuinely care for us and want to help us. This hope gives us a clarity not seen in many years. We find that someone loves us even when we feel out of control. And with this new found hope we begin pushing the isolation out and away from us.

By hearing the Steps and Traditions read and studied at every meeting we attend, we start to feel some willingness. The other readings fill in the blanks for us. It just begins to sink in. Our hearts recognize the honesty we hear and we start to want to be honest ourselves.

April 19

"The willingness to try new ideas and possible solutions will help open the door to our recovery."

Memphis Review Form - page 80, 26

Our recovery is our on doing. While NA can share information on how it works, we are the ones who surrender, come to believe and allow a loving God to run our lives. Staying clean from drugs, old friends and old ways, make a big difference but it is we who do the footwork. This becomes important when our disease tries to take over and discount all the wonderful things recovery brings us because it can force us to focus on some perceived imperfection or imperfect person. Since we work the Steps, we are entitled to the goodies. We tell ourselves, "Go back to sleep disease!"

Ideas contain various approaches to life that may work for us. All our willingness does is let us try them on for size. If they don't work so well, we set them aside for the time being. But just being open doesn't force us to accept them if they don't work! Some have to wait their turn, they can't work until we have made progress in some other area. That's ok, at least we know they are available and that's about all we can ask from a brief look-see.

There are a great many things in reality and it takes time to try them out. We wouldn't want a job at the bank if we weren't good with numbers or had problems with cash-register honesty. Recovery is no joke! It is the real thing! And while it may make it easier to be around us now that we are in recovery, we are the first to benefit - inside!

April 20

"We have defects, but a willingness to live as our Higher Power would have us is freedom."

Memphis Review Form - page 57, 8

Freedom is slavery unless it rises from within. As the fog of active addiction falls away through disuses, we find ourselves stepping out on new ground. Some of our virtues are going to turn out to be defective as we work our 12 Steps and view them in the light of our recovery. Some of our defects are going to mutate into assets!

Being humble and somewhat ashamed of the way we used to do is to be expected, but the real defects keep us from seeing the world and our lives as they really are. Living according the faith we have chosen to guide us will allow us to benefit from those who have gone before us, in recovery or in our new beliefs.

Sometimes recovery is like walking down a corridor with other people all around us. We are correct to think we are protected by their clean time and recovery experience. In time and through practice, we will come to know what they know through our own successful experience.

Freedom is actually free because it comes from doing the right thing, the right way, at the right time. We pay the price for things as we generally don't miss the price we pay. The clean life gives us resources we never had. We see and hear more clearly. Our thinking is better. We can admit fault or ask for help if we don't understand. The Program gives us people like ourselves who have walked out mile before us in a thousand ways.

April 21

"In working the Steps we need to come to depend on a Power greater than ourselves. We continue this relationship and utilize it for our Group purposes. If we each turned our will and our lives over to His care and seek to do his will, he will express Himself on a group level."

Memphis Review Form - page 93, 14

Sometimes things just go wrong. Maybe somebody thought they were praying for strength and guidance but had a belief system that made reliance on God a risky business. How could we know? We can only do the best we can on an individual basis with the understanding that we will honor our commitment to serve and cover the shortfall if anything goes wrong. This is what it means to say "Our Program" and mean it!

Believe it or not, there are people in NA who do not understand group conscience. They may think it is group opinion or hearsay. They may not know enough about our history as a Fellowship to know that addicts writing the Basic Text worked hard to look up words in the dictionary, discuss all things until a clear path appeared to them and actually asked group members specific questions on motions in the CAR before voting at the group, area and regional level. Without this system of informed members, NA would be flying blind!

They also found and wrote into the literature and structural guidelines the importance of having a group prayer before sessions in which there might be voting on issues before their service body. Without this spiritual process, we would be at the mercy of bureaucrats who think they know what's best for us. N A by the members, for the members, is the only real spiritual Fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous. All else is not N A.

April 22

"Meetings provide a safe place to share with others during this time. Many members whose recoveries have blessed them tell us that they continue to attend meetings on a daily basis even after several years of clean time."

Memphis Review Form - page 123, 1

We never get so much clean time that we lose our need for recovery meetings. Some of us are blessed with lives where we continuously talk, visit, host and travel within N A. Some of us can recall thinking, "This disease can kill me and all my dreams with it. I better get to more meetings, only to look up from the highway and realize we are driving in the middle of the night to a three day N A convention in a favorite recovery community. Back home, we still get to meetings if we want to stay clean. Recovery is the shore and the meetings are our life boats.

Getting used to being with people who love and understand us is essential to recovery. They can help us, whatever we are going through. Their trials and tribulations inspire us to go the extra mile in recovery. It is amazing to see hard core dope fiends behaving like civilized human beings. It is clear that we learned how to live from people who did not know how to live. So, whatever we missed, we have to get through the meetings. Home groups take it a step further because participating in group business meetings we learn how to conduct ourselves in an orderly manner. In many cases, a home group is the only honorable association they have had in their lives!

Long term associations take us deeper and deeper into our new lives. We have friends who have been doing better for a long time. They know about good jobs, owning houses and dealing with life beyond desperation.

April 23

"The experience gained with time insures our ongoing recovery. We must use what we learn or we will lose it and probably relapse, no matter how long we have been clean."

Memphis Review Form - page 123, 13

Addicts are prone to egotism and we need to be constantly aware of our built in self-will if we are going to survive. Such humility helps with our surrender. It is our surrender that helps us be open-minded and prayerful. Most of us seem to take the 'easy' days for granted. It may stop short of really thinking, "We can take it from here!" but the yearning to fall back into the old ruts still beckons. Experience tells to take it one day at a time and fill in the blanks helping others.

"If you stop pedaling, the bicycle falls over." This humble phrase covers so many situations it spells out what happens when addicts get proud and take recovery for granted. You are better and have earned the esteem of others because you are not longer staggering around trying to get through a day! Be grateful you're in the Program. We laugh about the stupid stuff that goes through our minds at times. The same stuff that could kill us if we kept it inside.

It has taken the last forty or fifty years to get N A members with forty or fifty years. People still relapse after all that time and they still die using if they push away the principles and ideals that brought them so far. There are pressures today that did not exist thirty-five years ago when NA really began to grow! Our disease doesn't offer a grace period when we relapse, it lulls us into erroneous thinking and takes away our internal resources so it can bust us in the chops. An addict alone is still in bad company.

April 24

“The group we choose to be our home group will be like a spiritual savings account. The more we can invest in it through our care and sharing, the greater the dividends it will pay.”

Memphis Review Form - page 123, 25

We must invest in our recovery. We need to put in time, energy and money to our recovery. Some people give thousands and thousands to their church every year. N A is our sanctuary.

Part of giving is providing for our meeting places but another important part is giving till it hurts. Giving until our giving inconveniences us a little bit. Until we reach this point, it may not be real to us. We skip visits to Starbucks. We have a garage sale. We work a side job. Our lives and recoveries are important too.

One member bought a \$37 dollar Igloo cooler for iced tea when it was needed at a Unity Day. At each event he saw his \$37 gift serving the fellowship. It was hard to glorify using and look at his sacrifice to the Fellowship at the same time. He stayed clean and now has many, many years and still sees that worn old Igloo cooler at events. It still bears his magic marker “Ice Tea” inscription from years earlier.

We must give till it hurts once in awhile for it to register with us that we are willing to go to any lengths to stay clean.

April 25

“Remember we’ve don’t recover overnight. When we realize that we have made a bad decision or bad judgment, we make an attempt to rationalize it. We become extreme in our self-righteous attempts to cover our tracks.”

Memphis Review Form - page 126, 14

Learning how to ‘catch ourselves’ is a big part of recovery. Personality change is necessary, not optional. As we become accustomed to the recovery process, we sort of relax in the saddle and sometimes this opens the doorway to our past behaviors. Each time we do this, we embed our chosen way of living and pave the way to a new life clean!

Helping others helps us realize our flaws are not that big a deal unless we act on them. To us recovering people, they are a gentle yet convincing argument for living a new life. It is not like the old ways got us what we wanted! They got us in trouble, into courtrooms, into jail cells. Hey, we don’t have to live that way anymore. Seeing what our newer members go through really helps us surrender and renew our commitment. We can identify with them and recall some of the foolishness we pulled when we were new.

Oh, and how embarrassed we were when we messed up. Clean, we can see the unwanted side effects of road rage, shoplifting, rationalizing why we do certain things. Now that we are clean, they really don’t make any sense. We are clean and see, hear and feel better than we used to. .

April 26

“There is something in our self-destructive personality’s big cries for failure. It permeates our total being – “You do not deserve to succeed.” We have all experienced this and without the knowledge that we finally have earned the right to be responsible, respectable members of society. The manner in which we returned to our addiction is not important. What is essential to each of us is that we have the choice not to continue.”

Memphis Review Form - page 126, 34

When we immerse ourselves in meetings, this cry for failure is eliminated. We see new people with three days clean who are elated. We see people who have landed a good job. We see people who finally got their own place after couch surfing for months. This is the reality of NA. Many of us slept on couches and floor, or in our cars, when we first got clean!

The failure syndrome grows in the dark. It grows when we are absent from the meetings. Some experienced members believe that most addicts simply do not attend enough meetings and therein lies the problem.

Our literature says that we attend ‘90 in 90’ and watch our lives change. But this promise is renewed every quarter. Four times a year our lives can change. The ‘90 in 90’ miracle does not apply just to the first 90 days clean. This concept is not to be found anywhere in our written literature.. In fact, some would maintain that the growth become greater as time goes on. The second ‘90 in 90’ may very well yield more growth than the first and so on. Meetings are a very, very powerful motivator and success builder. They get us out of the house and marking stuff off that to do list. They get us applying for jobs. They are energy pills. Maybe we should ask ourselves just how far we want to be from the polar bear that wants to eat us?

Never underestimate the power of going to just one more meeting that day. The oldtimers can be found burning up meetings with a vengeance and a regularity that would shame train schedules. “Meeting makers make it,” is not a new idea. It is said for a reason. Give yourself a break and try increasing your meeting attendance and see if things get better.

April 27

"We've made a lot of bad decisions and pawned them off as Group conscience. This worries many of us. How can we really tell if our decisions are really Group conscience or not, and how do we prevent painful mistakes?"

Memphis Review Form - page 94, 14

Easy answer: we can't! All we can do is work our program to the best of our ability. There are many choices involved with N A membership. We chose our friends and sponsors. We choose our home group. These choices sort out where we go and who we spend time with.

This takes care of many problems in a quiet and natural manner. Egos, personal preferences, and honest mistakes insure we will have some problems. Hey, when we are clean, we can handle most things that come up in a group so long as we follow our Traditions.

One trouble is many of us don't know when we are violating the letter or spirit of a Tradition. We stay away from the law of the land because outsiders, however well intended, cannot be expected to know our Program or understand our ways. We avoid affiliation for the same reason. When we are really focused on recovery and helping others, it takes up enough time and energy to keep us out of trouble.

(bs)

April 28

"It is very important to keep sharing with other people, so that when we come up with a rationalization for negative behavior, we can be told about it."

Memphis Review Form - page 57, 19

One of the things we can't forget is that we have trouble being objective with ourselves. Sharing in meetings, we let others know about our strengths and weaknesses. It is like a personality filter that cleans out patterns and echos from our active addictions. Newcomers need meetings for learning our terminology and mindset - persons with longer clean time get the help they need in meetings on the level that is appropriate for them.

Most members are very aware how painful and frightening it can be to discover certain aspect of our personal beliefs and behavior are flawed. Sometimes they are just surprised. Remember, habit patterns are just a part of our mental landscape until we can see how they may upset others. Often our fellow members are aware of our flaws long before we find out about them. They exercise patience and tolerance thinking of those who helped them come to terms with their inventory items. The 12 Steps guide us through a series of processes prior to getting down to brass tacks with inventory. We surrender, come to believe, turn our life and will over to achieve the fearless state required to write a list and share it.

The relief we feel often prods us to go deeper because we realize we don't have to be the way we were when we were out of our minds! It would just be pitiful if we had to be right all the time. What a joke! Nobody's perfect and our program is very good at helping people of all sorts.

April 29

"We have seen that we try to rest authority in the spiritual conscience of the group. In keeping with this, we make a special point of trying to prevent authoritarian leadership. We have learned that for our Fellowship, leadership by example and by self-less service works, and that direction and manipulation fails."

Memphis Review Form - page 94, 31

This is where clean time and experience comes into play. Without clean time or experience, all we can offer is opinion and personal projections. Perception is based on projection because that is what we know best. There is a need to have those who have gone before us to share what they have seen work in practice and what leads to trouble..

The old NA teaching model was based upon English craftsman guilds. Here a child was sent to a workhouse and learned under a master. The child was mentored by the older man. NA calls these roles 'sponsor' and 'sponsee.'

The sponsors used to state that they owned us. One was expected to do whatever the sponsor requested without question. It was quite Zen like in nature. Lessons were taught thru simple tasks and assignments. There was always a bigger picture in the background.

As the sponsee grew, he was then allowed to sponsor. But he would go to his sponsor when he got stuck. Having a strong grand sponsor was a feather in one's cap. Large sponsorship families evolved and large sponsorship picnics were held with a picture being taken of everyone and then being silk screened on a T shirt for each person.

Each sponsorship family had its own flavor. We became relatives with each other in a sense. If you were a great, great, great grand sponsor of someone, they had the right to come to you if their sponsor was not giving them what they needed. There was a lot of up and down communication, many parties and gatherings of parts of these large families.

April 30

““The main thing this Step [Step Nine] does for us is to build awareness that, little by little, we are gaining new attitudes about ourselves, and how we deal with other people.””

Memphis Review Form - page 52, 21

Many of us find a bonus in the Ninth Step when we avoid situations where amends might be needed at a later date for what is happening in the present. It is easier to get real and be honest in the present tense than to carry bad feelings in the past tense. And it seems to be a principle that when we move one way, we free ourselves in the other. So a little relief leads to more relief and more relief frees us from the shame and guilt that has been chasing us all along.

Clean, we do better and have less to regret or feel shame and guilt over. Probably, this increasing distance makes it easier to single out events where we feel we owe amends to the other people involved. Amending things that bother us frees us to go forward with a clear conscience. It may be important to realize the very fact of feeling badly shows a degree of morality that emerges as we move up the recovery scale from active addiction to real freedom, the fullness of being. .

One important aspect of our making amends where they are due, is that we will make a mark in our behavior to prevent repetition of the mistakes we have made in the past. Also important is the power of recent good memories against the power of bad memories moving further into the past. Helping others, being good to yourself, following a spiritual path, gives us growing internal resources that help us face each day anew.

MAY

May 1

“Am I being drawn in by some pattern of fear and resentment?”, Am I too tired “ “Am I too hungry?” “ Is my thinking getting cloudy?” It’s a vaccination against insanity on a continuing basis.”

Memphis Review Form - page 57, 23

In other words, personal, daily inventory is a vaccination against insanity. When in active addictions, we controlled our mental state with drugs. Today we are clean and take responsibility for our actions and make choices as to how we will be. Being clear headed makes a big difference! As we get better at monitoring ourselves including our thought processes, the less we need to act on our impulses. In NA, we learn from other members, meetings and recovery writings. Prayer and meditation enlarges the world we live in on a daily basis.

We allow our sponsors and friends to mentor us and help us find the way that best suits us. We get to become the persons we wanted to be all along, in many cases. A vaccination is much more acceptable than a week or two of flu! We learn to see things with new eyes. Patience, tolerance and willingness gives us internal resources to make is easier to cope with life on life’s terms.

It seems a vaccination gives us the illness we want to avoid in a weakened state and our bodies produce antibodies that specifically go after the target bacteria. So, we get a little taste of healthy selfishness in time to say, “Hey, wait a minute. That’s not how I want to be!” When we don’t say something or act out of fear or jealousy, we don’t have to take it back. Regaining our power of choice, we are able to change the future by changing our minds. This is the reality of spiritual growth. We change things in the world by changing things inside.

May 2

“Those of us who have relapsed found the true progression of the disease that plagues us. To know and come to understand that there is a Power greater than ourselves desiring to have a relationship with us, in spite of our faults, comforts us all.”

Memphis Review Form - page 127, 10

Most of our notions of a loving God change as we grow in recovery. Right from the beginning, feel the relief we have been seeking. Wherever we start from, we grow from there. We may not be sure what is difference but we can feel it. Hearing and studying recovery and learning from what other addicts share in meetings, we come to see parts of a new life of the spirit.

The prospect of having a relationship with a positive Power greater than ourselves can be scary. Pain brought on by beliefs that let us down makes us gun-shy and careful. Many turn back and only come to believe later in recovery. The sooner you can honestly make the decision in your 3rd Step, the better for you. But the part we eventually notice is where it says, “We made a decision to turn our life and will over to the CARE of ...” It is the ‘caring’ that allows us to give it a try.

Knowing can come is a flash. Coming to understand involves getting over past beliefs and learning new possibilities including the care and relief we have already received, even if we were not so nice.

May 3

“Some of us reach a point of complacency in recovery. If we stay at this level for long, the recovery process ceases and we begin to backslide. Clean time in the program acts as insurance. If complacency is not acted upon the disease begins to manifest apparent symptoms in us. Denial returns along with obsession and compulsion.”

Memphis Review Form - page 127, 22

If recovery is like eating cake at a table among friends who like us, a relapse is like a slap in the back of the head when we are not expecting it! Complacency can sneak up on us when we forget gratitude and the practices we learn from other members. It is so easy to forget where we came from and what it felt like to be without hope. Relapse happens long before we pick up.

Obsession is losing control of our thinking and obsession is losing control of our actions. Denial is like a dark veil that shields us from reality and makes it possible to remember only the good times. Many members compare complacency with a 'sliding slope' where by the time realize we are falling, we cannot stop. Warning: it begins with little acts of selfishness and egotism.

It may be that our disease is like a fluid that begins to fill our cup when we stop working our NA 12 Steps. When the cup is filled, it overflows into a bowl and when the disease reaches the top, we relapse. We have to give it away to keep the bowl filling. Asking for help, going to meetings, helping someone struggling with their program bleeds away the disease in the bowl of our life and soon our cup once more fills with joy and gratitude! We look at our cup and it is now filling again - this time with coffee! We look around us and we are no longer alone. We are among a group of recovering addicts.

May 4

“Meetings are a healing source. Writing about what we want, what we are asking for and what we get and sharing this with our sponsor or another trusted person helps us to work through those feelings, and letting others share with us about their experience gives us hope that it does get better.”

Memphis Review Form - page 128, 7

We addicts know more than anyone the pain and confusion to straps us down when we are ready to seek recovery. We do everything possible to make our meetings available and congenial. We set out coffee and condiments, sometimes cookies. Our rooms are comfortable, some even provide candlelight to make easier to share the pain in our hearts.

This is why we have no outside affiliation, no surveillance and a clear message in our group format. Being a part of a group steering committee is sometimes the most honorable position we have held. Anything we can do to make a newer member comfortable and supported is the second most important way we carry our message of hope and recovery! The first is being clean ourselves and paying attention that we adhere to the truth.

Along with social ineptitude, the drug-induced cloud prevents us from thinking effectively. Asking the three questions in the quotation consciously may help us get the answers we need to guide us. Frequently, the questions involve straightforward stuff like: “I want a job that pay enough money for me to live on.” We may be surprised to learn you cannot sleep on the job or steal tools if you want to keep the job! The connections between our actions and the results of our actions allows us to monitor our progress. We can’t change until we see the need for change.

May 5

"We want to get free of our fear, but we don't wish to do so at the price of anyone."

Memphis Review Form - page 52, 25

We do not want to create more difficulty and pain for others. We cannot push away our own embarrassment and disgust at the way we were living, while making new problems for others. That would only lead us back to feeling self-destructive about ourselves.

Instead, we move forward on a daily basis making amends as needed. Others see us as a different person. Without the fear, we find new motivation from the good feelings that come with raising our heads and examining the roles we are playing. We want to make sure we are not leaving damage behind us while we think we are going forward.

We build our new lives on solid ground by working our 12 Steps in order. Surrender, Faith, relinquishment - all three put us on a different path, the path of recovery. Acknowledging our defects, we are losing the hold they had on our lives. Through willingness and prayer, we ask that these defects be removed. With the barriers out of the way, we list and address our amends so we can walk down any road in life. .Inventory keeps us from rationalizing our faults when we get into prayer and meditation. We want our spiritual awakening to be real. We base our lives on following God's plan for us and practicing spiritual principles and carry our message of hope and recovery.

May 6

"We have discussed the preventative side of Tenth Step.. The love was there all the time, waiting for us to accept it."

Memphis Review Form - page 57, 27

For most all of us, we grew up without a lot of love. Or maybe there was love and we just could not feel it. It wasn't the love we were looking for or that we thought we needed to survive. Or maybe the love was in the form of teasing and bullying. Our friend's past on the sick type of love they got at home and in their own warped way, they thought they were helping us to feel like we were one of the gang. We were so loved starved that many of us accept a great deal of belittling and bullying just to feel like we belonged somewhere. The bullying is supposed to show it is ok to kid one another. We may even be in these types of relationships today with an abusive spouse or partner or we may be staying in a sick home life feeling we have nowhere else to go. We may felt trapped by life's circumstances with no way out.

In recovery we find one true friend, a sponsor and we put our faith and trust in them. For some, that is the best we can do in the beginning. We know in our heart of hearts that we have no business running the show so we must get direction from outside of ourselves. This small act of faith will grow and grow until we find ourselves surrounded by an entire world wide fellowship of folks that love us unconditionally.

Just for tonight: I will put my trust into this fellowship without reservation. I know that if I allow one NA member to love me today it is enough.

May 7

“Some of us reach a point of complacency in recovery. If we stay at this level for long, the recovery process ceases and we begin to backslide. Clean time in the program access insurance. If complacency is not acted upon the disease begins to manifest apparent symptoms in us. Denial returns along with obsession and compulsion.”

Memphis Review Form - page 127, 22

Our founder wrote “we know well what makes true addiction, obsession and compulsion. Obsession, that fixed idea that takes us back time and time again to our drug of choice or some substitute to recapture the ease and comfort we once knew.” Ain’t that the truth sister and brother! We have found that most NA members switch their obsession to drugs to one of our favorite substitutes: sex, sugar, over eating, gambling, road rage or compulsive spending.

The best line ever written about working Steps is at the beginning portion of Step one in the Step Writing Guide which states; “if we have been compulsive in some other area of our lives, we need to stop the acting out so our minds are not filled with using before we start working this Step.” Wow, wow, wow! No wiser words have ever been written about addiction. Knock it off! Whatever it is, pornography, credit card debting, lusting after newcomers, over eating. We need to surrender first as only then can we move forward into the solution.

Just for tonight; I am sick and tired of being sick and tired of being sick and tired. I will surrender my behavior and share about it with my sponsor or home group. I will choose freedom today.

May 8

“Meetings are a healing source. Writing about what we want, what we are asking for and what we get and sharing this with our sponsor or another trusted person helps us to work through those feelings, and letting other share with us about their experience gives us hope that it does get better.”

Memphis Review Form - page 128, 7

The magic of writing in recovery cannot be understated. For some reason when we think about pain in our lives or in our past we tend to have a quick rationalization method in place for not truly feeling the feelings. This denial is often a healthy part of our minds, keeping us from too much pain at one time but it can be a huge hindrance as well, keeping us in denial most of our lives. By asking God's help and letting our fingers do the talking, we tend to get to the truth of the matter. It's very hard to lie to ourselves in black and white, it just looks like what it is, another story that really doesn't add up?

By writing about our lives, we come to know the truth, the whole truth and nothing but the truth. When we write our inventories, the truth keeps coming out over and over and over again. This is how we begin to see patterns in our lives. This is where our character defects and the exact nature of our wrongs is revealed so we can work on them in Steps 6, 7, 8 and 9.

If the feelings are a bit too heavy, we can go to a meeting and share them so we can push on to complete our inventories and find true freedom from our defects. In meetings we will get healthy feedback from others when they share how they dealt with similar difficulties while writing their steps or dealing with similar wreckage from their past. One thing we have learned is that addiction and recovery are universally the same around the globe. We can find the answer anywhere if we are but willing to look for it.

Just for tonight: I will push on with my Step work. If I am stuck I will go to a meeting and share about it. I now in my heart that the Steps will set me free!

May 9

“Spirituality and sharing is the essence of their recovery. Keeping our illusion of reality rather than using the tools of the program and the people in the Fellowship will return us to isolation.”

Memphis Review Form - page 129, 4

When we first come to meetings the last thing we want to do is open up in a room full of people! We have been living a life of deep dark secrets which we thought nobody knew about. Of course they knew! One of things we have learned about addiction is that by the time we see using as a problem it has been very evident in everyone else's life for a long, long time. They may not have the label right but the condition is plain to see.

If we start by opening up to just one individual, our sponsor, or we just work on saying our name and that we are an addict, this will go a long way to breaking down the walls. One sponsor told his sponsee, share at every meeting, even if it's just, “My name is so and so, I am an addict and I am ok, or I feel sad, or I feel mad.” Just check in with the group. There is some kind of magic that happens when we admit in open that we are addicts. The lie is dead.

You know, the lies we have told ourselves for years and years; Like, “If it gets really bad I will do something about it.” Or, “When I get bad as Suzy or Bobby or whoever we picked as our ‘less-than,’ I will get my shit together.” Or, “I am not an addict, an addict sells their body for drugs, or an addict sticks needles in their neck!” or, or, or... whatever is the next bottom we haven't gotten to yet. Remember all those “I will never's,” we let go of years ago? “I will never use drugs that aren't natural, no chemicals.” Ok, that one went by the wayside, or “I will never stick a needle in my arm... whoops, we past that one years ago.” These may not be your whenever's but you have a bunch of them or you would not be reading these words.

Just for tonight; I will surrender to the program and get honest about something I am holding onto for dear life. We surrender to win!

May 10

"To use is to die, often in more ways than one. We have found this program at the right time or we wouldn't have found it at all. N.A. and its principles are here to help us achieve quality in our lives. If we were worthless we wouldn't be alive."

Memphis Review Form - page 129, 15

What's the old saying? "If he lives, we'll quit the drugs." It usually takes getting near death for something to break through our denial. The denial that we are not addicts, that we do not have a disease, that our using is not "that" bad. Often it is when we have no one else in our lives to blame stuff on that we finally begin to think, just maybe, it might be the drugs.

Do we really want to go back to that misery? We say to newcomers, "Keep your last high fresh in your mind." That is to remember the worst that using brought us which is usually at the bitter end. Of course, we hope that the bitter end is not in jail for life or in a hospital having lost the use of our limbs and so on. If we haven't gotten there in our active addiction, we can always say to ourselves "yet". Which stands for, "You're eligible too."

For many of us, NA was the last house on the block. As one addict said; "If this NA stuff doesn't work, I am surrendered to be a using drug addict for the rest of my life." She got clean and just celebrated 31 years in NA. Others came to NA as the last resort before killing themselves. As we say, "When at the end of the road we find that we can no longer live with or without the use of drugs we all face the same dilemma, what is there left to do?"

Just for tonight: If my surrender doesn't feel very strong today, I will take a good hard look at my life at the end of the road and remind myself, "If I pick up it could be a whole lot worse!"

May 11

“Left with a shadow of doubt, the mind of a newcomer and even the old-timer can prove to be this spark needed to set off the return of insanity and that first pill, fix, drink or toke.”

Memphis Review Form - page 129, 22

A member shared that when someone said in their very first meeting, “If you don’t pick it up, you can’t get loaded.” It was a revelation! It was so simple, I had no clue how to stay clean, it couldn’t be that easy could it? A sponsor told his sponsee, “You can teach a monkey not to use drugs! Just control the movement of your hand from the pill to your mouth.” It’s surviving our emotions from this wretched disease.

Our life depends on surrendering to the truth we have learned in NA, “One is too many a thousand is never enough.” If you are an addict and have found recovery or not, you know in your heart of hearts this is a true statement. We never did just one. If we did, it was to show some non-addict that we could. It wasn’t very long that we needed two then three. For most of us there was no such thing as a wake up shot because we did all we had the night before. When we woke we were off to the races just to get the sick off or to mask all our negative feelings that we couldn’t live with for another minute, we had to use.

Recovery can be very fragile in the beginning. This is why we stick with the winners and follow suggestions as we never know when using might sound good again. When we get such ideas it is vital that we share them with our sponsor or in a meeting. We have learned it is much simpler to rat on our disease then live with the destruction that awaits us if we relapse.

Just for tonight; I will come clean about my addictive thinking with someone today. I will get honest or die, it’s that simple.

May 12

“Life’s flow takes place in this manner: we come here powerless and the power we seek comes to us through other people in the Fellowship if we can only reach out for it.”

Memphis Review Form - page 130, 13

Get clean, get close and get clear of the wreckage and garbage that our life has dominated our lives. Even if we are idiots, we have learned something in our lives. With the loving support of others who understand and seem to care about us, we build on whatever we have learned that is still of use to us. Many things will be discarded only to be replaced by things that work or work better.

As we become evermore aware of our incompleteness, we hunger to be more than we are. Addiction has chewed a huge hole in our lives, our understanding. As we learn, we also help others. Doing this makes it more comfortable to ask for and receive help from others. We slowly realize that whatever goodness comes to us will be passed on to others. That makes it easier to progress. General improvement is not selfishness! NA recovery is a chain reaction of people helping people!

Reaching out is not entirely new to us. We used help from others to stay alive and out of jail. Many of us found jail time a relief from the scramble of active addiction whether in the streets or in the penthouses. We are careful - the world really is full of trickery! But since we are all sort of in the same boat, we often find ourselves exiting real dilemmas. Now, we are finding solutions rather than entrapment.

May 13

[“Living just for today relieves the burden of the past and alleviates fear of the future.”](#)

[Memphis Review Form - page 61, 34](#)

We find guilt is a large part of the burden of our past. Working Steps 8 and 9 teaches us forgiveness and relieves us of this load. Just writing out our amends list teaches us our wrongs are not limitless. Doing our inventory is a giant step to freedom because we have done something instead of just sitting on it!. It's a step in the right direction. Because of our pasts, we have fears about the future and worry about things that have not yet happened - may happen if no action is taken. Step Nine deals with these things. Issues from our pasts tend to ruin our present. Dealing with the past also teaches us things are flexible, there is hope. We don't know that making amends will make us feel better, but we suspect it will. The heat is off us.

By living here now in the present, we can make the absolute most of this moment. We learn to live in the solution. When we live by spiritual principles, continually doing the right thing right now, our past becomes pleasurable memories and the future begins to look golden. If we can clean up the past, there is a good chance our futures will change also.

Being clean is a paradigm shift all by itself. Even as we hover between disciplined aware of our past wrongdoings and our future in the unknowable giant question mark, we have a good feeling that grows with each passing day clean. If we can stay clean a day at a time, and work the preceding Steps, how many other good things are possible. Keep it simple and just do what you can on a daily basis. What we do first brings us improved feelings. These simple lessons don't go out of style - they make us stronger and work even better as we build on our experience.

May 14

“Slow down and live life. A cynic is someone who has been very disappointed. He does not hear until the heart decides to listen, then he can accept help. It is not shameful to relapse. The real shame is in not coming back.”

Memphis Review Form - page 130, 30

“Man who lives in house that is burning down is always in a hurry.” - Gautama Buddha

Always behind, always trying to catch up, addicts tend to rush forward even when they are not being chased. Survival skills are different when we are clean. Hopelessness and despair are replaced by positive expectation and newfound energy. Amazingly, from the first few days clean, we find a place to stay, food to eat. Soon there is a job and people look interesting in new ways. No longer victims of prey, we begin to explore our human potential. We slowly begin to find out what people are really thinking instead of endlessly projecting our thinking and attitudes onto others.

Dirty living has driven us into a deep well of cynicism. We may have to crawl up a ways before we tumble out on the ground around our pit of despair. The light and sound of being out of the pit woke us up and our cynicism faded. His - or her - heart warmed up and the sounds changed into words and he woke up to a new reality. Recovery started to mean much more than just not using. The excitement shook his world and he may have lost his footing but there was no fear of showing up at a meeting to testify that what he had been told was true. It is a disease and recovery is possible through the 12 Steps!

True members of NA are supportive of someone who comes back after a relapse whether it is for a few days or a few years. They instinctively know the courage it takes to come back. Surrender is a scary thing. Their need for recognition is great. It helps to re-enforce their decision to see recovery again through the 12 Steps of NA.

May 15

“When someone returns the Fellowship after relapse, we stress the importance of living just for today. The past is the past. We cannot change what has happened. What is important is to stay clean today.”

Memphis Review Form - page 131, 9

Recovery takes place with a daily decision not to use. Living just for today is stressed because it is a tool every one of us can use. It is a freedom statement that helps us step free of the life we left in active addiction.

To get recovery, we have to refocus our attention off the pain caused by addiction and onto the joy of having a new life clean. Our daily living pattern of waking up clear and clean and close to people who understand us reshapes who and what we are becoming - a clean addict. A few short decades ago, these two words could not go together. A clean addict, what a miracle!

Personality change may start with surfaces but a day at a time, it goes far deeper. A personality consists of the choices an individual makes. Personal habits don't often change once they have become established. Personal choices in food, music, friends, lifestyles become seemingly embedded into a man or woman in their bones! To change is earth shaking. Long live the changes we experience in recovery!

May 16

"We all find the feeling we get from helping others motivates us to do better in our own lives. If we are hurting, and most of us do from time to time, we learn to ask for help."

Memphis Review Form - page 131, 20

Giving help is somehow related to receiving help. Maybe it is the feelings that are similar. Maybe it is the openness. Exchange means the same door is open from the giver to the receiver.

When I am at the point where the need to give help in order to heal, sometimes we don't have time to give help. You need to fix the problem. "I don't have time to stop and help someone on the freeway because my utilities are going to get cut off," and that's the problem., So, I just stay sick because I can't get out of my immediate concerns. This conundrum keeps us turning in lazy circles.

The very thing I need to get well, is to help somebody. My brain tells me, "You fool, you didn't have time to help somebody." I have to override my ordinary thinking processes to achieve the focus needed to give me relief from addiction.

The guy is late for the party, and he can't stop and take out the map because it takes too long. I have to tell myself to stop and get help before going on. .

May 17

“Recovery found [in] Narcotics Anonymous must come from within and no one gets clean for anyone but themselves.”

Memphis Review Form - page 131, 26

In N A we have to cut to the chase to bridge the gaps between people and communicate. While on the surface, an onlooker may see and hear our interactions, they don't know all that is happening below the surface. Addicts seem to catch on that they feel more potent and energetic when they are spending time with someone who is hurting. Their focus is on others. Their own problems just melt away in passing. Not all the time or all the way, but enough for us to sense the difference. Addicts track their inner feelings in a way that is similar to what they did when they were using.

In recovery, it is similar to persons in war or some kind of emergency setting where they are moving around, helping people with injuries or in need of food or shelter. Some addicts are natural caretakers. We probably take advantage of this in N A. Some addicts are very intuitive and good with feelings.

Longtimers heal when other members talk to them. Newer members draw hope and useful information from longtimers that helps a person in day to day life. Some kind of osmosis is in evident in our recovery. Interpersonal contact stabilizes addicts when they communicate. It is important that we find release from our feelings and joy in helping others.

May 18

“When it gets to the point that we cannot hold the hurt any longer, amends will be made.”

Memphis Review Form - page 53, 5

When time comes to make amends, often an occasion occurs that sets the stage. Events conspire and all we have to do is be willing and honest.

The Twelve Steps follow a natural sequence and move from one necessary focus to the next. The need for amends comes from inner pain, guilt and shame. Some part of us knows there is something that we, and only we, can straighten out. Whether it involves feelings, money or things, our amends brings order from the chaos. We feel better.

Those who receive our amends feel better also. Unanswered questions may produce disorder again and again for years without resolution. Putting closure on things allows everyone involved to go on with their lives.

For example, at some point we took something that wasn't ours. The situation requires someone who 'owned' the stolen item, like a manager, who will wonder who took the items (s). Other innocent parties may be fired, accused, sanctioned even though they did nothing wrong. This could happen at work, in a family household and the same paradigm may fit countless scenarios.

The truth we share removes tensions, allows for restoration of whatever was taken, and everybody involved is off the hook.

Making amends will keep you clean. Stolen items may be returned anonymously. The Steps are in a certain order for a reason, however anytime we can do something positive is a good time.

May 19

“Sharing our lives with others seems to keep us from feeling lonely. The Steps lead to the kind of honesty that can help us let others know and accept us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 124, 1

The NA 12 Steps break us out our need for isolation. The Steps open up a new tool box for us. At first honesty may look like a bad idea. When we get to the Program, and hear others sharing their life experience, we find ourselves identifying. When a problem with the past comes up, we may feel like taking a different approach. Canceling out old personal debts frees the part of us that tracks such things.

Human beings are geared to communicate feelings, ideas and their need for help. Without this interaction, we become stifled and bored. Loneliness is a word to specify this lack of interaction. As we begin recovery by staying clean and going to meetings, we begin to take in the attitudes, feelings, problems and solutions of others who, like us, have had major problems with addiction. Suddenly we have an identity group. We are still addicts but with a difference. We are clean addicts, one among others. .

The myriad changes a person goes through are shared by our participation in NA recovery meetings. Our literature opens the door to many subjects that involve addicts who live clean and are growing spiritually. Our ideas about God and spirituality begin to change. Many doors open to us with seemingly little effort on our part. Many of us are surprised when we find ourselves helping others and repeating what we have learned in the meetings and literature.

May 20

“Trusting others doesn’t come naturally to us, but we must learn to trust because an addict alone is in bad company.”

Memphis Review Form - page 62, 20

At first we feel trapped by our addiction and we can’t see any way out. Our loneliness and despair have us boxed in. When we find NA, all this changes. As we share some of our feelings, we are surprised that it helps. We relate to what others are sharing and it gets even better.

Trust begins when we get to know someone, sharing problems, fears and hopes. We identify. As we get to know more group members, we begin to develop friendships and other relationships in an easy, natural way. Others trust us with their feelings and suddenly we find ourselves trusting them in return. Trust comes from honest sharing.

Active addiction showed us what ‘bad company’ will do for us. Then, in recovery, we find honesty leads us to trust one another. Of course, not everyone can be so honest but the members who stay clean usually have honesty in common.

Working with a sponsor is bound to increase our trust. The first three Steps bring us closer and the Fifth Step lets us bare our soul. The Fourth Step is almost like a rite of passage or initiation into the Fellowship of NA. For the first time we are dealing with how we have affected other people.

May 21

“As we grow, we learn to overcome our tendency to run and hide our feelings. Learning to be totally honest about our feelings helps other people take us seriously.”

Memphis Review Form - page 123, 31

Total honesty is pretty scary to begin with but we learn we are not alone. Hearing others share, encourages us to get it out and see what happens. Generally other members relate to us and our feelings. Having others around who are going through the same process helps us because we are not alone.

Facts and personal self-disclosure ring true to the listener and when they see us let our guard down, they are better able to share honestly with us. All this honesty is good for each one of us.

It is hard for us to share our feelings with people we are just meeting. Having addiction and a desire for recovery helps us relate to what others are going through. We realize the people we are meeting are just as nervous as we are!

This is what N A is all about! This is the process that makes N A attractive and effective. Honesty helps us be open minded and willing to try. Many of us have been told we have to ‘feel our feelings. Blocking our feelings is what led to our isolation.

May 22

“What happens instead is, the more we improve our conscious contact with God through prayer and meditation, the more often we pause when doubtful and say, “God I don’t know what to do. Please teach me.””

Memphis Review Form - page 58, 5

NA is a spiritual movement based on the facts of our experience. Our prayers are answered and conscious contact becomes a part of what we do daily. The Second Step deals with our insanity by encouraging us to find a belief we can trust with our lives. One of the most advanced spiritual statements on the planet is, “All we want to know is what you want to do about your problem and how we can help.”

Conscious contact is the basis for our spiritual growth in N A. This contact it is not elaborated on in terms of one religious belief or method of contact. Every person’s spiritual belief is left to the individual member. Because of this, many addicts have been able to find a spiritual life that works for them and find a unity of good feeling about a higher power. .

This freedom of encouraging our members to find a belief that works for them has opened the doorway to recovery. An open-ended prayer like the one quoted from the Grey Book seems to work for everybody, regardless of their personal belief system.

What happens when we say the prayer for help can be amazing. For many of us a solution forms almost right away. Something simple, so simple we could have thought of it ourselves but the questions is would we have found the solution on our own? For most of us, we know how often we have been baffled and confused only to find that with God’s help, things work out for the good of all.

May 23

"We seek creativity through the spirit. This spirit dwells within all of us. We need to understand that the spirit within each individual is the same. The action being that we tap the available resources of the spirit within ourselves. Some have tapped more than others. We need to create more soul searching within one another. This process is the creative action of the spirit. We listen to ourselves and others in order to recover and to stay on that path."

Memphis Review Form - page 124, 5

NA is a spiritual, not religious program of recovery from addiction. You could say recovery from being hung up on things of the world. Many people live out their lives in fear. Faith put first things first and allows an average person the ability to create good fortune through positive action and good attitude. Recovery can mean much more than simple abstinence though it begins there. We have a tremendous need for spiritual learning.

Revelations come to us in God's time, not ours. We cannot demand revelations, we must patiently wait for them to be revealed. One member asked his higher power what would make my life better and their higher power said, "Start going to a fluff and fold laundry, quit doing it yourself. You hate it!"

It is this sameness of spirit that makes N A a universal program. Our Steps and Principles have been applied and utilized in every part of the globe. Our original literature was written to include all people who might seek recovery in N A, regardless of their national language, history, religion or other factors that might hinder or limit their approach to N A recovery. Time has proven this hope to be true.

May 24

“Pride, fear, and procrastination often seem an impossible barrier and stand in our way of progress and growth through the Ninth Step.”

Memphis Review Form - page 53, 24

A thorn in our foot will keep hurting until it is removed. We may even fear the pain of pulling out the thorn and put off removal until it begins to fester and redden to the point of blood poisoning. One thing is sure: once the source of the pain is removed, the healing process begins. The same thing happens with various kinds of disorders stemming from our past behavior. Any form of meanness and wishing ill to others comes back on us to blindside us with new problems.

Pride keeps us from taking a close look at something that bothers us, even though it took place sometime in our past. It should be mentioned that we are paying a price for something that could be resolved by a simple, honest change of heart. In recovery when we realize, that change of heart comes pretty easy compared to the hell we went through getting to our point of willingness.

Fear is the same problem, we pay a price, getting nothing in return. Once we decide to inventory a feeling that's been bothering us, we may even put it off some more!

Another valid factor is the possibility of retaliation. Talking with our sponsor is often a good idea before putting ourselves, and those who depend on us, at risk. Step Nine spells out “except when to do so would injure them or others.” You are one of the others - you count too!

May 25

“Lack of spiritual quality within our lives leads us down the path to relapse. This part of our recovery is the essence of the program. Spiritual maintenance is indispensable if recovery is what we’re after.”

Memphis Review Form - page 124, 13

Many addicts are so wounded by past experience with any sort of spirituality, they try to work their 12 Steps on the mental plane. This may in fact work for some if they are totally sincere. Others get caught on a semantic treadmill and without a belief in a power greater than one’s self, it is hard to imagine how someone could complete the course of the 12 Steps under their own power.

The purpose of a sponsor is to guide us through the Steps. When we share what we are doing in our Step work - or not doing, a sponsor can make a few well worded, gentle comments that help us move forward. Listening to others share is the primary service we offer in N A recovery. We really listen and care!

Seeking knowledge of God’s Will for us and the strength to carry out that Will is the basis for a spiritual life. Our disease still crops up at the oddest times. It is an old saying in the program of NA that we grow more from a bad day than from a day when everything goes our way. Dealing with life on life’s terms steadily increases our ability to trust and seek help from the God of our understanding.

As addicts, most of us are masters at getting material things, like a new car on crushing monthly payments. This comes from our well honed skill at going out and coping a bag of dope somehow. But when it comes to maintenance, most are miserable failures. We don't change the oil on time, don't rotate the tires and run late on our payments. This spiritual maintenance can be very challenging for us. Praying on our knees every night may be one of the hardest things we have ever done, but such prayer may be critical to our survival.

May 26

[“Living just for today relieves the burden of the past and alleviates fear of the future.”](#)

[Memphis Review Form - page 61, 34](#)

We find guilt is a large part of the burden of our past yet contains the wisdom of our experience. Working Steps Eight and Nine teaches us forgiveness and relieves us of this load. We have fears about the future and worry about things that have not yet happened. This tends to ruin our present.

By living here now in the present, we can make the absolute most of this moment. We learn to live in the solution. When we live by spiritual principles, continually doing the right thing now, our past becomes pleasurable memories and helpful experience. The future becomes an opportunity to find new good things that work for us. If we have problems, we use our spiritual principles to get the help we need. Writing is a form of prayer!.

The present is what our HP gives us to work with. The past can serve as a data bank for what works and what does not. Also, we have had some successes to build on. Humility, patience, tolerance and perseverance give us advantages we could not see before we experienced them. Helping others has a funny way of encouraging us to take our own recommendations.

Curiously, as we grow, our remembrances of the past seem to change. They don't really change, but our perception is altered by our spiritual growth. In the same way, our perception of possible or likely futures shift towards good outcomes and exciting breakthroughs.

May 27

"We, of Narcotics Anonymity, do not promise to have all the answers, but we've found that our lives steadily improved if we didn't use and learned to maintain our spiritual condition. "

Memphis Review Form - page 21, 12

Recovery is what happens to us when we are clean, go to meetings and take time to help others. Whether new or well established in recovery, just by caring we are able to see into the lives of others. This helps reshape our own living attitudes and capacity to surrender. Life comes in a isolation walks out the door!

By trusting the program of N A, we discover recovery. By living differently, we change what we attract and what we involve ourselves with on a daily basis. We can just walk past side alleys and dead-end streets where we used to spend a great deal of our precious time.

Sometimes recovery in Narcotics Anonymous consists of long plateaus where it seems we are not really getting ahead. But these are followed by periods of intense growth with doors opening, opportunities presenting themselves and gifts being showered upon us. We have to change our hook-ups before we can plug into good new situations.

It can be difficult to just keep going to meetings in the plateau stretches and accepting that these times are the foundation for the coming growth periods. Thing about it! By definition, we need to be in a good, safe place to allow these changes to happen. While the changes occur, it may helps to reflect on our life is really pretty good! We're just not ready for all this good treatment.

May 28

“By nature we seem to be strong-willed, self-centered people, seeking self-gratification in the realms of money, power, and sex. As important part of our recovery is learning how to live with these drives; how to realign our misguided instincts, how to stop acting out our insanities, how to disarm our self-destruct mechanisms, and how to re-channel our energies toward constructive ends.”

Memphis Review Form - page 92, 16

As human beings we want to be productive, effective and well liked by the people we come in contact with. The problems come in when we are willing to use lies, deceit and thievery to achieve these ends. Honesty, openmindedness and the willingness to try seem impractical and sometimes, unworkable principles to apply to real life on life's terms. But since we heard about it in meetings, we sometimes go ahead not really expecting them to work for us. When they do, we get this little grim on our faces like we knew it all along.

The money, power, sex, food, gambling and codependency can actually cause some to go back out. If we can ask for help, our sponsor can help us with these things. But we have to open up and talk to him or her about them. There are solutions to all of these problems. We are not the first to have to face difficulties and we will not be the last.

It may help to recall just how hopeless and beaten down we were when we got here. Addictive disease has a way of sugarcoating the bad times and making the using days colorful and exciting. Actually, they were dull and depressing, with no way out in sight! Reading recovery literature and sharing honestly about our past insanity helps keep us honest and real about our need for help.

If we are blessed, we may find ourselves continuing to pursue spiritual growth and learning year after year as our clean time grows. One of the greatest gurus of all time once said, “I want to eat sugar. I don't want to be sugar.” It is ok to enjoy things of the world. We just learn to avoid the rattlesnakes and black widow spiders.

May 29

“One of our sayings is “Our best ideas got us here.” This seems apt as we look back and see how many times our schemes and plans got us into trouble despite their original intent.”

Memphis Review Form - page 92, 25

Some of the worst times in our past using days began with good intentions. But the disease of lies presented a false picture of reality to us and we found ourselves in over our heads before we knew what was happening to us. In recovery we learn that this is the nature of our self-destructiveness. Nobody can make us blindly plunge ahead like the disease of addiction under the influence and control of some mind and mood altering chemistry.

The mental plane has to do with the words and logic centered in the left lobe of our brains. It is very pushy and seeks always to have its way. Rationalizations, selfishness and illogical justifications pave the way to wasting time and energy on bad ideas instead of taking a few moments to pray and meditate before jumping into a fire. Act in haste and repent at your leisure.

The spiritual way of life gives us time to consider other people and outcomes that may not have been visible in the rush to jump on a good idea. For instance, some of us wait a day or a week if we want to buy something, knowing even though we have the money, we may not really need the thing or have a place to put it! Clean time gives us people to talk things over with someone who may be affected by our actions. Sometimes they will advise us against something where we eventually go ahead with our original impulse. This is because we are free. The time of asking and waiting doesn't cost us much and if we decide to go ahead, we have some vision beyond our immediate needs and wants.

May 30

“The Eleventh Step helps us, in the face of a problem, to be aware of God. The underlying principle of this Step is God consciousness. We try not asking for specific things.”

Memphis Review Form - page 58, 10

Spirituality leads us on a path that goes up a mountain of energy that underlies visible God. There are many paths up the mountain but only one top. A very wise teacher taught all he could reach that nations that believed in God should never go to war with one another. Addictions is a war within where nobody ever wins.

One member could not meditate. He prayed daily simply stating that he could not meditate. A couple of years later, he went to work for a very advanced meditator who paid most of the fee to go to a meditation organization and the training class. Now he has been meditating for almost 30 years. The key was that he never asked to go to a meditation class, he simply stated that he was stuck. HP heard and worked out a perfect solution.

Most members share that meditation gives them a time out to let their attachments to things of the world drop away long enough to keep their conscious contact shiny. Internal resources accumulate over time and these principles and methods lead to sound courses of action. Internal resources are evidence that the Program of NA works.

May 31

"In our daily lives, we are subject to emotional, environmental, intellectual, mental and spiritual relapses, causing us to become defenseless against the physical relapse of addiction."

Memphis Review Form - page 124, 27

Most members of NA who have been clean for a while know that a spiritual relapse precedes physical relapse. Justifying anger, character assassination and harming others is a reflection of what is going on inside. Recovering addicts learn to track their feelings and mental states to ward off relapse. It is not that hard but it is that important.

Regular meeting attendance pulls us back from the abyss. Often we do not even know how close to the edge we actually are, but meetings heal us, center us and bring us back. Meetings are no substitute for the other tools, but they are quick, handy and very effective when we are grumpy and don't want to work Steps or work with others. Never underestimate the power of going to a meeting.

If we have worked our First Step, we know the connection between our using and our pain. Using will hurt like hell if we fall into one of the many traps it lays for us, all pretty and tasty looking on top and steel jaws below. Want to feel lower than the sidewalk? You know the way. Want to feel joy and hopeful? These is a way called NA!

JUNE

June 1

“The unconditional love we experience will rejuvenate our will to live and each positive move on our part will be matched by an unexpected opportunity.”

Memphis Review Form - page 54, 18

Many members get clean, stay clean and begin to work the 12 Steps of N A only to get bogged down in details and forget the larger picture recovery brings to light. Recovery is about freedom and the help comes from many sources which have common denominators like those who help us share our feelings and courage. They respect what we are doing because they have gone or are going through the same things themselves.

No one is going to come to our apartment and give us a job. We have to get up off the couch and go look for work. The magical thing we have found in recovery is that once we put our bodies in motion, all manner of assistance starts to show up. The first man to conquer Mount Everest speaks of this.

Sometimes it is very hard for us to get motivated. We lack inertia, that thing that puts us into action. Either we have too many fears or doubts, or we are just plain lazy from our past life of doing nothing except getting and using and finding ways and means to get more. For that, we had a ton of energy, right?

The 7th Step tells us “rebellion is a character defect that robs us here. We need not lose faith, rebellion can be overcome by persistent effort.” This is the key. When we have no willingness to move forward, we try to take baby steps in the direction we need to go and we will get there. A baby step for doing step work is buying a pencil. Setting out a place in our home that is quiet. Buying a Step guide etc. Even a very, very, very small willingness to move forward maybe all we need to get the job done.

Just for tonight: I know in my heart that God is right on the other side of willingness. I will take baby steps and more to move into the solution today.

June 2

"Finally, throughout our lives, we surround ourselves with fellow members who continue to let us know we can count on them. One of the advantages of the N.A. program is that is (it) places us in an intimate, regular contact with recovering addicts who can most understand and help us in our recovery."

Memphis Review Form - page 68, 13

As newcomers we, sometimes fearfully, share our problems and feel a deep kinship with our predecessors as they share their actual experience and solutions to our problems.

Today, secure in the love of the fellowship... as the literature so aptly states.. we can look another person in the eye and be grateful for who we are. Once we surrender to the NA way of life, we create a life connected to other members. We often find spouses in recovery. We spend a great deal of time with our sponsors than latter with our sponsees. We tend to go out with members to social events. We begin to see other members as part of our family. For many of us, we had very dysfunctional families or our families had given up on us a long time ago. We are at peace with other members as they truly understand who and what we are and they speak our language every day, the language of the heart.

As newcomers we, sometimes fearfully, share our problems and feel a deep kinship with our predecessors as they share their actual experience and solutions to our problems. We come to rely on their wisdom as we learn that following the direction of those who came before us make so much sense as they have already gone through the trials and tribulations of getting clean and are more than happy to pass this hard-won experience onto us at no cost whatsoever.

Just for tonight; I will trust the saying that in NA there are no strangers, only old friends we've never met. I will make a family here in recovery that loves me and will be there for me no matter what. As long as I am doing the right things for the right reasons and even when I am not.

June 3

“A person who has realized their powerlessness and seen the vision the Higher Power has for them will see why we pray only for knowledge of his will for us and the power to carry it out.”

Memphis Review Form - page 58, 15

Learning spirituality involves study, discussion and listening to what others have to say. Spiritual principles may be based in a Higher Consciousness but the nuts and bolts are learned just like we learn everything else. We hear others share or read something that strikes us in a meaningful way and we try it out to see if it will work for us. Mostly we are amazed to find simple sounding solutions have great power to heal and instruct.

The Basic Text says, in Step 11, God's will for us is but a fleeting glimpse of our own true will for ourselves. We come to realize over time that our Higher Power only wants the very best for us, nothing more and nothing less.

Over time we have come to finally understand, after learning the preceding steps, that our job is to get out of the way so God can do his work in our lives. The biggest problem we have is putting our hands in to it and screwing it up. We see that true deep spirituality comes to us when we learn to trust God, clean house and help others. Once we do our preceding step work, we come to a place of calm resignation that there is a loving God and that he/she is taking care of us way better than we ever could by ourselves.

Just for tonight: There is a Japanese Haiku or short meaningful poem that states: “In the beginner's mind there are many questions, in the masters but few”

June 4

“The structure of Narcotics Anonymous is quite unlike any health or welfare agency known to us. Although N.A. practices may vary from place to place, all N.A. services are performed voluntarily by the addicts themselves and without cost. N.A. does not accept money for its services, is not funded by any public or private sources of agencies and accepts no outside contributions.”

Memphis Review Form - page 15, 1

Scientists can explain how to land a rocket on a planet millions of miles away. They can tell you how the body works, how diamonds are formed and so on. But they still have no idea why and how addicts get clean when they never wanted to before they came to NA? Treatment centers don't have the answer to recovery from the disease of addiction, that is why they send addicts to us.

You cannot buy a miracle! We have found through a long period of trial and error that our messages comes through loud and clear in meetings or private conversation. When persons outside N.A. try to produce our writings using academic techniques, it comes through crippled or distorted. We don't want insincerity or lofty thinkers taking pity on us. It is the identification and respect we share among our fellow members that brings our recovery process to life. Our message of hope and recovery is priceless. Whether in H&I, P.I., Literature or other services, it is our common bond that amazes the newcomer and holds their rapt attention.

The therapeutic value of one addict helping another truly is without parallel. For some unknown reason, a completely close-minded using addict will stop and listen to what an experienced member has to say to them. They may not heed our warnings right away but they will never, ever, ever deny that we are right when we tell them our truths; “One is too many, a thousands never enough” “if you don't pick it up, you can't get loaded,” “An addict alone is in bad company.”

Just for tonight: I will remember that I may be the only copy of the Basic Text that a newcomer sees, I will act accordingly and responsibly remembering that newcomer once was me.

June 5

“Many books have been written about the nature of addiction. This book primarily concerns itself with the nature of recovery. (There are no line numbers at top of page.)”

Memphis Review Form - page 22, 22

How many times have we heard members share that the Basic Text told their whole life story, it was amazing! The members who wrote our book prayed every time they sat down to write or edit it. This spiritually based work allowed them to write what we have come to call a “faith-based” book rather than a “fear-based” one. They wrote what was true in their hearts regardless of what others said could or could not be done. They spoke their experiences of recovering from the disease of addiction and the book rings true to this day. The Basic Text has been translated into countless languages and everywhere it goes, addicts get and stay clean! That is a powerful piece of literature!

Many of us who got clean in the 1970's knew from experience that outside interests have little information that we could use. There were and are many modes to treat the addictive personality. Many theories on what addiction is and methods of treatment abounded but we got nothing from them.

NA began to grow when addicts began to take up for ourselves, our message and our program. Our Traditions allow us to do things together that might otherwise result in conflicts and stalemates. One of the great benefits of our program is that we are not dependent on outside organizations for funding or direction. We are fully self-supporting through our own contributions and have only to seek a loving God in our group conscience for direction.

If not for the members in the early 80's who decided to make a stand in NA by only going to NA meetings, using NA language and standing up for the concept of “one disease, one program”, NA too may have gone by the wayside as another failed experiment in the long line of useless modalities to treat the addictive personality, sigh.

Just for tonight; “I know that NA works and I am proud to be an ambassador for recovery in Narcotics Anonymous!”

June 6

"We had a lot of energy, but we channeled it into self-destruction."

Memphis Review Form - page 62, 23

We now have a choice and can choose to channel our energy into things that bring us ongoing happiness and joy. The more we do this, the more we feel good about our recovery. If we are not busy making these choices, we will probably get ungrateful and begin the old whining and ingratitude that characterized our active addiction. Eventually we will say, "I am clean but I haven't changed any." Start over today! Freedom means we don't have to languish in our confusion and misery. We do the best we can on a daily basis and that leads us into our happy destiny!

The Basic Text states: "It is the nature of the addict to tear down" For many of us, when we got here, we weren't sick and tired, we were just plain tired. Our ego's once so large had been crushed by active addiction. We had no fight left. It is in this state of willingness that we call the gift of desperation, we finally come to feel in our heart-of-hearts what surrender truly means.

Just for tonight: I will remember that "if I always think what I always thought, I will always feel what I always felt and if I always feel what I always felt, I will always do what I always did and if I always do what I always did, I will always get what I always got!" I will surrender and fight now more.

June 7

“As a disease, addiction is subject to relapse. Reverting to using is a physical relapse. Physical relapse is on a symptom. We are never forced into relapse. We are given a choice.”

Memphis Review Form - page 124, 31

Many - if not every single one of us - have to get into the habit of praying and meditating, whatever level we are on. Contact with other members inside and outside our meetings keeps us on our toes recovery-wise. Honest sharing keeps us aware of the dangers of thinking we have it made.

Relapse begins when we start getting comfortable and cutting corners in our recovery program. True, clean time builds up a sort of protection against relapse, but why abuse ourselves with a slide down hill? Surrender isn't so bad. It just takes a little hope to keep us going in the right direction. Target sometimes you love and care about. Real growth comes when we're having fun! Take a minute to think of something good in your life due to recovery. If we aren't grateful for what we have, how do we think we'll be grateful for what we want?

Poor mental habits contribute to relapse. Allowing ourselves to become needlessly angry at someone is bad for us because we identify with other members. If we are mad at them, we may also be mad at the part of ourselves that identifies with them. Resentments are sent and resent until we get the message we are not dealing with. As long as we put it off, it will be resent. When we deal with it, it stops being a problem. We add to our collection of things we have gained in recovery. We could not always do this before N A. Now we can. If we feel like it is too much for us, we can share our problem in general terms with our home group - or in specific terms with our close friends and sponsor.

Our choice is to pray for strength and guidance. That opens the door to our getting the help and support we need. Trying to deal with things we are powerless over is impossible by definition. Asking for help attracts the very people who want to help and it only takes one of them to have our answer!

June 8

“Stagnation or just plain old character defects which we re-cultivate rather than let go of sends us back to where these defects were conceived.”

Memphis Review Form - page 124, 19

A sponsor told his sponsee, “we repeat all the time.... This too shall pass, this too shall pass.”. he said, no “This too gets buried!” We put a Band-Aid on it and push it back down only for it to come up over and over again. He said; the answer is “This too shall dissolve”. It’s gone, it’s healed. When I write an inventory it’s no longer there as it is no longer an issue in my life.”

For most of us, our defects of character were formed in our childhood. What we thought were assets that kept us somewhat sane in an insane environment, no longer work for us. They were probably born as we were either growing up or on the streets. They were merely our defense mechanisms. We would be overly people-pleasing or put on a ‘don’t fuck with me’ face to keep people away. We would blame others for all that was wrong in our lives so we never had to take responsibility for anything, ever. As the Basic Text states: “Defects are those things that caused us pain and misery all our lives.” Hello! Why would we want to hang onto something that caused us pain and misery? Why, because we used our defense mechanisms for 20 to 30 to 40 years and now we are asked to let them go and walk in faith, trusting the process that has worked for countless others.

One addict told his sponsor, “I can’t stop being negative, I’ve been that way all my life.” His sponsor responded, “Yes, and I shoot heroin.” The sponsee looked quizzically at his sponsor and said, “No you don’t!” “Exactly,” said the sponsor, “If God can relieve me from sticking a needle in my arm every day, he can certainly relieve you of a character defect eh?”

Just for tonight; “as my sponsor shared “the Steps are like Exlax, if you put them in one at a time, in order, the results come out the other side every single time.” I will trust the process and surrender my defects of character.

June 9

“Addicts respond instinctively to honest sharing.”

Memphis Review Form - page 16, 4

We have heard so many lies we pay little attention to what goes on around us. We stumbled into an N A meeting skeptical of anything we heard although we did feel something that piqued our attention at least for a moment. So we returned to another meeting not knowing why. It may have been the second or fourth meeting, we heard some truth. Instinctively, the truth attracted us and we began listening closer. The closer we listened, the more truth we heard. The more truths we heard, the more hope we felt.

These truths were starting to stick together into something we could wrap our minds around. It was when our minds found enough evidence to believe that our hearts started feeling soothed. Now we can surrender at least a little of our lives into our process. We find ourselves practicing honesty too and feeling good about these changes. What reaches the heart, touches the heart and nothing reaches the heart like honest sharing of common pain and the solutions that free us.

Just for tonight: “The truth will set me free, but first it will probably piss me off.” If other addicts can accept the hard-cold-truth, so can I.

June 10

"In our daily lives, we are subject to emotional, environmental, intellectual, mental and spiritual relapses, causing us to become defenseless against the physical relapse of addiction."

Memphis Review Form - page 124, 27

"Resentment is the number one offender" the chapter on Recovery and Relapse states. It is in times of despair that using seems to be a tempting idea. When we feel that no one understands us or how we in our current plight. We hammer away thinking "they" did this and "they" need to be held accountable! Resentment is like drinking poison and waiting for the other person to die!

If we have worked our First Step, we know the connection between our using and our pain. Using will hurt like hell if we fall into one of the many traps it lays for us, all pretty and tasty looking on top and steel jaws below. Want to feel lower than the sidewalk? You know the way. Want to feel joy and hopeful? There is a way called NA!

Someone once said, "Anger is too luxurious a feeling to waste on someone we don't even like." When I am in my head too long I know that I need to get with my sponsor or get to a meeting to share what's going on between my ears. As the book says, "Honest sharing is the antidote to my diseased thinking."

Just for tonight; I will rat on my disease and let another member know when I am in pain or thinking about using. This simple act can save my life and keep me from the bitter ends; "jails institutions or death!"

June 11

"The Second Step is the most important thing that must happen for us to achieve any sort of ongoing recovery."

Memphis Review Form - page 34, 21

One sponsor said to his sponsee, "If there isn't a power greater than you, we are all in a world of shit!" Surrender is just the beginning of the process of recovery. We have come to understand that if we are not getting direction from some other source, we are managing an unmanageable life. right? Even if it is just believing in a sponsor, or the literature it is probably for the first time in our lives that we are coming to believe something outside of ourselves could restore us to sanity. It is not brave to walk down the street with a few large friends and it is not cowardice to crouch down in an alleyway with large, hulking figures moving towards us in a hostile manner. Having a Higher Power to help out, only a breath of prayer away, changes our situation in a wonderful way.

It most certainly does not have to be a deity. It is simply the idea that we, on our own, cannot manage an unmanageable life. Belief in our Higher Power gives us the ability to meet the needs of life head on.

Belief tends to define our boundaries and what we are willing to be open to in our personal reality. If we can only find something to believe in, we can firm up our hope for a new life. Hope is the cure for depression. For most of us, it is pretty obvious that the Fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous as a whole is most certainly a power greater than ourselves because they are staying clean a day at a time and we have been abject failures at it on our own.

Just for tonight: If I am truly powerless and my life is truly unmanageable, I am willing to seek help from others in NA. I will turn my will and life over to the care of my sponsor and learn the NA way of life. It's the best decision I could ever make.

June 12

"We as addicts, suffer from a problem deeper than the drugs we took. Because of this, we must live by spiritual principles. Step Ten and all the Steps are to be applied to every area of our lives."

Memphis Review Form - page 54, 24

Starting with some basic touchstones of recovery, we learn about how to view the stages of recovery. While one stage blends into the next and all stages are linked up, we clearly start out as newcomers who must learn how we get along in the Fellowship. This stage is not a permanent label confining us to a 'less-than' status. When we experience some of the pink cloud and early lessening of pressure that comes from surrender, the joy of mutual support can make us almost manic. We all know addiction is a limiting and life threatening disease and yet the good feelings are important to our learning and growing also. As we go through these processes we often enjoy helping someone else who is just beginning recovery road.

The Basic Text says; "We thought we needed something and we thought we had found it in drugs" This tells us we had a lacking long before we even picked up. One member was listening to an NA know-it-all who was sharing from the podium "recovery is to take you back to where you were before you started using drugs!" and my friend thought to himself "if I was taken back to where I was before I started using drugs, I'D START USING DRUGS!"

As one member shared; "Drugs weren't my problem, they were my solution. It was when my solution became my problem that I was really in trouble! We have come to understand that drugs were merely a symptom of our disease and that we had an obsessive, compulsive self-centered personality long before we ever picked up drugs.

This is why NA is not a one or two Step program, don't use and help others. We need to heal that which made us want to use in the first place. It is only by working the 12 Steps that we can get past the pain of active addiction to the real pain of our younger years where the real healing can be done. Only then can we truly be able to help others find their way back to their lonely lost child so they too can heal completely. If we stopped growing when we started using, we being with the emotions of a teenager.

Just for tonight: "I refuse to give NA and the 12 steps a half-hearted attempt. I will give it all I've got and get the wonderful results recovery has to offer. I will trust the Basic Text when it says; "Not only is this life better than the hell we lived it is better than any life we could ever imagine!"

June 13

REDUNDANT - BUT ADDED NEW ESSAYS

“As a disease, addiction is subject to relapse. Reverting to using is a physical relapse. Physical relapse is only a symptom. We are never forced into relapse. We are given a choice.”

Memphis Review Form - page 124, 31

Maintaining our spiritual condition gives us a set of opportunities to catch ourselves before we fall over the edge. Low and high impact events may knock us temporarily off balance. Our disease is a tendency, often subtle and conniving, to set us up for a fall rather than pushing us.

When we find ourselves making excuses for not working our program is usually a good clue to remind us of what is happening. Justification our resentments is one. Allowing ourselves to wallow in self-pity over things we cannot change is another. Not praying for help is yet another warning sign. Blaming others when things go wrong rather than taking personal responsibility only complicates difficult situations. Dropping home group attendance or failing to stay in touch with our NA friends can turn into isolation.

Physical relapse is a final step in a series of life threatening and life limiting events. Learning to watch out for these and reminding ourselves that we are not out to ‘get good’ or live up to the expectations of others. We simply want to find a form of happiness we can live with on a daily basis.

June 14

“To us, at first, it feels like insanity to give another person knowledge of our pain. As we become more closely involved with others we will learn to share our pain and it will lessen. Part of the horror of addiction is being cut off from this human experience. Our fears and guilt kept us from receiving the benefits afforded to every day people.”

Memphis Review Form - page 68, 31

Isolation keeps us from the love and attention that would give us the support we need to face life. It makes a big difference in how we process the events and concerns that come with daily life. Someone who is in this sort of isolation is unable to see, hear, touch or feel our love and caring. They can even repeat the words we say without taking in the meaning. What isolates us is our shame and guilt. We feel unworthy and our sense of right and wrong works against us. Trouble is, we see ourselves as guilty of wrongdoing and begin to carry out a personalized punishment program, P-P-P.

With this attitude and viewpoint, we do not want to take on the anger and condemnation of someone else who is being nice to us. We are sure if they knew the truth about us, they would push us away. Our isolation and lack of internal resources prevents us from opening up to their care and concern. The situation is worsened because in many cases, their concern may be justified. It takes someone who has had similar experience to really help us find the path they took to self acceptance and forgiveness.

You can't find good support hiding in a closet. You have to gather yourself up and shuffle out the door to get to where there are people who might identify and make few suggestions.

June 15

"Before coming to the fellowship of N.A., we were irresponsible with our lives. We used drugs to cover up our humiliation, guilt, inferiority and feelings of inadequacy."

Memphis Review Form - page 23, 1

Blinking into the new life of living clean, we are able to make simple choices. We stabilize physically and emotionally. Our contact with insane individuals is eliminated and in their place we have friends who see life in positive colors and solution based living patterns. A lot of the upsets just literally disappear! Without these upsets, we are left in a clear-headed state where we take care of our business and take the rest of the day to enjoy our lives. The drugs we used to escape our problems complicated our problems.

Clean, we settle down to just live at first, then find our real likes and preferences. We are no longer dragged down with fear and guilt. Some of this comes from the meetings and free association with clean addicts but many things just come naturally. Our bodies have been designed over millions of years to live on this planet. We have survived incredible hardships, weather and diseases.

Most of us practice some sort of wake-up ritual, reading literature, listening to recovery tapes or CD's to get our day off to a good start. It is vitally important that we keep our focus on recovery. We look for things that work in recovery if we are going to experience the benefits of N A! The simplest things can make so much difference in the way our days go. Just missing a few meetings can cause us to begin to experience the feelings we associate with our disease. Resentments crop up over very small issues. We snap at co-workers and spouses. Just a member calling us can put us back in a better place."

June 16

“There is no area of our lives that the disease does not affect. The truth is that fear is present in every area of our lives. So, in our experience, the program can and must be worked continuously in every area of our lives.”

Memphis Review Form - page 54, 28

Just like our blood feeds and cleans our entire body as a natural part of circulation, what we learn in one area is applied in many others. And where we find fault with ourselves, we find the same need for correction in many other areas. Each instance of personal growth benefits the whole of our lives on a continuous basis.

Honesty may keep us out of jail but it also frees us from habits of caution and negative anticipation based on fear. Honesty lowers the stress. Fear of punishment for guilt that comes with whatever wrong thing we have done.

Humility gets our ego out of the way and lets us enjoy the clean life God gives us. We don't have to worry about getting credit for things. We can be happy and glad when friends do well. Humility is awareness that our HP works through principles that can be learned and practiced in everyday life. Being openminded allows us access to information that helps tune us into reality.

Owning our willingness to try usually means we don't have to do things in many cases. If we are not willing, we may be forced against our will.

June 17

"We choose not to have presidents, masters, chairmen or directors. Instead we have secretaries, treasurers, and representatives. These titles in themselves imply service rather than control."

Memphis Review Form - page 95, 3

Jailhouse lawyers, inexperienced persons and those who speak without thinking or praying, may miss the point here. Start with personal powerlessness. A surrendered person would want help and listen to what others have to say. Someone with a tender ego may see everything in terms of what will make them seem important or look good. This is a distorted misperception. Egotistical perceptions make problems from the get-go.

We care about all our members and practice in decision making and group activities builds a person's self-confidence and the skills we need for interpersonal exchanges.

In recovery, we move from attending a meeting to being a part of a group. As we attend several meetings, our circle of friends and acquaintances grows. None of this is by accident. Many of our group conscience processes do double duty by informing members at large while establishing and maintaining principled processes as well as spiritual principles. Good ideas that don't work in real life and dismissed in favor of practical solutions. That is why so much of our literature is based on success in living instead of great ideas.

Proud egos and credit taking mentality sets peoples at odds with one another. When a group sees someone in a position of service and trust acting out of petty rivalry or self-interest, it makes it hard for them to stick with principles. That is the value of 'trusted servants.' Many of you may recall from the earlier history of NA. Proud or arrogant people in service were called "thrusted servants." Humor, gratitude and growing insight into the nature of things sets us free, slowly or eventually. It's not so bad to go through tough time as long as we learn more about living clean.

June 18

“For the newcomer this is how they find out about N A and how they stay clean; and for the members this reaffirms and clarifies what they have learned.”

Memphis Review Form - page 2, 30

Sharing and caring are both active and positive expressions of our love for others. When we see the Steps and principles working for others, we get curious. Seeing things that work in real life confirms and strengthens our growth. Some principles may seem a little prissy in the beginning. After racking up some personal experience, our respect rises. Simple words keep people with addiction alive! We learn to live all over again or for the first time!

As we continue going to meetings and experiencing NA culture, new experiences and learnings will supply more food for thought and we are propelled forward into new discoveries. Real recovery is a stream of ‘aha’ moments. We discover new ways of seeing our world that just were not possible a short time before. Long held beliefs grow deeper and wider as we grow in our clean time. Honesty, openmindedness and the willingness to try become ever more applicable as time and experience accumulates.

This is important: what was seen as true in the beginning of our recovery is found to have ever wider application. While they are just as true a few years later, they have more uses and amazing new combinations. Honesty is important in the present tense. Openmindedness lets us see further ahead as we are growing. The willingness to try opens the world for us to try on a daily basis!

June 19

“What would happen if our groups had other primary purposes? We feel our message would be diluted and then lost.”

Memphis Review Form - page 103, 10

Part of the magic of NA is when we actively carry our message, we get the message. It's like what comes out of our mouths goes into our ears! Life on planet earth has plenty of distractions. It seems like our society is constantly making bigger and better distractions! Sometimes we devolve rather than evolve!

The big three are money, property and prestige. Add sex, security and personal recognition and you'll realize they are all related. Recovery involves staying alive and developing the quality of our lives!

In the 1980's NA in San Francisco was asked by the Haight Ashbury Free Clinic to pass out needle exchange flyers in our meetings. We politely declined. To do so would have implied that we were advocates of needle exchange, possibly involved with the Haight Ashbury Free Clinic and were advocating IV drug use. The vote was unanimous. No, we would not! Some addicts are so addicted to the needle they have been known to shoot up orange juice.

June 20

"An atmosphere of recovery in our groups is one of our most precious assets; and we must guard it carefully lest we lose it to politics and personalities."

Memphis Review Form - page 95, 13

If each one of us prays to relinquish their ego and self-will, the atmosphere of recovery will result. Honest sharing and personal disclosure set the tone for other members to follow suit. If there are people in the rooms who do not share or pickup on our message of hope and personal growth through the 12 Steps of NA, it throws our focus off recovery and our atmosphere of recovery will go 'poof,' up in smoke.

Addicts in recovery know how important the atmosphere of recovery is. Our lives and well-being depend on it. This atmosphere makes it socially acceptable to get real and honest about our personal experience, past and present. The reality of recovery beats any movie or tv show! Against the backdrop of our past lives in active addiction, the miracles of recovery really stand out.

Addiction will always come with some way to glorify using. Addiction will misrepresent the happiness, joy and freedom we experience in living the clean life. Early recovery is an adjustment to doing things while in a clean state. Grocery shopping, dancing, planning an outing or vacation clean brings home the reality of our altered state of existence.

Neuroscientists are finally pointing out that our consciousness is really all we personally possess. In recovery material, we have mentioned the drug-induced fog that clouds our thinking as we begin to experience clean living. A clear mind and good attitude makes all the difference in our daily lives! Be grateful!

If people do not want to be in the rooms, it puts a chill on recovery and the healing process ends. This may cause people to clam up and later use over bottled up emotions. We must safeguard our meetings to carry our message.

June 21

“After coming to the Narcotics Anonymous Fellowship, we find ourselves among a very special group of people. Many were a great deal worse off than we were. Here we found hope.”

Memphis Review Form - page 17, 9

Hope is the only spiritual principle that can be given. All other principles we must develop from within. Hope lets us know the program is working for us as it has worked for others. At each step in the process of recovery, we feel relief. Alternatives appear out of thin air and we find solutions that give us awareness that we are no longer trapped in a dead end.

When we attend meetings and see other addicts smiling and enjoying life in recovery, our spirit is renewed. This is the hope we share, the therapeutic value of one addict helping another. We must be careful not to quench the hope of others. Newfound hope can be a very fragile and must be encouraged and reinforced with positive suggestions and observations. Stepping on someone's experience or suggestion is almost always wrong. Addicts are quick to see relationships between words and can relate subjects to recovery if they are paying attention..

Nobody hurt like we did. You know, that sharp burning pain. In the rooms we hear personal experiences shared and are sometimes shocked to realize there are people who had it worse than we did! If we engaged in embarrassing sexual activities, there is always a new wrinkle on that subject. If we killed or participated in someone's death, we could always stayed at it and did even more horrible things. If we stole money or merchandise, there are always bigger and badder thieves out there and many find a home in our meetings. Recovery is for people who want a change and are willing to follow certain Steps to get it.

In the early days of NA, if you wanted to take out an NA girl, you had to first have a sit down. Your sponsor, her sponsor and the rest of the oldtimers would all meet and question your intentions, financial resources, and your program. If you got the OK, then a dinner party was arranged with you and the girl sitting next to each other. But you better not dump that girl or boyfriend without another sit down.

June 22

“Step 10 is a continuation of a fearless and searching look within ourselves in order to repair disorders that fear, pride, jealousy, and other ruinous defects can cause.”

Memphis Review Form - page 55, 4

It is worth mentioning that the disorders mentioned above involved keeping people at a distance. Distancing behavior is a regular pattern among addicts who have to be careful to cover up their using to avoid getting busted. The ongoing problems feed our addictive disease! Constantly justifying our actions and reactions that caused us problems with people will get more problems. If we are continually committing the same actions, present problems beget more problems.

When we tell a newcomer to stop making avoidable decisions, they generally do pretty good. It is when they start ‘deciding’ again that new upsets occur. Doing nothing is still doing something. We find food, shelter and clothing. Our feelings are tender in recovery. Some of our seemingly large problems are really small. They seem large because we are not used to dealing with them. New problems are diminished as we grow comfortable when dealing with them. Lots of recovery is making new habit patterns appropriate to our new lives.

NA's pamphlet *Living The Program* may possibly be the best piece of recovery literature in existence. It lists questions to be answered nightly about your program on a separate piece of paper. Some of us photocopy this pamphlet and fill out the copies every night. It is easy to add other questions like, did I gamble today, have road rage, overspend or anything else that might become obsessive. Fantastic literature like this only comes from group conscious and fellowship wide approval. Left lobe thinking is designed to restrict and narrow down concepts and ideas. Spirituality comes from the right lobe and deals with wholistic, field perceptions. Some members use this distinction to reshape their inner life and areas of sensitivity.

June 23

"The message is meaningless unless we live it. If we do live it, we give it more meaning with our lives than any words can express."

Memphis Review Form - page 60, 2

One must walk the walk, not talk the talk. We have seen the later go out the door after sounding so very good. Silver tongue devils can be deadly. This is why NA recovery is so unique and effective. We share our real experience and our success makes that very attractive. Living the Program involves a person's whole life.

Newcomers sometimes smile when they hear, "Recovery is easy! Your just have to change your whole life!" In time, they realize this is an understatement. The first three Steps help us get in touch and establish our relationship with a higher power. The next three pairs of Steps take us from intention to action to clean up our lives on the inside, the surface and among people we have known and places we have been. The last three Steps guide us into an ongoing spiritual life not possible without the first nine Steps.

Seeing addicts getting real life results from slogans and oft repeated phrases catches our attention because we are used to covering up things rather than getting lasting results. When we find ourselves saying these words to those seeking help we realize our membership is real, not just candy coated.

June 24

“The Higher Power we use in N.A. is a lot like this: We begin by simply admitting to the possibility of a power greater than ourselves.”

Memphis Review Form - page 35, 30

This simple admission allows us access prayers that work for us. We can pray for a higher power to help us find a belief we can live with. The help we need to stay clean multiplies the more we use it. We can pray for help to stay clean, just for today! We can pray for help dealing with things at work or with the people in our lives.

One of NA's most cutting edge ideas is that we have Higher Powers of each person's interpretations. Be it Buddha, The Force, Mother Nature, God, Jesus or Allah. When we refer to our higher power as HP in the meetings, it allows people to hear what we are saying without filtering the message. It truly puts NA light years ahead of most spiritual programs. We don't get caught up in emotionally-charged labels.

There is a social custom not to talk about religion or politics among people you don't know because it always leads to anger and conflicts. In NA we often talk about God in general terms and leave off the politics to be socially acceptable. God is good all the time!

June 25

“We apply what we learn in the meetings to all our affairs, using these teachings as a basis for living, but returning, again and again to our groups, both to help and to be helped in our recovery from addictions.”

Memphis Review Form - page 74, 32

The difference between superficial ideas and concepts and those that take us deeper lies in their applicability. It is like a magic screw driver that can turn all sorts of fastenings. We all, or most of us, fall prey to thinking we know all that is. It is seductive! Keeping an honest, open and willing state of mind allows us to take things a step further.

In NA we learn everything we need to stay clean in the first two weeks. Then we just keep forgetting it unless we continue going to meetings. When we forget, it can be deadly. This is what is meant by addiction being a recurrent condition. Surrender and continual learning through going to meetings and helping others keeps our program alive.

Sometimes a member with sixty days sitting in a meeting can transmit a message of hope to a newcomer like no one else. The newcomer can grasp someone having sixty days, but not twenty years, it's just too huge. So when we just go to a meeting, it can have a profound effect we never realize at home or on our own. And at the meeting we need to hear and speak the truth!.

June 26

“One of the simplest and most important parts of our whole recovery process is the concept of “live a day at a time.””

Memphis Review Form - page 75, 1

By living in the present, fully focused on what is happening now, we can be mindful of our actions and not simply react to outside forces. We can take time to figure out an appropriate response in accordance with spiritual principles. We are also going to notice how beautiful our world has become and take pleasure in it. Joy is an essential element of recovery. Gratitude is a muscle that grows with exercise.

“A day at a time” is one of the great liberators for addicts in recovery because it removes the brick wall that confines us to things which do not work out. We can change and change back if we need to. We learn as much or more from our failures as our successes.

How do you eat an elephant? One bite at a time. We can stay clean until the meeting time. Then we can stay clean till bedtime. Our bites may need to be very, very small. Getting from one meeting to the next during the same day is sometimes required. Never underestimate the power of multiple meetings in one day.

June 27

“Some of us sought spiritual guidance through churches, different religions, meditation and cultism. Some of us sought cure by geographical changes, blaming our surroundings and living situations for our problem. This attempt just gave us new people to take advantage of.”

Memphis Review Form - page 24, 25

What we failed to realize is that wherever we are, we bring the problem with us. Solutions to our problems cannot come from outside sources, they must come from within. We have to be open to receive from within! The Steps are the answer to our problems if we can find the courage, willingness and honesty to use the Steps to look inside, see who we are, accept ourselves and seek change.

Finding and developing a relationship with a Higher Power gives us the spiritual power to accomplish great changes we would otherwise be incapable of accomplishing. We start to gain self-acceptance and self-love by realizing we are no longer the despicable depraved people we used to be but are becoming capable of giving hope and love to those coming in after us.

NA is bone head simple. You sit your ass in a lot of meetings, dump the old friends, get involved in service, work the Steps and such. NA is delivered on the third grade level. But doing religions and recovery at the same time and confusing religion with recovery from addiction can be so confusing that it can kill us. What some good members fail to understand is church people are not recovering addicts in most cases and some will offer beer or wine not knowing what a relapse can do to us.

NA is like the short bus. Once we are clean for some time, we are much better equipped to go on to more complicated things. In fact, NA can be boiled down to “go to a meeting”, “go to another meeting”. Ok, now “go to another meeting”. You can sit in the meeting and look at the ceiling fan and still be doing a great job. You do not have to think. Just put your ass in a chair...a lot.

June 28

"The only way we keep from continuing a habit is not to take that first fix, pill, drink or token."

Memphis Review Form - page 85, 25

This line was taken out of the material reviewed for the Basic Text, *Narcotics Anonymous*. The idea was to focus on the disease and not the venue. While this is still a good and valid idea, there is power in breaking habits what makes it important to avoid the context as well as the content. The context involves habit patterns, mood swings, availability of other drugs like road rage, suppressed anger or resentment. When we avoid the specific drugs we took, it may help us make it. But any drug can become our drug of choice. Body drugs are drugs too! The whole program revolves around changing our personalities and getting away from escaping reality. Newcomers are still told to avoid people, places and things associated with their personal using patterns and that will come to include drugs in various forms.

"It's not the caboose that kills you" read a sign in one meeting room. The first one opens the door and then we are no longer in control. The disease has taken control. We may not get back to NA for 15 years...if at all. We may be dead in 24 hours or be facing life in prison. If you are in the rooms of NA, it is almost never by accident.

There was this good looking guy who had a few months and went out. When he came back, he was missing a foot. I will always remember that. A young lady thought she could smoke a joint. The guy she was with killed her with a brick. Addiction is a tragic and progressive disease. What we learn and put into practice changes our whole life for the better!

June 30

"We looked at our differences rather than our sameness. Yet the things we had in common put us all in the same dimension, the dimension of addiction."

Memphis Review Form - page 3, 16

We are often told as newcomers that we need to look for the similarities, not the differences. As newcomers we often looked for anything that would disqualify us, free us from the reality of our addiction. As we look around the rooms, we start to realize that we are not unique. Although our stories might be different, the feelings we have are in common. The self-centeredness, the insecurity, the unworthiness, the fear, guilt, remorse, regret, uselessness we feel we hear shared by others. We also hear how they overcame their negative self-images to have lives of joy and purpose, of peace, serenity and usefulness. We realize we have two things in common, addiction and recovery.

The spiritual life makes us aware of some of the fears and concerns that occupy space in our heads without paying rent. There are words we learn to deal with these things. There are ways to deal with these things that are learnable. The dimension we share grows and this growth gives us room unavailable before the program. "Diction" is the root word in addiction can so imbeds the idea of expression or statement in our disorder. When we are a mess inside our minds and bodies, that gets expressed in our behavior. The characteristics of a using addict are all too well known! The characteristics of a clean addict are only now becoming known to the general public.

Time, movies and personal experience will eventually replace the old picture of an addict stuck in addiction and unable to get out into a new picture of someone happy, balanced and especially grateful to be alive.

JULY

July 1

“Now that we are clean, we have recognized the advantage of getting our own house in order. We can recognize ourselves as the heart of the problem.”

Memphis Review Form - page 55, 12

It was no surprise to discover that our lives had become quite unmanageable as a result of our drug use. This was very clear to see. The real eye opener was after we had been clean for a while, our attempts at controlling our lives, caused us to experience feelings of unmanageability similar to what we experienced when we were using. This is when we discover surrender is the key, and we are the heart of the problem. This discovery is a blessing because if we're the problem we can use the 12 Steps to change.

We might recall the Serenity Prayer at this time, knowing we cannot change another person, we can only change ourselves and pray for the wisdom to know the difference. Part of the miracle of recovery is knowing we can actively participate in our own recovery and cease to be the problem. When we do this, we find ourselves becoming part of the solution.

Computer companies worked hard to make more perfect devices. Much time and energy was devoted to agonizing over which white was the whitest. They also looked at the experience of the customer opening the box. Care and concern help make things better and we want to get better ourselves!

July 2

“Managing our own lives got us to the program of Narcotics Anonymous. What we knew about living when we got here had almost killed us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 65, 33

We may find a way to do what we used to stumble into with something we took time to think through. This is a program of surrender. Each Step will gently ask us to surrender a little deeper. This is why the first step is about surrender. If we fail to grasp this first spiritual principle of surrender, none of the other steps will make much sense. All 12 Steps are based on surrender. As we say in the meetings “we surrender to win.” On a practical level this means we have come to a place in our lives where forcing life had not worked very well for us. We never seemed to grasp that using force to get our way usually puts us at odds with someone else. This can result in the wreckage of our present.

This conflict usually concerns our family and then the law. When our lives become unmanageable, someone tends to step in to manage it. This may be spouses, sometimes our parents but most often toward the end of our addiction, it is the law. We have lawyers who tell us where to go and what to say or we have judges that tell us what to do. Larger and larger consequences will result if we don't do what we are told. We lose our say in our own lives!

In NA we surrender to recovery. We turn our will, our lives, our decision making process over to NA and a loving sponsor who will help guide us into this new way of living. Many sponsors have been living a surrendered life for a many years. They are very knowledgeable about how surrender is done on a daily basis. Most often they will be more than willing to help us learn this new way of life. How to let go of our lives and not try to run the show. How to let go and let God or just how to take our fingers off the situation and let Good Orderly Direction takes its naturally correcting way in the situation. We have learned in recovery that oftentimes our attempts to control causes more harm than good. If we just let life happen it often has a naturally self-correcting way about it.

Just For Tonight: As the comic book character Pogo Possum said; “We have met the enemy and they is us!”

July 3

“Learning the art of helping others when it is appropriate, without creating resentments, is a marvelous benefit of the N.A. program.”

Memphis Review Form - page 60, 5

As the 3rd Tradition states: “The only requirement for membership is a desire to stop using.” The first thing we do when helping the still suffering addict is to make sure they have this desire. We have learned through much difficulty there are many people who come to NA that are not through using. They are not done manipulating others. They are not done with their addiction and are just looking for someone else to get over on. They are so lost in their addiction that they don’t even have a clue, nor think they need one. They are not even sure they need help. Except someone or some institution says they need this help. They are not even sure they have a problem and actually require help to change. Often times, we have learned to give them minimal assistance by giving them some literature or aiding them in getting to meetings. This is where the magic happens. We don’t bring them to our homes as they are sure to come to size up what they can take from us.

For every one of these ‘not-so surrendered folks,’ there are dozens of addicts who are basically through using. They want no more of their old way of living. They are ready and willing to follow directions, take the suggestions and do the assignments without question. We learn to focus more of our efforts on these folks and spend less time on those who just want to take and take.

We have come to understand that the therapeutic value of one addict helping another is the magic of simply sharing our experience, strength and hope as to how we have met and overcome the challenges of getting and staying clean. The amazing thing is that by carrying the message to others, it helps solidify these spiritual principles in our own lives.

Just For Tonight: I can only keep what I have by giving it away!

July 4

“Any thought that we are going to be perfect has to be smashed.”

Memphis Review Form - page 55, 16

The idea that perfection for humans ignores our experience. If we are willing to surrender and do the best we can, that is enough more often than not. In ourselves, or in our friends, we pray for strength and guidance when overwhelmed by a demand or situation over which we are powerless. Personal surrender frees us of much of the poor thinking we practiced in active addiction. Feeling badly about ourselves makes us set unreachable goals to feel better. As we listen to others sharing in meetings, we begin to realize other people have the same problems. We see how turned around we have been. We find ourselves telling someone to not be so hard on themselves - then we apply the same to our lives!

Constantly striving for perfection and falling short can give us feelings of not being good enough, that can result again in those feelings of low self worth. We may not be perfect, but we are definitely doing better than we ever had in the past.

Setting reasonable goals and standards for ourselves give us immediate relief. Without the tension and stress that goes with trying to reach impossible goals, we can see, hear and feel more accurately. Part of the magic of helping others is having information on how other people feel as hopeless and confused as we do at times. This information based on our own observation and experience mixes in a little reality. We can deal with life on life's terms when we have a better idea of what those terms are!

July 5

"The only way we recover is to apply what we learn from each other, on a daily basis. Our growth is a lifetime process."

Memphis Review Form - page 62, 32

The more we learn, the more we are capable of learning. Generally, our next best move is right in front of us. We don't recognize it because we dislike and distrust openness and honesty. When we try something new and it works for us, we become curious about checking out some of our other scary opportunities!

One member was at a Unity Day and a woman approached him and asked how he was doing. After explaining his complicated life and game plan, she stopped him and said "You need to get out of your head". He was stunned at how she had just hit the nail on the head.

Later in the day he was walking down a hall and she was talking to another man. As he walked past he heard her say "You need to get out of your head". He realized that this piece of universal advice was so powerful it applied to many situations.

Clean is a whole new experience for us. Many of us associate being clean with cleaning up wreckage as we prepare for our next spree! Living the clean life on a daily basis is a whole new ball game. Generally, we over-analyse everything. Recovery is getting in touch with our feelings and balancing them against what we are learning.

July 6

"Many fortunate things occur mysteriously, but there are no accidents. We come to understand that our recoveries are a gift from a Power greater than ourselves."

Memphis Review Form - page 36, 3

Getting used to having a higher power may seem a bit strange at first. Spiritual growth can feel frightening or unreal. Elusive understandings and surprising good luck can lull us into taking it all for granted. After all, if we are not using, lots of things do get better, apparently on their own! Relapse often follows taking recovery for granted. If this happens to us, we get back to a meeting and start taking the N.A. program more seriously. As addicts, our very lives depend on it. This is the harsh reality we have to revisit time and time again. Addicts die of addiction all the time!

Developing habits of thoughtfulness and living one day at a time, we hear others talking about higher power and conscious contact. We get curious about what they might mean. One day, we are sitting quietly and letting our mind go out of gear and realize we are doing it. We are doing conscious contact. And things are working out for us! One thing about clean time, we have more of it to consider and ask for help. We also find the NA Program gives us people who understand and many who are willing to help us! And the things that are happening are evidence of our higher power! Why didn't someone tell us about this! Then we realize many of these things are repeated in the meetings and written in the literature we have been reading.

Having a Higher Power we can love and trust with our lives, makes it easier to practice our conscious contact. At some point we discover that this is not confined to recovering addicts only, it is a regular part of the healthy human condition. Surrender, prayer and meditation are part of our daily lives in NA.

July 7

"We admitted that we used drugs, but many of us did not think we had a problem."

Memphis Review Form - page 1, 5

What we knew about recovery came from uninformed people like fellow students in school and co-workers. TV and movies were another untrustworthy source of information. Budweiser will get you dates, Chanel No. 5 will make you beautiful and smoking Marlboros will make you a real man! By the time we get to N A, we are hungry to get some real answers - answers that will work in real life! Using drugs was confused with partying, having a good time, an attitude adjustment or dealing with tension. Taking more drugs was not an answer we could live with.

Another great realization came when we realized we were getting our information from fellow addicts who were also in denial and still using drugs!

This is the most confusing disease of all. The oldtimers are the most expert people at understanding this disease because they have years of experience working with other addicts, listening in meetings and working the steps. These are the few people on the planet who can help newcomers recover.

We hit what we call a bottom. This consists of two parts: hitting the low point and perceiving we are in trouble. We must have both to have that moment of clarity to want to quit. Going to meetings, working with a sponsor and reading the literature increases our perception. Sitting in prison has given many addicts the time needed to realize they have hit their bottoms!.

July 8

"The smart ones who argue a lot usually die. The open-minded ones get to live."

Memphis Review Form - page 55, 18

It is harder for more intelligent people to surrender because in our world many things give way to intelligence. It is easier for them to rationalize. There are things that require sensitivity and savvy to understand. These are sometimes wordless, or defined by special words that go beyond objects and labels. A loving, caring person is not especially respected in certain parts of our society, yet their value is beyond price. Those who go along, get along. This may help us at work and in some areas of our lives.

Many of us used drugs that disrupted our minds and left us blasted. Fortunately, we regain many of our former skills and abilities. Others may have to learn to be grateful they have any good sense at all. Many suffer permanent damage to some extent. Addiction is a seriously limiting disease. Mental and physical disability may be something we have to learn to live with. Compassion and giving comfort to those in distress is a positive ability and helps to see someone disabled like we are get better. We can be grateful when we someone asks us for help..

Many addicts in recovery are clean for years only to find themselves maneuvering into positions of control. Learning to laugh at oneself is a handy tool on many occasions. The man who cannot laugh at himself is missing one of life's biggest jokes! Humor and talking about the crazy thoughts that wander through our minds from time to time gives us a healthy outlet.

July 9

“Being able to serve as an instrument of a loving God and participation in the recovery of others keeps a sense of wonder and gratitude in our lives. Giving comfort and encouragement to others encourages and comforts us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 69, 7

In general, when we keep our focus on gratitude and doing our part, everything gets better. Being open to what others are screaming at us, allows us to take pressure off a difficult situation and shift over to doing something to help things along. Apologizing for making someone uncomfortable can't hurt in most cases. Treating someone the way we want to be treated is also a good idea. Saying a quiet, silent prayer keeps us in touch with our higher power and this is our main source of solutions.

Often the smallest kindness on our part can make a huge difference to newcomers. Simply shaking their hand, getting to know their name, these can be huge to a frightened addict just coming in. They know no one and everything familiar is gone. It's terrifying to just go into a meeting room for the new person. They need a friend and they need one fast if they are to not cut and run. We are warm people who know how to do this. We forget just how it was when we first walked in the door. How quickly we forget.

Many members may not know about the secret of saying a silent prayer like, “God, use me as an instrument if it be your will. I feel good about this person and would be glad to help.” When we do that, we find the words come to us with surprising ease. The response from the newcomer tells us when we get through to them. It is a definite thrill to identify with an addict who does not yet know they can live clean!

July 10

"We are experts at making ourselves so frustrated that we lose perspective completely."

Memphis Review Form - page 75, 7

Losing perspective means our thinking is off and we need to take a break. Since surrender is a keyword in our recovery, we find we get relief by not fighting. We stop exerting pressure and take a break. Usually we can see right off where we were going wrong.

We lose perspective all the time and don't even realize it, we just feel lost and confused. Fear of loss of control is common among us. Learning to stop and pray for help is a multipurpose tool in recovery. We use it to deal with things we are powerless over.

Actually, a lot of the tasks we do come off without a hitch. We show up at the Department of Motor vehicles as soon as they open and breeze right thru. We go to the grocery store with an exact list of what we need. We call the wireless carrier and make arrangement to pay the bill a bit late and keep it turned on. We need to give ourselves credit for these small wins.

It's easy to beat ourselves up completely if we read these quotes too much. Information is like food, eat a little and let it go down before eating more. Acting on good information keeps it from going stale.

July 11

[“Being open-minded allows us to hear something that might save our lives.”](#)

[Memphis Review Form - page 66, 2](#)

If this sounds pretty dramatic, it is. Most of us have developed defense mechanisms that keep us locked up in a narrow, defensive and lonely state of mind. Our new found hope opens many doors for us, starting with believing change is possible. Hope is like a flame that warms us. Even if it is small in the beginning, the warmth makes a difference and feels good. We learn to trust our feelings and go with them as our life steadily improves. Sometimes it is hard for us to see the old ways creeping in and don't accurately notice we can begin to work our recovery program in reverse - using our tools to justify and condone behaviour of self-righteousness and isolation.

One addict noticed that if he went to three meetings in a row, that he became more receptive to hearing new ideas and looking at himself. He concluded that the first meeting found him shut down, the second began to open him up and the third found him almost completely open minded, anxious to learn and willing to change. Missing meetings works against this effect. We begin to fall into our old habit patterns. We begin to justify picking people apart. We start thinking they comb their hair funny. We look for differences, right past the similarities.

Being open lets in the fresh air. We identify. We develop an ability to acquire memories without having to go through all the pain! We can try on new ideas without having to necessarily adopt them permanently. Our interaction becomes a treasure house of new ideas, attitudes and opportunities.

I knew an addict who sold mobile homes. Often he would be baffled about why a person failed to qualify for a loan. He would wait a few weeks and call up the loan officer and chat them up. Eventually, he would ask them why the person failed to qualify. And get this: the loan officer would tell him exactly where the deal went wrong! Gradually, he began to see the world from their point of view. He changed the way he filled out the forms and his loans began to go through. Through honesty, open-mindedness and willingness to try, he stepped right past former limitations.

July 12

“Abstinence is the basis of our program. Any mood or mind-altering chemical, prescription or not, is poison to our bodies.”

Memphis Review Form - page 85, 31

There is literature available outside our approved material that goes right to the heart of the thinking behind taking drugs to ‘feel better’ or adjust our moods without changing the things that produce stress or bad feelings in our day to day lives. This is hardly an outside issue. There are plenty of people who may benefit from various treatments that include meds. They don’t have to call themselves N A members or follow our 12 Steps. There are also many members in good standing who both work our program and get the relief they seek from good doctors. Folks have to find what works for them. Our role is supportive, not directive. The important thing for me to remember is that I can’t use drugs in any form. That’s total abstinence. If someone else can, that’s ok by me. But do not call it clean or try to ‘adjust’ our literature to open the door to use of chemicals that might make us feel a little better but also keep us from dropping the habits and attitudes that create the stress and tension.

One addict noted that in his 30 plus years, he had only seen 7 people take antidepressants and stay clean long term. The ones who didn’t want to hear it, said it was just his opinion. He responded that it was his observation. Once we open the door to mind and mood altering chemicals, we are no longer driving the bus, our disease is behind the wheel. We know from sad personal experience that any one of us is susceptible to the disease of lies, the disease of addiction.

To the man with a hammer, everything looks like a nail. To a doctor with a prescription pad, everybody needs a pill. Antidepressants are so over prescribed, especially when the doctor hears the word “Addict”, that they are a drug epidemic in themselves. These doctors are not versed on addiction. They are taught to treat the symptoms and to prescribe an anecdote to those symptoms, meaning that for each symptom goes along with a drug. A computer may make the decision for them! Of course they do not understand the disease, it is baffling. That’s what baffling means! We addicts cannot afford to be confused about this, our very lives are at stake. There are many ways our being nice takes the edge off our stricture that NA is a program of total abstinence.

July 13

"If we clean our bodies by daily abstinence we should clean our minds of preconceptions based on past experience. It is those who stay clean when it seems like it isn't worth it who make it."

Memphis Review Form - page 86, 3

Not picking up isn't everything, it's the only thing. If we are going to get loaded over a car or a relationship, we must have not wanted recovery very bad. In the old days the rules were much stricter. Naturally we want to find an easier, softer way. We like to be enabled. If recovery were easy, we wouldn't appreciate it. We learn self-respect as we continue to stay clean and begin the process of working the Steps. We learn that by taking the focus off of self and go to a meeting to find someone asking for help. It may be that they may not want help, but just taking the focus off of self, is a success in and of itself. When we are not thinking about using, we begin to focus more on recovery.

Preconceptions based on past experience often do not work because if we are clean, our situation has changed for the better. Past experience belongs in our crazy past, not our clean present. We get up, clean up and go to work every day. We don't need to know who's got what and what's coming in next week. Our life gets simpler, then our life gets better. We get to spend more time with our new friends and travel to check out new meetings. When we dump old habits and mannerisms, we make room for new stuff. We can actually sit down and plan a charming evening for a special person. We can remember someone's birthday!

While it may seem like these are little things, they are the very things we could not do before. Clean time means we have more time to take with living. And as we all know, the more you learn, the more you can learn.

July 14

“During our active using, we often lived way beyond our means, out of necessity. Unfortunately, not all of us lose our extravagance and greed easily, ever after we stop using.”

Memphis Review Form - page 75, 17

Living within our means and practicing a little restraint just means we'll pay the rent on time and our lights won't be cut off next month. Later, it means more, much more. It means we will be free of financial worries that we had become accustomed to enduring. Many of us were addicted to a painful way of living. By creating conflicts, we could sometimes hide our games. We hid behind clouds of confusion.

We love the grandiose lifestyle. Big cars, big jobs and big breasted women. Some ladies live to flaunt! We can flaunt it, but we also need to have some degree of humility. No one says we have to live like monks once we got clean. If this were so, not many people would stick. Working the 12 Step provides a steady supply of good feelings of accomplishment. Happy npeople make things happen!

One member wore a lot of turquoise jewelry to establish that he was not broke. But he also went to lots of meetings and his service commitment was cleaning the mens bathroom weekly.

In China, everyone works in the rice fields one day per month to keep them humble. The best service commitments in NA can be at the group level.

July 15

"Clean living is only the beginning of a new life. Life without fear is a gift we receive for the price of acceptance."

Memphis Review Form - page 36, 12

Incredible as this may be, it is really that simple. Considering the pain and despair we have suffered, it almost seems unfair to find such a simple way out of our insanity. There are things ahead of you down recovery road that you won't be able to see until you get there. That's why we practice the NA Program on a daily basis. Do what's in front of you and don't let yesterday and tomorrow distract you from taking full advantage of what's in front of you right now, today!

Freedom from active addiction sounds almost impossible to us when we first hear it, until we see others smiling and laughing . As we stay clean for a while, we begin to feel better about life as we begin to experience surrender and acceptance. We feel some of that freedom from active addiction that we read in our literature, and hear about in our meetings! We can get clean, stay clean and find a new way to live. This is how we become free from active addiction. Stopping using has to come first. We learn to stay clean, work with our sponsor, and see evidence that active addiction is not just actively using drugs. It is also our reaction to people and situations as well.

Many of us lose track of how much 'fear' controls much of our lives, thinking and actions. Fear can be treated like 'just another habit!' You break habits by doing things differently until the new way replaces the old. If you are drug free today, don't let fear drag you around by the nose. Life without fear is a gift we receive for the price of acceptance.

July 16

"Humility is an honest self-acceptance, which leads to further acceptance of the conditions around us."

Memphis Review Form - page 76, 2

While humility is seen by most persons in our culture as a matter of bowing and scraping, real humility is more likely plain honesty. Humble persons have strength of character and will be staunch if mistreated or dealt with unfairly. It is not ignorance or a lack of inner strength. Probably it seems that way to those for whom humility is just a word. Internal resources build up within our minds and hearts that allow us to acquire what is known as good character.

Adaptation to the reality around us puts us in a condition where we are able to meet the demands and situation we are likely to encounter. This results in personal self-confidence and the ability to help those in need.

One of the nice things about recovery is it gets 'in your face' real about what's been bothering us and what we can do about it. Addiction is a life-limiting and life-extinguishing disease. Recovery is a life expanding and life affirming process where we gather strength with others and make common-cause of rebuilding and reconstructing our shattered lives.

Our internal state determines what we can perceive and how we meet reality on it's own ground.

July 17

“Addiction is physical, mental, and spiritual . Therefore,we believe that we must develop faith in a Higher Power before we can hope to recover from its destruction.”

Memphis Review Form - page 63, 1

The entire basis of the 12 step programs rests on self-evident truth. Helping one another access the people and information that will help pave the way to new lives. Helping others like ourselves gives us a window on reality we can get no other way. . The Twelve Steps of NA lead us from surrender to discovery of a higher power we can trust with our lives. Our will is our thinking and our lives are our bodies. Care is loving attention and concern.

Then we reduce our personal histories to a list of things we did right and things we wish had gone differently. By sharing our inventory with God and another human being, we take power away from the gnawing pain of negative expectation that we will repeat our errors. Our willingness to let go of personal habits and preferences allow our old ways to drop away and make room for new pathways to open. We move through these pathways in our new freedom. Closure removes the barriers to our personal relationships, even if it is only on the level of willingness. It is not merely symbolic, it changes things in reality.

The big changes come from personal prayer and regular meditation with inventory cleaning up messes as we go. Meditation stops the endless rush forward and we learn to reprogram ourselves. This is why NA is not a cult! These lead to our spiritual awakening and the galaxy of principles which help guide us in situations as they arise. All this comes from our origins in simple faith and trust in a proven pathway to recovery from addiction. We have to stop doing the things that make us feel badly if we want to feel goodness. We leave the world of things behind as we move into the realm of spiritual reality.

July 18

“If you want to change your life -- risk sharing! It is by taking risks we have almost lost our lives, by asking for help in the same way, we can change.”

Memphis Review Form - page 69, 18

Sharing allows us to see into the lives of others who like us have lost their way. We can choose and pick up on things that we can try to practice on a daily basis. In this way we find what works for us. If we try out enough shoes, we are bound to find a pair that fits. If your ego keeps you from asking for help, you are not likely to get help. Even if help comes to us, it is hard or impossible to accept help until we believe it possible. Addiction keeps us from recognizing help even if it is staring us in the face! We often feel insulted that someone presumes to offer us help! It makes us feel 'less than.' Big mistake!

Many of us have found that abstinence, meetings and interacting with clean addicts helps us see through the fog and take notice that help is at hand! Even if it is hard for many of us to understand in the beginning, it may help in the beginning to realize that addiction is a self-destructive disease. Addiction attacks us in our ability to perceive and communicate. This is why meetings are so important. We do a group reality check. Most often we find we are in there, creating the very problems that seem to have us tied in knots.

Helping others helps us see ourselves differently and after a while we treat ourselves differently. Everyone has heard the old saying, “Slow to anger, quick to forgive.” How about a new one? “Slow to get in trouble and quick to get out!” “Take it easy” is an NA slogan because if something is hard, we have learned to slow down and look more closely. Sometimes our HP is just trying to avoid difficulty that we cannot see coming with our physical eyes. We have to use our spiritual eyesight!

July 19

“We no longer have to make fools of ourselves by standing up for some non-existent values.”

Memphis Review Form - page 66, 9

Pretending to be more than we are is a fear-based behavior that seemed to protect us from negative judgements by others as to our conduct or behavior. Hiding from the truth is not necessary if our house is in order.

False pride and ego may be all someone has to hang on to if they lack real skills and abilities. As they calm down and get with the Program of NA, they acquire new skills their need to put up a false front disappears. The more we grow, the more we know. The more we know, the more we can do things that were once out of reach.

A lot of the changes we do not see, but from time to time we happen to recognize that we are able to do things that we could never do before, put up with irritants that we could not endure before and visualize what move to make next in almost any situation!.

From time to time we have huge leaps ahead that simply cannot be ignored. All of a sudden we seem to be completely different people, able to do seemingly impossible tasks a few weeks ago. But most of the time the changes are so slow and subtle that they don't even register till someone says “You have grown.” Sometimes we realize life is like a rapidly processed movie that runs by itself, and then, we realize we are all writers, actors and directors. Our ideas, our actions, and our focus makes up our experience of life. God grant me a good role, please! I will, I can and I'm going to.

July 20

"One of our greatest enemies is resentment. It has the power to kill. The only way to be rid of resentment is to develop humility, in the form of forgiveness."

Memphis Review Form - page 76, 9

Actually, praying for those people whom we resent is a very effective way of clearing resentments. We can pray for them to have all the stuff that we wish to have. Strangely, curiously, when we do this, we experience relief. It is almost like the resentment is like a bone stuck in our throat that keeps us from swallowing. Free of the re-sent-ment, we get to go on with our lives.

One addict, very angry at NAWS, prayed for the World Board to have unlimited money, property and prestige. His resentment at NAWS was so completely removed that he could no longer talk with others who were angry with NAWS. The message is that as the resentment decreased, he could study, discuss, and envision ways to accomplish things that once seemed blocked by a small West Coast corporation. It's all our money. When we want low cost, high quality conventions, we will have them. When we want a meeting in that jail, we will go see the warden and talk it up until we find some members who agree with us. You rarely get good results when you are loud and negative.

There appear to be some spiritual laws that regulate reality. Like you have to give it away to keep it. You have to teach what you have learned to make room for more learning. While discussion may not always prove you to be right, it always tends to make you more correct! Recovery allows us to pursue these spiritual laws with others doing the same. The result is knowledge of spirituality that amounts to a great series of breakthroughs that continue all through our cleantime.

Make no mistake about it, just as a lion trainer is most likely to die from a big cat attack, we as addicts are most likely to be killed by a justified resentment. This is our nemesis. The problem is that in the midst of a justified resentment, we forget our training. We are over taken by rage and are likely to go out and revert to our old ways.

Black belts train incessantly to automatically go into their stance. For recovering addicts, we go to meetings all the time to remember the basic tools of recovery including being aware of justified resentments. This is how we survive. And unless we regularly go to meetings, when we are in the midst of resentment, we will not go to a meeting. Going to meetings has to be an automatic routine. We just go every few days regardless. Then when we are in trouble, it occurs to us, "I have not been to a meeting for 3 days. I guess I better go." This then saves us from our resentment.

July 21

“The bottom line of Narcotics Anonymous is staying clean. When we realize that we can’t use drugs in any form and live, we are ready to admit our powerlessness.”

Memphis Review Form - page 86, 9

When we are exhausted, out of money, friends and excuses, it may be easier to admit we are powerless and our lives have become unmanageable. We may find the resulting teachability can be applied to many other areas. Surrender is a mighty tool. We can ask for and accept help and help comes from many sources. Puffed up on pride and ego, we may find our ability to ask for and receive gratefully help decreases. Then when the help slows down or stops coming entirely, you’ll hear some members complain the Program doesn’t work! After a time, we begin to see the ‘trouble’ is actually helping us by keeping us in touch with our need for help!

Relapse is not a subtle state to be in! The effects are immediate and devastating. If we are a little quieter and go to work on time, that may be a misleading benefit. Like the prohibition against taking the first drug in any form, the visible relapse comes later when we imagine we are using successfully. This vicious cycle must be avoided at all costs. It’s not the last one that gets us loaded, it is all the times before that!

Relapsing into self-will is quite instructive. Many businessmen are supportive, positive and alert to their employees need for instruction and guidance. Their businesses flourish and sometimes their competitors become bitter and jealous of their workforce! They become critical and get drawn into a negative mindset that forces their best employees to run for cover. They dare not excel else the boss will get angry! A company that retains bad employees will find that their best will leave lest they become undercut by misplaced blame. Like many other things, it may take a while to see through to the core of these problems.

July 22

“Those of us who have been involved in service for a long time or in getting a group started and keeping the doors open through the hard early days sometimes have a hard time letting go of the reins. Sometimes our egos get in the way, sometimes ungrounded fears get in the way, and sometimes the group gets in the way.”

Memphis Review Form - page 95, 17

No one claims to completely understand the miracle of our message and our recovery. Therefore there is no safe and sure way to make rules for members to obey blindly. We all need to look up now and then to see how we are doing. Paying attention to the facial expressions of other members gives us the best way to determine when to pass the baton of leadership to someone else. If the moment passes, it can break the spirit of interpersonal sharing. The optimum is usually brief, genuine shares about what is happening in one's life or a current concern, then sit back for others to share. Cross talk and a few members swapping comments leaves out the rest of the group and that too can interrupt the sharing. If you and I share our personal truth and experience, we leave it at that and pay attention to what others are sharing.

Someone observed that people generally share with other people who are at or near the same level of growth and development. This may be true. If it is, it might partly explain why people hold back or leave the room if someone is talking down to them or gives an unscheduled lecture. It disadvantages others and stops the open sharing of personal truth. They may not be consciously mad or angry, they just feel unwanted or unneeded. This is one reason we wait from someone who is hurting to ask for help. Questions signal readiness to receive help.

For some reason, many of our best members forget to pray or meditate to get their answers. What if we found out someday that many of our biggest questions could only be answered if we slowed down and opened our minds and our hearts.

July 23

“ When we have a strong faith in a Power greater than ourselves, and use that faith in our daily lives, that Power will be able to reach us and supply us with the strength and guidance that we need to recover.”

Memphis Review Form - page 63, 3

Faith is visible in the changes we can see in our lives. Staying open to what other members share is a good practice because it gives us dozens of windows into the recovery experience of others. There is no end to what we can learn and practice. Sometimes it takes a few tries to get it right. Nobody recovers overnight. We practice what we learn and may have to wait a while to see the results. Hey, we waited for the dope man! Don't give up before the next miracle.

Going to meetings, reading good recovery literature and visiting with our HP gets us in the 'mood to receive.' The mood to receive keeps the door open in our minds and we find some strange, helpful, stuff tumbling through to our conscious minds. We use these spiritual hints and clues to assemble our own mental picture. We usually find it useful the same day. .

Conscious contact seems to be a spiritual doorway to our personal belief system that best suits us. We all have a right to our beliefs and what we build on that platform becomes a tower of strength and principles that fill in the canyons of our pain and swamps of our confusion. When we are able to pass it on, it becomes part of our internal resources.

July 24

"It is a way of life for the addicts who want to learn to live clean and have discovered one another. We share our mental and spiritual resources for the good of everyone."

Memphis Review Form - page 69, 29

NA must be woven into the fabric of our lives. It must be part of the daily routine, the weekly routine. We go to the 5:30 meeting simply because we go there all the time. It's like school children getting hungry at the scheduled time for lunch.

We get to know the people in the meeting and what they are into. It takes time to make friends. This is why we go out for coffee after the meetings. We learn about people's hobbies, passions, families, dogs. It seems trivial but this is what being friends is all about. Knowing that other person's world opens the door of friendship and creates the bonds between us. .

And they learn of our world. The irritating neighbor, our beloved dog, the Mustang in the garage that we hope to get running again. We become a band of brothers. Many times we pick up where we left off at some point before addiction began to crumple our lives. Human beings are built to live in communities that are mutually supportive. Each person has perceptions and talents that help feed and protect the members of their communities from the youngest babe to the oldest lady or gentleman.

July 25

“Along with this they also accept that they do have special and valuable experiences which can benefit the group. They become a resource for the group; seeking neither to control the group nor to set themselves apart. It is at this time that their long service truly contributes the most. They encourage us, inspire us, and teach us by example.”

Memphis Review Form - page 97, 2

The material in the Grey Book leads up to this sentence enumerating the things that a person can go through as they progress in service. Direct personal service is the most important service NA has to offer. Calling up members we barely know and writing down what they say, leads us into the amazing recovery world that connects all our members. The ‘resource’ idea is crucially important. A group without someone to turn to in the advent of unexpected difficulty is in trouble. This happens if everyone is getting confused and ready to set aside spiritual principles to get their way. Having a resource to get them back on the same page is a non-toxic exit to conflicts resulting from simple disagreements.

Realizing that the differences among our identity group is an asset not a liability is an important jump forward. If we are having trouble with something and call a few members, we can sort out what they say in general along with helpful particulars. Shared recovery experience is the basis for all NA recovery. Since we focus on what we really do in our lives, it gives power to the general ideas and principles that guide us.

Each one of us become ‘resources to NA’ as we accumulate information from our travels, readings and personal experience. In general, persons serving as resources are careful to qualify the information they give out as to hearsay, personal observation, or reliable source. They respect anonymity unless the person asking for help knows personally the person they are speaking of. We get numbers from the questioner and pass them along to another member who can then contact the person wanting information. We don’t give out numbers to third parties. This practice is not cut in stone but is the practice applied in most cases.

July 26

"The newcomer is our lifeblood of N.A. and when one comes to us seeking help we welcome them with open arms."

Memphis Review Form - page 97, 30

The principle here is obvious. Evaluating the situation requires some common sense. Sometimes newcomers exhibit symptoms of mental disturbance that make it hard to determine if they are serious about recovery or dancing on air mentally. Most often we are qualified to determine which is the case. We have always seen people transit into N A members if the disease and desire are there. Some people with mental illness benefit from the 12 Step process where all else fails!.

Surrender, belief in the process and just calling a halt opens them to help. Sometimes it just takes time. Perhaps the important thing here is to remind us everyone in N A is a miracle and we were all in bad shape when we got here! Patience, tolerance and humility are tools we use to carry our message. No sense in telling people something they are not ready to hear. Fear and memories of past pain erect walls to protect us. We allow others to have their own individual preferences out of respect. We never know for sure what a person has been through. Anyone smart enough to seek help has earned our respect. We don't use their asking for help as an opportunity to play God or lay down the law to them. When we walls come down through trust and faith, it is time to gently bring up sensitive subjects.

Seen in this light, recovery and carrying our message become like an art form. We move by feel, trusting the Spirit to guide us. Since we pray to be used as instruments, we are constantly growing in our ability. Newcomers will establish a few members they turn to for help over time. It keeps our message free and open to the many variations that occur among addicts seeking recovery.

July 27

"Many of us could not visualize a life without drugs, let alone want it. Many of us had reached the point in our addiction where we felt there was no hope for us, we only wanted a little relief."

Memphis Review Form - page 98, 11

Carrying our message requires us to pay attention and raise our consciousness to scope out what the newcomer is seeking and what they need to know next. Staying clean is the main thing. Our open door policy insures that there will always be issues about medication and total abstinence. Some people have to take meds to survive. But taking meds which do not get them high. They are not drugs sold on the street. There is now and probably will be plenty of confusion on this subject. So we have to pray and be open minded. Our combined experience is a great resource.

Still there will always be addicts seeking recovery who need and require total abstinence. Generally those who practice total abstinence need to be sensitive to those who have problems. Those who have problems, should not criticize those who practice total abstinence. We practice 'consciousness based recovery.' The most important thing is to surrender and practice what works for us. Unfortunately, members on meds may not really need them and will want to make their usage part of the NA program. This cannot be. In a world populated by profit oriented prescribers there is plenty of room for care and concern on this subject. Many members stay on their meds and later get off under their doctor's supervision. Many are mis-prescribed. We cannot control this. We are not all powerful and never claim to be!

The information we gain about addiction helps us stay clean as long as we are focused on adding to that information with our own personal experience. If we let ourselves drift into distraction and forget the basics of recovery, we can pave the way to relapse by dropping the new attitudes and living habits that helped us get clean in the first place. There are countless time when we feel all is lost and the next day, we just wake up and go about our business.

July 28

“Many of us have come to believe that the forces of life know what our real needs are and will take care of us when undisturbed by self-will.”

Memphis Review Form - page 36, 19

One of the things we get to do in recovery is inventory our lives. What we have done in the past, how we are doing at present and what we foresee ourselves doing in the future. In fear and desperation, we were often driven to do things that led to shame and guilt. In recovery we are gently led away from obsession and compulsion. It may be that the strong drive to deal with things helped us survive. Today, we have a choice. We can stop, look and listen. We can pray for help from our HP. We can ask our new friends and sponsors for help. All these take out some of the bumps and many of the grinds that used to comprise our lives.

It is obvious that the forces of life are in our favor, else we would not be here. Surrender and faith are the keys to a new life. The next is to straighten out our muddy thinking and problematic living habits. Then we begin our awesome journey into the life of the spirit. Spiritual principles based on honesty, open mindedness and the willingness to try take us far beyond our former boundaries. Honesty about what happened in the past, open-mindedness about finding what role we played in events and willingness to try for the future. A good attitude always helps.

We find our futures are controlled by our beliefs. When we change our beliefs, our futures change to match our beliefs. Believing ourselves to be in the loving care of our higher power allows us a chance to sit back and let God paddle the canoe. Our past inventory is taken out of the dark and into the light. We put our defects into the light and are willing to let them go. When we ask God to remove them they go away. All that is left are the occasions and events we want to put closure on by making amends. Now we are free to go on with our lives and follow the road to our spiritual awakening.

July 29

"Do we really want to be rid of our old resentments, our anger, our fears? Do we really understand that they are a deadly poison in the heart of an addict?"

Memphis Review Form - page 46.20

When we argue for our limitations, sure enough, they are ours. Most all of us have a few complaints about things that bother us when we get clean. We will never be happy until we get rid of our resentments, anger and fear. Much of our concern stems from our inability to surrender and our lack of a belief in a loving, caring higher power. Each time we eliminate something that blocks our happiness, we make room for something good to take its place.

We hear during readings at the beginning of each meeting that "most of all we harmed ourselves." Once we have done a fearless and searching moral inventory we come to understand the truth in this statement and how our actions and behaviors have damaged more than just our relationships with others. The negative behaviors during our active addiction damaged our spirit, which led to low self esteem as we diminished ourselves in our own eyes. That in turn caused us to seek relief and escape through using, which led to even lower self esteem. This cycle of diminishing returns is part and parcel of active addiction.

If we want to break this cycle, when faced with the choice of holding onto resentment, anger and fear or letting go, we can begin by asking ourselves, "How is this going to harm my spirit? Do I really want to do that to myself again?" The power to choose, to make healthier choices is a gift of recovery. We are no longer trapped in a cycle of negativity. Letting go and turning over our fear and resentments to the God of our understanding is a process we can undertake by making a simple decision to show ourselves the love and kindness we all deserve.

July 30

“Recovering addicts take great pleasure in helping other suffering addicts recover. Recovery as found in Narcotics Anonymous must come from within and no one can get clean for anyone else.”

Memphis Review Form - page 69, 33

Nothing is so exhilarating as taking a homeless addict to lunch. We see the disbelief in their eyes that someone actually cared about them. Often, we see them waiting for us to talk down to us. Make a point of telling them someone helped us. Don't give advice. We do not have all the answers! Then as we see them putting days together, we get a warm fuzzy feeling inside. A life has been saved and we carried the messenger. Others have befriended us and now we befriend others in our turn.

Through this process, we are praying for strength and guidance. We are careful to keep our egos in check. Sticking to spiritual principles, we share our own true experience. We do not want our recovery to be based on mumbo-jumbo. Facts of real addict experience guiding us in our recovery. Listening to their problems reminds us of what drugs do to us. Listen for questings. They indicate what the person is ready to receive.

Our spirit bubbles up when we pray to be used as an instrument. It does the work for us. We smile as we realize once again, the principles of NA work when nothing else will do.

July 31

“Many of us cling to our fears, doubts, and self-loathing or hatred of others, because there is a certain distorted security in familiar pain.”

Memphis Review Form - page 46, 22

It is natural to seek comfort and pleasure yet there is a danger we addicts must face. Getting clean and staying clean means we do things a little differently each day. This is the basis for our strength. We dare to change - for the better. Some of the things we try don't work out. There is a great advantage in living clean one day at a time. We don't have to keep doing things that don't work out. We share at meetings and carefully listen others. It is this cleansing learning process that produces recovery growth!

These ways of seeing the world have a way of hanging on for addicts. That is why N A is a day at a time program. Our personal list of N A basics are so important to the formation of “new habits.”

How regularly we find ourselves thinking we have come quite a ways in recovery only to realize we were thinking unkind thoughts about other members who were not going the way we wanted them to go! We are lucky if we catch ourselves before we begin to work a vengeance on our fellows. When we forgive others, we may find we are really forgiving ourselves!

It's a deep, deep hole that we have dug for ourselves. It takes a lot of gumption and faith to humble ourselves and pull ourselves up by our bootstraps. This is not an easy thing to do, but it's simple. Anyone can get clean, you just have to want it more than anything else in the world.

[bs]

AUGUST

August 1

“This is a Step of willingness. That is the spiritual principle of Step Six.”

Memphis Review Form - page 47, 10

This principle is also what we find in Step Three. Without willingness what do we have? We must become willing and have a desire for us to get clean and to continue to stay clean. When we become ready to try a new way of life. Life has become easier rather than the pain of fighting.

Willingness is a state of readiness to get into the solution, replacing depression, anxiety and self-pity. There is a viewpoint that we do something to help others, something different, and something we hear or read about in recovery material each day. Each tiny step forward eventually add up to milestones in recovery.

Our NA recovery is all about willingness. The willingness to get outside of our comfort zone. The willingness to do assignments that make our skin crawl. The willingness to do what we are told regardless of whether or not we think it's a waste of time. Sometimes it is just a matter of trying out something different - only to find that it really does work!

[MSG]

August 2

“Spiritual and religious freedom is one of our most basic principles. Each of us are free to work out our own concept of God, or reject the concept of a God..”

Memphis Review Form - page 63, 29

Like other freedoms, the power is in the right of choice. If our old ideas of a higher power did not produce the results we wanted, that is encouragement to go looking for a new understanding! Many of us come in to recovery, with the God of our parents or families. Take your time reading, studying and asking others what they believe. Whatever we choose, we stick with it in order to grow. If we add to our believe, that's a good thing. If something in our belief is faulty, we change it. Not casually or capricially, but seriously for our lives and our futures depend on it.

Through the practice of regular simple prayers, we find that the powers found in the principles in the Second Step: Surrender, Faith, Trust, Hope, Sanity, begin to give us a more clear view and understanding of powers greater than ourselves. We begin to see these powers helping us almost immediately. We begin to see that other addicts have been helping us along. Eventually we begin to see signs of a more clear vision and develop a concept of God for ourselves. No one else can determine that for us. We begin to trust this Power as we go forward in our recovery.

One of the common problems we have with the Second Step is “how do you put something wordless and beyond this world into words?” Many members shy away from the ‘concept’ of God because of this semantic problem. Yet they can tell a difference when they experience conscious contact. They can experience the ‘presence’ of their Higher Power. The great fact of belief is THAT you believe, not what you believe. The writers of the Basic Text, *Narcotics Anonymous*, openly discussed this matter when considering the pronoun to be used in reference to the Higher Power. Should it be he, she, it, they or something else? English grammar clearly states that ‘Him’ refers to belief with no gender reference. So, ‘Him’ can be anything you want it to be. As long as It is loving and kind. Grammar books state that ‘Him’ refers to all human beings.

August 3

“Sometimes, the best revenge we can have over a manipulative or unpleasant person, is in not allowing them to “pull our strings” by making us react unkindly to them.”

Memphis Review Form - page 76,25

No one, except ourselves, and our own character defects can get in the way of anyone else's behavior. The only thing that we can do is to practice the principles that we have learned in our own lives. This begins with the 1st Step. We have no power over another addict's behavior. They don't have to listen to us unless they want to. We can, however be a positive example, by not reacting to negativity ourselves by feeding into theirs. This is certainly not always an easy thing to do. It takes practice surrendering to our own emotions so as not to react to our own feelings that we still carry with us. Sometimes the other person catches on that we are practicing principles. There must be a cosmic law that people react in kind.

Whether they stop their fooling around or not, we don't have to dance to their tune! Power is the ability to define reality and we exercise that power now that we are clean. With the help of our Higher Power, we rise above old reactions and attempts to control us.

In Shaolin Temple training, the goal is mind like water. When a pebble is thrown into a pool how does it respond? Exactly correctly. Ripples go out, calm down and the water soon becomes calm again. The Shoalin Warrior must have his mind go back to calm after every attack upon himself. This way he is ready for the next one.

August 4

“Remember, we can’t change other people. We can, through the program of Narcotics Anonymous, change ourselves.”

Memphis Review Form - page 76,31

We are powerless over people, places and things. When we were out there, we felt we had to control everything to avert disaster and get our pleasures. It was exhausting. When we get clean, surrendering is a very, very different mode of operation. It's 180 degrees from our old way. And not surprisingly it's damn hard to do most of the time. But the results are great! If getting clean was easy there would be no drug epidemic. Sometimes it hurts really bad, but we gotta do it. No pain, no gain. Fortunately we don't have to do it alone. And the proof is all around us. When we surrender to the disease concept, we stop fighting and that energy is put to better purposes.

We check in with our and practice taking things one day at a time. Jogging our memory and starting off in the recovery mindset each day brings us extra blessings and helps us see opportunities that might otherwise miss.

As most NA members know, the little things we do build up our recovery and lead to bigger things! The old ways of going for 'newer, bigger, better, quicker, faster' may bring us into close contact with brick walls we didn't see coming. Slowing down a little and staying focused give us advantages. Like we have a better chance to see what's coming in time to change it!

August 5

“Being human we will of course fall short. We still get mad and still feel hurt, especially if we are too hungry, angry ,lonely, tired, or too serious (H.A.L.T.S).”

Memphis Review Form - page 47,13

While our human condition is subject to limitations, we learn and practice spiritual principles. We stop running into obstacles that trip us up and prevent our human joy and freedom. As addicts who have experienced hell on earth, happiness and comfort seem like impossible goals for us. HALTS gives us a simple way to identify where some of our negative feelings come from. We will catch ourselves thinking some negative stuff and realize it is only fatigue or hunger that tries to assign our internal feelings to some outside force. Taking better care of ourselves, we quickly recovery our senses and shake out heads.

One new addict was on a road trip with some seasoned addicts. The car broke down in a strange town. The older addicts decided to get something to eat and then deal with the car. This was a revelation for the new addict. A new way of doing things. A new tool. Doing things differently gets different results. Putting more pressure can break things and make it worse. We will never stop learning as long as we are putting the NA 12 Steps into action. After the meal, they all felt better and found a way to get the car fixed and got on the road again.

We are accustomed to adversity and having to fight for what we want or need. Taking a few breaths and making a quick prayer for strength and guidance lets us see past obstacles. Taking our foot off the accelerator and slowing down gives us time to think things through. You are at a time in your life when you can breathe easier and work with new approaches beyond what desperation allows!

August 6

“Alienation and isolation are symptoms of the mental part of our disease. To the practicing addict, life is just a movement between connections and oblivion. Normal concerns are pushed aside, as the disease progresses.”

Memphis Review Form - page 77, 4

The great French writer Jean Paul Sarte said, “Hell is other people.” One wonders if he was an addict. We often seek refuge in isolation. Sometimes life is overwhelming and we must go into our cave. We just can’t live there all the time. For some of us going to a meeting and mingling is our social time. This can be good because it gets us out of the narrow confines of our minds!. The meetings are peopled by persons who have learned to live without using and practice principles that open doors long closed to them

For our very survival it was important getting to NA. Now, we practice another form of survival, one that introduces ideas and practices that work in daily living. Before recovery, many of our sayings and terminology sounded weak and ineffectual. In recovery, we find principles that are stronger than steel and harder than a diamond! Once we realize what is happening to us, we want more, more and still more. Amazingly, our growth is endless. Helping others we discover that we feel compassion without feeling better or wiser than those we help. This is anonymity in a pure form. We no longer feel alone and needful. We feel fortunate and often amazed. These feelings make it easier for us to ask for help and try out new ways of living.

We know from our own experience that others feel the same way when they help us. A whole new world opens to us. Imagine if we were a wolf and had to make it alone! Friends make our world bigger. When we play like puppies, we learn rough and tumble without pain or hurt. So, with our new NA friends we jump and bounce feeling alive and wonderful. It takes time but now that we are clean, we have the time.

August 7

“Three “musts” are honesty, open-mindedness, and willingness to try. Agnostics and atheists generally start out by just talking to “Whatever’s there.””

Memphis Review Form - page 64, 9

This daily meditation stresses the importance of being open and experimental. We learn positive ways to investigate and check out things before committing ourselves. Because of our former limitations, we may not know we are free to really take a look around. We can read books, ask others to share their experience, and think over our experiences before adopting or committing ourselves. We each have our own personal understanding of a higher power. When we have our own belief, we begin to capitalize higher power. A Higher Power of your own understanding is the key to ongoing recovery and spiritual growth. Asking for help is a daily tool for living a spiritual life.

It is the difference between a defeated person and a person filled with spirit.

Sometimes people call their spirit “The Force” or a “Presence.” It doesn’t seem as churchy. It takes the formality away. It seems more friendly and available. Religion has a lot of different connotations for people. Sometimes it can get confusing. We stress the right of our members to find their own Higher Power. We regularly remind ourselves and our members to avoid preaching or telling each other what to think. We share our experience from the past, our strength from today and our hope for the future.

Belief is what controls what we are open to. Sometimes it is like being able to tune in to a different tv or radio station. If our device is not in working order or we are having trouble with our channel selector, we have to snap out of our loss of service and restore our contact!

August 8

“Personality change is a natural progression set in motion by our surrender to the program.”

Memphis Review Form - page 81, 4

When we came into the Fellowship, we were full of fear and doubt. For many of our members surrender was a gradual process, not an event. We began to see our lives less chaotic when we slow down and learn to take it easy. If it's not easy, something is wrong. We can save ourselves time and trouble by stopping and reduce the friction or fix what's broken. It may be a simple misunderstanding. We begin to see that our efforts to control sometimes continue to make our lives unmanageable. As it says in our Prologue, “That at the end of the road, we can no longer function as a human being ,either with or without drugs.” We become more human.

Our lives can become unmanageable again when we are not practicing surrender. That is why the surrender is so important. When we put conditions on anything ahead of our recovery, we put limitations on our recovery.

One member was sharing in a group that he needed to know God's will on taking a great job but which required working on the Sabbath. How could he know God's will. An oldtimer said “Ask your sponsor. God's words will come from his mouth as if he is an Oracle.” At this point the meeting secretary said “Kiss the ring”. This is being hip, slick and cool. We have not seen the person who made the suggestion since that time. Persons with quality recovery will go elsewhere if made fun of.

For example a guy came into a meeting and said that he had just gotten into it with his mother. The oldtimer simply said that he was sorry to hear that. It validated the original speaker. So how hard was that? The response spread unity instead of disunity.

August 9

"Most addicts have strong feelings about their Higher Power and vigorously defend their right to their own understanding of a Higher Power. The strength to move into action comes from our Higher Power."

Memphis Review Form - page 37, 2

There is the illusion by non-believers that "higher power" is just an excuse to do as we please. The reality of life in the care of a loving, caring, all powerful being is not self-will. It lifts us to better things and gives us the strength and guidance to deal with the worst things that happen to us.

In NA our higher power is our friend, our buddy. This can be confusing to church goers. But many think this is what our HP craves. To be our very best friend. And it makes perfect sense. Why would God want barriers between Him and us. The phrase "God is my copilot" speaks volumes. We take road trips with our higher power. Talk to Him while we walk down the street. We don't ask for stuff and become comfortable just hanging out with HP. Spirituality lets us see beyond selfish boundaries.

Our belief system is comforting and based on real life experience. It has to be located and practiced to become useful. Everything that comes up doesn't have to be a crisis. Praying and meditating at the end of a day is a good time to focus and renew our belief in the ways of the God of our understanding.

August 10

“We have also met members who are uncertain about where they really belong. We suggest that they ask themselves three questions: 1. What message do you carry? (What is the nature of your recovery and what have you recovered from?) 2. Who are you trying to carry this message to? 3. Where are you trying to carry this message?”

Memphis Review Form - page 99, 15

Reviewing basic ideas gives us a chance to make sure we are on common ground with reality. We are great ones for charging off in directions composed of our own projections and negative expectations. Just because we run a definite risk of running off the road does not mean we have to run through a catalog of fear every time we get behind a wheel! Obsession can really mess up your perception of reality. The clean life requires a few adjustments! Compulsion means acting without thinking. When we do this, things can go from bad to worse in the blink of an eye.

Carrying a message of love and hope to an addict who really wants the program recharges our recovery batteries! We set up an energy exchange that works for both of us. There is a “Spirit” in the rooms of NA that guides us and is always ready to lend a hand when we ask for help. Asking for help is very important because we don’t boss people or treat them like we’re the royalty and they are our subjects. Membership is a great honor!

To carry our message, we have to have three things: 1. Experience with NA recovery, 2. An addict who wants our help and asks for it, and 3. An atmosphere of recovery that may be in a meetings place, a private phone call or two chairs and a little privacy.

August 11

"In our groups we share our experience, strength, and hope, and this is our message - that an addict, any addict, can stop using drugs; lose the desire to use again; and find a new way to live. Their message is hope and the promise of freedom."

Memphis Review Form - page 103, 19

When an addict gives their opinions, rather than their personal experience, strength, and hope to a newcomer, they may be forgetting the courage it takes to ask for help. When we allow our Higher Power to use us as instruments, respect, care and genuine concern are appropriate. We do not judge the addict asking for help. Addicts are very perceptive people and can see through the untruths. When we are honest and speak from the heart rather than our head. It is not our ego which provides the message of hope. Shared experience is usually clear, and carries the hope that we can give to another suffering addict.

One addict recently got into another twelve step group on some issue and wondered if it really worked. Then he realized that many newcomers were sitting in NA meetings wondering the same thing. Does this thing actually work or not. Is it possible to actually get clean. So from time to time we need to emphatically state that this program is 100% effective in every case if the person just follows direction, surrenders and works the tools with a sponsor. It's a guaranteed program of recovery. The only way to fail is to not get involved up past your eyeballs. You have to want it more than anything else in the world. Period.

August 12

“Our Fifth Tradition defines our primary purpose and our Sixth Tradition tells us some of the things we must do to preserve and protect this spiritual aim. This Tradition tells us that we ought never endorse, finance or lend the N.A. name to any outside enterprise. And then we are warned exactly what can happen if we ignore this advice.”

Memphis Review Form - page 103, 26

If we do not adhere to these Traditions, if we violate them, then the recovery process stops. People go to meetings and such but don't stay clean. That's why it's said that our Traditions are non-negotiable.

Our Traditions are just as important as the Steps. A glass of water is water on the ground without the glass! One addict was in a town where Area Service Committee demanded that every meeting sign court slips, regardless of whether they believed it was affiliation or not. . Soon meetings began to go dark and people were getting loaded right and left. Each meeting was no longer autonomous so the miracle of recovery stopped.

Another meeting had people coming in with SCRAM units to blow into and had tv cameras on them to identify the person blowing. One guy began swinging the camera around the room taking everyone's picture. It was not long till people quit going to that meeting because their anonymity was being violated. Some had warrants. The meeting eventually went dark.

We have to follow these Traditions. They are there for a reason. They guide our Fellowship by giving us boundaries that keep our vehicle out of the ditches!

August 13

“The choice of membership rests with the individual.. We feel the ideal state for our fellowship exists when an addict can openly and freely come to an N.A. meeting; wherever and whenever they choose and leave just as freely if they want to. We realize that there is nothing we can do to make an addict stop using.”

Memphis Review Form - page 99, 25

Without understanding and acceptance of this basic idea, the rest of our recovery process fails. Taking first Step makes us a member. The old saying “You can bring a horse to water , but you can’t make him drink.” Holds true. It can also be said that ,” we sure can make him thirsty.” Once again it comes to the Addicts willingness to get clean, stay clean, and find a new and better way to live.

We have some meetings filled with horses who are not thirsty. They make it hard for the thirsty one to survive. Forced attendance is the government’s idea of solving the problem. We are not affiliated, so these meetings fail the definition given in our Twelve Traditions. This is not an opinion, it is a reality. The impact on NA has been brutal and devastating. Many meetings have gone dark, oldtimers have fled and many have died.

The disease is baffling and so people and institutions can be expected to make mistakes. Once recovery becomes a business, it gets really confusing. The simple fact is we cannot play God and make addicts stop using. NA recovery is based on simple truths like this.

August 14

“We may still, however, feel that we cannot have a happy life without drugs. We may suffer from the fear of insanity and feel we have no escape from using other than an insane and depressed existence.”

Memphis Review Form - page 81, 13

By staying clean and going to meetings, we stop many of the things that set us up for failure and confusion. It doesn't take too long before we begin to take care of our basic needs, have a roof over our heads, food in our bellies, and begin to see and to identify with other addicts. We listen to others share their experiences and we can identify. We can see that they too have very similar feelings and that we are not alone. Sometimes we have to stand in a room for a while before we can see, hear and feel others in the room with us.

Identification is what we need to feel a part of the group. Then we can see that we are not as bad as we thought we were. This keeps us coming back. As we put together clean time, many unsolvable problems resolve themselves. The stability we establish in our lives is infectious in a good way. It bleeds over to problem areas of our lives, bills, taxes, teeth, cars. Everything stabilizes at the rate at which we work the tools: surrender, faith and positive prayer with action.

The disease of addiction is powerful and seeps into our lives from time to time. We have tools that help us deal with the disease on a daily basis! It all begins with surrender but develops into ten thousand pathways of recovery. One of the worse mistakes we can make is to think recovery is optional and take it for granted. Recovery is the result or product of our desire. We cause our recovery by seeking and absorbing new forms of goodness and positive action into our lives.

August 15

"What a change from how we used to be! That's how we know that the N.A. program works."

Memphis Review Form - page 27, 3

Time, and our disease of addiction, will constantly work to make us forget and ignore all our many blessings. Some of us stop working the program that worked for them in the beginning. Addiction never sleeps, like rust. Even if the sayings and catchy phrases get boring and repetitions, we keep working the program. Many of us write our gratitude lists to maintain our awareness of the new things that could never have happen to us when we were dirty (using). When we work on getting better, often others can see a change in us before we can see it in ourselves. Slowly we realize we are not losing our temper as often, gossiping as much or lying quite as easily. Prayer makes good effects in our daily lives. Praying for strength and guidance is one of the best prayers we can practice on a daily basis.

It is said that we get an extra second for every year clean before we go off on someone. This gives us time to walk away if nothing else. It does get easier, much easier. But the rate is full of fits and starts. It's not an even sort of healing. It can be two steps forward and one step back. Much of this is our Higher Power teaching us lessons. Lessons on how to live life and help each other. Growth is not optional, it is a result of the spiritual life.

We must embrace every flat tire and broke shoelace. God cannot teach us all lessons by showering us with endless gifts. Some of them have to be learned thru the school of hard knocks.

As a boy, one member received wonderful Christmas gifts from his dad who had a good job. Electric train set, Three speed English Bike, etc. Every year the boy would make up his list and every year it would be under the tree. But one year he asked for a Michigan Crane. A big metal Tonka like Crane with steerable front wheels and outriggers for stability. It even had a hook and a clamshell. Upon inspection, Christmas Day he saw it was not under the tree. In its place was a wood burning set. The father said to the son, "Lets take a walk." On the walk, the father explained that by showering his son with gifts, he was spoiling him. The boy nodded but still felt upset. Later, in college, the boy had a beautiful girlfriend. She dumped him for the star football player. It was then that the boy understood what the old man was telling him. You can't always get what you want. Being grateful for what you have precedes being grateful for what you get.

August 16

“We had nothing left to lose. We gave up... quit struggling...surrendered, completely and unconditionally. Then and only then did we begin to recover from the disease of addiction.”

Memphis Review Form - page 33, 13

Paradoxically, with this complete unconditional surrender, we started to find some power. The resources we had depleted fighting our addiction started to rebuild - giving us whatever we needed to start recovering. Literally, from the very beginning, we are guided to what is most necessary for our eventual happiness and release from our disease. All those reservations are like little hooks that hold us back. We might as well look at recovery as a magic kingdom where all the rules are remade in our favor. Because we let go, it is understood we are free to rebuild our fractured lives.

Look at the words in the Memphis Review Form excerpt: “quit struggling, surrendered, completely and unconditionally.” If we hold back in any way, it creates a hole in the blanket of our recovery. We remain weak and vulnerable in that area. If it is old habits, there you go. If it is financial, that’s easy to see. If we still fear and distrust others, we will find it hard to make progress in that area.

All the things we recommend in our recovery program are designed to help us cast off from the dock of active addiction and enter the sea of personality change. Often. We are so nuts the release from stress and anxiety of pain and confusion leads us to imagine nothing is happening. Hey, didn’t anyone tells you to get ready for few differences when you start working the NA 12 Steps? There will always be some addicts who try to wiggle out of full and complete surrender. You can watch them and decide if they have what you want! If you target higher consciousness and raised vibrations, you can start by finding ways to accept them and finding ways to help them.

August 17

“The Steps guide us into our place in society. We begin by straightening our internal disorder and obtaining release from the defects that prevent us from being all we should be.”

Memphis Review Form - page 70, 5

While ‘should’ is often times regarded as a bad word, the idea is still pretty useful. Perhaps it could be rephrased to read, “If we want powerful results and noticeable changes for the better, it is recommended that we go at recovery with a whole heart and an open mind.”

It is useful and humorous to say, “I will not ‘should’ on myself today.” however if you think you are to first addict to try to get the goodies of the clean life without giving up the old games and trick your way into a new life, you might want to think that through a little bit. What is the cause and effect? If I do so-and-so, what will happen? If I follow the pathway taken by so many others addicts just like me, I might just get what these good people are recommending to me.

After all our games and attempts to live the wild and crazy life failed, perhaps it is time for a change! Isolation did not work for us either. Is it really so hard to be loving and kind? Time spent with others like ourselves changes our self-image as we become part of humanity again. Recent good experiences has great power over our painful past. Surrender stops the accumulation of bad outcomes. Finding a loving, caring Higher Power can redirect all our energies into correcting the errors of our past and check out what has worked for countless others.

August 18

“Recovery is a beautiful chance that many addicts thought had passed them by until they found the Fellowship of N.A. It’s a chance to live again.”

Memphis Review Form - page 27, 18

Right now, alive in the present and living fully! It is a new day and we commit to the courage we need to step up to the challenges and opportunities we find rising up to meet us. The longer we are clean and the more we let ourselves experience the miracles of personality changes and spiritual growth, the more we can accept and believe a whole new life opens up to us one day at a time!

We see people that love themselves, love their lives, have dreams, are pursuing dreams and most importantly, achieving dreams. They assure us that we, too, can have this. We start by having attainable goals like getting one more clean time tag. Then, maybe, we get a job or a car or a bank account.

Then the day of ultimate success, we have completed the Steps for the first time and have achieved a spiritual awakening. We slowly realize we have become people that love ourselves and our lives. We are pursuing and achieving our dreams and most importantly, we are capable of helping others reach for their new lives. A miracle has occurred. Don’t get off the bus just because in your opinion it’s not going fast enough! Compared with the hopelessness and despair we come from, the 12 Steps move us forward at the speed of light.

August 19

“The essence of addiction is that it is easier to change our perception of reality than the reality we perceive.”

Memphis Review Form - page 81, 34

Living clean switches all that around. Changing reality means the changes we acquire in recovery stay put and need less correction as we go along in our new lives. Imagining we are in any position to judge the results of our investment in our personal program belies the facts that led us to our First Step! Remember being broken with no help in sight? Remember trying to cover our tracks with tearful admissions of fault to those who loved and cared about us only to turn around and do the same things again? Remember wondering what is wrong with us without seeing the connection between our actions and the consequences of those actions?

We may have some amends to make but that is infinitely better than endless feelings of guilt and shame and all the avoidance patterns that go with unmade amends. When we humbly ask our personal Higher Power to remove our defects of character, the bad stuff just stops happening. Don't let your disease blindside you into fallen back into your old ways. We have seen good members fall into this predictable trap many times. Relapse begins when we stop praying for help.

It may help to consider how we lacked internal resources to do better in life. Without patience, humility and tolerance, we are jerking people around, puffing up with arrogance and kicking people when they aren't doing too well. Our ego can blind us to the reality that we are inflicting the same unworthy treatment on ourselves without realizing it. Keeping our cool and doing push-ups of gratitude builds our spiritual strenght to deal with the good things appearing in our lives.

August 20

“The autonomy of our groups is one of our most precious possessions. This sounds great but what does it mean? What is it to be autonomous? Webster’s defines autonomous as “having the right or power of self government,” “undertaken or carried on without outside control,” “existing or capable of existing independently,” “ responding, reacting or developing independently of the whole.”

Memphis Review Form - page 100, 2

There is a spirit that develops among individuals dedicated to a common cause or purpose. Common understanding and agreement results in unison of action and purpose that works to get the desired result. It takes freedom of belief and action to achieve this. Addicts who want to stay clean and enjoy a life in recovery should by all means be free to do so.

A classical example of our God given ability to find ways to disagree is over where we say, “a half dozen or six.” Of course, it makes no real difference and with a little effort most people can see this but there of those who insist on their terminology and reject any variation out of hand. Considering word choice helps us understand more deeply the meaning of words in recovery. This openness is good. Insisting others accept and adopt our terms of expression is dogmatic and insulting. We don’t want cookie-cutter recovery. The very essence of real and lasting recovery is being able to hear others and share our own feelings as best we can,

If getting clean, staying clean, and helping others is why we go to meetings, we stand on common group and are likely to be effective. Needless conflicts should not ruin our efforts to achieve our primary purpose. Spiritual maintenance brings us back to the wellspring of kindness again and again.

August 21

“Recovery begins with the first admission of powerlessness. From that point forward, we can see that every clean day is a successful day, and that any seeming failure is only a temporary setback.”

Memphis Review Form - page 33, 16

Our disease of addiction enlarges our painful past through the miracle of tunnel vision. Time with clean addicts, reading recovery writing from the NA point of view and the search for a loving God of our own understanding renew our lives. Personality change doesn't seem strong enough to cover the way we step into a new life, one day at a time. Many of us cling to our new existence as if our lives depend on waking up in a new world because it does!

Sometimes all we get done on certain days is to just sit on our hands and stay clean. These can be some of the most successful days of our lives. One addict wanted to use and sat on the couch at detox for three days till it passed. There may have been the most successful days of his life. He now had over thirty years clean. Looking back it seems incredible yet it happened. Spiritual growth goes on with a steady series of awakenings. We gain new understandings both from our freak new understandings as well as the wonderful way discovery re-defines our worst memories.

In some strange way, our bodies and our minds rebuild what was once broken. It is internal, Lost dreams appear anew right before our very eyes. The life that comes to us through vibrations of sight, sound and body rearrange themselves into clean, healthy patterns.

August 22

“Our deepest longings and recurring images of the kind of people we’d like to be are only glimpses of God’s will for us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 58, 18

Later in this paragraph, we read, “It is our own real dreams that come true.” To continue the idea that many people seem to know intuitively. God is in all of us. The idea that a supreme all knowing and all powerful creator lives within each of us seems overwhelming to begin with. But as a solution to all our living problems and the resolution to all our thinkings, it certainly fulfills the criteria.

Our 12th Step makes clear that to carry our message, the disease concept keeps us from wandering off on a tangent mis-using notions of spirituality. We are more apt to rationalize what God told us than to relinquish control of our life and will! Prayer and meditation open doorways to a new reality that most of us only saw occasionally, if at all! Drugs messed up our minds and we would lose track of our spiritual direction as it flew past us.

After a great deal of dust has settled, we find ourselves on track with God’s Will for us. As progress is made from that point forwards, we enjoy a deep sense of accomplishment. It’s like the feelings we get at the end of solving an interlocking puzzle. Many of the pieces are already in place and then the next pieces fairly jump into place! Or perhaps we go to a special place to pray and meditate. After a while, just going there gives us a sense of completion and satisfaction by association. .

August 23

“The answer, of course, is that these things are not N.A. They are services that we can utilize to help us in our recovery and further the primary purpose of our groups.”

Memphis Review Form - page 100, 15

Clarity of mind and heart-felt feelings help us distinguish between reality and fantasy. Those who get caught up in symbols can miss out on the real thing. A recovery group or member has some claim to conscious contact and therefore some claim to divine guidance as opposed to personal preference in matters affecting others.

The notion that we pray before voting in a service body seems to be more of an afterthought rather than a guiding principle. “Directly responsible” is lost in the shuffle. Real service makes a member feel good inside. Emotions of love, gratitude and a touch of wonder let us know the Spirit of NA is using us as instruments.

NA politics have run off more members than the disease of addiction - or maybe they are the same thing. When we put personal preference ahead of group purpose, it is safe to say God is out of the picture. Service is doing positive things to help addicts just like us get to a meeting and have the tools we need for a lasting recovery. Jockeying for a service position can deceive us into violating principles and doing unseemly things to get elected. Actions unfounded in God’s Will for us push us away from our Higher Power. Our disease is based on fear and so we expect to be disappointed in some way at some future time. Seeking to put God in a jar, we change the nature of what we love and care about when we try to trap and control what once was free.

August 24

“When we came to N.A., we were physically, mentally and spiritually bankrupt. We hurt long enough and badly enough that we were willing to go to any lengths to stay clean.”

Memphis Review Form - page 29, 10

Nothing motivates us like pain and, boy, did we hurt. We became willing to follow suggestions we didn't completely understand because of hope. Hope offered by N A members we recognized as fellow addicts who were obviously no longer in pain but enjoying life. It was their continued assurances that we could get better, too, that helped us find the courage to go on for one more day, one more hour or maybe just one more heartbeat.

We learned that gratitude defeats self-pity. Mountainous problems become small molehills when we accept the circumstances and look for solutions. Life doesn't need chaos to have pleasure.

The worse we hit our bottoms, even in early recovery, the more we think “I don't want to ever go thru this again”. And they do what it takes to stay clean: work the Steps. Positive actions take the impulse of goodness and make it into a reality in our daily lives.

August 25

“Remarkably, the Twelve Steps guide us from a state of humiliation and despair to a state wherein we are able to act as instruments of God’s will.”

Memphis Review Form - page 60, 7

“We have seen many miracles thru people working the Twelve Steps. I have seen people learn to read, get advanced degrees and regain their health and families. I have seen severely mentally ill people become whole again in recovery. I have seen hopeless addicts stay clean for many decades. People who could not stay clean a day on their own, never use again on a daily basis.

“We have seen one addict start a meeting that some thirty years later is still helping people hear the message and learning to live clean. “I have seen recovery sweep thru families like wildfire. I saw all four brothers get clean one by one and stay clean.”

The power of NA, if handled properly is one of the most powerful forces on earth. It can move mountains and heal the masses.

The expanding drug epidemic will be a wakeup call as to the effectiveness of NA in the past. At least within our Fellowship, we are aware that there are hundreds of thousands of clean addicts in the world today. Right now NA is in a difficult point in time. Traditions have not been followed, group conscious has not been honored and many have gotten loaded on money, property and prestige. Some believe that the drug epidemic would not have happened if NA had been left alone to do its work.

When the dust has settled some ten years from now, the errors of our leaders will be blaringly obvious and their corruption as hangable offenses. The drug epidemic could have all been prevented quite easily had the NA way been followed. Perhaps the millions who will be dying will be a lesson that we have to tether our trusted servants before they get addicted to power.

August 26

“There is a danger that we will minimize or rationalize away our part in situations.”

To do our inventory, we may use a practice that works for many experienced members. Just divide the process into two or more parts so you can write out whatever comes to mind and when you stop writing, take a short break and then review what you have written. You have plenty of time to add and remove so that your input makes good sense, at least to you! The trouble with minimizing or rationalizing our inventory is it gives the illusion that you have done an inventory! At best you have begun the inventory process. Your life, the quality of your life, is at stake here. When we addicts begin to feel badly, we are apt to go into a downhill plunge that ends in relapse. Just monitoring and tracking things that bother us as we go along our way allows us the opportunity to change.

If we get out of the habit of daily inventory, we suggest just resuming the process. The idea that we are 'behind' just makes us confused and may act to keep us from even trying!

We are masters at finding scapegoats to blame. It's always someone else's fault. In rationalization, it's never wholly our fault. We are Monday morning quarterbacks. We could have run the Viet Nam War better, prevented 9/11 and had JFK put on the bubble top. We would have stopped Hitler early on and radioed the Titanic to head south into warmer waters. We are legends in our own minds.

This seems to be one of the defining attributes of being an addict, this finger pointing and attributing blame to others. We have our work cut out just addressing this one defect, the character defect or 'blame assessment.'

August 27

“We give freely and gratefully of our time, our services and our experiences to our fellow addicts.”

Memphis Review Form - page 60, 16

Giving freely is one of the most effective tools of NA. We give without expectation of reimbursement. If we give till it hurts, then we must be getting some real results. One addict bought three gallons of baby blue paint to paint a meeting room. He is still clean today.

One addict went to speak in another city and refused a motel room. He slept in his car and ate at Jack in The Box. This made his speech very powerful as people saw him asleep in his car the night before and then he walked up to the podium. Quiet sincerity can sometimes be heard over the roar of a crowd.

It is safe to say, our program rests on our ability to help and be helped. Helping others not only feels good, it gives us feelings of joy and self-worth. These feelings encourage us to work the 12 Steps of NA and so guide each of us to our own spiritual awakening.

August 28

“Narcotics Anonymous is a Fellowship of men and women, addicts, meeting together in groups, and using a given set of spiritual principles to find freedom from addiction and a new way to live. All else is not N.A.”

Memphis Review Form - page 100, 18

This simple statement has been made to appear disunifying and obscure enough to be removed by three members before the first publication of our Basic Text, *Narcotics Anonymous*. We hope through time and personal growth we will come to a high level of basic agreement.

The importance of limiting perceived power in our service bodies is great. The huge majority need not be restricted to the level of a very few members. Even if they are gifted or full of noble sentiments, they do violence by setting themselves above the individual members and groups who wrote and reviewed the Basic Text.

If they have trouble seeing this simple point, it illustrates the importance of having a general and agreeable basic understanding in our written recovery material. Else readers will sooner or later take issue with offending items they fail to understand and some will leave N A.

It is simple enough to write in an inclusive manner. Giving undue excessive to trusted servants who surely may have problems understanding and maintaining proper boundaries for the sake of our common welfare. After all, most trusted servants have leeway to do their job and ask for help as needed.

Whereas who takes up for the members if excesses occur or accumulate? Irreparable harm may continue for years without correction. All because a few ‘powerful’ members take it upon themselves to disregard the deep consideration that went into the original wording of the 12 Traditions. They really don’t understand. They take off in a direction based on their lack of understanding. They choose instead personal profit and gain.

August 29

“This Tradition is the basis for our policy of nonaffiliation and is extremely important to the continuation and growth of N.A. Unfortunately, this Tradition has also been a point of controversy within our Fellowship.”

Memphis Review Form - page 104, 3

Tradition Six warns us in plain wording that money, property and prestige threaten our recovery. Simple logic makes it clear that affiliation with outside groups or organizations opens a door to encroachment and unending problems will ensue. Our primary group purpose is essential, not optional, to our recovery process.

If we make a mistake and affiliate and do not believe we have done so, the recovery process still stops. We simply cannot violate the Traditions and get results. Its poison to the recovery process. When we are new to recovery, it's hard to grasp this.

In San Francisco in 1983 they wanted us to exchange needles in our meetings to prevent spread of disease among those who were more likely to relapse. We had to refuse as it was an outside issue. We could not have an opinion on it and could not appear to be endorsing it. We had to walk away. Otherwise, many, many more would die than from dirty needles. The message would not be effectively carried and the destruction would have been massive.

August 30

“A direct endorsement is often used to try and persuade someone to do something.”

Memphis Review Form - page 104, 14

Isn't persuading someone to do something against their will the same as manipulation? And isn't manipulation along with control a primary symptom of our disease of addiction? This is part of what Tradition Six is warning us about? We have to stake our own area of focus or concern to have a Program of recovery.

When something is being endorsed, people can smell it. It blares out at them. Addicts are particularly sensitive to this.

When one member came in, none of the meetings were in churches as it was feared that an implied endorsement might be sent to newcomers. No, you do not have to be a Methodist to belong to NA or even a Christian or other religion. All are welcome with respect and appreciation. We have among our recovering membership people who are uncomfortable with calling their Higher Power God! Heck, being an atheist is fine for some. Now that's open mindedness. They may or may not change their position on belief in time. That's freedom to find a God of their understanding.

We stay back from direct alignment in any form because it would generate the same lack of freedom and belief. Since we want all addicts to be free to come to NA for help, our policy is 'open to all.' While some later modify their belief, other do not and no one says a thing.

August 31

“The third thing warned against is lending the N.A. name. This means letting someone use the name, Narcotics Anonymous, for something that is not Narcotics Anonymous. It also means letting an outsider mention or utilize our name for their own purposes.”

Memphis Review Form - page 104, 21.

One Federal program points out that they send their charges to Narcotics Anonymous. Is this a violation? There is actually controversy over this issue which seems clear cut to many.

NA can be so effective that it can be touted as elements of other programs.

The problem with the Federal government program is that they never talk to us, they just send people. We have no idea what goes on with them and vice versa. It's a total lack of communication. This is simply what we have decided is acceptable.

While we do this we see our meetings going dark and our recovery rate crashing. But because the disease is baffling, people can't see what's really happening. In Kansas City, Missouri, we have gone from 94 meetings to 16 meetings per week. The number of meetings keeps falling. NA works as a stand-alone program of recovery. Affiliation modifies our Program of recovery based on the truth of our experience. .

SEPTEMBER

September 1

"We who were unable to function as human beings now find anything is possible for us. Those dreams we gave up long ago can now become realities with God's help."

Memphis Review Form - page 106, 21

"One member had an American Flyer electric train as a child. Every year he would receive a new catalog from AC Gilbert about the trains and accessories. He would go thru the catalogues so much that it would finally fall apart. When he got clean he went into a hobby store on his lunch hour and picked up a model railroad magazine. Listed there was an American Flyer Club in his city. He began going and bought most of the dream equipment from his childhood." This is just one example of demolishing our past pain points!.

We usually require a reminder to jolt us into remembering past dreams, dreams gobbled up by our addiction. Finding and fulfilling these dreams can have unforeseen positive effects. Remember how amazing our nervous system is and how our memories work over decades of time! It may be that disappointment is buried deep within our memories and actualizing them may awaken other remembrances and continually enlarge parts of our personalities.

Free your mind to remember your own life lessons! Our society knows little or nothing of recovery. No need to allow uninformed persons to set boundaries for us. Contact with those who have experienced miracles of recovery, will help you experience the same miracles. "Lost dreams awaken." is a fact of life in recovery!

Remember also, each day clean is a miracle and an important part of recovery is daily renewal. What we were ready and open to yesterday may have changed. We owe it to ourselves to ask God to give us nice wake up calls on what the day could hold for us!

September 2

"We know that the more eagerly we wade in and work to stay clean, the higher we're going to get and the richer our spiritual awakening will be!"

Memphis Review Form - page 60, 19

"The first step to recovery is to stop using" The first sentence found in the Chapter Five in our Basic Text. That is where we begin our recovery. Going to a meeting a day for the first ninety days is suggested. The more meetings we go to, we see a change happening. We begin to feel hope, and begin to see, and feel change. We feel more comfortable in our skin.

As we continue going to meetings each day, hours become days, days become weeks, weeks become months and, before we know it a year has past. Our involvement increases, and we see others participating in service. We feel a part of and no longer feeling alone. As we begin to get to know other members, we find new friends who truly care about us. A feeling of peace comes over us, and we are actually having a spiritual awakening right before our eyes. Growth and freedom comes with surrender. No longer fearful or afraid, other people sense our calm. We are no longer hemmed in by a bad attitude. Just as negative begets negative, peace begets peace.

We work with our sponsor, learning and writing our steps, talking with others, "How was it for you?" We find it easier to look within ourselves with the help of a loving God of our understanding, and our sponsor. The companionship of fellow members is encouraging. Helping others overcome the invisible habits of mind and body language, we find our own habits are attractive, not repelling.

It helps to know that the 12 Steps of NA lead us to our very own spiritual awakening. Imagine that, we're going to be free to live a life of the spirit. Is that a miracle or what?

September 3

“Spiritual principles are basic truths that do not change with time or place; they simply work in all cases.”

Memphis Review Form - page 109, 9

Universality is characteristic of spiritual reality. This may be a new idea for many of us. Just think how many situations we can utilize the principle of surrender! Humility cancels out all or most of the conflicts we have with others. Patience allows reality to rearrange itself to include our own personal choices! What we focus on tends to materialize before us because we select for whatever it takes to actualize. It seems clear when we are clean. The things that used to block our way forward are simply gone.

Unfortunately, the same spiritual function can bring into existence things we fear, if that's what we focus on! This is part of what we mean when we say, “Watch what you pray for!” Praying for specific things narrows the range of our focus. Although there are no guidelines for what we pray for, we do have cautions. Some blessings are more expensive than others! In the course of things, we find what works for us!

A principle is a fundamental truth or proposition that serves as the foundation for a system of belief or behavior or for a chain of reasoning. Spiritual principles come from the spirit world have to be experienced to become part of our working, everyday life. Spiritual reality is eternal, worldly reality is transitory.

September 4

“When we were told in meetings we were flirting with relapse, we had to make a decision. We had reservations about anything which did not describe us to a tee and built these up until we thought we could use again.”

Memphis Review Form - page 125, 1

What a disease! The stupid stuff we use to build long standing resentments against other members is incredible. We don't have to worry about outside issues disrupting N A as long as the ties that bind us together remain strong. Lies and gossip can weaken those ties! Most all of us have sponsors with much more clean time and recovery than we do. They tell us of the painful times they have seen otherwise good members fight and carefully build resentments based on rumor and gossip that last for decades. Maybe someday we will be able to address all these issues but until then we have to pray for strength and guidance to not fall into the same traps ourselves!

How clear can you get? Unless we connect our using with our pain, we cannot work the First Step. The admission of our powerlessness is the basis for all recovery. The person who cannot ask for help is helpless. Those who ask for help get help. When we are learning about N A, we also learn to monitor our progress. In recovery, we find we are our own worst enemies because we have not been able to see or hear clearly. This keeps us from sorting out our feelings properly.

Recovery is like combing your hair. Uncombed, our hair gets matted and twisted. Combing only works for a little while, then you have to comb some more! Inventory only works for a little while too! The closer we look, the more we find.

September 5

“When we realized this had related to our new group oriented way of life we often experienced a sort of gut-level panicky feeling.”

Memphis Review Form - page 93, 5

The panicky feeling occurs when a change challenges a long held belief or attitude. It may take time to understand where these feelings come from. Change requires faith and courage. Many times what we lose is replaced by something better and more workable. Interlocking with others can be scary to us loners. But there is strength in the warmth of others near us.

Depending on people we are just getting to know can feel like risky business. In ‘real’ N A, we come to know down deep that those who are really working their 12 Steps have a vested interest in recovery and live the program like their very lives depended it. Their words and actions reflect the changes from within our mind and hearts.

Not everyone is able to jump into recovery this way. They hold back from habitual fear that is based on their past experiences. N A recovery is only available for those who work our 12 Steps. Recovery is not an everyday miracle. It is the result of faith, experience and positive intention.

This is where a good sponsor or home group can help. Sponsoring others helps us as well. We need to look at recovery from every angle. The NA Program seems to grow as our knowledge and personal experience reveals just how wonderful recovery is.

September 6

“Relapse is a sign we have had reservations in our program. We slighted our program and left loopholes in our daily lives. Aware of the pitfalls ahead, we trod blindly on in the belief we could make it on our own.”

Memphis Review Form - page 125, 5

Most underestimate their disease and then relapse as not enough effort was put into staying clean. But to the addict with a week clean, they feel that they have mastered recovery. In the old days the ratio of oldtimers to newcomers favored long clean time. It was so overwhelming that newer members could not argue with the oldtimers. Now the ratio is reversed and newbies explain that “they have got this”. All we can do is sit back and watch the passing parade as we pray and do service to NA on a daily basis..

Our addictive disease expresses itself outwardly in so many ways, it is surprising how much has to do with honesty, open-mindedness and the willingness to try. Perhaps it is the built-in memory of a painful past that continues to build up protective walls long after the need for them is gone. Respect for our own past pain helps make us patient with the pain of another member who has come to us for help.

In certain cases there has been a purge of oldtimers when the money, property and prestige caused uninformed leadership to fear being corrected. This war on oldtimers was very effective and today we are feeling the pain some 30 years later. Even to this day, many, many long time members will not go to meetings remembering what happened back then.

Our most valuable, dedicated, enlightened and generous members were shunned and effectively thrown out of NA. But the joke is on the ones that chased them out for now people are waking up that they have been bamboozled. What is coming is not a pretty sight.

September 7

"The breakdown of old ideas and old ways seems to be beyond our conscious control. The only control of the situation we seem to have is a choice of acceptance."

Memphis Review Form - page 47. 22

Acceptance allows us to take all sides of a concern into account and take whatever action seems to be indicated. Critical thinking is one of the abilities that comes with recovery. Critical thinking is not necessarily negative. It just holds up something like a thought, feeling or perception to the light of a new understanding. We can then decide to include or exclude items once we have had the opportunity to think it over. What we learn increases our ability to learn more. One of the "pay offs" of learning is we get to a point where we can talk about almost anything without fear or anger. By doing these things we are no longer chained or limited to our past low levels of understanding. We choose to accept only things that we have gone over in our hearts and minds.

We learn to be patient and wait for the next sign from our HP. We want to move forward, but often we must wait. That is how it works. The messages sometimes come from out of the blue like bolts of lightning. Then we must be ready, willing and able to go to any lengths. Sometimes these ideas come from people's mouths.

One addict bought a beautiful hot food server from a steamship at an antique show. It was surprisingly cheap and the seller explained the low price by saying that it was missing the insert or tray. He went on to say that Pyrex used to make these but had stopped and so the trick would be to find an old one of the right size. The addict thought "Piece of cake. I will find one". But months later had had no luck.

Discouraged, he asked a woman in an antique store how he might solve his delima. She said to go to a certain kitchen store. The addict went there, although they sold no antiques. The kitchen store owner told the addict to go to a restaurant supply store at 783 Mission Street. The addict went then and at that address was a beauty supply store. He went in and inquired and was told the Restaurant supply store had moved to China Basin.

The addict went to China Basin and found the huge Restaurant supply store. He went in and told them his problem. He was told to follow one of the salesmen who explained that the trays were actually made of metal. He pointed the addict to two 7' high stacks of these trays..one regular and one that was heavy duty. The addict did the footwork and was persistent.

September 8

“We believe the solutions for the problem of having drug-fogged minds, sick bodies and tormented emotions is in a spiritual way of life.”

Memphis Review Form - page 86, 22

Spiritual means learning about the things that affect how we think, feel or act. Anger, resentment, judgemental attitudes, allowing ourselves to focus on what is bothering us rather than looking for new ways of looking at things will generally put us in a bad mood. Focusing on what we have to be grateful for, seeking help from our sponsor or other members we trust, making a gratitude list and a whole lot of other different ways to process our feelings, improve our spiritual condition and open the many doors that will lead us out of our misery and ingratitude.

Many members are addicted to their powerlessness. Reading material on prayer and meditation can put us in touch with others seeking to improve their lives by following a spiritual path. Old experiences with religion and hokey non-sense may bar the door to new ideas and ways to improve our condition. Spiritual involves our quality of life.

A spiritual way of life is acquired by prayer, meditation, smiling and putting ourselves in a good mood by recalling the many things we have to be grateful for in our new lives. We used to be powerless but when we admitted it, we gained the power to change our lives. We could seek and find a higher power we could trust and get the answers we needed. Conscious contact changes everything!

September 9

"We emphasize setting our own house in order and trying to do more than our part. We trust in our Higher Power to give us strength and to meet our needs."

Memphis Review Form - page 70, 11

Making the bed in the morning, listing monthly bills and sitting down to pay them once a month, remembering and honoring our commitments is keeping our house in order. Inventory, prayer and meditation daily keeps our spiritual house in order. Study and learning keeps our mental house in order. These good habits wipe out most of our day to day concerns.

When unexpected demands come up, we learn to pray immediately for strength and guidance. This too changes everything. Enjoying conscious contact makes solutions and energy available to meet almost every need. We get extra help from our friends and loved ones.

Trust comes from ongoing positive expectation based on our own good experience. Rust is decomposition. T-rust is the opposite. T-rust is accumulated positive experience in recent clean time! Solutions in one area tend to apply in other nearby locations or situations. Trust becomes one of our most prized and useful internal resources.

September 10

"It takes some of us a while to realize how unmanageable we were and are still. For others this is the only thing that (of) which we can be sure."

Memphis Review Form - page 86, 12.

The First Step lets us know that we are powerless and our lives were unmanageable. It was easily evident that the lives that we had led brought us to places we hadn't planned on going. They led us to jails, institutions, near death. We also witnessed the death of our friends. After getting clean and learning to live clean, we experience the care, concern, and love from other addicts. They had lived unmanageable lives just as we had. Our stories and experiences may have been different, however, the pain, shame, and woundedness that we lived all feel the same .

Living clean, going to meetings and getting personal information on other addicts seeking recovery rounds out our picture of 'unmanageability' to include things we could not see before. Many things we realize we are doing some of these things even in our new lives. Seeing and acknowledging these things enlarges our awareness and gives us an opportunity to self-correct before they get any worse.

The recovery process leads us to expand our recovery until we can hardly recognize our new selves. Learning creates its own energy, like a ball rolling downhill. We literally do not know what it feels like to pay our bills on time until we do it for a while! When we are poor and disorganized, we get pulled over for tail light that have burnt out and a thousand other things that happen when our resources are low. After a few years clean and working our NA Program, we pull to the side of the road with the words, "What seems to be the problem officer." People who haven't been to jail don't usually know that policemen can tell just by looking at us!

September 11

"Our motivation is simple; this program was given freely to us by addicts who cared. We only do the same."

Memphis Review Form - page 109, 33

The newly recovering addict deserves to get the same chance we got, a clear message of recovery. We need to focus on that one person who needs to hear the message of recovery. The other ones who are talking and playing grab ass should not prevent the eager newcomer from hearing a clear message of recovery.

It can be hard for us to not walk away from the chaos of some NA meetings, but the interested newcomer should not be punished for it. Ours is a cunning, baffling disease and defies recovery. Newer members can tell if we really care and hear their questions about recovery. Just stay tuned into what they are telling you they are ready to hear about. Their questions are a good clue.

Attention and appreciation are things all people crave. We respect the courage it takes to walk through that meeting room door. When they share their pain and condustion, they can tell if we are paying attention. We know their pain. It seems painful to even ask for help when we have been disappointed so often.

September 12

"In the Twelfth Step, we practice the spiritual principle of giving away the N.A. message of recovery in order to keep it."

Memphis Review Form - page 60.24

We learn thousands of tiny lessons on the road to recovery. They all add up to create a loving, caring human being. Instead of being obsessed with our own problems and issues, we have lots of time to take with those who need help. Helping others burns in the lessons and we always find ways to apply or re-apply the lessons to ourselves.

Surgeons have a saying about performing surgical operations: "See one, do one, teach one." Point being, you must jump in with both feet. You must teach others to really learn the subject matter. The first step is study and learning. The second is putting into action that which you got from books. The third is developing deeper insight by helping others learn from you.

In a similar fashion, we must carry the message of recovery to keep ourselves clean. It's why we are clean, the only reason we are clean according to some people. Learning facts without application is dead. Acting on learning makes it real to us and our bodies remember learning put into practice.

September 13

"We have learned the value of teaching by example rather than direction. This has worked for us and we utilize this principle when we work with other addicts. Our message is most obvious in our lives."

Memphis Review Form - page 113, 23

If we are paying attention, they pay attention. If we seek to understand and ask good questions, they do too. If we are somewhat selfless, they can do that too. In NA we take advantage of these basic human traits to get good results in letting people we know and we care. They can feel it.

So, just by working a good program, we are encouraging them to be honest, open and willing to try. They emulate us and our actions. Later, they will apply what they see and hear from us to encourage another new person. Just do it! It feels good and it is good.

This honest, genuine human experience is what becomes rare as our disease of addiction progresses. We are hungry for caring and sharing and that's the basis of carrying our message. We don't lie, cheat and steal our way into their hearts, we just give them the truth of our experience instead of telling them what to do!

September 14

“Promotion is representing ourselves as something we are not. In order to accomplish something we want, we don’t use promotion to encourage addicts to come to us and we don’t use promotions to make ourselves more acceptable. Our successes speak for themselves.”

Memphis Review Form - page 114, 17

Attraction rather than promotion is a main difference between us and religious organizations. Our antennas are being sold that particular religion and it may make the religion seem desperate for new members as what they are offering is not good enough in itself to draw in new members. It’s sad really, to be sold a religion when you are seeking spiritual healing out of a genuine desire to get help.

Many feel that our attraction rather than promotion puts NA miles ahead of any other spiritual group. That sincerity is our main difference. NA is not like a store having loss leaders. It is like the emergency room. The people working in the emergency room wait around for people to walk in. They help the walkins as best as they can. There are never sales at the emergency room or loss leaders.

Many long time NA members feel that our long affiliation with Drug Court is a form of promotion. We sign the slips and they come because they are forced to. And then, perhaps, just perhaps, they will want what we have. It’s a source of fresh blood. A way of promotion. But it doesn’t produce recovery to hang around waiting for people who don’t want to be there and only come under threat of incarceration.

Many of our best members have left NA over this issue. Message givers that we sorely need, especially when we get 5,10,15 years clean. It can be hard to find sponsors when your sponsor dies and you have 20 years clean.

EDIT LINE

September 15

“Each of us has our story, and our own recovery. Individually, we’re powerless but as a Fellowship we can achieve great things.”

Memphis Review Form - page 115, 3

This is one of the main advantages of NA recovery. We relate, share and our load is spread out equally among our peers. A strong fellowship can move mountains, but an addict alone is in bad company. This is one reason that we begin and maintain recovery in meetings. Interaction with out fellows allows us to help and be helped in a natural setting. Whatever we need, we pick up on as other share their experience. Whatever we have experienced is available to others as we share. It is human nature at its best.

We carry what we have gained or shared with us in our hearts and in our minds. After hundreds of times, honesty comes a little easier. Opening our minds is less scary and threatening. Repeated acts of trusting interactions makes trying out new approaches gains an air of positive expectation.

While many times we can look back with awe on how well some of our problems have been resolved, it doesn’t feel like that big of a deal. Baby steps lead to large accomplishments. And in combination with others we go well beyond our former boundaries and brick walls!

September 16

[“Personal anonymity is really much more. It is a corner of freedom, and personal recovery.”](#)

[Memphis Review Form - page 114, 32](#)

We have no anonymity with people sent by the courts. They are not bound by our rules, They don't want to be here and further are mad at us for making them stay through the whole meeting. Our literature was designed for people who seek recovery, not persons under pressure from a courtroom. We are not affiliated with outside organizations and certainly not with the legal system.

SCRAM Systems monitors with tv cameras in them that video record the people in the meeting and use facial recognition to see exactly who is there should never be tolerated in a meeting of Narcotics Anonymous. Really inexperienced people can make all sorts of errors but that changes nothing anymore than leaving a scalpel inside a surgical patient defines hospital rules.

When we must sign our name and supply our phone number on court slips, we have no anonymity. When we are signing attendance slips under penalty of perjury, we have no anonymity. When rehabs bus people in, we have no anonymity. When we are meeting in government building with video and audio surveillance of the entire meeting, we have no anonymity.

Attending meetings in the name of NA, we have to speak up to Tradition Violations and leave the meeting. Where Traditions are routinely violated, we do not have any anonymity any more.

September 17

“These are the things we are and how our program works. They are a reality for us. We have our Steps; we have mobility; we really understand and care; and we are motivated by survival. All these things are a contradiction to traditional recovery approaches and to professionalism. The professional has no place in our fellowship; our very nature prohibits this.”

Memphis Review Form - page 110, 4

For those who have not yet experienced the life and joy of NA recovery, these lines can appear to be mistakes of language. They are taken from the real experience of addicts who live clean in Narcotics Anonymous. They are crucial elements of what works in NA. The lack of these things is why we need our recovery program tailored to meet our very special and important needs.

Steps are arranged so that while each one builds on the Step before, they lead us out of the confusion and despair of active addiction. First surrender, admit our addiction and go looking for belief we can trust with our lives. That belief is the key to our prison cell.

Mobility lets us meet freely wherever we find a location that is close enough to attend on an everyday basis or good enough to make an extra effort to get to from time to time. We can reach other addicts and they can reach us.

Identification brings us together in a natural and easy manner. We recognize our common ground as we share in meetings or fellowship. We can speak openly of our pain and errors among others who have made the same or similar mistakes.

Survival gives us experience that means hope both to ourselves and those who may have the same problems. No one can argue with our experience. They can pick at our good ideas or take issue with what we have heard or read from books but experience is different. Even surprising or unlikely events or outcomes hold up under close examination.

Traditional recovery and professionalism bundle what can be known of the recovery of others without the identification of personal experience.

September 18

"We don't set ourselves up as God. That is why it is spiritual. We get to be an instrument of God's grace in action."

Memphis Review Form - page 60, 35

We exist with all our strengths and shortcomings. Recovery allows us to acquire knowledge and information that goes beyond what we know to be true for ourselves. Some of it helps and other things seems pointless. Occasionally, we find things that seem to answer many questions at once. These things are called principles. They work often and well to help us out in a variety of situations and challenges that may have had us backed up against a wall in our pasts.

Spiritual is a word we associate with how we feel inside and what encourages or empowers us. Spiritual is beyond what is physical or mental. Sometimes it is workless and is only recognized by how we feel.

Some believe that God speaks thru one's sponsor. It just pops out of their mouth. One NA member became a famous actor became his sponsor told him to go on a casting call for a movie. He got a bit piece and is now a household name. Did the sponsor know this would happen. Probably not.

Some sponsors have admitted that when they gave direction they were later on surprised at what had come out of their mouth. It just popped into their heads and came out of their mouth. And they are even more amazed when their sponsee came back thanking them for their shrewd, insightful and effective counsel. There is something spiritual in the sponsorship relationship. It is often called a two-way street.

September 19

Tradition Nine

"This Tradition defines the way we run our Fellowship. A lot of confusion has occurred because of misinterpretations of our Ninth Tradition. Our members are addicts who have the desire to stop using, who want what we have to offer, and who have chosen to join us. Our meetings are a gathering of members for the purpose of staying clean."

Memphis Review Form - page 111, 1

Not putting a member qualified for NA by the disease of addiction in a position of perceived personal power protects us and them from many errors of perspective. If the group is the source of our combined wisdom and power, it is properly positioned to cushion personal errors and bring out many viewpoints that go beyond what individual group members have to offer. We don't get ahead by leaving people out.

NA began to grow as a Fellowship when we learned to share in service settings where information was routinely distributed to keep the general Fellowship informed. Information is brain food. Without food, we starve. You cannot have group conscience from an unconscious group. .

You can cut up a phone book into little strips and put them in a barrel but you cannot find the one you are looking for without putting them into alphabetical order. In other words, in 'formation.' And the formation needs every single listening if it is to contain the one you're looking for. So, you can't leave one out. Each one is important, just like our group members. You never know which member is going to have what we are looking for!

The desire, the need, and chosen to be among us. These make each member special. Our servants can carry out group conscience but they can't tell us what to do. If they do, they fall into error whether they know it or not. And in time, they will be replaced by those who can follow group direction.

September 20

"The 12 Traditions of Narcotics Anonymous are even more interrelated than our Steps. They complement each other and are bound together by the principle of anonymity."

Memphis Review Form - page 115, 6

"Anonymity is the whole basis of the program; it is truly the foundation. In order to survive, we must set aside the differences we live by and become a part of a greater whole." Recovery leads us back into the fabric of our relationships among members. To enjoy this new way of life we have to drop a lot of the personal preferences that get in the way of our relationships. The preferences are not as important as the relationships. In the end they usually don't mean that much to us and we later find they blocked the way to our happy destiny.

"Anonymity is the spiritual foundation of all our traditions". One member saw this as the Leaning Tower of Pizza. If the anonymity is lost, the foundation fails and all of the Traditions begin to lean, eventually crashing to the ground in a big pile. Without anonymity the Traditions will eventually crash to the ground and the clear message cannot be carried.

When we violate one tradition, we violate them all. We may not realize it but later we find we violate even more.

One member went to the Area Service Committee and asked to start a non-court slips signing meeting. They were told, "We have had a very long affiliation with the Drug Court. We promote Drug Court and let them use the NA name in their brochure. In our opinion, the Drug Court is very effective." Without travel and study, it is easy to make mistakes. The reason we don't affiliate is because every organization has its own strengths and weaknesses. We take care to protect what we as a Fellowship have found to be important and essential for NA to exist as a spiritual Fellowship.

September 21

"If we're not grateful for the things we've got, we won't be grateful for the things we are yet to receive."

Memphis Review Form - page 70, 16

We make gratitude lists often. These can be of small things like shoes with no holes in them, a sandwich for lunch, a noon meeting to go to. They can be of profound things like being clean, being healthy and having a roof over our heads.

These lists are profound and should be used often. They put things in perspective. We get lost in habitual negativity. It takes some work on our part to get used to being grateful. Listing brings the reality close enough for us to see it.

One member, at his nightly prayers, counted off on his fingers all the nice things that happened to him every day. These could include a free cup of coffee at the bank, a woman who let him go ahead at the store since he only had one item, a good lunch, a nice compliment from the boss and even someone letting him go in front of them in traffic. Isn't it wonderful how something so simple can help save our lives in recovery!

September 22

“Those of us who do service work are the luckiest people on God’s earth! Those who have been in the pits of despair, now strive to help other people to find a new and better way to live.”

Memphis Review Form - page 61, 2

This statement only works when the service is genuine giving. Blunt routines may support but do not constitute the evidence of our loving and caring. Loving is the thought or intention. Caring is doing the actions that stem from the intention. When we help others we find it easier to accept help ourselves. We slowly realize we don’t feel better than or proud and arrogant when we do service. It feels good to do good. You can’t be useless if you are being useful!

When we are helping others, it puts us in a creative state of mind and we think of things we could easily afford to do better ourselves. Addiction boxes us in and our encounters with other people become defensive and evasive. For years people with polio were locked in full body casts to prevent them from shriveling up in contorted positions. How’s that for a world of hurt? Movement, polio vaccine, diet, and general exercise turned the whole treatment attitude around. For years, addiction was thought to be an incurable disease of heart, mind and body. Now we get help from admission of truth, belief, faith and inventory which leads to spiritual practices. It makes all the difference.

Listening, reading, discussing and learning what works for others give us immediate access to the things we need most to re-discover happy, healthy living.

September 23

“Honesty, open-mindedness, and willingness to try, work hand in hand. The lack of one of these principles in our programs can kill us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 66, 18

Many people who call themselves members may be under a false impression that addiction is not a disease that can kill us. Rocking chair recovery can appear to work for a while, but it may leave us without the tools and principles that comprise the N A Program. Inaction replaces healthy strength and movement with weakness and disability. Many members rest on the widespread meetings and body of literature as if there is nothing left to do for the growth and continuance of N A. Nothing could be further from the truth. When we stop working the Program, the Program stops working! Without knowledge of who we are and where we come from we remain children.

When the Basic Text was written, there were discussions as to whether honesty, open-mindedness and the willingness to try (HOW) were spiritual principles. Honesty requires surrender, belief and faith.. Open-mindedness sets our minds ‘open-to-receive.’ This takes away the filter we use to exclude un-approved information! We don’t have to buy the new information, just pay attention and consider what someone is saying. The willingness to try is a strange one because if we are willing, we usually don’t have to do whatever is under consideration. If we are unwilling, the reverse is true. The subject will reappear until we do it!

Honesty, open-mindedness and the willingness to try remain our big three spiritual principles because they are so useful in recovery. We addicts in recovery can attest to the need for repetition and re-focusing our attention as we grow spiritually.

September 24

“Our Steps and Traditions are uniform and set in a specific order. They are numbered; they are not random and unstructured. Certainly they are organized, but this is not the organization or our Ninth Tradition. For the purpose of this Tradition, organized means having an administrative structure, and this implies management and control.”

Memphis Review Form - page 111, 9

Businesses are arranged in order this way. Do it our way or the highway! But businesses are not spiritual Fellowships. Addicts in recovery often make recovery ‘mistakes’ because they have not learned better! Persons with clean time wait for them to ask for help because we have learned not to crash through the doors of their old ways. What they learn builds up and new connections become visible to them. We are always learning in this way.

The growth of NA recovery literature leads us to realize no one will ever know it all. Discovery is a big part of the thrill of recovery. Many addicts are afraid of spiritual growth. Things of the world seem more pertinent and real. While this is certainly true, you don’t hear of many people moved to awe and wonder by constructing erector sets! Recovery requires us to learn how to get the results we need to live clean.

It may be what we learn in recovery is we are given the keys to unlock the doorways that led to what we sought through our drug use. When we try out some of the recovery principles and find they work for us, many of us get downright curious. We want to know more. Others get a little better and try to leave the game with their winnings and resume something like their old life. We have learned that this can lead to other changes, like the things that used to make us feel good.

September 25

“Many of us have nowhere else to go if we could not trust our N.A. groups and members. We were no longer afraid to ask for help. How then did we lose our fear?”

Memphis Review Form - page 115, 11

At some point we realize that we are the baby in the meeting. We don't know how to stay clean or live life. Those who do not realize they are the baby, often become hip, slick and cool and find they cannot stay clean at the same time.

Asking for help can be very hard for most addicts. We were self sufficient as cowboys in the old west. All they needed was their cowboy hat, cowboy boots, six shooter and horse and they were good to go. They could live off the land and shift for themselves. They shot a wild boar cooked it, unrolled their sleeping bag and put their rope in a circle around it to keep the rattlesnakes from crossing over.

Addicts are like this, we got up every morning and went out to boost something to be able to score. We licked our wounds when hurt, always had a backup plan and knew how to survive until the end when the disease simply took over our lives completely and started trying to kill us in earnest.

We adapted to the clean life like that cowboy coming into Dodge City. We got a hot soapy bath, ate a home cooked meal and slept in a bed. We realized that this was much better than living out there in the brush on our own.

September 26

"The awakening of anonymity in each of us occurs when we've finally given up trying to manage our lives and begin to depend on a power greater than ourselves."

Memphis Review Form - page 115, 16

Thinking we are different from others, insisting on having our way, needless conflicts with others: all these are the prison bars of our active addiction. They keep us more or less in conflict with all the people we come in contact with in our day to day lives. Newer members by definition are accustomed to the company of people who are using! Clean addicts walk to the beat of a different drummer.

Anonymity, meaning here that we are all the same in kind. Seeing the similarities, even in our faults and shortcomings, we discover our new identity. It occurs to us, it is ok to be imperfect. In fact, all people are imperfect. Getting better is not an unattainable goal! It is merely a process that feels better as we get used to living a new way of life. We all have the disease of addiction in common, which is what promotes unity, and our common welfare has to come first. Our personal recovery depends on this identification.

Our differences no longer set us apart or result in loneliness. Our choices may be changed if we find they don't really suit us. Choice allows us to improve our situation rather than locks us into permanent fixation. As freedom becomes our state of existence we realize the importance of regaining our human right to make changes!

September 27

“As the benefits of basic honesty in the world begin to roll in, we are ready to consider honesty at a deeper level. Self-honesty is being in touch with the way we really feel and the way we spend our time.”

Memphis Review Form - page 82, 4

Admitting faults is one of the gifts of honesty. We don't have to shadow box with life as if we are punished for each and every mistake that happens in the course of daily existence. “Opps, I'm sorry.” costs little and eases situations where an unexpected error pops up. “That's ok.” says someone and life goes on.

One member went to a past business partner and apologized. The stunned business partner blurted out “It takes a big man to apologize”. Many cannot bring themselves to do this and wind up relapsing. We must get honest and do the work if we are to survive.

As we scrape away the layers of fact, fiction and supposition, we find the most useful tool is honesty. Many items on our list of personal concerns didn't even happen. Others happened but not the way we thought or recalled and with a different residue. Some of the worst things happened but were blocked out of our consciousness by our built in defence mechanisms. Constant contact with the higher power of our understanding will help us no matter what the case at hand may be. “It's all about love.” applies to humanity in general. Mind and mood altering drugs distort and confuse our perceptions and our ability to process what we hear, see and feel correctly. Recovery and the the 12 Steps of NA help us sort out the sad mess of our lives.

At the end of the process, we are on different terms with reality. We make amends where possible and are freed to move on with our lives.

September 28

“Remember too that H.O.W. are spiritual principles which mean that they can be relied on to get us out of trouble that dishonesty, closed-mindedness and unwillingness got us into.”

Memphis Review Form - page 66, 23

Interesting how the words line up. In active addiction, we practiced honesty when it was convenient but lies and distortion of facts kept us alive and out of jail. Lots of times we still have a tendency to lie even when it is just out of habit. Many of us are still amazed when truth telling eases a tense situation and then there is no more trouble. How about that? Honesty results in ‘no more trouble.’

Many drugs induce hallucinations where we see and hear things that are not there. This can be a real kick for some of us, especially if our living situation is not too hot. After a while, we have to avoid non-users who would freak out if we started rambling all the stuff rattling through our brains. Ordinary learning and practicing social skills was an encumbrance. Our world shrunk to include only addicts like us where we felt somewhat safe and comfortable. In recovery, open-mindedness is a tool we practice to work our very own 12 Steps and rediscover life with the drug-induced side-effects out of the picture..

After some memorable difficulties, jail, beatings and car crashes, we began to play it safe whenever possible. Anything new and difficult was best avoided. Failure and shortfall became the rule, not the exception. So we just stopped trying. In recovery, we have to learn failure is not so bad in most cases. It may only a step in learning valuable to us. Other times willingness is a necessary item in a series of events designed, perhaps by an all loving higher power, to help us move on with life.

September 29

"It wasn't until we made a real mess of our lives that we realized that we couldn't do it alone."

Memphis Review Form - page 48, 30

Being clean clears our vision and increases our ability to hear what others are saying. It may be that the isolation that characterizes our disease comes from the many, many times we wake up when the drugs wear off and look around for all the things we have to answer for. Then, we go around saying, "Hey man. Sorry I did that, it was the dope not me." Like the using gives us a smoke screen to avoid personal responsibility.

Clean, we can string together events as they occur in our lives and see more vividly how one thing leads to all the rest. It may take awhile, and that's ok. Healing should not be a rush job. It takes time clean for recovery to penetrate past our surface issues into the depths of our being but the result is the workable, more complete and satisfied being we become.

God, life and nature conspire to make us happy. If we just have to touch the hot stove to believe it will burn, that may be our choice. But, boy do we learn from some experience. Recovery moves us from a world where we many not be able to trust our senses to a world where sense perceptions are more accurate and useful.

Finding ourselves amazingly sitting in an NA meeting, we recognize what we are hearing from the people in the room exactly the same things we have been going through. The more we hear, the more recognize our identification at some point we try out something that worked for someone else. We were surprised when it got us good results and began to try other things. This is when we realized we could do better trying out things that worked for other addicts than when tried to control things.

September 30

"The ego of the addict must be busted for him to have a chance at recovery. "Terminal hipness" and "fatal cool" are symptoms of the addictive personality."

Memphis Review Form - page 82, 11

When we stopped beating the square peg, trying to get it to fit in the round hole, we considered giving up. It just wasn't working. We noticed no one was being fooled by our efforts and set the hammer down. We probably grinned a little and tried to act like it was no big deal. That's right, we didn't want to seem embarrassed in front of people and wanted to keep our cool. Right.

Ego is not a bad thing, in and of itself. It is just us being ourselves. But, you know, drugs will mess with your mind, and in that sense it's not our fault. Yeah, no ego trip here! The longer we stay clean and our vision improves along with our hearing, we leave off the ego bit. We're just human. And clean, well things steadily improve. Good food, sleep and exercise begin to bring us back into focus. Fear, loneliness and general confusion loosen their grip. It is important to recall what the last one did for us, maybe it will stay the last one.

What used to be one of our biggest problems, our ego, shifts into a healthy sense of self. We have a God given right to our preferences whether they fit in with everyone else or not. There are some good reasons why we don't drink milk or milk products if we discover we are milk intolerant. If we had some happy years in high school, we may prefer certain forms of music over others. We have all sorts of preferences in clothing, food, excursions, whatever. But they don't isolate us or keep us from enjoying the company of others. The pretensions fall away and the real self, in our case, can come out!

September 31

“At least one meeting a day for ninety days seems to be a good guide for those who are going to any lengths.”

Memphis Review Form - page 82, 21

Going to meetings, reading recovery literature, calling your sponsor, asking for God's help, don't pick up - these are five recommendations that seem to work for all members regardless of age, sex, etc. It is astonishing how helpful these simple things give us a daily reprieve from the hell of active addiction!

Only a sincere member of N A gets to participate in this wonderful thing we call simply “recovery.” The price of membership is high - it costs our self-will and ego. The idea we can handle it on our own can kill us. You are the one who decides if you are sincere or not. Identification with other N A members brings a special calm and new self appraisal since we begin to compare our feelings with others in the same boat we are.

You may not be new to NA but we know our addiction is waiting to make its move. Some of us fight back by doing ninety in ninety again. We pray for a newcomer and check out a new meeting now and then. Traveling in the Fellowship reminds us, it is principles, not personalities that keep us clean and growing!

OCTOBER

October 1

"N.A. should never be run by bureaucracy or management nor controlled by individuals within administrative structure. If we were to allow this, N.A. this would surely lose the best it has to offer and choke to death on our insanities."

Memphis Review Form - page 111, 16

The man that carved the Crazy Horse Memorial in the black hills of south Dakota had worked on the four presidential faces on mount Rushmore. His mentor told him that it had been a mistake to take funds from the Federal Government as there were too many strings attached.

So when the Crazy Horse Memorial was begun, Korcjack Kilowski paid for every stick of dynamite, every gallon of diesel fuel for his Catterpillar and every dynamite fuse out of his own pocket or with donations from people visiting the site.

Twice the federal government offered him ten million in grants and both times he refused. When asked if he doubted the validity of the contract offered, he replied, "You broke every treaty with the Indians. Crazy Horse spent his life trying to enforce the treaties given by the Federal Government and fought wars over it.

The bureaucrat had no response. We must beware of these folks. Caution is the watchword here. We have learned from many painful lessons that keeping it simple and avoiding contact with political bureaucracies puts our whole program at risk Big fish eat little fish. Bureaucracies are the enemy of self-help programs.

Too often our great mission to live and live clean gets lost in platitudes. We are on our own and survival depends on our courage and gratitude. It ok if we are slow and imperfect. We don't aspire to perfection. Life is dirty sometimes and unclean but then NA is a self-correcting program. We inventory and pray for our Higher Power to free us of our defects and give us the strength to make amends when they are due. Prayer and meditation reveal the path before us and we take it in gratitude. God, help us be humble, patient and tolerant.

October 2

"We were in the depths of despair, degradation and lost in a destructive chaos. We came in puking, sweating and shaking. Some of us stayed. Was it through our own merit? We think not! Our way got us here. Recovery was done through the help of others, the tools they shared with us, and a Higher Power."

Memphis Review Form - page 67, 7

It is oh so easy to forget just how bad it was and what it felt like to have no hope, no way out and no one to turn to. Almost all humans select for a softer, easier, way. The difference for us is that that way offers only the illusion of security because we put only a coat of paint over our old behavior and call it clean! A softer, easier, way can kill us because it offers no change in how we live our lives. And without change, our recovery, our freedom and our life may be at risk.

"Enough is enough!" doesn't set any boundaries. One size doesn't fit all. "It takes what it takes." Our using resulted in making a mess of our lives. Recovery calls for us to bring the progress of our addiction to a halt by avoiding that next drug. Once we can do that, the pain and tension will eventually subside. While we get better, we have to bear in mind that it was through no effort our own. It depended on what worked for others working for us. The help, the tools and above all, our Higher Power gets all the credit. Just because it gets better doesn't mean we can return to our egotism and take control again.

It may be safe to say, that any addict who has gone back to using has found a way to wiggle out of the disease concept - or never been properly 12 Stepped to begin with! Some people are not addicts. That's not us! We begin - and continue - our recovery when we can admit to our powerlessness over addiction! Our unmanageability is a sure sign we need help!

October 3

“Guilt and worry keep us from living in the here and now. The denial of our disease, or reservations, keep us sick. We lack humility, clinging to old ways.”

Memphis Review Form - page 83, 2.

Gaining humility takes time and a thorough working of Steps 6 and 7. Humility is a total acceptance of ourselves, both our good points and our character defects. We need to achieve such a total acceptance of ourselves that we don't feel the need to justify our actions or viewpoints. We don't have to explain ourselves, defend ourselves or promote ourselves. We can just calmly state our truth and move on without further discussion or argument. Our sponsors and home groups are there to help us in difficulty.

Guilt reviews our past and contains events and instances that make us ashamed and embarrassed. Worry is the mental state we experience when we see bad things coming our way or just 'feel funny.'. Both lock us out of the moment we are standing in. The present is the only time we have an opportunity to surrender to what we are powerless over or admit fault and go on with our lives, making amends as we go. Basic recovery repeats the truth that it is only through being conscious in the present moment that we can take effective action to change things for the better.

Old ways did not work when we had nothing better and there is a very good chance they won't work now! Even if we s tumble, we stumble upward.

October 4

"We came to this program for many different reasons. Those of us who stay, do so for the same reason--to stop using and stay clean."

Memphis Review Form - page 88, 6

This is our one chance, today! Some of us recognized that. Others missed it entirely and went back out never to revisit NA ever again. Today, I am grateful that I had the clarity and desperation to realize that it was my one chance. Had I not been so beaten down, I would have missed it and died from my disease. Staying clean leads me into a new state of existence wherein I can see, hear and feel accurately and think through what's happening to make better choices. Conscious contact and help from my higher power give me resources I didn't have before.

We are all amazed how easy it is to forget our basic dependence on our HP as soon as things get a little bit better! Praying seems like so much trouble when what we really need is a miracle! Here's how it goes, "God, I don't think I can handle this. Please help and guide me in my recovery. I need your strength and guidance!" See? Was that so hard?

We have been taught to snatch and grab, sure that is the only way we can get a fair shake. Actually, when we give we open our hands and hearts to receive. Spiritual non-attachment frees us to move and make new choices. Attachment weighs us down with fear and acts of desperation. Letting go reduces our burden and when we relax, we can see, hear and feel better. Attention is a price we all have to pay. Important things make it worthwhile to take our time. We are important. Thinking gives us a chance to check our facts before jumping into trouble. If you want something, wait a few days. You may not want it later on. You get paid for your waiting!

October 5

“Usually one of the first things we try to do when we’re working with a newcomer is to get them to a meeting. After all, that’s what worked for us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 88, 19

An N A group has one primary purpose, and that is to carry this message to the addict who still suffers. This can only be done through *our* members sharing their honest experience, strength and hope. By watching newcomers who have raised their hands, or when we notice the scared addict sitting by him or herself in the back of the room. In a loving way, remembering their name or just simply introducing ourselves, “Hi, I am an addict named ____.”

Meeting attendance helps the new member to identify with other recovering addicts and provides a pathway to the experience, strength and hope of those who came before us. It also provides an opportunity to be of service for our more experienced members when we “12th Step” newcomers by taking them to meeting.

This approach also helps our long timers to remain humble. Our surrender helps us put ego aside and remember that it is the group that is our most powerful vehicle for carrying the message. Our recovery fosters the spirit of the therapeutic value of one addict helping another. Even long time members of NA find it impossible to stay clean if they do not work their 12th Step. You can’t carry our message if you don’t have gratitude and hope.

October 6

“We react angrily as recovering addicts if anyone tells us what to do. In N.A. meetings, we share what it was like in our practicing addiction, our suffering that brought us to the turning point and how we stay clean today.”

Memphis Review Form - page 67, 20

One of the unspoken facts of our clean life and recovery is there are people in the rooms who do not share our enthusiasm, energy and willingness to commit to our Program. They may go further with their program and realize the stakes are their lives, their happiness and their dreams - lose all three. One general statement stands out clearly and that is the Program as we know it was built by people who lived it and wrote it down in the Basic Text. Some caretakers have attempted to 'own' and take credit for our literature yet are almost completely in the dark as to how it was written and the spirituality involved! So, in our daily recovery we are free to embrace, learn and apply the deepest and most loving N A light we can find and apply to our lives.

The old saying was “You can tell an addict, but you can't tell him much.” The ratios between long timers and newcomers were very different today from in the past. Back then the long timers outnumbered the newcomers and could convey information thru sheer numbers. Now there are places where in many meetings the number of newcomers outweighs the long timers by 10 to 1 and then the long timers become voices in the wilderness.

If someone in the meeting has no clean time and can't surrender, they will find it difficult to make the program. Only the sincere will be able to work our 12 Steps. Interrupting members or discounting on their shares is a sign of ego and self-centeredness. Experienced members may try to talk with them after a meeting if the spirit moves them. But each member has a God given right to say no to NA and go their own way even if it kills them.

October 7

“Before coming to the fellowship of N.A., we were irresponsible with our lives. We used drugs to cover up our humiliation, guilt, inferiority and feelings of inadequacy.”

Memphis Review Form - page 23, 1

Most of us practice some sort of wake-up ritual, reading literature, listening to recovery tapes or CD's to get our day off to a good start. It is vitally important that we keep our focus on recovery and things that work in recovery if we are going to experience the benefits of N A! The simplest things can make so much difference in the way our days go.

Just missing a few meetings can cause us to begin to experience the feelings we associate with our disease. Resentments crop up over very small issues. We may snap at co-workers and spouses. Just a member calling us can put us back in a better place.

We must realize when we are uncentered that the longer we stay there, the greater the likelihood that disastrous things will happen. They may simply be stupid decisions or may result in the calamity of picking up. The person who left the bar or shooting gallery did not know they were going to kill someone or die trying to drive home. Learning how to live clean is an ongoing, daily process. There is a saying, “If we aren't growing, we are going.” Scary but true.

October 8

"Many of us were convinced that we were right and the world was wrong, and used this belief to justify our self-destructive behavior."

Memphis Review Form - page 1, 8

When we judge ourselves and find ourselves unworthy, self-destructive behavior results. We are in a terrific position to punish ourselves. There are quirks in our nervous system that make punishing ourselves a kind of answer. The more we punish ourselves for doing things we didn't feel good about, the less pressure was on, at least for the moment. Beyond simple mistakes and lost jobs, some go so far that they cut themselves and engage in other dangerous forms of abuse.

In N A we find a new mindset and a new vocabulary: the NA Steps and Traditions. Words like responsibility, forgiveness, gratitude, caring and sharing lead us into a strange new world where all the rules are changed. Honesty is a way to stay out of jail, not a way to get arrested! How many other words have changed meaning or usefulness? Looking up words in a dictionary can surprise us!

When first we found drugs, they seemed to make the world look crazy and weird. It was funny! As our using progressed, crazy and weird began to look normal. Coming out of active addiction, we have to make a few changes. Generally, the more we change, the better it gets!

October 9

"In the past we have relied on desperation to give us the strength to periodically re-order our lives. There is another way."

Memphis Review Form - page 70, 26

When we stay in the middle of the herd, work the tools of NA and attend meetings regularly, we operate like a well oiled Swiss watch. We take bad news in stride and keep on trucking. We become efficient, pleasant and happy more often than not.

When we neglect our program, and things begin to fall apart, sometimes we must hit a severe crisis to wake up and run back to the program and redouble our efforts at recovery. Sometimes even this crisis does not wake us up and stop the slide.

It seems that given to our own devices, we tend to slack off on our program. We blame it on relationships, being too busy and the program changing for the worse. Some believe it is the disease causing this in order to get us away from the program so that it can start moving us towards using again. For us there is no safe using! It is like starting a forest fire forgetting our house will be burnt to the ground by the blaze!

October 10

“When we pray a remarkable thing happens; we find the means, the ways, and energies, to perform tasks far beyond our capabilities. By the surrender of our own power, we gain a far greater power that will see us through.”

Memphis Review Form - page 58, 23

The truth of this statement bears out our spiritual power being ‘higher.’ The easy way to say this is that surrender and prayer gives us the ‘luck.’

“Expect a miracle, you’ll get one” was the old saying. But we must open the vortex for HP to step in and make the miracle. Sometimes, intensive prayer will break things loose for us. But however it is packaged, it is the quiet, simple surrender that leads us back to the path that works for us in NA.

Seeking and practicing conscious contact with the higher power of our understand give us a multipurpose tool that opens all doors. Begin with small things. “God, handle this or handle that.” We we find that things are working out, go for more! Apparently, there is a secret compartment hidden in the back of our minds - or hearts - and we can contact this force by stopping and taking time to as for God’s help.

October 11

"Life then becomes for us what we always wished it to be -- a constant state of awakening."

Memphis Review Form - page 83, 13

Many of us used drugs to intensify our minds and this helped drive us crazy! Sick, tired, on our knees, we sought and found recovery. Looking inward for answers encourages us to go further inward. The quiet little voice within becomes our new best friend.

Some people believe addicts turn to drugs to make an unbearable situation bearable. That may be. We were sure looking for something. Active addiction tore our minds up and almost all addicts agree that they reached a point where they could no longer think clearly and lost control of themselves. They would do whatever the drugs told them to do. So, recovery allows us to snap out of the old ways of thinking and new thoughts arise to take their place.

Waking up, we find opportunities to change. We look at life differently. Just having friends with many of the same living problems helps. When we get involved with helping others, many of us find ourselves taking our own good advice. Seeing others asking for help taking our advice, helps us lower our guards and ask for help ourselves!

October 12

“The tools we use to maintain our willingness are practice and prayer. How sincerely we work Step Six will be proportionate to our desire for change.”

Memphis Review Form - page 47, 27

Every member of N A has experienced the desire for recovery before they got clean. Practice gives us a way to get better by repeating our efforts until we get it right. Prayer sets us in the mood to receive without putting up a fight to receive what we are going after. Our efforts are based on our desire for recovery. This is what gives us the power we need to work all 12 Steps.

It is our desire for recovery that powers and guides us through the process of the NA`12 Steps. We want to get clean, so we surrender. We want a higher power we can trust and so came to believe. We wanted the care of our higher power and found it only awaited our willingness. Desire is a little like a candle flame, a little bit destroys the darkness. Then a little more lets us look around. We can keep going as long as we are willing to take care of the flame. It was there, inside, all along.

As we become more sensical, we realize we can explore and try on ideas before adopting them. We are really allowed to pick and choose what we like and move away from what turns us off. Recovery is all about positive change to suit ourselves.

October 13

"This force in the meetings isn't just the people there, but also something within the people. We return to these meetings and use them like medicine in the form of unconditional love."

Memphis Review Form - page 68, 2

There is a strong spirituality in the love we share at our N A meetings. We express as best we can what we are doing in our day to day to lives. We share the way we use the principles of N A to deal with things that used to have us on the run. Hearing some of the hair-raising episodes that occur in the lives of our friends will automatically encourage us and change the way we do things. Sometimes it helps us in our daily living just to stop and get in that "N A state of mind" in the midst of whatever is going on. We focus better, we recall things we need to deal with life. We are more honest and considerate of others. As we succeed using N A principles, honesty, openmindedness and the willingness to try become woven into the fabric of our lives.

One member was hopelessly stuck on a big project. He went to a meeting and it was terrible. The room was full of smoke and they had opened the windows which made it cold inside. The speaker talked about getting loaded while kids ran screaming thru the entire meeting.

The member went home shaking his head and woke the next morning totally centered. He focused on the project and completed it in good order. He realized that there was a presence in the room that had healed him. He never looked at meetings the same ever since that time. Every meeting was a perfect meeting from then on. See, it isn't just what's in the meeting. When we are in the meeting, we are there too. Our surrender helps change us inside.

October 14

“What is it about our meetings that’s so special? Usually, about all we can say is that there is a feeling there, a feeling of strength and hope and love; an atmosphere of recovery. Our meetings are very special to most of us. They’re a place where we feel safe; a place where we fit in.”

Memphis Review Form - page 89, 1

For many of us this is the first time we have felt that we fit in. Many addicts have felt different from everyone else all their lives and to finally feel we belong is an incredible feeling. We love it. We are greeted, told we will be loved until we learn to love ourselves and accepted just as we are. Later, we want to help the newcomer feel this way too.

Because I came in to meetings where no one was forced to attend against their will, the feeling was that I was safe there.

Drug court has proved to be a growing problem. Our program is designed to carry our message to sick and suffering addicts. Judges are sending people who are disruptive. This is not the NA Way. Angry people there against their will can kill that force. In fact, it’s hard to have both in the same room. Many feel that this is a small price to pay for the unwilling addict facing prison to avoid incarceration. They believe that if we can just enable them, then we will feel wonderful. They believe that chaotic meetings can be very effective and pleasant for us. Was that attractive to you when you came into recovery?

DRT is another modern problem for us in a program of total abstinence. Many members are having to sort this out for themselves. NA will always be a program of total abstinence so we have to find ways to make this clear. Naturally some recovering addicts are silting ducks waiting in the pond! The unfairness of this situation seems not to bother some people. Sometimes all we can do is stay clean ourselves and hope these unfortunates make it through to recovery.

Chaotic meetings are upsetting and eventually run off addicts seeking recovery by offering none. Then the meeting shrinks until the sincere and surrendered begin to relight the desire for recovery. This is a tough process.

October 15

“Even without this Tradition (9), organization such as this would be in opposition to our spiritual principles. A loving God as He may express himself in our group conscience would find no place within an administrative structure.”

Memphis Review Form - page 111, 21

Once we abandon the spiritual principles, we are dead ducks. The Fellowship begins to unravel and a clear message is no longer carried. Newcomers do not get clean or stay clean. They cannot stay clean unless they get clean first. Many are years from hitting their bottom. Since recovery is based on desire, they have to hurt bad enough to ask for help.

Some people simply do not believe that the Traditions are important or even relevant. It's hard to stay clean when ignoring the Traditions. We have grown tremendously in recent decades. New problems have developed that were hard to foresee. Outside forces in government and medicine have pushed their way into our rooms. We must deal with these matters or we will die. There is no outside force to turn to except the great spiritual reality of our Higher Power.

Administration means applying the conclusions of a small group of people on a larger group of people. This is one of the big blind spots for members seeking recovery. They may not yet fully realize that Narcotics Anonymous is built on the accumulated successes of thousands of clean addicts. It is not a matter of personal opinion. Newer members have a hard time seeing this. They depend on us for the truth.

Our service structure was built on direct responsibility to the many and entrusted to a few. These few members must be capable and willing to stay true to NA members in recovery. An administrator would flop around and try to substitute corporate tactics in place of spiritual principles. Eventually this leads to failure and removal of procedures and policies that work for us. The Twelve Traditions are not negotiable because nothing else works for us.

October 16

“Once a group registers they are sent a starter kit. This contains many suggestions and is one of the way we share our experience to help the group. Whether or not they take our suggestion is their decision. In this starter kit it says that we must abide by the Twelve Traditions in order to call ourselves Narcotics Anonymous. This is also true, but these Traditions are part of the set of spiritual principles that are N.A. Without the Traditions, N.A. does not exist.”

Memphis Review Form - page 100, 31

Just as a surveyor can get careless and mark his charts quarter of an inch off, it may make him a mile off down the line. Where great numbers of persons are concerned, great care must be exerted. For a few people to come in and re-write the work of very intense effort and review is a tremendous liability.

Recovery teaches us to take care and proper concern in all areas of our lives. Members who have a vested interest in the growth and continuance of NA have only three ways of dealing with bureaucratic problems: correction, relapse or death. In time we hope for restitution of our original, attractive and edifying literature. We cannot permit statements and treatments of subjects in our approved literature that go against our Steps or Traditions. For instance, total abstinence and DRT or no surveillance and drug slip attendance. We have to be very careful and able to state the truth of our experience regardless of corporate or medical pressure to serve the views or issues of outside enterprises.

The new SCRAM monitors have tv cameras in them with facial recognition. They are used in the meetings and it tends to drive the long timers away. But the newcomers will argue that the long timers are jerks for leaving. So they have to try and get clean with little experienced members to guide them. The results are mediocre.

For NA to continue, we have to shield our members and meetings from outside influences. This is not close mindedness. It is necessary to keep our focus on recovery and spiritual growth. We are all free to pursue whatever belief system we love and trust. Trouble is people who are not in the Program know little or nothing of what we go through to get clean and stay clean. So, be careful and stick to Traditional NA.

October 17

“Having decided we want God, as we understood Him, to relieve us of the useless or destructive aspects of our personalities, we have arrived at the Seventh Step.”

Memphis Review Form - page 48, 12

This Step is the ‘game changer’ because we finally leave our defects behind. Because everyone who works the 12 Steps is human, we have to take apart the illusion we are in control by making an inventory list, sharing it with someone and becoming willing before we ask our higher power to remove our defects. This allows for corrective personality change. Because HP is inside of us, we have to shut off the engine before we work on the car. Our willingness lets us step aside while God helps us with the necessary changes.

Defects are things that don’t work and the ways we fall short of our goals are our shortcomings. Like changing a flat tire on a car, we first have to realize we have a flat, find the tools and a spare tire and then go through the process of correction. These things have to be done in a certain order. Addicts seem to try to do it all at once, like snapping their fingers.

All kinds of tiny miracles lead up to our birth and beginnings. Our parents and people around us prepare us for life in various ways. Addicts come from dysfunctional families and our jumbled values and habit patterns reflect unworkable approaches to life. Recovery is finding a safe place to refit our fractured personalities and rebuild.

October 18

“Groups of self-centered, self-willed, isolated individuals just can’t meet together peacefully and safely’ but we do. The reason that we can is that we have Twelve Traditions that help to keep our groups “safe” and “free.”

Memphis Review Form - page 89, 8

Often we forget or never learn just how essential our Traditions are when it comes to basic stuff like the atmosphere of recovery in our meetings. Study and open discussion give us insight and a deeper understanding of how our freedom has to mesh with the freedoms of others. There is no doubt that our members go on binges of obsession on a single point or two and for the time can’t see a broader picture, even if others are trying to help them.

Fortunately we have extensive training in dealing with nuts. Patience, humility and tolerance come easily to some of us. Loving and caring for others is not seen as an ongoing affair. Mostly, our members come out from obsession to gain information or they get to the bottom of something that bothers them.

It is said, “The NA 12 Steps keep us from killing ourselves, and the NA12 Traditions keep us from killing each other.” Most experienced members with long clean time will agree that all of recovery in NA is a giant, incomprehensible miracle. No one can explain it but just like a mountain - it is there and cannot be denied. Personal and collective conflicts are inevitable and each carefully drawn Tradition plays a role in a comprehensive system of ongoing recovery. As a car consists of parts which wear out in time, we have to maintain our Traditions to keep our Program working.

October 19

“Living clean each day at a time will reveal to us the things that truly come from within and give us better understanding over things that would interrupt our flow.”

Memphis Review Form - page 83, 20

Without the drugs and addictive distractions, what we go through reconnects us to reality and if we want to add or take away something, our new way of living gives us that power. Many members forget their power to ‘change gears.’ If something is bothering us, we can do something about it! Just because our lives are better doesn’t mean we are stuck at a certain level. Ongoing recovery is ongoing inventory and growth!

At this point, many of us have learned to get back to what worked for us in the beginning! We read literature again, check out some new meetings, write down our feelings and read short examples of what seems to be bothering us. While it is always the disease in one form or another, it helps to let others know and get things out in the open within our loving, caring Fellowship.

Our flow is what we are doing with our lives. Letting our checking account get out of hand, missing appointments and other small things going wrong let us know it is time to get back to our program - the things that we do to stay clean and grow spiritually. If we don’t tell others what’s happening with us, we have to stagger on helpless because we are not asking for help.

October 20

"Most of us had never experienced the kind of attention and personal care that we found in the program. We are accepted and loved for 'what we are' instead of "in spite" of what we are."

Memphis Review Form - page 90, 28

Because we have adapted our Steps and Traditions from another program, we have to remind ourselves we have only taken a recipe from another program but also we have baked our own cake by writing our own literature and working our program. .

We have expanded our program of recovery to include the many forms addictive disease can take. Once you take away the drugs from a drug crazed maniac, you just have a more efficient maniac. Addiction comes out in many ways. Recovery reflects our surrender to the fact of our addiction and our need for ongoing inventory, prayer and meditation. By giving the same love and good treatment we received when we came to NA, we renew and breath life into minutes, hours and days of our life.

We get addicted to ideas, places, people, moods, activities: anything that qualifies for obsession or compulsion. Recovery is regaining our choice. Addiction is not having a say in what we do, when we do it or why we do it. We lose our rights to freedom when the addictive process takes over.

October 21

“Specialization and professionalism are the basis of any management scheme. Any administrative structure, by its very nature, eliminated the possibility of autonomy. An organized N.A. is a contradiction in terms and any attempt to force organization on us would destroy us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 111, 28

This program is based on our personal desire for recovery. We can have a dance together. We can have a service structure as long as it listens to what we say and does what it is told. The minute it can't do that, the so called structure ceases to exist because it fails the definition of "...we may create...." Nobody can make us follow their orders. The service structure is a one way street coming from the membership and our service boards and committees can exist only if they are directly responsible to the membership. There can be no two ways about this. This truth is not clearly understood by members who get into service and forget where they came from. Spiritual principles are not negotiable, just like Traditions!

If any of this bothers you, best check your inventory. As the disease of addiction would have it, many times our 'twisted serpents' get confused and wander around a bit expecting others to follow orders. Let it be. They will come off their cloud eventually. Pray for strength and guidance and cover the service shortfall the best way you can.

Organizations and professionals have failed to make progress when it comes to addiction for thousands of years. The only thing that ever helped us is to get away from chemicals that make us crazy and begin to take responsibility for our living practices. We created NA by the grace of a loving God and the quality of our surrender.

October 22

"When we first came into the Fellowship of N.A., we were often resentful at the suggestions some of the members made to us."

Memphis Review Form - page 30, 1

As we learn more about how N.A. works, we realize members try to wait until we ask for help. There is a chance that we may have asked for help in some area and the members responded to our request without our fully understanding. Sometimes body language speaks better than words. When it comes to recovery, almost every single thing we share has withstood the repetition of working in practice. It came from those who came before. Be clear about this: recovery is escaping our limitations, not warmed over egotism.

None of us claim to be perfect and, while we are very capable of slipping into ego trips and authoritative roles, it is just our disease acting up. Really, we know better and some of us are comfortable laughing at ourselves. There is a good saying for this. "Man who cannot laugh at himself is missing one of the world's greatest jokes!"

Our awareness grows and as we discover the linkage between our actions and the results, we frequently say "Oh, my God." when we catch ourselves doing things on impulse.. The truth often seems threatening at first but later on it proves to be a great friend! Honesty is not only the best policy, it is a spiritual principle!

October 23

“The Ninth Tradition goes on to define the nature of the things that we can do, outside N.A., to help N.A. It says that we may create service boards or committees directly responsible to those they serve.”

Memphis Review Form - page 111, 34

This Tradition is making it clear that our service boards and committees cannot tell members of the NA Fellowship what to do as if they were an employer. May seem like a tiny difference but talking down to people and giving orders is killing to the spirit within. The fact is taking on the role of a caregiver or an employer can only result is the member eventually walking away - which they have every right to do. We don't want our members leaving our Fellowship because of misguided leadership. Leave that ego at the door! Ego tries to take over when we forget to pray for help and forget who we are and where we came from.

Humility, patience and tolerance allow us to work miracles by leaving the authority in divine hands. We are beneficiaries, not benefactors. The help we give is based on our surrender and willingness to follow divine guidance. The Program of NA developed because we need help accepting goodness into our lives. Addiction is losing control of our thinking and our actions. When we cut ourselves off from our Higher Power, we slip back into powerlessness.

Working on our 12 Steps is necessary because if we can't turn our lives and wills over to a loving, caring and competent power greater than ourselves, we will justify our actions rather than ask for help. Being a trusted servant worthy of trust is behind many of the successes in our history.

October 24

“Letting go of character defects should be done with love. It is important we think, to be gentle with ourselves when putting our ego to rest.”

Memphis Review Form - page 84, 1

When we are gentle with ourselves, we may be more likely to be gentle with others. We adjust our literature to soften the truth just enough that it doesn't blast away at the reader. Humor, self disclosure, restatement create a learning atmosphere and when we are having trouble understanding something new to us, it can really help to lead by example or suggestion rather than a heavy handed approach!

It is easy to get all worked up and create new problems by lashing out in anger, even if our intent is to change our ways for the better. We can attack others and do damage to ourselves without intention. We need always to bear in mind our program works a day at a time and going slow and deep is better than quick and shallow.

The program is constantly guiding us to be responsible and alert to our side of the road while being considerate to others we interact with. We may be missing the point if we push others away for the sake of being right in matters of mutual misunderstanding.

October 25

“Unity is the direct result of application of the principle of anonymity within the group and the fellowship.”

Memphis Review Form - page 115, 25

It is not who made a proposal but what was proposed. A popular person may make bad proposals because they are trusted. An unpopular person may make a great proposal that fails to get support due to prejudice. Justice is to discuss proposals to filter out the “who” and get to the “what” prior to voting on what may be an important issue.

Generally, the best group decisions are made when they fit in with other decisions and have the benefit of experienced members familiar with the subject or issue at hand. This may be the ‘unity’ referred to in the sentence quoted from the Grey Book. All things considered makes the best agreement and the anonymity means it is usually self-enforcing.

We are all subject to limitations which we may not be aware of due to proximity. Open discussion and evaluation raises consciousness and that is the basis for “group conscience.”

October 26

"If we continue to fall back into the illusion that drugs would make life easier, we must not be ready yet. We believed that drugs would change us and forgot the changes would be fatal. Unless the illusion is shattered that we, in any way, can stop using on our own, we will use again."

Memphis Review Form - page 125, 8

In general, people do not reach an understanding of why and how the N A program works. Try paying more attention to what others are saying with their words and their faces or body language. Some will be attending every word spoken by a newcomer to our rooms because they came to the meeting to help others. What they share can tell you where they are at. Crosstalk breaks the atmosphere of recovery, after the meeting is the time to get with someone and interact. Trying to do it within the context of a meeting creates an interruption of the "meeting" of minds and hearts of attending members.

A dialogue is between a few people and a monologue is even less. Because of the various gatherings of persons in treatment or therapy, it is easy for members to slip into the interruptive format without realizing they are out of order or inappropriate. They may fail to see what they are doing takes away from the purpose and function of a Narcotics Anonymous meeting, which is a different thing entirely. They don't mean to take away from the group members because they are conditioned to share in different formats like group meetings in a recovery house or therapy..

Many times the group members or secretaries do not know how to handle situations like this and it takes a good sponsor or an effective NA learning day to inform people what to do to pleasantly bring the meeting back to order. We share our E, S and H. Interruption is egotism. .

October 27

"We took the opportunity to avoid several of our responsibilities, missing meetings, skipping work, neglecting Twelve Step work, and most important, we stopped asking for help. Growth in the program stopped."

Memphis Review Form - page 125, 14

Other good stuff in this paragraph from the Grey Book. The idea is that certain things we do in recovery can be written out and listed work together to help us stay clean and grow spiritually. If we stop doing one or more of these things, we may put our whole recovery at risk.

Yes, we could coast forward for a little ways. But our spiritual deposits were soon matched by our spiritual withdrawals. The flow of miracles stops coming. We need these miracles and it is sometimes hard for us to see where the prayers make such a big difference.

Sal things are not of this world and so are difficult to quantify in terms like sight, sound, piritutaste, color, etc. They are spiritual and beyond things of this world. Does someone need to spell this out for you? Is this not your experience? We see the difference in the way things work out for us. The way others react to us when we are working the Program gives us the feedback we are on the right track! When we get twitchy and unreasonable, it is a signpost of discomfort because we are out of sorts spiritually. We find the power to stop, look and listen for what we have forgotten or done wrong in time to correct it and so restore the balance within. No dope, no trouble, no need for amends. Just self-correction.

October 28

"No single person (no personality) has authority. This is vested in a loving God to whom we have turned over our will and lives."

Memphis Review Form - page 116, 1

Although self-willed, self-appointed addicts will seek control, it is a farce. NA is built up on addicts who can share honestly from their hearts what they are feeling and the concern they have for others., Authority is based on putting one person's certainty above what their find true about service and recovery. Service without feelings is a misnomer. Recovery without helping others is misguided.

We do not help ourselves at the expense of others. When we help others, we get better because of the good feelings we have about ourselves. It is these feelings that wash away the shame and guilt of our past by replacing it with our new life experiences. Where we used to act without thinking, we pause to pray and ask for the help of our Higher Power.

Every time someone asks for help, we make a prayer to be used as instruments. God answers these prayers and our betterment is proof positive that prayer works. It is not 'us' that gets better, it is the roles we play in the times of our life!

October 29

"In order to achieve our spiritual aim, Narcotics Anonymous must be known and respected. Nowhere is this more obvious than our history. N.A. was founded 1953. For twenty years our Fellowship remain small and obscure. In the 1970s, society realized that addiction had become a worldwide condition and began to look for answers."

Memphis Review Form - page 112, 14

Among those looking for answers, there were many addicts. From the bare bones of what worked in another Fellowship, we found a solid foundation to build our NA Program. What works in NA moves quickly where it is not interrupted by ego and relapse. One addict helping another in an atmosphere of truthfully sharing our pain and desire for recovery allowed us to move, as a Fellowship, beyond our former boundaries and almost overnight, meetings sprang up here in America as well as many other countries worldwide. The newly written and approved service structure, *the NA Tree*, supplied a working group conscience base to bring addicts together. Addicts pulling together pooled our resources into a great movement of love and caring.

While problems of dealing with success and money flourished, we still surrendered and applied 12 Step recovery among our membership. This is where we continued to grow and prosper disconnected from those who profited and built on our successes. While many of their efforts proved helpful, many members felt alienated and left out. We have never gotten anything easy. Frustrating as it has been at times, answers were found and important principles were utilized to keep members moving forward together. Aided by modern communications, addicts continued to learn from their mistakes. Pulling together and working on personal recovery continued to feed a growing pool of members who never lost hope and were willing to do their part for the general good.

In the 80's and 90's many changes were made that left groups and individual members largely out of the loop yet communications still allowed enough members to maintain their attitude of gratitude and interpersonal bonds to keep the spirit of NA strong. As the drug epidemic spread, we continued to grow from within. It is from this internal repository of love and wisdom our heart and spine grew stronger. In making spiritual growth and active part of our lives, we too must be looking for answers on a daily basis. We need to repeat what works and discard what fails.

October 30

"We do not define our members. We only insist they have a desire to stop using. Nothing else should matter. This desire is the one crucial must of our program."

Memphis Review Form - page 116, 7

There will be many times when a member comes to us so broken in mind and spirit that they cannot see or hear clearly. In our early days, there were many sincere members who could not understand that pot and liquor were not as powerful as the drugs they could relate to addiction. They had to learn from other members or the painful additional experience of relapse that any mood or mind altering drugs breaks the continuum of recovery that cleantime represents.

The notion that there are no musts in NA misleads members who disagree with portions of the Program they do not yet see as true or important. Only time will tell what they need to complete their understanding. This is the growing body of written recovery that gives us the benefit of acquiring information from others in an atmosphere of surrender and shared experience. Only someone with an honest desire for recovery can learn in this way. If's and but's have no place here. If you want a new life and believe your life depends on it, you become what can only be described as 'totally willing.' This is what we mean by desire!

We are careful to never put a ceiling on our desire to get better. Addiction is not a disease that goes away just because we are good boys and girls! It stays waiting for the day when we are 'recovered enough.' Then it is prepared to bite a real hunk out of our behinds!

October 31

“We seek creativity through the spirit. The spirit dwells within all of us. We need to understand that the spirit within each individual is the same.”

Memphis Review Form - page 124, 5

The spirit we are talking about is wordless yet finds endless meaning in each moment of our daily lives. Conscious contact is probably the most important single blessing we have to share in NA. Just stopping the show long enough to check in with our Higher Power gives us ongoing advantage over the vagaries of daily living. When we can't do this because we are too busy or regard conscious contact as hocus pocus, we are in trouble.

It is this inner connection that guides us through the countless opportunities to go right or go wrong.

A member asked how we stay clean in the early days of his recovery. He was asked if he felt like using at the moment. He said, “No, I'm at a meeting.” He was told to stay in that meeting state of mind all day long! That's what going to meetings, reading the literature and picking up the five thousand pound telephone does for us. You're in NA. You become a member when you say you are. Our disease is capable of the most despicable maneuvers to trick us into using again!

NOVEMBER

November 1

“It is easy to slip back into our old ways. We have to learn to maintain our new lives on a spiritually sound basis to insure our continued growth and recover. God will not force his goodness on us, but we will receive it if we ask.”

Memphis Review Form - page 58, 28

Many important spiritual principles are presented in quiet and a carefully worded manner. There is a selfishness hidden when a mortal tries to tell G-O-D what to do. While those early in their understanding of our higher power's love for us may not quite agree, the reality is if we could tell our higher power what to do, we might, in effect, be talking down to God.

NA member's! Do not sell yourself short in this manner! Get a higher power, not a equal or lesser power! If you want a higher power to help your paddle your canoe in this life, get a big higher power, one with great bulging muscles that can really do the job! Many of us did not understand this in the beginning of our recovery. We thought any help would do some good. We later discovered we could do better if we chose a belief system that covered more ground than we could see the need for when we were still in the grip of active addiction. It may have even seemed egotistical to get a really larger higher power! We may want to review choices on this important point!

Asking for God's goodness is a quiet, clear-headed way to live our new life. Building on sand will get old after a while. Ask for strength and guidance because the help available may go far beyond our personal power of vision. It might be like asking our higher power to clean part of the floor in our room or prepare part of our meal. They may be others at our table who need to eat with us. A partially swept floor is still half dirty!

November 2

“Anonymity is everywhere in our Traditions and in our Fellowship. It is one of the basics of recovery. The principle of anonymity protects us from our defects of personality and character. Where anonymity exists, personalities and differences have no power. Anonymity in action makes it impossible for personalities to come before principals.”

Memphis Review Form - page 117, 26

Anonymity is a principle that will continue to grow in our personal program so long as we are working our Steps. One way to get a glimpse of anonymity is to understand that reality is like a great river we live in all our lives. When we are going with the current, we understand it is the power of the river that carries us forward, not the strength of our arms or the kick of our legs. The current has all the power. Our higher power may be thought of as the current from which we come and with which we go forward.

The power of the group is greater than our personal power. We can access part of this power when we listen to everyone who has a stake in the health and well-being of the group. When we leave people - their viewpoints and perceptions - out of our reckoning, we weaken the potential power of the group.

Think of voting that the sky is chartreuse. Vote how you want to, the sky remains blue. If we win the vote, we can delude ourselves and those who follow our lead, but the sky is still blue. Our personal power is limited. Our games of manipulation and control are empty. Our loving, caring members may declare, “Well, Billy Bob, the sky is really a nice shade of chartreuse today,” out of acceptance and understanding of your personal need to feel secure and powerful, but it is still just a courtesy. It is understood if your desire for recovery is sincere, without wax, you will grow to notice the nice color of the sky is not exactly red or yellow, more like a color you could not see before.

November 3

“If the defects we have discovered are real and we have a chance to be rid of them, we would surely experience a sense of well being when we rid ourselves of them.”

Memphis Review Form - page 49, 2

Recovery is not something imposed on us from the outside. That is probably one of the reasons N A works for us. It is an inside job. It is our desire for recovery that propels us and our desire to know ourselves better and discover what our real self is like.

Having habitually done things a certain way makes them familiar and somewhat 'normal' - at least to us. The more we get in touch with what 'defective' actually means, the more embarrassment sets in and more happy we are not to have to live that way anymore. This is what happens when we raise our consciousness.

'Facts' are little breaks in reality due to an inability to see the context clearly. 'De' is a latin prefix so the whole word, "defect." It means incomplete and partial. Not really workable and not enough to bear the load demanded by reality. Perhaps we got it wrong when we were growing up. Or perhaps some painful experience taught us to avoid emotional vulnerability even if it cost us the ability to fall in love.

November 4

“For us, to use is to die. We have seen addicts come to our Fellowship, try our program, say clean for a period of time, only to drift gradually away.”

Memphis Review Form - page 119, 1

It is hard to see why a person would work their Steps unless it was a matter of life and death for them. I know people, and whole populations, are subject to changes we can't really see unless we stop our busy minds and think about it. The Anti-War Movement certainly fired the flames of addiction. The residue in the 1970's resulted in many men and women realizing they had some serious problems and needed help. NA was fertile ground for recovery.

Our population, and individuals, today have developed a strange aversion to reading more than a few pages at a time. It is probably an outgrowth from computers and the silver screens. There are still college students and job demands that push these limits. Many folks just breeze through life trying to give the right answer and move on with what they're doing. Not entirely shallow but you don't hear terms of praise like, "He's a really deep thinker." or "She is so thoughtful!"

Addicts seeking recovery have special motivations for reading and study. Once they learn the disease concept, they begin to realize they are seeking a state of existence not otherwise available to addicts in general and drug addicts in particular. Recovery is an abnormal state for us and it requires some study and learning if we are to have any hope at all. Reading, study and discussion offset the powerful force of addiction.

November 5

“No longer comfortable with our using friends, we were not yet at home in meetings. Basically, we lost our fear through the experience of sharing. We share our fears with other addicts.”

Memphis Review Form - page 119, 14

NA has a wide landing strip right at our front door. It is labeled, “Keep coming back!” We come to the program from a mission to self-destruct. We are equipped to do ourselves in by a variety of ways. We have to learn the meaning of big new words like Patience, Tolerance and Humility. Our vocabulary of spiritual words and states of existence is in need of repair. You can’t talk about things without words for what you mean or need to know.

A two word term for something important we all need to study and practice is “SLOW DOWN.” It means we have to take more time with our living and learning. Recovery is not a road race. It involves reflection, sincerity and going deeper into who we are and what we want. The new people we meet in the rooms reflect our feelings and life problems. Listening to them and sharing with other people seeking recovery, we are often pleasantly surprised to notice they really listen, care, identify and seem to understand what we are going through. Sometimes, when they share what works for them, we go home and try out what worked for them. A new approach to things often results in personal breakthroughs to a world of happiness and joy. It is not defective to get your hopes up anymore. In fact, it is a lot like stretching your muscles to dream and envision happier times.

Many of the delusions created in active addiction pop into focus when we realize they make no sense when we are clean! Happy people make things happen! Former boundaries were real for us in the past but in the now, they just don’t apply!

November 6

“For us to use is to die. We have seen addicts come to our fellowship, try our program, stay clean for a period of time only to drift away.”

Memphis Review Form - page 119, 1

It is important to remember that the disease will undercut and derail our efforts to get with the N A program. Saying, “I’m clean but I haven’t changed.” is a really sad statement because it is up to each individual member to surrender, admit unmanageability and begin to learn what has worked for others. We go looking for a Higher Power and find ways to go on from there. Strong egos can stop the recovery process before it has a chance. Surrender is the cure for egotism!

We attend funerals of fellow members and this brings home the importance of working a strong program and carrying a clear message of recovery. Anyone who has been in the program a while has seen a person nurse a futile resentment until it drives them out of the rooms. What has changed besides our not using? Are we collecting resentments or forgiveness where others seem to conflict with us? Or are we seeking resolution of past events instead of carrying them forward?

This does not have to happen when we do the things that work for us. We go beyond just staying clean off drugs, we use our sponsor, go to meetings regularly, find a homegroup that we attend and support, where we can feel safe and comfortable. By simple prayer, and discovering that we are experiencing true miracles, in our lives, we are becoming more comfortable in our own skin. We see that our obsessions have left us. Now we can believe and see that maybe this thing, called Narcotics Anonymous is working for us.

November 7

“Basically, we lost our fear through the experience of sharing. We share our fears with other addicts. The more we do this, the more our fear slips away.”

Memphis Review Form - page 120, 1

The real scary things are the things we can't talk about. As soon as the air moves over our vocal cords and the sound forms the words, the fear slips away. That's when we know people care and we are being brave enough to stick our necks out and expose heretofore unspoken feelings. While we are sharing and focusing our thoughts, we may also realize the change in our body and heart as the fear is lessened. We can actually feel the pain and tension going away. We can do this without talking in meditation.

Through clean time and many meetings, we hear most of our secrets shared by others through their own personal experience. Fear just dries up. “Joy shared is joy increased. Pain shared is pain lessened.”

As our knowledge and experience taking our own inventory goes forward, we find ourselves applying some of our learnings to other areas of our life. The past becomes largely a 'done deal.' Our future is clearly not here yet. The only thing we have real power over is the present. Tomorrow never quite gets here. By the time it gets here, there is another tomorrow waiting.

November 8

“However we want to handle it, we go all the way. Think of what we have to lose! As soon as we feel ourselves willing, we should go ahead and ask God to remove our shortcomings.”

Memphis Review Form - page 49, 10

We gain momentum as relief replaces reluctance and we realize we are not going to miss those damning defects! Their removal makes for effective habits and routines that allow our real selves to come out and take over. Our ego may want to jump in and wallow in the glory but the grace of God helps us remember when all this recovery stuff felt weird. In the present, we experience the changes as improvements and not hindrances. We are free to go and see and do things that have long been beyond our reach. Surrender works because when we get up off our knees, our feet are finally on solid ground!

It is the insanity of addiction that holds us back. Shame and guilt have a positive effect when we find there is a way out! The combined experience of others strengthens us. Our prayers and faith further strengthens us. Our hope for the future makes us brave.

The beauty of the Seventh Step is not only the relief from character defects, it is the good feeling and ability to envision wants and desires we have not yet fulfilled. Fulfillment means means great joy and becoming the person we always hoped to be someday. Addiction and the things that happened blocked our way and held us back. Now we get to be free.

November 9

“It all begins with our first admission and surrender. From that point, each addict is reminded that a day clean is a day won. At first we can little more than go to meetings. Probably we cannot even remember a single name, word or thought from our first meeting. What we do remember is the feeling we got.”

Memphis Review Form - page 78, 1-5

Keep that feeling alive and it will come to be your best friend. Learning to treasure certain feelings helps us build our new life clean. They fill our minds and memories and replace the sadness and lack of hope..

The idea that by staying clean one more day we are winning a victory is a powerful tool for newcomers. There is also a time that comes later in recovery where we have to dig into our early experience to get a grip on early surrender and recall the necessity to surrender to our need for help.

The feelings from our early meetings can awaken our gratitude and hope. The whole world looks different after you've been clean a few years - or a few decades, one day at a time. Every step forward leads to another. Some of the situations we fall into become great learning experiences. Going through stuff isn't so bad when we realize it's getting better, not worse.

November 10

“Addicts must patiently re-learn things forgotten and learn how to live. This is what Narcotics Anonymous is about.”

Memphis Review Form - page 120, 31

“Everything we did while we were using, we will do again in recovery.” I saw this in my recovery. Working in the same town, going to the same car clubs, meeting a lot of the same people and doing a lot of the same activities.

We learn from our mistakes. We can only learn so much from books and teachers, after that it is the school of hard knocks. We really can only see our mistakes as learning experiences. Otherwise, we would beat ourselves to death.

I learned much from the oldtimers. They had been down the path before me. They could tell me to watch out for that limb, watch out for that snake and watch out for that hole so you don't twist your ankle. It was much less painful to hang around them and bounce my plans off of them. They would give me helpful advice.

Some now would see this as controlling, but I was grateful for it. With my ego safely tucked away, the helps I receive from others sure makes me glad I didn't have to go through pain and trouble to get the benefits!

November 11

"If we are to continue abstinence we must be responsible and productive, not necessarily in terms of normal definitions, but in terms of spiritual principles. We must grow."

Memphis Review Form - page 121, 11

Each one of us is different and we have different requirements. The freedom N A offers allows us to take in and concentrate on the subject we need most. As we grow a divine hand guides us to exactly what we need to be happier and more effective. We cannot always understand what is happening at the time, but clean time gives us a chance to review what happens and the results of our growth.

Every so often I need to take out the meeting schedule and start going to different meetings and checking them out. I can only go to the same meeting and hear the same story so many times without screaming.

A guy was sent to prison for the first time in his life. He looked to his cell mate for direction. At dinner, someone shouted out 17 and everyone laughed. Then another person shouted out 23 and everyone laughed. The new guy ask his cellmate what was going on. The cellmate explained, "We have been in here a very long time and we only knew so many jokes. And after a while, instead of telling each joke in its entirety we decided to give each joke a number."

The new guy asked the cellmate "Can I try it?" The cellmate told him to go ahead and the new guy shouted out 11. A lot of the other prisoners stared at the new guy with serious faces. The new guy turned to the experienced prisoner and asked "What did I do wrong?" The cellmate said "You didn't tell it right".

November 12

"When we accept that we are responsible for our problems, we realize that we can be equally responsible for our solutions."

Memphis Review Form - page 70, 29

True freedom starts when we take full responsibility for our actions, the consequences of our actions, our feelings and our attitudes. We no longer are victims, either of others or of circumstances. We become free to "be here now" finding the solution to our problems without wasting time or effort on how we got here. Having the ability to live in the solution is a result of incorporating spiritual principles in every aspect of our lives.

One of the problems that comes up in ongoing recovery is we get so comfortable that we begin to leave off the daily practices that feed our recovery. Recovery is the result of positive thinking and gratitude painting our daily lives in cheerful or thoughtful colors. If we forget our prayers for health and recovery, our colors fade, become pale and go over to black and white - or grey! When we make a decision for the best, we change right then into a mindset that allows us to look for the positive and experience anew the joy of living.

Even when problems come up, if we surrender and open ourselves to help and help comes along. Sometimes we don't recognize solutions when they appear. Pain hurts and clouds our thinking. We learn to relax and search for something to be grateful for - then even something small comes and the gratitude puts a little wind in our sails.

November 13

“That no matter what we have done or what course our addiction has taken, we can relax and enjoy the love that fills the room at every meeting which follows the Twelve Traditions.”

Memphis Review Form - page 79, 1

In each one of us is a shrivelled up little pissed off addict. To that shriveled up little addict he is a parasite and the person attending NA is the host. A clear NA message is poison to the shriveled up little addict parasite. Love and hope dilute the poison of negative thinking and then suddenly, the sun comes up. Life is learning to be grateful and plunge into the water of life again. Call up someone who is hurting. Pray for someone sick in the hospital. Pray for a newcomer who really wants to get clean and needs help learning how to use the 12 Steps!

We know addiction is a disease and it doesn't play fair. The clear message delivered in meetings is so painful that it hurts to try to optimize. The shrivelled up little addict uses crosstalk to stop the meeting and break up the message. The little addict steals energy from someone sharing honestly by interrupting. Their ego prevents them understanding their rudeness and discourtesy.

Because many are forced to attend NA and the shriveled up addict is so threatened that they must cross talk all the time. Hence, our meeting now have much chaos of crosstalk in it.

November 14

“Spirituality as a way of life for an addict seems a total contradiction. Many feel that they have found what they were searching for in drugs through spirituality. By working the Steps we are relieved of our obsession to use and many gratefully serve the Fellowship for this reason. Growth means change and we feel we must live on a spiritual basis in order to change.”

Memphis Review Form - page 121, 26

It should not go without saying our pettiness and ingratitude will resurface as soon as we stop focusing on gratitude and hope. Anyone can find something to complain about no matter how great their lives are going. It is possible that negativity is part of humanity but it doesn't get us anywhere. It just makes us dissolute and ungrateful.

Addiction denies the power of spirituality. It pretends physical comfort and an agile mind can supply all our needs! This is a lie. Many times and in many ways people find that they need more than the physical and mental can offer. We always want more and the only way to satisfy our needs is through the power of the Spirit.

Change of mind and mood is available through a life of the spirit. This is most easily available when we sit quietly, close our eyes and meditate. Isn't it surprising that when our eyes are closed, we still see things? The confused images can resolve into words or visions. In meditation we learn to be more fully awake than when we are going about our daily lives. This wakefulness allows us to experience life more fully and many small matters cease to give us trouble.

November 15

“From self-centered, angry, frightened isolated people, we become loving, sharing, self-assured spiritual parts of a greater whole. We changed from hopelessly helpless to hopefully helping.”

Memphis Review Form - page 121, 35

Our daily recovery offsets the gravity of our addictive disease to draw us into the same selfish and benighted condition we were before recovery with a suitable coat of paint to protect us from the notice of our fellow N A members. We want to look good. This is not a badness in us, it is simply our disease and all members admit they have it! Rationalization, justification and projection are tools we use to stay sick and avoid recovery.

Only when our sense of unworthiness is washed out by faith and inventory will we begin to outweigh our hopelessness. Recovery comes by degrees many small acts of seeking and surrender build up to increase our tolerance for good things in our lives.

Who was there every time we messed up in our active addiction? Mr. Ego. What got us into recovery in the first place? The idea we could overcome our former boundaries and live clean and free. We send Mr. Ego on his way and let down our defense mechanisms and calmly walk into the light of recovery. Things still change but they change for the better.

EDITING

November 16

“We don’t want to settle for the limitations of the past. We want to examine and re-examine all our old ideas, and constantly improve on them or replace them with new ones.”

Memphis Review Form - page 18, 6

Being able to change our lives by changing our beliefs and entertain new approaches to old problems is a great discovery.

The courage to change our old ways puts us on the path of recovery. The 12 Steps are the tools we use to navigate that path that leads us to freedom from active addiction. We can feel ourselves coming alive!

The 10th Step can keep on-going spiritual growth a reality. Every time we cancel out an old habit that no longer works or fits our life, our view expands and we can see more defects that can be changed. The more we grow, the more we can see. The more we see, the more we can change. As we grow, we realize we get closer to our Higher Power and eventually His Will becomes Our Will. We do not have to fear anymore.

November 17

“Asking for help in specific terms usually precedes getting that help. By opening the gates of our hearts, we become ready to receive the help we need.”

Memphis Review Form - page 37,6

This applies to prayer as well as people. Loosening the grip of our egocentric nature makes it more reasonable to just ask for help instead of contriving a way to steal or trick someone into getting what we need. Everyone has different needs and faces different problems. Learning to seek help from a Higher Power, we are frequently surprised by how well prayer works! One common thread that keeps coming up in the stories of our members is that at some point they said the words “Please help me”. We have heard this over and over and over thousands of times. The funny thing is a prayer is not selfish - it includes a special component: surrender and faith in a HP!

Getting what we need, sometimes even when we need it, is a good sign we are working our N.A. program. Other times, our HP says, no, wait a bit or offers something better. Even when we don't get our way, it usually works out for us. A prolonged 'best' is better than a brief 'good.'

Obsession can be simply habitual desperation. When our bellies are full and our most pressing needs are met, it gets easier to take our time and attend to the details in our daily life. Recovery is learning to use spirituality even when things are going well for us.

November 18

“We must puncture our egos and realize that we have much more work to do. When someone points out a shortcoming, our first reaction is one of defensiveness.”

Memphis Review Form - page 49, 22

We learn to realize that someone cares enough about us to show us our character defects. Then we learn to find the willingness to take a look at them. It is only with awareness, acceptance and action that we have any hope of changing.

We learn to pause instead of instantly react. We think about our responses and what is the right thing to do in accordance with our growing understanding of spiritual principles. Only then do we take action. It is this momentary pause before action that helps redirect efforts in a direction that is not only good for ourselves but often for those we love and care about.

We gotta get in the habit of keeping our mouth shut. Its critical, really. We simply cannot go off on people all the time. We just create messes that we have to clean up. It is said that whoever is the first to raise their voice, loses the argument.

We always tend to error on the side of shooting off our mouths. So we have to train to error on the side of not speaking up. It seldom does any good to sound off anyway, so why even go there.

November 19

“When a resentment or any other emotional relapse occurs, failure to practice the Steps and result in physical relapse. Many of our newcomers have difficulty coming into the Fellowship because they do not understand we have a disease called “addiction.” We are doomed (spelling corrected) to see our past behavior as part of ourselves and not part of our disease.”

Memphis Review Form - page 125, 22

After we have experienced a loss or serious difficulty in recovery we then learn to take a hit. Some people believe that changes for success in the program depend on one's ability to take a hit. We are talking repossessed cars, IRS problems, angry creditors attaching wages and dire medical diagnosis. One member had his house burn to the ground and did not miss a beat. This is working the program.

I pray for them for a few weeks in the shower to have classic cars and fantastic sex. It works every time. It may be that when we are emotionally charged, the energy can strengthen a wordless prayer that manifests in our own lives.

Our recovery is an ongoing study of our disease concept. Addiction substitutes a mind or mood altering drug for real change or improvement. Changing our reality works better and through recovery, we have the internal resources to do the job.

November 20

“We remain honest to free ourselves from guilt. As we begin to function in society, our creative freedom helps us sort out priorities and do the most basic things first. Daily practice of the Twelve Step program enables us to change from what we were to what our Higher Power would have us become.”

Memphis Review Form - page 122, 6

We learn that addiction is a disease of confusion and when loaded we couldn't really help ourselves. Clean, we practice personality changes with the help of many others and learn to make better choices and substitute inspiration for desperation.

Functioning in society, we become active parts of a greater whole. When others hurt, we feel their pain and discomfort. When they get help for their needs, we experience a matching sense of relief. Becoming a part of humanity, we regain our sense of purpose and experiencing community with other people. We realize this is what was missing in our former lives. No wonder we were so lost and confused!

Doing first things first, we have less to bother us or worry about. It may take some time to accustom ourselves to our new situation. The 12 Steps give us powerful tools to resolve old issues and delete unwanted defects of character. This gives us extra time and resources to find our own happy destiny.

November 21

“Having begun attending meetings regularly, we were introduced to the 12 Steps. Working the Steps got us out of our old attitudes.”

Memphis Review Form - page 79, 6

Attitude is another word for beliefs. Poorly formed beliefs, personal habits and unmade amends can really cloud a person’s view of reality. Point is that while it is all really there, most of it can be changed without great cost or expense. Personality change is mostly a change of heart or mind.

Just hearing “How It Works” in meetings seems overwhelming. This may be because we have not had a clear enough mind to ask questions. After a few meetings and our minds begin to clear, we may speak up in a meeting for the first time. This is a good time to ask questions in meetings and begin seeking a sponsor. Asking someone to sponsor us can also seem insurmountable yet once you ask, you realize it’s no big deal. Just another doorway we open to self-improvement.

Because of fear and a lack of understanding, we go to more meetings to find if we really desire this lifestyle. After all, addicts with a strong desire for recovery built the Program and wrote our literature. Their gratitude and love shine forth unmistakably.

November 22

“We cry easily and find it safe to cry and express love and share all our emotions in the atmosphere of recovery found at N.A. meetings. The steps become our framework of daily change. Continuous abstinence requires spiritual growth which leads to emotional recovery in our lives.”

Memphis Review Form - page 122, 14

Getting in touch with our feelings, we begin to come together as human beings. Our perceptions and responses change from defensive and fearful over to empathetic and caring. We tend to look for ways to help.

Our brain deals with information, our hearts deal with how we feel. Both are necessary and important for healthy human beings. In modern times, it has become more common knowledge that antidepressants dull our senses and result in deadening our sense of personal responsibility. Spiritual growth rebuilds our internal resources to the point of a spiritual awakening expressed in caring and sharing.

The commonality we share with all other people gives us a general awareness of others and suggest ways we can help. Acting on the positive, restorative impulses strengthens us and gives us confidence in applying spiritual principles and carrying our message.

Over time, we adjust our habits and beliefs to reflect the principles that have proven to work for us when nothing else could! The feeling that no matter what happens we are somehow at fault goes away to be replaced by automatic concern. We identify emotionally and don't deny our emotions.

November 23

“Though the freedom in our new lives , we are finally able to see the special qualities that we possess as individuals--qualities that we used to envy in others--never realizing the potential within ourselves.”

Memphis Review Form - page 161, 2

Our defects kept us from seeing our own good qualities. Freed from our defects, we can finally find what we were looking for all the time. "Don't judge your insides by another person's outsides" is a cliché we have often heard. Our low self-image was no longer valid, when we began to see ourselves as we really are.

Accepting ourselves as we are, just for today, with the understanding that there will always be room for improvement. We gain new insight each time we revisit the Steps. Watching other members grow, encourages us to make our own improvements.

Where once we suffered from low self-esteem to the degree that many of us shunned even the image of ourselves in the mirror, we now face life on life's terms with a sense of dignity and purpose.

November 24

"It has been our experience that personal problems will be resolved when we are willing to accept responsibility for them."

Memphis Review Form - page 84, 32

Personality change used to be rare among addicts. Once an addict, always an addict used to be the way it was. Now, through the 12 Steps of N A, we have a new way to deal with our disease of addiction. We can follow a certain order and remake our self-will and ego at its roots.

First we surrender to the truth of our addiction. Then we find a belief system that works for us and place ourselves the care of a Higher Power. The rest of the 12 Steps have to do with clearing the wreckage of our past and paving the road to a new life.

Accepting responsibility is what gives us the right to change. We may be powerless over other people, places and things, but we enjoy great power over taking our own inventory and changing ourselves!

November 25

“Each day we stay clean by practicing the Steps in our lives, our chances of relapse decrease. Each of us is only one drug away from a painful active addiction, but living our program through regular honest sharing in the Fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous increases our chances for uninterrupted clean time.”

Memphis Review Form - page 122, 19

Living our Program of NA, we restore our self-image into someone who can admit fault and admit their need for help. This is why we stay clean on days good and bad! At first it may feel funny to be honest, but after a few experiences we begin to adjust to a new attitude. We learn not to fear the truth. We grow even when we are hurting. Everyone of us can recall going through hard times only to look back and thank our HP we didn't use when things weren't going our way.

Spirituality is full of surprises. The more we grow, the more we can look inside and see things that used to be hidden. The power of our Loving God is enormous and we are often amazed at how many ways we are protected and guided past harm and hurting others.

Day by day we practice our new way of life until it becomes our natural way of doing things. The further we get from our last usage, the closer we get to our Higher Power and the relief recovery brings. The more we practice, the better we get. Honesty comes easier and asking for help becomes an impulse.

EDITING

November 26

'Being clean is abnormal to us, and we must learn how to live in an ongoing manner. A great magic is found when we help others. As clean addicts in the Fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous, we help ourselves by helping others.'

Memphis Review Form - page 70,33

Clear headed awareness tells us what we experience and guides us into our responses. Narcotics are a self-imposed sleep disorder. We are not really awake when we are loaded and our perceptions and conclusions are distorted by the drugs we are taking. Clean it may take a while to see, hear and feel more accurately what the heck is going on!

Helping others we can identify with gives us a personal, ongoing education in the problems addicts face and different perspectives on what improvements can help. Since we are getting our information from others, our ego is not so threatened and our willingness is prodded by observing the embarrassing quality of what is clearly not working. Sharing the pain of others gives us insight into our own dilemmas. This insight gives us great power to see our own faults and strength to make changes as we grow.

The change is something we carry in our hearts as well as in our heads. We find our feelings are actually located in our hearts and our feelings become more accurate and trustworthy with time. When we reach out and put ourselves in the shoes of someone else, we are blessed with insight and ability to change rather than feelings of condemnation or fear.

November 27

“Much of the loneliness and fear will have been replaced by the love of the Fellowship and the security of being a part of a new way of life.”

Memphis Review Form - page 144, 2

The loneliness inside becomes peopled by those we come to know well. We have internal resources to see into problems and make connections we could not see, feel or hear before the changes worked by the 12 Steps. As we work our Steps in recovery, the Steps work on us! It is hard to be afraid of things once we gain insight and understanding.

Love coming from other members prevents us from feeling isolated and trapped. If we were in jail with a few hundreds of our new friends, it would be a whole different experience! People who take our side in things or help us clarify misunderstanding wipe away pain and confusion. It is a far cry from facing life alone.

Secure in the family of new friends and associates opens doors that used to look like brick walls. God and the NA way gives us more than one answer when we are in trouble. We can actually ask our HP to handle things that we are powerless over.

November 28

"The enemy we have to fight is our own self-destructiveness. When we begin to work our program, we will like ourselves better."

Memphis Review Form - page 144, 34

The changes we make prepare the way for us to live happy and effective lives. We are not self-destructive by accident, we simply cannot see any way out of the messes we make of our lives. Then we surrender and the closed doors swing open and we can see alternatives where there used to be none.

Self-destructiveness can actually guide us forward in ways that used to have no options. When we change inside, our outside changes because our new attitudes and behaviors make it possible. Self approval gets us past the blockages and admitting fault or apologizing is no big deal.

For one thing, when those we are interacting with see we are more relaxed and able to take personal responsibility, they will often lighten up. They may even offer suggestions that may work out well for both of us. Our negative position may be one of the causes of our difficulty. They can't dance with a partner who seems to be deliberately stepping on their toes!

When we like ourselves better, the world around us seems to like us better as well!

November 29

“Complacency is the enemy of members with substantial clean time. We never fully recover. Guilt, remorse, fear, lust and pride may all become unbearable if we fail to invest ourselves totally in the program, no matter how much clean time we have.”

Memphis Review Form - page 122, 29

Write it on the wall! The idea that our good time drug use was fun will be like the call of the wild and at some point we will confuse ourselves enough to the point using seems like an option. We may actually think just one or two won't be a problem. This is amazing considering all we've been through. All we have to do is just remember what the last one did for us and after a few moments a miracle happens and we are restored to sanity!

Complacency is a sort of mind-trick that goes against our own most painful experience. It allows us to set aside painful memories of confusion and hopeless despair. Addiction is a tricky disease. It will sneak right up beside us and stick a knife in us before we know it! It will drain our gratitude and punch holes in our brand new tires!

Remember feeling guilty over taking advantage of a friend's trust? Remember a car accident that resulted in someone's injury or death? Remember tensing up when the phone rang or someone was at your door? Remember getting turned on by the attentions of another where you knew a price would be paid by you for your betrayal? How did it feel to take credit for someone else's work. Hmm.

The time and energy we put into helping others fills us with joy and good feelings. We never have to use again against our will. We do have to practice focusing on our gratitude and do the things we do to work our program. Whether we know it or not, we have a lot to be grateful for in our new lives.

November 30

"We had to reach out and to accept the love and understanding that the Fellowship had to offer."

Memphis Review Form - page 84, 10

Going to meetings, asking hard questions, making new friends - these are things that will give you a new life. Our disease will minimize the attention and friendliness because we may not realize members are being polite and considerate. We learn to avoid overwhelming newer members with attention that may be interpreted as 'social pressure.'

Reaching out can be scary when we are accustomed to being alone and when we have trouble making 'small talk.' So, giving new folks their space and letting them show they are ready before asking questions. We learn not to bring up subjects that may make someone feel uncomfortable. Many new members are caught up in trying to decide if they should take NA seriously!. Who knows what they may have heard or experienced on their way to the rooms of recovery!

Coming to the Program of NA may be the biggest decision a person has made in their lives. Respect and forbearance may be received as kind and considerate, as is intended. When someone is ready, they will let you know. Remember how it was for you in the beginning.

DECEMBER

December 1

"We want desperately for the place where addicts recover to be a safe, free from outside influences. We feel safe at our closed meetings. Everyone's an addict. We feel totally free to express ourselves because no law enforcement agencies are involved. "

Memphis Review Form - page 20, 19

Many of our members desire personnel anonymity, especially when we are new to the program, though within a short time most come to cherish the therapeutic value of one addict helping another that is found in the process of identification, and that process is often fostered only in the safety of a circle of clean addicts living a program of recovery.

Anonymity is half our name. The ability to share peer-to-peer gives us a chance to share and express ideas we had been forced to keep to ourselves. Many times we 'self-correct' when we hear ourselves say something that doesn't make sense. Keeping things inside perpetuates some really dumb ideas. Sharing our feelings and ideas with other addicts who are free to call us on our bullshit can give us great insight into where we have gone wrong.

As we have grown rapidly, we have also suffered intrusion where new members have adopted some really strange ideas. One idea is that the newcomer is the most important person at any meeting. They omit or never learned the second half of the sentence, "because we can only keep what we have by giving it away." While this can be humorous, it can also be a serious problem. If enough 'important members' repeat it they apparently come to believe they are hot stuff. The reality is they know little or nothing of recovery when they are totally new!

Rapid growth can punch a few holes in a well formed and effective program. There are places where the newer members practically run things and openly attack members with clean time. It is up to you to stand up to these poor souls and try to carry a genuine message of recovery. We pass on what works in NA!

December 2

"This Step must cut into our character defects and expose our motives and our actions for what they really were. We have no right to expect these things to reveal themselves."

Memphis Review Form - page 45, 11

The saying, "How come everything I let go of has claw marks all over it?" lampoons the way we tend to cling to our established habit patterns. Since Step Five continues the inventory process begun in Step Four, it helps us sort out our assets and liabilities. To make this clear, liabilities are things that cost us plenty without delivering anything worth keeping. Inventory is what leads to our personal spiritual awakening and general betterment.

Active addiction clouded our minds and threw our thinking off track. We were unaware of just how cookoo we had become! It often appeared as if people were over-reacting to our regular habits and mannerisms. We were just kidding or cutting up! Recovery gives us new resources we carry with us inside.. We can hear and see more accurately. When people ask us what's wrong, they are really being pretty nice. Some of our behavior is awful and we don't even pick up on it!

Working with others makes us more sensitive to bad manners and prods us to check-out our own behavior. We catch ourselves and have great power to correct our errors thought it may feel strange to do so.. As we get better, we lose track of our improvement and don't realize that in some cases people mistake our kindness for weakness. And recovery doesn't allow us to react in kind to bad behavior in others. But part of getting better is gaining internal resources and social skills that can stand firm against the pressure put on us by addicts who may be seeking recovery but still operating in the same old ways.

December 3

"N.A. reawakened old memories of what it felt like to be a member of the human family. Slowly, we opened up, reached out, warmed up, and let ourselves love and be loved. The original desire to be clean leads us to a desire to help others."

Memphis Review Form - page 85, 19

Each time we helped others was like a stitch weaving us back into the human race. For those members with long clean time, it is important to remember how NA became their family when they first came into NA. Being one among many people submitting to a process that allows us to change our lives gives us a good feeling. It was like a true loving family and very nurturing. One difference in the Program is we are not punished when we screw up. Other people notice but their reactions are different. In many cases they understood and were supportive. We need to reflect back on those days which were so tender to us. These memories of yesteryear can save our bacon and give us vitality since they were based on our own experiences. These were the golden days of NA. We were so fortunate to have been there and to have been a part of it. We are truly blessed.

As those with long clean time become more numerous, it affects the whole Fellowship. We can read, study and become ever more informed about our NA history and what works for addicts. It is also important to note that simple NA became more effective as we learned more and more. Some got lost in the crowd. The maxim that NA works doesn't include those who stop working their 12 Steps! Stop pedaling and the bicycle falls over. Recovery can be arrested and forward progress reversed if we let ourselves slip onto our old ways, even if we are still otherwise clean!

The reason we stress helping others so much is that each member is a mirror image of ourselves to some degree. Helping others we see up close how things can go wrong and self-correct to avoid the problems we see others create for themselves unwittingly.

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December 4

"Many times, our efforts have produced in us feelings of peace and serenity that we have never known before."

Memphis Review Form - page 58. 34

I was in a one year meeting tonight (these are meetings where only people in their first year are allowed to share). Someone read the sentence from our literature, "The newcomer is the most important person in the room because we can only keep what we have by giving it away." Imagine what happens if you don't read the whole sentence!

I felt very calm and at ease. I had no major problems in my life and no deadlines to meet. All was well. Had I been able to share, I would have told the newcomers that someday, they would be at ease and calm too with no impending problems. Peace and serenity come to those who surrender and work the 12 Steps. The Traditions work with the Steps to provide a healthy atmosphere to encourage spiritual growth.

Spiritual growth is affected when we surrender and find a higher power. Turning our life and will over to the care of this higher power grants immediate results: peace of mind, freedom from fear and curiosity about new good things coming our way. Being addicts, many of us begin to loaf and act like recovery is an effortless process. Many fall into a popular trap wherein the members will say, "See, NA isn't working out so good for me!" We are quick to forget the hopelessness and despair that had us on the ground when we first sought recovery in NA!

The good part is all we have to do is renew our surrender and go back to working our program on a daily basis. Every day is a new beginning. Remember the basic principles like patience, tolerance and humility. Getting back in the habit of thinking and speaking with your higher power get the ball rolling again.

December 5

"In our addiction we consistently placed our personal welfare before anything else. Here we found that in the long run what's best for the group was usually good for us. We chose to conform to the common good because that's what worked for us."

Memphis Review Form - page 91, 8

We learned to put group purpose ahead of personal preference. Where there were conflicts, it was understood that we are free to re-consider our stand on issues. No one can make us do much of anything. We'll leave the group if we are not happy there. We can even reconsider and come back later if we like. But for purposes of recovery, we all have to pull together if we are going to enjoy the miracle of recovery.

One addict told me, "I may leave a group in a huff but I have learned never to tell them that I will not be back. I cannot afford to burn any bridges, meeting wise. I may have an urge to use and need to run into that meeting and I always want it to be there for me." I considered this very wise advice.

Fortunately, NA Is a giving and forgiving program of recovery. We all make stupid mistakes and self-correction gives immediate relief. Consequences can be dealt with because surrender changes our attitude. Other members may understand and help. Group members are quick to forgive the same mistakes they make on a day to day basis. Life allows us to keep correcting our mistakes and staying on the right track.

December 6

“Any addict clean, without the compulsion to use, is a miracle. We keep this miracle alive in ongoing recovery with positive attitudes and awareness involving personal growth.”

Memphis Review Form - page 144.14

When we first came in, most of us could only relate to the person with a week or two clean. The idea of having years clean was something we simply could not comprehend. This shows just what a miracle a day clean can be to an addict.

As the weeks, months, years and decades pile up and we acquire toys and life's problems fall away, it is easy for the miracle to seem like a given. Not like the ultimate gift. Lack of gratitude seeps in as we seem to be doing so well, the maintenance Steps may seem less important. Perhaps it is a mistake to look at Steps Ten, Eleven and Twelve as maintenance Steps! Perhaps they are like the other nine Steps - paths to the future growth that is just as important as the other Steps forward.

Recovery is the gift of life, freedom and joy. It is the gift of unlimited dreams come true. It really cannot be compared to any other gift in the world. It is the cure for a fatal disease, the key to unlock any door and mental serenity on a level not experienced by most people in their entire life. This is why we sometimes hear someone say that they are grateful addicts. Just because we passed our early learning periods, might we not have Steps ahead that can only be taken once our waters have cooled and we are more able to see and hear more clearly. The early grades of learning make us able to take on new journeys we could not undertake before. Look for new doorways that pique our curiosities. Ways that fill in the many blanks still missing due to our addictive personalities.

December 7

“As our lives become more comfortable , many of us lapse into spiritual complacency, and we find ourselves in the same horror and loss of purpose from which we came.”

Memphis Review Form - page 144, 22

Some of us longtimers become fixated on the rules that got us clean, complete abstinence, non-affiliation, etc. We must remember that NA is a living breathing entity. Sure, group conscious was cool back in the day, but these days time is scarce and we need to figure out ways to do stuff faster and quicker. Sometimes procedures must change. Mostly, all we are required to do is study how our procedures worked when they were first adopted and make sure the changes don't eliminate other working parts of our program.

We cannot hang onto the past and wallow in it. Those were very different times. Today we have pressures on us to adopt new and improved methods of getting clean, even if they are not a part of the NA Program. It is nuts to take drugs to correct addiction. Gasoline is not a cure for fire. Outside enterprises had invested incredible sums of money and effort to produce drug replacement therapy that promise relief from withdrawal symptoms and used to have packaging that contained warnings against taking the withdrawal drug beyond a few months. Other meds which neatly point to 'harm reduction' as more pertinent than 'total abstinence.'

Newcomers can easily be fed information that doesn't accord with NA Steps and principles of recovery while in treatment or under threat of incarceration. .Clean means you are not taking mood or mind altering drugs. While there are many good members who have to take medication to deal with special problems, never should they try to change NA members away from total abstinence. NA is a program of recovery from addiction. Patience and tolerance in the case of members who have to take something to stabilize is not a weakness. We don't use, no matter what. We have never promised to have all the answers for all the people!. Those who follow our path have accumulated decades of recovery, one day at a time.

December 8

"The Twelve Traditions of N.A. are not suggested, and they are not negotiable. There are the rules that keep our fellowship alive and free."

Memphis Review Form - page 89, 22

Not all share these views. But those that stay clean for the long haul tend to be very rigid on honoring the Traditions. We are here for the duration. We need to be rigid on certain important items if we are going to remain a program of recovery from drug addiction. Changing our Program to satisfy a minority of our membership miss-represents the larger body of our Fellowship. Accepting outside authorities who often get their information from those who have a conflict of interest and no personal experience with the subject puts our lives at risk.

There are some people with mental illness who get help from working the NA 12 Steps when nothing else works for them. Surely we who have so much to be grateful for would not deny these kind and worthy people. Life can be tough and choose to be grateful and honorable while maintaining our spiritual beliefs and the bedrock of abstinence. Those who would argue for basic change apparently do not realize they have no right to change what works for so many.

It may come as a shock to some looking for dominance among our membership that egotism may be the source or trying to change our Program. NA is a place where we can come in out of the storm of active addiction and begin to recovery process in the safety of people who have learned to live clean and deal with issues that used to trip them up.

December 9

“When we came to our first meeting it was though a big weight was lifted from our shoulders, guilt feelings rolled off, and a feeling of peace came over us, as we realized that with our surrender to our higher power, would come the help we so desperately needed.”

Memphis Review Form - page 143.3

We kept trying to do it on our own. It never worked. After our most strenuous intentions, we would ourselves using again. So, we came to this new fangled thing called Narcotics Anonymous. For most of us, our first meeting is vividly remembered just as we remember where we were when we heard that Kennedy had been shot. There was a genuine thrill of recovery!

One member recalls, “I was in room with two couples and a pink bathroom door. It was in a church and they said that I never had to use again no matter what.” This was exactly what I wanted to hear. It was music to my ears and I lapped it up. It was a turning point in my life and I somehow knew it at the time. In the time when I might have picked up I recall that moment and it remains a turning point for me.

It takes what it takes. Giving ourselves the privilege of thinking, we can sit and quietly recall the sense of adventure and joy of relief of our moment of decision to stay clean and live the Steps of NA recovery. There will probably always be moments of confusion when our recovery hangs by a thread. That’s only natural for an addict. We stay clean because if we can remember what our last one did for us and to us, it will remain our last one. Call a member, go to a meeting, read come literature - Don’t Pick Up!

December 10

“We also felt the great feeling of warmth and love that came from the group.”

Memphis Review Form - page 143, 9

When I came into the Fellowship of NA, the group meeting was very tight. We always went out for coffee after the meeting. We talked about our lives, our sponsors those we were interested in helping and those we depended on to help us. For many of us it was the intimate family that I never had growing up. Mom's and Pop's, aunts and uncles, even your people we felt protective of replaced the days, months and years of pain and confusion of active addiction.

We were all incredibly grateful, each one of us. The daily drag was replaced by the daily delight! Real recovery is fun and interesting. Those who hold onto grudges of get lost in clouds of confusion just need to settle down to the clean life and work their Steps. Surrender sets us free, new believe in a HP feed a growing hope that recover is real and will last, one day at a time. Turning our life and will over to our HP is very different from letting our connection provide a temporary high.

I cannot express how wonderful it was. It is hard to put into words how good it feels to not have to bother with all the confusion and discomfort that used to rule my days and nights.

December 11

"It is only through understanding and application that they have power."

Memphis Review Form - page 90, 6

We have all heard this line read at each N A meeting we attend. You can become a member when you say you are. You become a member in good standing when you stop using, go to meetings and work the N A 12 Steps. Members in good standing also become familiar with our N A 12 Traditions. Pulling together, learning about our group purpose and dealing with powerful personalities are extremely important as a floor plan for recovery to take place. All the Traditions interlock. You can consider a Tradition violation and with a little thought and study you can see where it affects the other eleven Traditions as well. The spirit of the Traditions brings us together with plenty of individual freedom along with the loving support of the group to pull on for what we need.

The traditions provide a platform for carrying a clear message. Without this clear platform, it is impossible to carry the clear message. Carrying a clear message depends on mundane things like having the room unlocked early and not shooing people out after the meeting when they need to talk. It means having the A/C or heat turned on in time to make it comfortable inside. We need to have literature, order and no crosstalk.

The time in the meeting is a window for addicts to learn they can do it and how. Every moment is precious. For some addicts, this one meeting will be all the NA they ever hear. For others, what they hear will determine if they ever come back to NA again or go back to using.

The importance of leading a meeting right may be the most important service position in NA. We are talking life and death here. Death chased us into our first meeting. Many of our friends had died in the past. We knew we could be next. Many of us only came to NA when someone near and dear passed away.

December 12

"We cannot make these changes alone. We need our Higher Power's help, and the help of the Narcotics Anonymous Fellowship. "

Memphis Review Form - page 46, 8

One of the greatest blessings in the N A 12 Steps is realizing our HP is always with us and always on our side! This is where "Never Alone" comes from. Some of us constantly pray, "God I need your help. I don't have to power. Please help me." This not a empty idea. It really works when you work it! Pray to have a great day - today.

N A also means "Need Answers" which our Higher Power is willing to give us if we learn to listen to the still small quiet voice inside. We can also get answers by asking more experienced members to share their experience, strength and hope with us. The importance of a wide support network comes into bearing here. By building relationships with many members, we build a repository of strength and experience to draw upon in troubling times.

NA can become like a huge library of what to do when the going gets rough. Simple surrender eliminates some of life's thorniest problems for addicts. Gaining a workable belief we take to heart and allow to help us every single day delivers a whole new outlook that make possible all the changes we need to live the clean life, free of flaws and defects what used to be our standard daily diet. This may sound impossibly good but it is the honest truth. Most humans have some sort of a belief, they just don't take it seriously enough to get real results. Maybe we should say the results we would like to enjoy!

December 13

“Our attention focuses on the solutions, and our old ideas break up and dissolve like icebergs in the tropics. When the compulsion to use is lifted from us, and we begin to think of others before ourselves, a true miracle begins. Working the steps, practicing the principles and using the tools, we begin to see ourselves in a new light.”

Memphis Review Form - page 71, 1

One reason I love going to NA is to see people being reborn. They learn how to read, become humble, get jobs, go back to school and learn to cope. The growth can be at light speed. I have never seen else anything like it. Honesty becomes a way to avoid trouble instead of a hazard to avoid being put in jail. Open-mindedness is a way to access information that used to hide behind a doorway marked ‘Closed.’ The amazing behind our willingness to try is that many times when we are simply willing, we don’t have to do whatever it is.

Many addicts have commented that as soon as they surrendered and came to believe miracles began to happen. Our defects fell away as we progressed through Steps Four, Five, Six and Seven. We still had to deal our pasts by making amends. Once we worked those Steps, we continued with inventory, prayer and meditation. A spiritual awakening brought everything together and became spiritual leaders on the many levels that make each member special and important.

Helping others as no one else can, we constantly find ways to improve our lives through being there for others. To be effective, our grasp of spiritual principles have to stand the test of watching others progress in recovery. What we have been through become active working principles that provide a sense of safety and positive expectation to those who come to us. We know all the time it is the power of a loving God working through us and not some cheesy egotism drawing us back into self-will. We truly turn our lives and will over to the power of a Loving God.

December 14

“One of the most important parts of our new way of life is being a part of a group of addicts also seeking recovery.”

Memphis Review Form - page 90, 9

When I came in NA was truly a tribe. It was the high school clique, the college frat, the army band of brothers except closer. We lived together, traveled together, ate together and recovered together. It was the most wonderful experience I have ever known.

One member shares, “It is so wonderful that I miss it even now, thirty-four years later. I love to sit and reflect on it. It makes me happy to this day. It was true bliss. We were broke but happy. In time even our worldly needs are met.” This feeling of togetherness generally comes as a result of following standard program recommendations like, “Keep coming back!” “Never Alone” and “Caring and Sharing the NA Way.”

Isolation and despair characterized our lives because our personal resources were exhausted in active addiction as a necessary step towards our surrender to our need for help. The parts our personalities that had either been chewed up by our disease or omitted by coming from a dysfunctional family are supplied by the literal change of estate by our membership in NA.

December 15

“A great many addicts have a hard time with acceptance in recovery. For so long we wanted and demanded that things go our way .When we came into the program of Narcotics Anonymous we were asked to be more patient and accepting. This is a critical part of our recovery.”

Memphis Review Form - page 144..3

Some would argue that acceptance is the key to recovery. You can't have things not go your way and let that cause you to use. Our disease is characterized by resistance to change and reliance on beliefs that never worked for us before! Surrender lets the light shine in through our personal doorway.

Life happens and some of the time it's not what we want. It can be unfair and painful. It can be very frustrating and annoying. It comes in various forms but they all grate on us. Learning the skill of letting them go and just taking a hit or injury is an acquired skill. Recovery doesn't come all at once although some instances of improvement come as a wonderful surprise. Remember, our surrender and openness to help changes everything. Building an attitude of gratitude cements these good changes into functional parts of our lives.

Someday, it's going to happen to the best of us. We use the tools of NA to cope and get thru these vexations. Once we have been thru one or more changes for the better, it gets easier to go thru the next and so on to the next.

We can do this. People file bankruptcy, get diagnosed as terminal and get fired. It's all part of the game. We find that often the circumstances and situations we hold on to are actually impediments to our personal progress. We have to let go and let God help us move forward. Many times if we had gotten what we thought we wanted, it could have led to big time trouble!

December 16

"Asking for help in specific terms usually precedes getting that help. By opening the gates of our hearts, we become ready to receive the help we need."

Memphis Review Form - page 37, 6

This applies to prayer as well as people. Loosening the grip of our egocentric nature makes it more reasonable to just ask for help instead of contriving a way to steal or trick someone into getting what we need. Recovery is about conditioning yourself into really getting ahead. You deserve to get what you want. Your disease has fooled you into feeling unworthy. All you have to do is do some unworthy things and that's how you'll feel. To feel worthy, you have to do some worthy things! Then you will be worthy, not just feel it.

Everyone has different needs and faces different problems. Getting what we need, sometimes even when we realize we need it, is a good sign we are working our N.A. program. Other times, our HP says, no, wait a bit and creates something better and brings that into reality. Remember, you are dealing with the supreme creator of the universe!. Even when we don't get our way, it usually works what's best for us.

Obsession can be simply habitual desperation. When our bellies are full and our most pressing needs are met, it gets easier to take our time and attend to the details in our daily life. After all, this is what real life is all about! Simple things, done on time, pave the way for our general happiness. Compulsion is sometimes the need to do something to move forward when nothing seems to be working. Most, if not all, of us can remember a time in early recovery when we slowed our lives down in recovery, and we were surprised things went so well.

It is always interesting to watch someone begin recovery by not using and just going to meetings. They find a place to stay, get meals, find a job, or a better job and all goes well. Many get ungrateful and imagine they were just going through changes and tried to use again. Then things can really blow up on them! Don't use, go to meetings, find a higher power are more than just words. And they bring miracles into your life. Miracles you can live with!

December 17

"We put spiritual living first and exercise patience, tolerance and humility in our daily lives. The further we get from the last pill, fix, drink or take, the more we see of our past and more we realize the miracle of the release from our disease of addiction."

Memphis Review Form - page 71, 9

Practicing a life of spiritual practices, whatever our belief is, seems to work incredible changes for the better for addicts seeking recovery. All we know is it works for anyone who surrenders, stays clean and builds a strong desire. Things that did not work for us in the past may surprise you by working just fine, now that you are clean.

We are like the holy men in India who only own a begging bowl. They are called Masts and we would call them beggars. They do not even own clothing. Meher Babba was an Avatar who did not speak for around 30 years. He talks about these Masts and says they sometimes need intensive caring and loving. Being spiritual can take a toll on us.

Learning about spiritual practices that have had good results provide a growing repository of information that illuminates the fascinating ways God has worked for people all over the world regardless of their belief system. The many forms taken by the love of God enrich and ennoble our own personal experiences. The more we learn, the more we know and the more we desire. Desire is the vital element that propels our recovery into the open waters of clean time!.

December 18

“The key to this Step is an understanding of the humility. Humility is a part of staying clean, as food and water are to staying alive.”

Memphis Review Form - page 48, 21

Ego is so pervasive and tricky, we can be really selfish and not even realize. Cultivating humility by praying to have our egos reduced to a level that gets the garbage taken out without demanding the whole world do it our way. Like most addicts when I first started with N A, some of the lingo threw me. Surrender to win? Let go and let God? Routinely expanding our positions and ideas until they become unworkable paints us into many corners. Different information about surrender and driving home the point that it is the losing battles we stop fighting helped me with surrender. Getting some new ideas and changing my belief allowed me to see where a higher power could cover bases I couldn't reach because my human arm wasn't long enough. Well, that actually began to make sense. And it goes further on a daily basis..

I realize now that humility is giving God credit for the things God does and still be set on ready when something comes up I can do. When I meet or have contact with someone I feel is humble, they seems steady and solid. Competent. Yet they lack a certain presumption and arrogance that would indicate they are self-bound and apt to overdo things. Those things would limit my co-existence with them. You have trouble paddling the boat if others are smacking you with their paddles instead of pushing water!

Humility is usually brought up along with patience and tolerance. All defects start out as virtues and go overboard into trying to trying to do things their way without bothering to hear what others are trying to say. Good listeners are the best conversationalists. Toning myself down, listening and thinking through makes a big difference, more in focus. I give myself time to fit our mutual points of agreement before launching into another tirade.

December 19

"We have never before experienced gut-level honesty because we covered up our feelings by using."

Memphis Review Form - page 65, 23

Most often we were unaware of avoiding our true feelings because using distorted our feelings. Adapting to this bizarre mish-mash of feeling became our daily view of the world. Recovery is re-adapting to the world as it is, so there is no need to run and hide the way we used to do. Honesty has always seemed like a losing set-up for us before recovery.

When we look at our past lives, it usually not a pretty picture. One woman in NA told me "You have a right to be very angry having to live life as an addict". That answered a lot of my questions. It was rough out there, especially at the end, when I had had enough.

However we found the NA Program, it always worked well and quickly once we were ready to surrender and began working the Program in earnest. Some members take five or ten years to become ready! Even so, we find we have been strangely guided by a power greater than ourselves and the changes we had to go through were precisely what we needed to make a complete and lasting surrender. Recovery is a real event in our lives and the changes are for the better in most cases. Even if you are going through a difficult period right now, surrender and do what you can. Doing the right thing often feels like we are sticking out necks out!

December 20

"This program can do for us what we could not do for ourselves. We came and saw this program work in the lives of other addicts."

Memphis Review Form - page 90, 17

Some of us were trying to quit on our own with little success. Then we came to NA and met and talked to people who had gotten clean and were staying clean. Then we knew that it could be done. But could we do it. They told us "You never have to use again, ever." To a using addict that is huge. The impossible dream. The solution to our biggest problem.

Could it work? Would it work? Would it work for me? Many of us came back out of curiosity if nothing else! Identification did the rest. Every time we listened, really listened, to a fellow member share, we could hear ourselves talking. And we occasionally noticed the number of days beyond our last usage grew longer. Trouble was, we were so unused to having drugs wash out of our system, we had forgotten what it felt like to be clean!

But they were adamant, "You never have to use again." Again and again we heard their words until we began to guess they applied to us. We were doing so much better, we had trouble focusing on something to worry about. We began worrying about things months in the future. We have a court date three months in the future. We begin to spend our income tax return half a year before next April! One day we heard a recovering addict doing the same thing and realized the importance of living the program one day at a time. Helping others, helps us!

December 21

“Truth seems to be something that is impossible to understand until it becomes obvious. Truth is something we never suspected until we knew it. There are no exceptions--only incomplete truths. Everything we know is subject to revision, especially what we know about truth.”

Memphis Review Form - page 71, 35

When we close our eyes to the truth, we deny ourselves the new possibilities that come with our new way of life. Freedom comes from not just staying clean , but in our ability to surrender unconditionally. When we learn to just let go, we experience a freedom many of us have never experienced. The only way to do this is not just for the day, but right now, in the moment. It takes practice, but is attainable.

Seeking the truth always pays off because we find new things, unexpected things that open new doors or close old ones. Even when things appear to be going wrong we are surprised how they turn out. We lose some things to make way for other important things that lead to betterment. We live in time, the endless procession of surprises. The best things are yet to come.

Helping others is one way to come to an appreciation of just how wonderful life can be. Painful moments clear the not possible to reveal reality. Sometimes death is the end of pain and many believe life goes on beyond the body. The more we learn about the life of the spirit, the less we fear and the more we can accept. Truth is what's left after illusions are blown away.

December 22

“This surrender was the starting point of our recovery, and is a primary point of unity for the Fellowship.”

Memphis Review Form - page 90, 21

One member shared “I had a sponsor in the eighties when Japan was booming. He thought they were head and shoulders ahead of us. He had Japanese furniture, Japanese plates, Japanese car and a Japanese girlfriend. He would say, ‘Japan surrendered and look at them now. They took over my life!’”

He was trying to teach me to surrender and let go and not fight it. We are mortals and subject to things of the world. We learn about spiritual reality and suddenly one day, everything looks bigger, more peaceful, with opportunities we could not see the day before. Learning to sit in peace and gratitude break open the strongest locks and freedom awaits just beyond the doorway.

Fighting would be great if it worked. Mostly, we get bloody knuckles! Surrender to things we are powerless over leaves things ahead of us that we can do. When we do what we can, new possibilities come into view. If you are powerless, you can always ask for the help of your Higher Power. Those who ask for help, get help.

December 23

"This is our road to spiritual growth, to change our character, day by day, to gradually, carefully and simply pull ourselves out of the isolation and loneliness of addiction into this mainstream of useful Fellowship."

Memphis Review Form - page 49, 31

Instead of following a professional approach to recovery subject to the ebbs and flows of trends within the treatment industry, we follow a sensible set of principled steps that lead us reliably and predictably into exactly the things we need to work on to complete our fractured personalities and gain the habits and associations needed to live our new lives.

Some of our growth can be expressed in words and many are in the realm of feelings that do not fit into the little boxes of language. Our hugs and body language convey our feelings along with what words come to us. Finding out and participating with others going through similar changes keeps us rolling forward. We finally realize what it means to be never alone.

The program of NA is a tried and proven method of recovering from addiction. It has been proven to work for many decades. Its bulletproof. But you have to follow the rules, use the tools and be willing to take suggestions. It must be worked correctly to guarantee that it will be 100% effective.

Anyone can recover in NA, anyone. There are no exceptions. If you want it more than anything else in the world, then you can have it. Period. But you must do the footwork. Other recovering addicts can appreciate your courage and will respect what you are doing if you work the principles. Make sure you are continuing to do the things that worked for you in the beginning. Build on your own experience.

December 24

“Many of our dreams, forgotten and obscured by our addiction, return and help us regain the sense of wonder and excitement at the miracle of living clean. The old compulsions fade and the habits of mind associated with addiction weaken and are broken. A great many things become possible for us. Since we live clean and grow, we are able to take our place in the world.”

Memphis Review Form - page 71, 18

The healing can take place in fits and starts. There are long plateaus, deep valleys and high mountains in our journey. Sometimes we are on a roll. Other times it seems that nothing happens for weeks on end and then things break loose. Many break throughs come to us out of the blue.

We can have pretty much whatever we want, it's just a matter of making a plan and working it, keeping God in the loop and staying connected to the fellowship. Usually we will find others seeking similar goals. We may help each other but our best source of guidance is from within.

When things get rough we do not go shopping, we get really close to the program, going to a ton of meetings and talking to our sponsor often. We connect with newcomers. We read literature and do step work. We help others. This is how we get thru the bad times. Gratitude and deepening our commitment to recovery will keep us on the track. Like drugs stored in our bone matter, we sometimes discover ourselves doing what we did in active addiction. Just make a prayer for strength and guidance and feel it wash away. We have to go through some painful changes now and then but it gets better after the bend in the road straightens out and we follow the path before us.

December 25

“Each of us has learned to depend upon a Power greater than ourselves, which is our source of strength.”

Memphis Review Form - page 90, 26

Our Higher Power is the engine that drives all of this. After a few years we begin to realize that he has our back. It's such a new phenomena that it's difficult to accept but possible. It's a big, big step for us. But we must do it again and again at many points along the way.

We all have many things to learn about the life of the spirit. Most addicts resist being told what to do, so we have to experience the pain of powerlessness before we reach the point of being able to ask for spiritual help. Later on we cringe at the struggles we had to go through! As we work with a new comer, we notice they have trouble asking for help, even in the most desperate times. We ask ourselves, “Did I do that? Am I doing that right now?” Later on, it makes more sense and feels kind of natural.

Depending on our Higher Power is not a weakness any more than depending on our heart to pump our blood or our lungs to suck air. To live, all our parts have to pull together and God is very much part of our lives.

December 26

"The individual is precious to the group, and the group is precious to the individual. No one can revoke our membership or punish us, or make us do anything that we don't choose to do."

Memphis Review Form - page 91, 3

Balance and focus are two very important points to keep in mind. We are all important and contribute something to the people we are with at any given point. Likewise, we are not in the group by accident. We give and receive and need both for health.

While the combination of personal views strengthens the whole, the whole is dependent on accurate information from each group member. On just the feeling level, we need the presence of other people in our lives. Isolation deprives us of this good company and we find ourselves substituting fantasy for reality with no one to help catch our errors. Just thinking of the members in our lives, we feel their presence. 'Never Alone' means we always have members to turn to for love and caring. Even if we are brand new to recovery, there is something comforting and restful about realizing we are home among people to love and understand.

If we are growing, we will always have answers to seek, time to find them and those who need them. Prayer and meditation become like breathing in and breathing out. Focusing on our breathing opens a doorway to the spirit that cannot be denied. Filling our lungs with clean, pure air brings us into a state of concentration on the life force within and the God of our understanding is ready at hand. There is energy in the air you breathe, breathe deeply. Take your time, you have it coming. Strength and guidance help us all to make the most of our lives and feel the satisfaction we have long sought.

December 27

"In dealing with the other people in our lives, we develop a loving attitude. We forgive more easily, anger more slowly, expect less, and give more...."

Memphis Review Form - page 71, 21

They say that for every year that you have clean, you get one more second before you go off on someone. This allows us to at least leave the room before we explode and then have to go back and clean it up. At some point we realize life has given us many changes, we just didn't hang in there long enough to appreciate the opportunities at hand. Good things take time. Being unafraid we don't act defensively and others don't have to protect themselves. Makes it easier to give us what we want when they don't fear us.

As we are entering new territory, it should not be surprising to need a little time to survey our surroundings before we begin to recognize the opportunities! One of the amazing things about clean time is realizing new things may be challenging at first but yield many new opportunities. Knowing about conscious contact gives us the opportunity to ask our higher power directly for help making the most of our surroundings. This seems the stuff of science fiction - and it really is!

Expecting less is the key to happiness. This is not to say minimize everything. Just don't habitually demand more than your share aggressively. It makes you unpleasant and hard to deal with. It runs off potential clients or friends. When we apply for a position, hope we get a free sample, go to pick-up something being repaired, sometimes the answer is not what we desire. The key to to mentally say "I am going to be Ok with this however it goes." It makes life tremendously easier.

"God helps me see the world anew today, and help me enjoy the new things before me!" This may be a useful prayer. Strength and guidance is a real blessing.

December 28

“In our addiction we consistently placed our personal welfare before anything else. Here we found that in the long run what’s best for the group was usually good for us.”

Memphis Review Form - page 91. 8

This is a revolution in perspective, a complete turnaround from our negative viewpoint of fear and loss. It will occur to you at some point just how habitually we have seen the world as a hostile and negative place. You can go overboard on good stuff also! Recovery seeks to balance our personality so that we can enjoy the good stuff, tolerate the not so good and avoid the negative almost completely!

Once we get our hearts and heads right, our defects removed and our amends made, we can go deeper with inventory, prayer and meditation. It is amazing how much improvement is there once we get the blockage out of the way.

One member gave an orange Igloo cooler to the group for holding iced tea at NA gatherings. Everything he attended one of these, he saw “his cooler” sitting there. It’s hard to use when you become invested in NA in such a manner. Using would be inconsistent with his actions. The subconscious just would have a hard time reconciling the two. Giving stuff and time and services to NA is almost a sure way to insure staying clean.

One member gave two gallons of baby blue paint to paint a wall in a meeting room. He considered it an honor that he was the one allowed to buy that paint. Early literature reveals how we have grown. Quality comes from sincerity that money can’t buy.

December 29

"If we want to reap the benefits of staying clean, we find it necessary to take continual inventories of ourselves. Hidden fears and needs are still potential driving forces. Just because we don't recognize fear or anger doesn't mean that it isn't influencing our lives. We found it important to examine places where we grew angry or our beliefs were tested."

Memphis Review Form - page 71, 26

In the spirit of reciprocity we must continually look inside to receive the benefits we are seeking for our lives. For so long we were living in darkness. In order to place love in our lives we need to objectively see the darkness that has covered our spirit. This takes continual surveying and plotting new courses to steer our way to a more healthy lifestyle. Once seeing the darkness does not serve us, we replace it with a loving attribute. If we desire different results, we learn to vary our approach to get different results.

We can do this as often as needed to find what works best for us in our creative freedom. When something we are experimenting with does not serve us well, we inventory again seeking another idea that may serve us better. Each avenue finds something else we may use for finding our freedom. We also may take each perspective we have found, mix and match to find what works best for us in the moment.

We find that it is important to remain flexible, remembering that the only constant is change and that nothing - good or bad - should ever be perceived as being set in stone

It takes continual searching and fearless inventory to replace the unhealthy attributes with the light we seek. To find light we needed to seek the light we had covered in darkness.

An inventory is a tool to take stock of our assets and liabilities. Seeing and hearing clearly gives us a chance to take a reading on where we are and what we are doing.

December 30

“The last five Steps of Narcotics Anonymous, the Eighth through the Twelfth, are the “get out and live” Steps.”

Memphis Review Form - page 50, 10

There are many references and correlations within the Twelve Steps of N A. One to Three and Ten to Twelve match-up to open the doorway to recovery and to maintain your new life. The six Steps from Four to Nine directly address mechanisms that help us change. The quotation from the Memphis Review Form addresses the rock over from the first six to the last six. The changes within make the changes outside stick and help us work forward with our Program.

It just seems to have worked out that the first Three lead us from surrender to a state of empowerment that is clearly miraculous. And the last Three represent an almost totally spiritual daily life that gives expression and increase of what is best in each of us and continues to help us change for the better and better.

In between, there are three pairs of Steps that go together. Four and Five bring what's bothering us out into the open. Six and Seven open the doorway to a new life by appealing to our Higher Power to remove defects that no longer have a place in our lives. Steps Eight and Nine eliminate the fear and concern we may have over the consequences of our old defects.

It takes our willingness to allow do this for us without the injury that would come from having our defects forcibly taken away. As we grow what has been wrong with us becomes ever more visible and clear. This embeds the changes recovery has given us in our new lives.

December 31

“Though the freedom in our new lives , we are finally able to see the special qualities that we possess as individuals--qualities that we used to envy in others--never realizing the potential within ourselves.”

Memphis Review Form - page 161, 2

Our defects kept us from seeing our own good qualities. Freed from our defects, we can finally find what we were looking for all the time. "Don't judge your insides by another person's outsides" is a cliché we have often heard. Our low self image was no longer valid, when we began to see ourselves as we really are.

Accepting ourselves as we are, just for today with the understanding that there will always be room for improvement and new insight to be gained each time we revisit the Steps. Watching other members grow, encourages us to make our own improvements.

Where once we suffered from low self esteem to the degree that many of us shunned even the image of ourselves in the mirror, we now face life on life's terms with a sense of dignity and newfound purpose. Strength and guidance give us the direction we need to enjoy the clean life while continuing to work our NA 12 Steps!

When we get clean, we become sought after by employers. We always show up with a smile on our face and work hard. We do not steal stuff, argue with customers and can be counted on. This is exactly what the doctor ordered in the workplace. Many doors open for us as we work the NA program. Just look around at the other members.

Every day is a new day for us!

NOTE: THIS SECTION IS IN ORDER BY PAGE AND LINE NUMBER

i, Forward "The full fruit of a labor of love lives in the harvest, and that always comes in its right season..." (There are no line numbers at top of page.)"

Memphis Review Form - page

A labor of love, just think, a labor of love. Our Grey Book and our Basic Text were written as labors of love. This meditation book is written as a labor of love. Love by members of this Fellowship for this lifesaving program that has given us new lives, lives we are proud of. The full fruit describes how we grow and change as we work the Steps and start living the Program. Doing this work is labor, hard labor, but it becomes labor we love. We were barely little buds of hope when we came into the rooms, we were nurtured and fed by the love of our predecessors. We were pruned and encouraged by the love of our sponsors and grew abundantly by the light of our Higher Power as we came to understand Him. We bloom and become ripe fruit in our proper seasons as our lives are shaped by spiritual principles and our relationship with our Higher Power grows. Then we start new little buds of hope in the hearts of newcomers just as our buds were encouraged when we arrived. The ongoing process of birth, growth and maturation continues and will continue as long as we hold true to our Program, our Steps and our Traditions. Our right season is ever now as we strive to live by spiritual principles in the here and now. We are proud to be members of Narcotics Anonymous.

1 *Who is an Addict.* "We use to live and live to use. Very simply an addict is a man or woman whose life is controlled by drugs." (There are no line numbers at top of page.)

We are all the same, victims of the disease of addiction. We all want the same thing, an end to pain and recovery from our disease. Although our stories may be different, the feelings brought about by this disease are the same: worthlessness, abject misery, regret, hopelessness, remorse, resentment, fear, anger, grief, shame, self-pity. We have all done things we would take back if we could and things we will never want to admit to. But, by the same token, if we have a deep enough desire, if we are willing to make the effort, we can be given hope, we can learn honesty, willingness and open-mindedness, we develop acceptance, courage, strength and perseverance and we are gifted with power and wisdom by the God of our understanding. We become respectable members of society with integrity, freedom, joy and serenity if we are willing to do the work required to take the Steps. The Steps lead us to total creative freedom to become the very best people we can become. Respected, responsible, productive members of society. People we are proud to be, recovering addicts.

1, 5 We admitted that we used drugs, but many of us did not think we had a problem.

What we knew about recovery came from uninformed sources like fellow students in school and co-workers. TV was another untrustworthy source of information. Budweiser will get you dates, Chanel No. 5 will make you beautiful and smoking Marlboros will make you a real man. By the time we get to NA, we are hungry to get some real answers - answers that will work in real life! Using drugs was confused with partying, having a good time, an attitude adjustment or dealing with tension. Taking more drugs was not an answer we could live with.

Another great realization came when we realized we were asking fellow addicts who were also in denial and using drugs! We were, in fact, asking the disease of addiction if we had addiction? The answers we got were usually distorted by the other addicts' perceptions of what "normal" use was. Which to them was massive daily consumption of drugs. None-users were generally looked down on as lame or not cool. Problems we were having related to our heavy drug use were generally explained away in one artful form or another as our denial merely reinforced each of us our right to use drugs at will.

It never occurred to us that our disease had us living in close association with other addicts and kept us sheltered from most "normal" people, or those that might question our heavy drug use. When life brought us in contact with non-addicts, more often than not, we felt either out-of-place or they confronted us in one form or another. The more reason to avoid them at all cost.

In recovery we come to own our problem. We don't need a Physician to tell us we are in too deep, we know it in our innermost-selves. We once were blind but now we see. This is what it means to admit that we are powerless over our addiction, that our lives had become unmanageable. Today we own the truth, not hide from it.

just for today, have I admitted to myself, if to no one else, that I am an addict. If I have, I must be willing to do whatever it takes to stay clean a day at a time or face a life of jails, institutions or death.

1, 8 Many of us were convinced that we were right and the world was wrong, and used this belief to justify our self-destructive behavior.

We can let go of drugs a day at a time, our lives will get better. We will have a lot less daily problems as we are not stealing, or avoiding people. But if we do not work the 12 steps we will have the same inner low self esteem that we came to recovery with. If we don't heal the inside we will have what one of our early members talked about... "when you take the drugs away from a drug-crazed maniac, you get a more efficient maniac!"

If we don't heal the hurt, damaged child within, we will do everything in our power to create the chaos and rejection that little guy feels he deserves in life. We will self-sabotage without even knowing it. We will pick partners that put us down or belittle us as our parents or peers once did. We will do what is needed to co-sign our inner feelings of worthlessness.

When we judge ourselves and find ourselves unworthy, self-destructive behavior results. We are in a terrific position to punish ourselves. There are quirks in our nervous system that make punishing ourselves a kind of answer. The more we punish ourselves for doing things we didn't feel good about, the less pressure was on, at least for the moment. Beyond simple mistakes and lost jobs, some go so far that they cut themselves and engage in other dangerous forms of abuse.

The only answer is to work the steps and free ourselves once and for all of the low self-esteem we have lived with for so long.

Just For Today

I will do whatever it takes to be free from the bondage of self, forever!

2, 4 We became capable of depravity--of betrayal to ourselves and to others.
Temporarily clean, we ran around trying to get it all squared away before our next spree.

Waking up can be a painful process when we recall what we did last night or in the recent past. Befuddled and cloudy from mood and mind altering drugs, we suspended good sense and found misbehavior funny. Angry or resentful, we felt liberated when, in our own minds, we were released from unwanted pressure from authority figures we did not respect. Sometimes our friends egged us on. This only gave us excuses to act out in even more bizarre behavior.

Today in recovery, if we work the 12 steps, we tend to go to bed with all our tasks completed so we have peace when our head hits the pillow. When we awake it is generally in a peaceful well rested state. When using we had bouts of abstinence that gave us respite or rest from our last run which had usually ended in total collapse. We were broke, busted and disgusted with ourselves and the world around us. We stayed clean for a while out of sheer fear and exhaustion. Hell, we weren't sick and tired we were just plain tired! Once the fear let up, the exhaustion was replenished, our disease told us it wasn't that bad? IT WASN'T THAT BAD??? IT SURE AS HELL WAS THAT BAD!

Just for today

I will surrender to the truth, that it was that bad and that I cannot take just one of any mind or mood-altering drug as I no longer am willing to live in hell. I am willing to work the steps and live in heaven with my fellow survivors who have found true freedom from active addiction.

2, 15 We regretted the past; we feared the future.

This is the way we lived in our addiction. We were never aware in the present but were using to escape our feelings and, mistakenly thinking, making our present bearable. In reality, we were obliterating our present so we could regret it in the future. Very few of us were ever really in the present except perhaps when calamity or disaster overcame us. Then, of course, we had to use again. Now through working the Steps, we learn to live in the present.

Developing a deep sense of self-honesty is essential to our recovery. By giving ourselves completely to the program of Narcotics Anonymous and working the Steps, we begin learning to live by spiritual principles. As we progress through the Steps we clean up our pasts and acquire the skills necessary to live in the present. Eventually, we are able to live fully in the present, doing the right thing for the right reason. This brings us the great freedom to be able to focus our full attention on the present, right here right now. When we can fully focus on the present, we become aware of the great joy and beauty surrounding us all the time. We see how much we have missed in the past and get a sense of how much richer our lives are now. We are grateful to be in the present.

Just For Today

I know that recovery is not in the past or the future but in the present. Yesterday is history, tomorrow is a mystery but today is a gift, that's why they call it the present.

2, 22 Drugs could no longer hide the pain. We just wanted an easy way out. Suicide was on many of our minds.

Unfortunately, many of us masked our pain from conscious memory. With or without drugs, we lost the ability to remember what was making us feel so badly. It was all we could do just to get through a day! People yelling at us or putting pressure on us kept us even more distracted.

Recovery gives us a brand new life without all the self-inflicted wounds. While recovery takes place on a day by day or moment by moment basis, the changes are often at a level so fundamental that they touch every part of our lives and attitudes. Personality change for the better is possible through the NA 12 Steps. Spiritual growth replaces the broken parts with things that work for us.

2, 25 Part of ourselves could see what was happening; another part would not accept it. We were caught in an illusion of "what if," "if only" and "just one more try."

During our using, the part of us that could see what was happening got ignored or discounted so often, we stopped believing it. Our illusion of "what if," "if only" and "just one more try" got us building walls of denial so thick, the truth could not be seen. The Steps and the Program gives us the tools to break down our walls of denial (Don't Even Notice I Am Lying-DENIAL) with honesty, open-mindedness and willingness. Our insane illusions are replaced with sanity. Sanity

has been defined as living in harmony with reality. We learn to be fully focused in the present, observing all the joy and beauty that we used to miss in our search for “just one more.”

Not thinking clearly, we sought easy answers and easy answers usually turned out to be time and energy consuming substitutes for real action. We were bumping into the walls without really getting anywhere. Even in recovery we can find ourselves coasting without thinking things through. It helps to review our goals and methods every once in a while. The drug induced fog can become so familiar that we lived there. Snapping out of habitual non-reaction gives us a break from the insanity.

2, 31 We had used all sorts of drugs over the years and experienced numerous living problems as the result of our using and yet did not consider ourselves addicted.

It usually takes a total catastrophe or disaster to penetrate our walls of denial. Denial is so all pervasive, we actually believe our own lies. The acronym “Don’t Even Notice I Am Lying” is such a wonderful description of denial. Spinning stories and then believing them is an ability we have all become so skilled at we often are not aware we are doing it. When we hit our bottoms, when our lives are so unmanageable and out of control we can’t believe our own lies anymore, our addiction becomes apparent. Even then, it often takes a long time before we are ready to do anything about it.

When we finally truly accept that we are addicts and can’t live this life of addiction anymore, we can make the admission and surrender required by Step One and begin to recover. We must start developing a relationship with honesty, not just cash register honesty, but the deeper level of self-honesty required to look at ourselves. It takes courage and faith to take a deep look inside and see all the mistakes we have made over the years. We need to realize that we are not evil, malicious horrible monsters, but we are simply human beings who made mistakes and poor choices. We are capable of learning to make good choices and fewer mistakes. This is where the Fellowship, the Program, a Sponsor and a strong relationship with a Higher Power can help us. There is indeed hope for all of us. We can learn to love ourselves, have lives filled with joy and happiness and become people we are proud to be.

3, 16 We looked at our differences rather than our sameness. Yet the things we had in common put us all in the same dimension, the dimension of addiction.

We are often told as newcomers that we need to look for the similarities, not the differences. As newcomers we often looked for anything that would disqualify us, free us from the reality of our addiction. As we look around the rooms, we start to realize that we are not unique. Although our stories might be different, the feelings we have are in common. The self-centeredness, the insecurity, the unworthiness, the fear, guilt, remorse, regret, uselessness we feel we hear shared by others. We also hear how they overcame their negative self-images to have lives of joy and purpose, of peace, serenity and usefulness. We realize we have two things in common, addiction and recovery.

The spiritual life makes us aware of some of the fears and concerns that occupy space in our heads without paying rent. There are words we learn to deal with these things. There are ways to deal with these things that are learnable. The dimension we share grows and this growth gives us room unavailable before the program. "Diction" is the root word in addiction can so imbeds the idea of expression or statement in our disorder. When we are a mess inside our minds and bodies, that gets expressed in our behavior.

14, 19 We can die from untreated addiction. But before we die, the disease takes from us our pride, our self-esteem, our families and loved ones. And finally, it takes our very will to live.

The pain and confusion of active addiction makes it hard to realize we are slipping into a hole until it is too late. Actually, there is no such thing as 'too late.' Most of us arrive in an NA meeting feeling hopeless and expecting things to continue getting worse. The lessening of despair and the early glimmers of hope come as a surprise!

In our recovery program, we do not dwell on the horror show of active addiction but rather share and emphasize the processes of recovery. We surrender and therefore end the struggle to deny our addiction and continue our efforts to control our lives. Just by not using, going to meetings and reading NA literature we become focused on a new way to live. Hope is given to us and grows in us.

15, 1 The structure of Narcotics Anonymous is quite unlike any health or welfare agency known to us. Although N.A. practices may vary from place to place, all N.A. services are performed voluntarily by the addicts themselves and without cost. N.A. does not accept money for its services, is not funded by any public or private sources of agencies and accepts no outside contributions.

You cannot buy a miracle! We have found through a long period of trial and error that our messages comes through loud and clear in meetings or private conversation. (When persons outside the N.A.'s point of view try to produce our writings using academic techniques, it comes through crippled. When academics and treatment professionals try to reproduce our writings, they come through crippled.) We don't want insincerity or lofty thinkers taking pity on us. It is the identification and respect we share among our fellow members that brings our recovery process to life. Our message of hope and recovery is priceless. Whether in H&I, P.I., Literature or other services, it is our common bond that amazes us and holds our attention.

16, 4 Addicts respond instinctively to honest sharing.

We have heard so many lies we pay little attention to what goes on around us. We stumbled into an NA meeting skeptical of anything we heard although we did feel something that piqued our attention at least for a moment. So we returned to another meeting not knowing why. It may have been the second or fourth meeting, we heard some truth. Instinctively, the truth attracted us and we began listening closer. The closer we listened, the more truth we heard. The more truths we heard, the more hope we felt. These truths were starting to stick together into

something we could wrap our minds around. It was when our minds found enough evidence to believe that our hearts started feeling soothed. Now we can surrender at least a little of our lives into our process. We find ourselves practicing honesty too and feeling good about these changes. What reaches the heart, touches the heart and nothing reaches the heart like honest sharing of common pain and the solution out of it.

17, 9 After coming to the Narcotics Anonymous Fellowship, we find ourselves among a very special group of people. Many were a great deal worse off than we were. Here we found hope.

Hope is the only spiritual principle that can be given. All other principles we must develop from within. Hope lets us know the program is working for us as it has worked for others. At each step in the process of recovery, we feel relief. Alternatives appear out of thin air and give us awareness that we are no longer trapped in a dead end. When we attend meetings and see other addicts smiling and enjoying life in recovery, our spirit is renewed. This is one aspect of the hope we share, the therapeutic value of one addict helping another. We must be careful not to quench the hope of others. Newfound hope can be a very fragile and must be encouraged.

18, 6 We don't want to settle for the limitations of the past. We want to examine and reexamine all our old ideas, and constantly improve on them or replace them with new ones.

Being able to change our lives by changing our beliefs and entertain new approaches to old problems is a great discovery.

The courage to change our old ways puts us on the path of recovery. The 12 Steps are the tools we use to navigate that path that leads us to freedom from active addiction. We can feel ourselves coming alive!

The 10th Step can keep on-going spiritual growth a reality. Every time we cancel out an old habit that no longer works or fits our life, our view expands and we can see more defects that can be changed. The more we grow, the more we can see. The more we see, the more we can change.

20, 19 We want desperately for the place where addicts recover to be a safe, free from outside influences. We feel safe at our closed meetings. Everyone is an addict. We feel totally free to express ourselves because no law enforcement agencies are involved.

Many of our members desire personnel anonymity, especially when we are new to the program, though within a short time most come to cherish the therapeutic value of one addict helping another that is found in the process of identification, and that process is often fostered only in the safety of a circle of clean addicts living a program of recovery.

Anonymity is half our name. The ability to share peer-to-peer gives us a chance to share and express ideas we had been forced to keep to ourselves. Many times we 'self-correct' when we hear ourselves say something that doesn't make sense. Keeping things inside perpetuates

some really dumb ideas. Sharing our feelings and ideas with other addicts who are free to call us on our bullshit can give us great insight into where we have gone wrong.

21, 8 Our program is in fact a way of life. We learn the value of principles such as humility, surrender, and service. The idea that we have to do it alone is obsolete.

As a way of life, we enjoy the company of others who are in the same process we are engaged in ourselves. We become so closely associated with fellow members, we really enjoy the type of closeness otherwise found only in families. This is a very natural way to obtain feedback that is simple and honest. Many times their answers turn out to be our answers.

Humility is simply honestly setting aside our egotistical ideas and being open to others. Surrender gets us out of ourselves and lets us shake off many of the chains that used to bind us. Service involves extending ourselves for others. We can practice projecting our feelings into those in need and help them find solutions that will work for them.

21, 12 We, of Narcotics Anonymity, do not promise to have all the answers, but we've found that our lives steadily improved if we didn't use and learned to maintain our spiritual condition.

Actually, recovery is what happens to us when we are clean, going to meetings and taking time to help others. Whether new or well established in recovery, just by caring we are able to see into the lives of others. This helps reshape our own living attitudes and capacity to surrender and trust the program of NA. By living differently, we change what we attract and what we involve ourselves with on a daily basis.

22, 22 Many books have been written about the nature of addiction. This book primarily concerns itself with the nature of recovery. (There are no line numbers at top of page.)

Many of us who got clean in the 1970's, know from experience that outside interests have little information that we could use. Many theories on what addiction is and methods of treatment abounded but we got nothing from them. NA began to grow when addicts began to take up for ourselves, our message and our program. Our Traditions allow us to do things together that might otherwise result in conflicts and stalemates. One of the great benefits of our program is that we are not dependent on outside organizations for funding or direction. We are fully self-supporting through our own contributions and have only to seek a loving God in our group conscience for direction.

23, 1 Before coming to the fellowship of N.A., we were irresponsible with our lives. We used drugs to cover up our humiliation, guilt, inferiority and feelings of inadequacy.

Most of us practice some sort of wake-up ritual, reading literature, listening to recovery tapes or CD's to get our day off to a good start. It is vitally important that we keep our focus on recovery and things that work in recovery if we are going to experience the benefits of NA! The simplest things can make so much difference in the way our days go. Just missing a few meetings can

cause us to begin to experience the feelings we associate with our disease. Resentments crop up over very small issues. We snap at co-workers and spouses. Just a member calling us can put us back in a better place.

24, 25 Some of us sought spiritual guidance through churches, different religions, meditation and cultism. Some of us sought cure by geographical changes, blaming our surroundings and living situations for our problem. This attempt just gave us new people to take advantage of.

What we failed to realize is that wherever we are, we bring the problem with us. Solutions to our problems cannot come from outside sources, they must come from within. The Steps are the answer to our problems if we can find the courage, willingness and honesty to use the Steps to look inside, see who we are, accept ourselves and seek change. Finding and developing a relationship with a Higher Power gives us the spiritual power to accomplish great changes we would otherwise be incapable of accomplishing. We start to gain self-acceptance and self-love by realizing we are no longer the despicable depraved people we used to be but are becoming capable of giving hope and love to those coming in after us.

25, 4 When we came to the Fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous, we faced many disturbing realizations.

We realized we had run from our feelings, we had lost control of our lives and become victims of the disease of addiction. The compulsion and obsession that had ruled our lives had forced us to take many actions that were against our will. We have lied, stolen, cheated, sold ourselves and many other vile things all in the name of getting one more. Now faced with the total unmanageability of our lives, we were filled with guilt, remorse, shame and sorrow. We couldn't see a way out. Going to meetings started to give us hope. We heard others share about how their lives got better. We started to learn there was a better way.

Learning is an ongoing process in recovery. Rethinking and sharing with others one on one or in meetings, we wake up to where we have been and what we have been doing! Living a day at a time frees us from repeating things we no longer approve of or care for. Each day is a blank slate. Hope and the freedom that comes from surrender and belief enables us to take a good look and review our lives as casually as we comb our hair. We can substitute actions and viewpoints until we are satisfied. Even then, when they stand for inspection, we are free to make other improvements. Our progress encourages us to continue the process. Instead of feeling lost when something comes to mind, we just think, "I'll share about this at the meetings tonight. Surely I am not the only one who has this problem." Not longer trapped and out of touch with supportive people we can move forward. No more concrete shoes!

25, 5 We were sick and tired of pain and trouble. We were frightened and ran from the fear, but no matter how far we ran, the fear followed us. We were hopeless, useless and lost. Feelings of worthlessness overcame us.

Our insidious disease will always try to re-assert itself regardless of the period of our clean time. One of the things we wake up to is the fears come inside and need to be dealt with before they will stop manifesting. Self-worth is based on the abilities we value. False pride and ego take the place of real skills and assets. The more skills and assets we gain, the less we need false pride and ego. Hope is positive expectation and it grows larger as we move forward in recovery clean time and experience. Helping others resets many of the things that seem to permanently block our path. All it takes is one moment of realization to being the change process.

25, 11 In N.A., we learned that members concentrated on recovery and how they felt, not what they had done in the past.

Everyday clean we have an opportunity to start afresh. Many of us find that things we have been putting off are the very things we have to do before we can go on with our lives. Writing down things on the edge of our consciousness is one way to help move us forward to correction of details that may prove to be of great importance later on.

Learning to identify our feelings and how to cope with them is an important early step in recovery. We begin to realize we don't have to act out on our feelings but can simply accept them and move on. Recovery takes a giant step forward when we realize we can learn from our past and forgive ourselves. We are not doomed to repeat it.

25, 18 Personality change was what we really needed. Change from a self-destructing to a self-affirming pattern of living was imperative.

When we were using, a change of any kind of personal nature was the farthest thing from our minds. We were getting and using every day, the only thing we wanted to change was the pain of living, that in many cases, we were unable to clearly see.

It wasn't until we were able to get clean, when it was said to us, that in order to stay clean, all we had to do was pray, go to meetings and not pick up, and change everything in our lives. This was almost too much to absorb at once. After It

25, 24 Today we have feelings of love, joy, hope, excitement, sadness and friendship. Before we were either elated or depressed with very little in between.

In recovery we find much of the color and beauty in life is found in the details we used to blow off as unimportant. Going more slowly and thinking things through gives is a chance to see what we have been missing. What breakthrough lies just ahead of us today if we take time to catch it?

25, 29 Although our heads told us we would never make it, the people in the Fellowship gave us hope by insisting we could.

We will find that our hopelessness and despair is always waiting to take over any time we slack up on our prayer and meditation. Spiritual maintenance is what we use to get clean, stay clean and grow spiritually. When we turn our attention to helping others, we change our whole situation. We can move from despairing and needful to sitting up straight and thinking up ways to encourage someone else. This change is crucial to our new lives. The important thing for us to remember today, is we have to make this change of situation every day.

27, 3 What a change from how we used to be! That's how we know that the N.A. program works.

Time, and our disease of addiction, will constantly work to make us forget and ignore all our many blessings. Many of us write our gratitude lists to maintain our awareness of the new things that could never have happen to us when we were dirty (using). When we work on getting better, often others can see a change in us before we can see it in ourselves. Slowly we realize we are not losing our temper as often, gossiping as much or lying quite as easily.

27, 18 Recovery is a beautiful chance that many addicts thought had passed them by until they found the Fellowship of N.A. It's a chance to live again.

Right now, alive in the present and living fully! It is a new day and we commit to the courage we need to step up to the challenges and opportunities we have rising up to meet us. The longer we are clean and the more we let ourselves experience the miracles of personality changes and spiritual growth, the more we can accept and believe a whole new life opens up to us one day at a time!

We see people that love themselves, love their lives, have dreams, are pursuing dreams and most importantly, achieving dreams. They assure us that we, too, can have this. We start by having attainable goals like getting one more key tag. Then, maybe, a job or a car or a bank account. Then the day of ultimate success, we have completed the Steps for the first time and have achieved a spiritual awakening. We slowly realize we have become people that love ourselves and our lives. We are pursuing and achieving our dreams and most importantly, we are capable of helping others reach for their new lives. A miracle has occurred.

29, 10 When we came to N.A., we were physically, mentally and spiritually bankrupt. We hurt long enough and badly enough that we were willing to go to any lengths to stay clean.

Nothing motivates like pain and, boy, did we hurt. We became willing to follow suggestions we didn't completely understand because of hope. Hope offered by NA members we recognized as fellow addicts who were obviously no longer in pain but enjoying life. It was their continued assurances that we could get better, too, that helped us find the courage to go on for one more day, one more hour or maybe just one more heartbeat.

We learned that gratitude defeats self-pity. Mountainous problems become small molehills when we accept the circumstances and look for solutions. Life doesn't need chaos to have pleasure.

30, 1 When we first came into the Fellowship of N.A., we were often resentful at the suggestions some of the members made to us.

As we learn more about how N.A. works, we realize members try to wait until we ask for help. There is a chance that we may have asked for help in some area and the members responded to our request. None of us claim to be perfect and, while we are very capable of slipping into ego trips and authoritative roles, it is just our disease acting up. Really, we know better and some of us are comfortable laughing at ourselves. There is a good saying for this. "Man who cannot laugh at himself is missing one of the world's greatest jokes!" Our awareness grows and as we discover the linkage between our actions and the results, we frequently say "Oh, my God." when we catch ourselves doing this. The truth often seems threatening at first but later on it proves to be a great friend!

30, 11 After attending a few meetings, we began to feel like we were finally getting somewhere. It was in these meetings that we were first introduced to the Twelve Steps of N.A.

Surrender seems like the last thing that would help us dispel the negative feelings and emptiness we feel inside. But, really, if we are powerless, we get instant relief when we stop fighting. Life is not our adversary. Addiction is our problem, substituting using and parallel behaviour for real life and solutions that deal with things as they come up. Usually, we are listening to someone share about what happened when they stopped fighting the inevitable fact of their addiction and began looking for new answers or ways of understanding. Identifying with the speaker, the idea caught hold and helped us change our loser's point of view. We become winners when we can accept life as it is and learn ways closed to us before.

30, 20 When we admit our powerlessness and inability to manage our own lives, we open the door to a power greater than ourselves.

The belief that a higher power exists and can help us get results where we used to have this naked, lost feeling is a powerful bringer of hope. Praying for guidance, reading, listening to others share their experience and feelings gives us courage to approach the same goals. Clinging to the notion that we can manage our lives is a control game. By the time we reach the NA program, control is something we left behind. If it isn't practical, it isn't spiritual reminds us to keep our feet on the ground and use spiritual principles to get what we want or need.

30, 23 It doesn't matter whether we just took a few pills, fixed eight times a day, suck on a pipe, drink bottles of cough remedy behind drug stores, or have one tranquilizer with our first martini

each day..... we have certain things in common, no matter to what degree or what kind of addict we are.

The obsession and compulsion were two things we had in common. We were also all familiar with the feelings: guilt, remorse, fear, self-loathing, anger, desperation, self-pity, inadequacy. The twin attributes of obsession and compulsion just didn't work. It is like an animal stuck in a laboratory that keeps mashing a button without getting the food. Desperation usually the driving force and as our needs are met, we slow down and make more sense.

31, 1 Upon working Step One, we affirmed our surrender to the principles of N.A, only then did we overcome the alienation of addiction.

For many of us this is our first experience with the life saving principle of vulnerability. Our unconditional surrender is the key that will unlock the door and allow others into our lives, providing the help we need and averting the penchant to continue in self will.

The pain of being clean and having the realization, that we cannot successfully, not only not use drugs, but in addition, not use others, control situations through manipulation and control. When we find that we are unable to control life and see how our lives are unmanageable we can free ourselves through surrender. Surrender becomes a positive move away from things that no longer work for us.

31, 7 We needed proof. In that N.A. meeting we found people like ourselves with the same, or worse patterns of of drug dependency and failure, yet they were clean. They smiled. Their eyes were clear. They cared for each other.

Patterning after happy people seems to be an innate quality in human beings. We can pick up good vibes and without much preparation, find ourselves looking, feeling and sounding better as our internal state changes from fear-base to something new to us.

31, 30 Step One means that we don't have to make excuses for the way we are, and that is a great freedom.

Our freedom results in more energy and open-mindedness. This is the raft we ride into the Second Step where we find connections to a power that can help us. Surrender would not work out on the streets or places where we have all been. In the loving, caring circle of friends in an NA meeting we find a protected environment made just for us. As we grow in recovery, our need for and ability to surrender grows as well.

31, 31 Surrender means not having to fight anymore. It took a while, for some of us, to realize how unmanageable our lives had become; for others, this was about the only thing of which we could be sure.

Surrender becomes one of the most powerful weapons in our arsenal. As we truly accept our powerlessness over just about everything but ourselves, we find our power over ourselves is growing. We can change our attitudes, our beliefs, our feelings, our actions and our responses. We learn to take a moment to think about our actions in accordance with our growing belief system and then respond instead of just blindly react.

32, 5 The pain of working the program did not seem as great as the pain of addiction, so we surrendered.

We have often heard one member or another lamenting the hardships of recovery or life on life's terms in general, but how does this compare to the desperation of active addiction?

Perhaps each member might recall the fear, paranoia and degradation experienced while using. It took a monumental effort for most of us to maintain our addiction once our disease had progressed to the latter stages. The sheer number of lies we tried to remember to keep those we loved in the dark about our addiction could wear down even the strongest of wills.

The suggestions of the program seem simple, even easy by comparison. Going to meetings instead of to cop, calling our sponsor or talking with another recovering addict instead of a dealer or reading literature are all very doable.

32, 10 None of the Steps work by magic. We do not just say the words of the Steps; we live them.

Belief in magic was part of our illusions and delusions in our using days. We could convince ourselves of the most unbelievable things. In recovery we learn that we have to work for our achievements. First, we learn the words to the Steps. We hear them repeated in every meeting and their meaning starts to sink in. When we start to work them with a sponsor, they become real to us. They start to make sense and slowly become a part of our lives. As we progress through the Steps, we learn spiritual principles and incorporate them into our lives because life becomes easier and makes more sense. The more we work the Steps and practice living by spiritual principles, we find ourselves living in the solution and finding self-value. As we practice the spiritual principles taught by the Steps over and over, they become as natural as breathing to us. We master living in accordance with the will of our Higher Power and our lives become richer and more beautiful. Eventually, going against what we know to be the will of our Higher Power becomes difficult and the pain we get proves we have made a poor choice. We start to have a light shining through us that is readily apparent to others. We become grateful for this new way of live and want to share it with others.

32, 14 We read this book and attend N.A. meetings. We see for ourselves if the Fellowship has something to offer us. It is not where we are that counts, but where we are going!

We start to realize we are on a journey of recovery that will be a life-long trek of discovery. Changing, growing and learning become pleasurable to us and we look forward to the next

day's developments. Often others will notice changes in use before we do and surprise us with their insights. Upon reflection, we realize we are no longer who we were and we like who we are becoming. We are afforded glimpses of what we might become in our deepening friendships with long-timers who have infinite patience, humility and joy in their lives. This becomes our dreams and goals, to live happy, joyous and free. Serene in the love of our Higher Power.

32, 18 None of us stumbled into this Fellowship brimming with love, honesty or open-minded willingness.

Most of us actually showed up at our doors brimming with degradation, isolation and loneliness. With that fear, we needed to see how simple it could be using NA as a means of fulfillment instead of the shooting galleries we used to frequent. Not near as stressful in 'our' rooms, we begin seeing a little more clearly. We see members laugh, have fun and genuinely care for us and want to help us. This hope gives us a clarity not seen in many years. We find that someone loves us even when we feel out of control. And with this new found hope we begin pushing the isolation out and away from us.

By hearing the Steps and Traditions read and studied at every meeting we attend, we start to feel some willingness. Our hearts recognize the honesty we hear and we start to want to be honest ourselves.

33, 13 We had nothing left to lose. We gave up... quit struggling...surrendered, completely and unconditionally. Then and only then did we begin to recover from the disease of addiction.

Paradoxically, with this complete unconditional surrender, we started to find some power. The resources we had depleted fighting our addiction started to rebuild giving us whatever we needed to start recovering.

33, 16 Recovery begins with the first admission of powerlessness. From that point forward, we can see that every clean day is a successful day, and that any seeming failure is only a temporary setback.

Essay starts.

33, 20 We quit fighting. We accept our addiction and life the way it is.

How smoothly we find ourselves slipping back into our old habit patterns. When we quit fighting, we can start our days on a whole new platform. We can start our days being grateful and surrendered. It is funny how we find ways to get along with others when we are mindful of our release from our addictive prisons. Pain can make us real open-minded! Gratitude can make us more open to what others are saying or going through. When we pay attention, we get attention.

34, 7 All of us have this one thing in common -- we but the disease that kills us and, one way or another, we usually pay for it, a bag at a time, a few pills at a time, or a bottle at a time until we die.

Putting our energy into the things we really care about or blindly following the obsession of the moment without considering the cost is a choice we have today. Taking life a day at a time helps us reach escape velocity from our old habits and preferences we developed when we were out of our minds. Being in the present is an important tool for finding a new way of living. Stopping now and then to make a written list of all we have to be grateful for is a good way to improve our mood and raise our energy for the day to come. Saying "thank you" and asking permission before forcing an issue or getting someone's help smooths out our relations with everyone we encounter.

34, 21 The Second Step is the most important thing that must happen for us to achieve any sort of ongoing recovery.

Belief defines our boundaries and what we are open to in our personal reality. If we can only find something to believe in, we can firm up our hope for a new life. A power greater than ourselves changes what we bring to the table on a daily basis. It is not brave to walk down the street with a few large friends and it is not cowardice to crouch down in an alleyway with large, hulking figures moving towards us in a hostile manner. Having a Higher Power to help out only a breath of prayer away changes our situation in a wonderful way.

35, 30 The Higher Power we use in N.A. is a lot like this: We begin by simply admitting to the possibility of a power greater than ourselves.

This simple admission allows us access to prayers that work for us. We can pray for a higher power to help us find a belief we can live with. The help we need to stay clean multiplies the more we use it. We can pray for help to stay clean, just for today! We can pray for help dealing with things at work or with the people in our lives.

36, 3 Many fortunate things occur mysteriously, but there are no accidents. We come to understand that our recoveries are a gift from a Power greater than ourselves.

Getting used to having a higher power may seem a bit strange at first. Spiritual growth can feel frightening or unreal. Elusive understandings and surprising good luck can lull us into taking it all

for granted. After all, if we are not using, lots of things do get better, seemingly on their own! Relapse often follows taking recovery for granted instead of remembering the other things that go with not using and taking in meetings on a regular basis. If this happens to us, we start taking the N.A. program more seriously, our very lives depend on it.

36, 12 Clean living is only the beginning of a new life. Life without fear is a gift we receive for the price of acceptance.

Incredible as this may be, it is really that simple. Considering the pain and despair we have suffered, it almost seems unfair to find such a simple and wrap around way out of our insanity.

36, 19 Many of us have come to believe that the forces of life know what our real needs are and will take care of us when undisturbed by self-will.

One of the things we get to do in recovery is inventory our lives, how we are doing and what we are doing. In fear and desperation, we were often driven to do things that led to shame and guilt. In recovery we are gently led away from obsession and compulsion. It may be that the strong drive to deal with things helped us survive. Today, we have a choice. We can stop, look and listen. We can pray for help from our HP. We can ask our new friends and sponsors for help. All these take out some of the bumps and many of the grinds that used to comprise our lives.

37, 2 Most addicts have strong feelings about their Higher Power and vigorously defend their right to their own understanding of Higher Power. The strength to move into action comes from our Higher Power.

There is the illusion by non-believers that "higher power" is just an excuse to do as we please. The reality of life in the care of a loving, caring, all powerful being is not self-will. It lifts us to better things and gives us the strength and guidance to deal with the worst things that happen to us.

37, 6 Asking for help in specific terms usually precedes getting that help. By opening the gates of our hearts, we become ready to receive the help we need.

This applies to prayer as well as people. Loosening the grip of our egocentric nature makes it more reasonable to just ask for help instead of contriving a way to steal or trick someone into getting what we need. Everyone has different needs and faces different problems. Getting what we need, sometimes even when we need it, is a good sign we are working our N.A. program. Other times, our HP says, no, wait a bit or offers something better. Even when we don't get our way, it usually works out for us. Obsession can be simply habitual desperation. When our bellies are full and our most pressing needs are met, it gets easier to take our time and attend to the details in our daily life.

37. 27 Obviously our way did not work. In utter desperation, we looked for another way. In Narcotics Anonymous, we are told that we can turn our will and our lives over to a care of a God of our own understanding

Essay starts

38, 1 We don't have to be religious. All that is required is a willingness to believe.

It is shocking how easy it is to get the spiritual life once we are willing.

38. 5 We have only to believe what we see with our own eyes in the transformed lives of other N.A. members. That's all it takes -- an open mind.

Essay starts

38, 27 Go off by yourself and say silently, "God, I've made a mess of my life. I can't solve my problems and I ask you to take care of me and show me how to live."

This simple prayer has changed countless lives for the better. These few words show self-awareness, surrender, acceptance, humility, willingness to change, honesty, hope, trust, faith,

simplicity, dedication and devotion. When said with sincerity from the heart, we are no longer spiritually bankrupt.

38, 35 In the Third Step, we simply recognize that there is a force for good in the world and we cooperate with that force. We let good things happen to us.

This incredibly beautiful and inclusive observation opens the doorway to a spiritual life for all kinds of people. In NA, we need to get on a good footing with a God of our understanding. Like many things in life, it doesn't matter where we are at, it matters where we are going. One step at a time, we can move towards new goals in recovery. The road never ends and the learnings are amazing.

Putting what we learn into practice turns up new items to think about and usually lead us to even brighter horizons of discovery and application.

39, 6 If we have come this far in the N.A. program, we have already noticed some change in our lives. However, the change may not be as fast nor as dramatic as we wish.

Astonishingly, almost everyone of us is surprised to find out that gratitude is a muscle instead of an exterior force. We exercise gratitude and find we are able more often to become consciously grateful.

39, 13 We find that we will continue to have living problems.

In time we may see where these 'problems' are part of our learning curve and lead us to understandings we could get no other way. We may even reach the point where they are no longer problems but simply challenges we take in stride as we continue to live in the solution. Pain can be a motivator, in that when we don't clearly look at our wounds that still can be haunting us after years of clean time time ,we may need to search inside a little more with our sponsor, with other members, and to continue to remember that we cannot do this alone.

39, 22 We have surrendered our will and our lives to the care of a power greater than ourselves. We are now a part of the Ultimate Reality which has brought Order out of Chaos.

As long as your belief works for you, we are happy for you. We are serious about finding a loving Higher Power. There are many lower powers.

Our Program only asks that this Power being loving, caring and greater than we are. Ascribing the characteristics of loving and caring is not difficult for us because we certainly had surrendered our lives to a vengeful harmful, even killing, power greater than we are, addiction. To surrender to our growing understanding of a Higher Power which will not only do us no harm but actually help us to relieve our pain is easy.

39, 28 Day by day we discover the magnitude of the Third Step.

If we put pennies in a jar every day we are clean, the jar would fill to overflowing, We would have to get another jar! After some time, we would have a row of jars. We have countless opportunities to make bad choices and regrettable decisions each and every day. Not making these poor choices becomes a tidal wave of goodness touching every current and ripple of our lives. Recovery gives us back our losses while eliminating new mistakes as we go.

40, 15 We are finally beginning to become honest when we admit that our addiction had whipped us and that we need help.

When we first arrive to NA, it is suggested to pray, go to meetings, don't use, and change our entire lives. It was also suggested while in meetings to listen to the similarities and not the differences. By remaining open-minded we may hear someone that moves us in a way that we can consider that addict as our sponsor. It is only when we ask for help that we can receive it. None of us are mind readers. Others can help us in our recovery but we must be willing to meet them halfway.

As we become more closely involved with others we will learn to share our pain and it will lessen. As addicts, we are all wounded individuals, to one degree or another, some of us may be more wounded than others. This does not make us different. It really makes us one in a kind, that is the true meaning of anonymity. We are the same in kind. As we continue to get closer and develop relationships with other addicts the more we will see this to be true. This is the way we develop long lasting friendships

40, 21 Ask anyone who has some time on the program and who has the kind of life you want for yourself, they will tell you that the Fourth Step was a turning point in their lives.

In our early days, many members viewed the Fourth Step as upsetting and many felt pain and upset. The reality is Step Four takes us out of our old habits and ways of dealing with life. We are free to examine and evaluate what we want to keep and what no longer fits our life.

41, 21 You may approach the Fourth Step in a number of ways. It is advisable that before you start, go over the first Three Steps with your sponsor.

We need our surrender, belief and our decision to let our Higher Power care for us - lest we try to take control and work our Fourth Step on self-will! If this happens to you, just take a break and think about how it feels to push harder on something that is not working. Slow down and think about your HP until you get that 'cared for feeling.' Remember, we don't want to lose our assets, just the attributes and habits of mind and action that make trouble for us.

42, 18 When we pray and take action it always goes better for us.

Turning one's will and life over to our Higher Power grants us access to great power and tremendous vision. In recovery we can use this Power to build our new lives. Every day is a new chance to practice our new life and do things differently.

42, 26 We examine in depth our relationships with people, places and situations asking ourselves what we have demanded of these relationships. Often the answers will show that we are placing unreasonable demands on reality. WE find that we are demanding other people to stop being who they are.

What we demand of others, we need to be willing to give of ourselves. Setting ourselves above those claim to care for is not only bad manners, it angers people instead of helps.

43, 2 This Fourth Step can be a wonderful adventure, reviewing our past performance and our present behavior to see what we want to keep and what we want to be rid of.

The 'rubber hits the road' when we work our Fourth Step. Steps Four through Seven make real the personality changes we have been seeking. The journey of a thousand miles begins with that one simple step forward.

43, 11 We are not going to be perfect. If we were perfect, we would not be human.

In all organizations there are ranking systems. Sometimes these are simple roles that are employed without sanctions or coercion. The mental plane is full of surface appearances and labels. Anonymity allows principles to emerge where we all get to work together for our mutual satisfaction and benefit. Perfection - there can be no perfection in the final sense of accomplishment. As living beings, we always have a way to go...

43, 31 Many of us, before we take Step Five, fear that God will turn away from us, when we reveal ourselves to Him.

There are plenty of curves our disease will throw at us to keep us worried and fearful. We have to look to our oldtimers to see what they have learned. They share that the process of spiritual growth is never ending. The higher we climb the mountain of spiritual growth and recovery the more mountain appears before us.

As soon as we think we are approaching the top of the mountain, we see a little more appear before our very eyes!

44, 8 For years, we avoided seeing ourselves as we are.

After years of masking our feelings, we begin the program scattered and hurting. Our beginnings are full of anxiety, fear and apprehension. We may search for a reason to continue staying clean at all. If we stay clean, we began hearing stories we can relate to. Seeing members looking more healthy than we've have felt in many years, we start believing in the hope we are starting to experience.

A few weeks into abstinence, our thoughts are beginning to clear some and we can see, feel and hear a part of the true us returning. "There is hope for us also", we exclaim! With this in our forefront we sometimes trudge, sometimes gleefully forge ahead in our new way.

44, 23 We must carefully choose the person who is to hear our Fifth Step.

Like all things spiritual, our Higher Power gives us lots of helpful guidance in this area. We pray for our HP to guide us to the right person! We want someone who cares about us and yet is able to be honest with us. We find someone we trust will keep our Fourth Step secrets confidential. Also, sharing with God, ourselves and another human being does not mean we give that person the right to judge us one way or the other.

45, 7 There is a danger that we will minimize or rationalize away our part in situations.

To do our inventory, we may use a practice that works for many experienced members. Just divide the process into two or more parts so you can write out whatever comes to mind and when you stop writing, take a short break and then review what you have written. You have plenty of time to add and remove so that your input makes good sense, at least to you! The trouble with minimizing or rationalizing our inventory is it gives the illusion that you have done an inventory! At best you have begun the inventory process. Your life, the quality of your life, is at stake here. When we addicts begin to feel badly, we are apt to go into a downhill plunge that ends in relapse. Just monitoring and tracking things that bother us as we go along our way allows us the opportunity to change.

If we get out of the habit of daily inventory, we suggest just resuming the process. The idea that we are 'behind' just makes us confused and may act to keep us from even trying!

45, 11 This Step must cut into our character defects and expose our motives and our actions for what they really were. We have no right to expect these things to reveal themselves.

The saying, “How come everything I let go of has claw marks all over it?” lampoons the way we tend to cling to our established habit patterns. Since Step Five continues the inventory process begun in Step Four, it helps us sort out our assets and liabilities. To make this clear, liabilities are things that cost us plenty without delivering anything worth keeping. Inventory is what leads to our personal spiritual awakening.

46, 8 We cannot make these changes alone. We need our Higher Power’s help, and the help of the Narcotics Anonymous Fellowship.

One of the greatest blessings in the NA 12 Steps is realizing our HP is always with us and always on our side! This is where “Never Alone” comes from. Some of us constantly pray, “God I need your help. I don’t have to power. Please help me.”

NA also means “Need Answers” which our Higher Power is willing to give us if we learn to listen to the still small quiet voice inside. We can also get answers by asking more experienced members to share their experience, strength and hope with us. The importance of a wide support network comes into bearing here. By building relationships with many members, we build a repository of strength and experience to draw upon in troubling times.

46.20 Do we really want to be rid of our old resentments, our angers, our fears? Do we really understand that they are a deadly poison in the heart of an addict?

Argue for your limitations and they are yours forever. Most all of us have a few complaints about things that bother us when we get clean. We will never be happy until we get rid of our resentments, anger and fear. Much of our concerns stem from our inability to surrender and our lack of a belief in a loving, caring higher power. Every time we eliminate something that blocks our happiness, we make room for something good to take its place.

46, 22 Many of us cling to our fears, doubts, and self-loathing or hatred of others, because there is a certain distorted security in familiar pain.

These attributes have a way of hanging on for addicts. That is why NA is a day at a time program. Our personal list of NA basics are so important to the formation of “new habits.” How regularly we find ourselves thinking we have come a quite a ways in recovery only to realize we were thinking unkind thoughts about other members who were not going the way we wanted them to go! We are lucky if we catch ourselves before we begin to work a vengeance on our fellows. When we forgive others, we may find we are really forgiving ourselves!

47, 10 This is a Step of willingness. That is the spiritual principle of Step Six.

This principle is also what we find in Step Three. Without willingness what do we have? We must become willing and have a desire for us to get clean and to continue to stay clean. When we become ready to try a new way of life. Life has become easier rather than the pain of fighting life.

Willingness is a state of readiness to get into the solution, replacing depression, anxiety and self-pity.

47.13 Being human we will of course fall short. We still get mad and still feel hurt, especially if we are too hungry, angry, lonely, tired, or too serious (H.A.L.T.S).

While our human condition is subject to limitations, when we learn and practice spiritual principles we stop running into obstacles that trip us up and prevent our human joy and freedom. As addicts who have experience hell on earth, happiness and comfort seem like impossible goals for us. HALTS gives us a simple way to identify where some of our negative feelings come from. We will catch ourselves thinking some negative stuff and realize it is only fatigue or hunger that tries to assign our internal feelings to some outside force. .

47. 22 The breakdown of old ideas and old ways seems to be beyond our conscious control. The only control of the situation we seem to have is a choice of acceptance.

Critical thinking is one of the abilities that comes with recovery. Critical thinking is not necessarily negative. It just holds up something like a thought, feeling or perception to the light of a new understanding. We can then decide to include or exclude items once we have had the opportunity to think it over. What we learn increases our ability to learn more. One of the “pay offs” of learning is we get to a point where we can talk about almost anything without fear or anger. By doing these things we are no longer chained or limited to our past low levels of understanding. We choose to accept only things that we have gone over in our hearts and minds.

47, 27 The tools we use to maintain our willingness are practice and prayer. How sincerely we work Step Six will be proportionate to our desire for change.

Every member of NA has experienced the desire for recovery before they got clean. Practice gives us a way to get better by repeating our efforts until we get it right. Prayer sets us in the mood to receive without putting up a fight what we are going after. Our efforts are based on our desire for recovery. This is what gives us the power we need to work all 12 Steps.

48, 12 Having decided we want God, as we understood Him, to relieve us of the useless or destructive aspects of our personalities, we have arrived at the Seventh Step.

This Step is the 'game changer' because we finally leave our defects behind. Because everyone who works the 12 Steps is human, we have to take apart the illusion we are in control by making an inventory list, sharing it with someone and becoming willing before we ask our higher power to remove our defects. Defects are one thing and the ways we fall short of our goals are our shortcomings. Like changing a flat tire on a car, we first have to realize we have a flat, find the tools and a spare tire and then go through the process of correction. These things have to be done in a certain order. Addicts seem to try to do it all at once, like snapping their fingers.

48, 21 The key to this Step is an understanding of the humility. Humility is a part of staying clean, as food and water are to staying alive.

Ego is so pervasive and tricky, we can be really selfish and not even realize. Cultivating humility by praying to have our egos reduced to a level that gets the garbage taken out without demanding the whole world do it our way. Like most addicts when I first started with NA, some of the lingo threw me. Surrender to win? Let go and let God? Routinely expanding our positions and ideas until they become unworkable paints us into many corners. Different information about surrender and driving home the point that it is the losing battles we stop fighting helped me with surrender. Getting some new ideas and changing my belief allowed me to see where a higher power could cover bases I couldn't reach because my human arm wasn't long enough. Well, that actually began to make sense. And it goes.

I realize now that humility is giving God credit for the things God does and still be set on ready when something comes up I can do. When I meet or have contact with someone I feel is humble, they seems steady and solid. Competent. Yet they lack a certain presumption and arrogance that indicates they are self-bound and apt to overdo things. It limits my co-existence with them.

Humility is usually brought up along with patience and tolerance. All defects start out as virtues and go overboard into trying to try to do things our way without bothering to hear what they are trying to say. Toning myself down, listening and thinking through makes a big difference, more in focus.

48, 30 It wasn't until we made a real mess of our lives that we realized that we couldn't do it alone.

Being clean clears our vision and increases our ability to hear what others are saying. It may be that the isolation that characterizes our disease comes from the many, many times we wake up when the drugs wear off and look around for all the things we have to answer for. Then, we go around saying, "Hey man. Sorry I did that, it was the dope not me." Like the using gives us a smoke screen to avoid personal responsibility. Clean, we can string together events as they occur in our lives and see more vividly how one thing leads to all the rest. It may take awhile,

and that's ok. Healing should not be a rush job. It takes time clean for recovery to penetrate past our surface issues into the depths of our being but the result is the workable, more complete and satisfying being we become.

49, 2 If the defects we have discovered are real and we have a chance to be rid of them, we would surely experience a sense of well being when we rid ourselves of them.

Recovery is not something imposed on us from the outside. That is probably one of the reasons NA works for us. It is an inside job. It is our desire for recovery that propels us and our desire to know ourselves better and discover what our real self is like. Having habitually done things a certain way makes them familiar and somewhat 'normal' at least to us. The more we get in touch with what 'defective' actually means, the more embarrassment sets in and more happy we are not to have to live that way anymore.

49, 10 However we want to handle it, we go all the way. Think of what we have to lose! As soon as we feel ourselves willing, we should go ahead and ask God to remove our shortcomings.

We gain momentum as relief replaced reluctance and we realize we are not going to miss those damn defects! Their removal makes room for effective habits and routines that allow our real selves to come out and take over. Our ego may want to jump in and wallow in the glory but the grace of God helps us remember when all this recovery stuff felt weird. In the present we experience the changes as improvements and not hindrances. We are free to go and see and do things that have long been beyond our reach. Surrender works because when we get up off our knees, our feet are finally on the ground!

49, 22 We must puncture our egos and realize that we have much more work to do. When someone points out a shortcoming, our first reaction is one of defensiveness.

We need to realize that someone cares enough about us to show us our character defects and then find the willingness to take a look at them. It is only with awareness, acceptance and action that we have any hope of changing. We learn to pause instead of instantly react, think about our responses and what is the right thing to do in accordance with our growing understanding of spiritual principles and only then take action. It is this momentary pause before action that helps redirect efforts in a direction that is not only good for ourselves but often for those we love and care about.

49, 31 This is our road to spiritual growth, to change our character, day by day, to gradually, carefully and simply pull ourselves out of the isolation and loneliness of addiction into this mainstream of useful Fellowship.

Instead of following an academic approach to recovery subject to the ebbs and flows of trends within the treatment industry, we follow a sensible set of principled Steps that lead us reliably and predictably into exactly the things we need to work on to complete our fractured

personalities and gain the habits and associations needed to live our new lives. Some of our growth can be expressed in words and many are in the realm of feelings that do not fit into the little boxes of language. Our hugs and body language convey our feelings along with what words come to us. Finding out and participating with others going through similar changes keeps us rolling forward. We finally realize what it mean to be be never alone.

50, 10 The last five Steps of Narcotics Anonymous, the Eighth through the Twelfth, are the “get out and live” Steps.

There are many references and correlations within the Twelve Steps of NA. One to Three and Ten to Twelve match-up to open the doorway to recovery and to maintain your new life. The six Steps from Four to Nine directly address mechanisms that help us change. The quotation addresses the rock over from the first six to the last six. The changes within make the changes outside stick and help us work forward with our Program. It just seems to have worked out that the first Three lead us from surrender to a state of empowerment that is clearly miraculous. And the last Three represent an almost totally spiritual daily life that gives expression and increase of what is best in each of us and continues to help us change for the better and better. In between, there are three pairs of Steps that go together. Four and Five bring what’s bothering us out into the open. Six and Seven open the doorway to a new life by appealing to our Higher Power to remove defects that no longer have a place in our lives. It takes our willingness to allow do this for us without the injury that would come from having our defects forcibly taken away. As we grow what has been wrong with us becomes ever more visible and clear.

50, 28 We had to feel better internally before we could even bear to think about whom we had harmed and how we had harmed them, and exactly what was the way we perceived ourselves.

There is a lot of love and sensitivity built into our NA Twelve Steps. They come in a given order that helps insure we are ready for the Step we are working at each step forward. It is rare to find language fitting into the real lives of people in desperate trouble and hopeless states. And it is very supportive and caring that along with each Step we can see how others have gone through the same things. So, as we progress, we are also woven into a Fellowship of men and women just like us, all on the road to a new life clean.

51, 4 Our purpose is to achieve freedom from the guilt we have carried so far, with so much pain, so that we can look the world in the eye with neither aggressiveness nor fear.

When we are becoming new people, it makes us brave as our curiosity overcomes our negative expectations. We addicts are a curious bunch, always wanting to know how things work. It probably began as a way of feeling like we were gaining some control over life and all the

confusion that kept us racing in circles. When a person is less afraid they stop running and start asking questions.

51, 13 The thing that will make us better is to clean up our lives by relieving ourselves of guilt. The Eighth Steps is a mighty stride away from a lie dominated by guilt and remorse.

The willingness to admit fault and release the chains that have held us back from re-experiencing painful guilt and shame is real movement. Life no longer has to be the way it has been. It is one thing to think about freedom and it is quite another to walk down new roads in our lives. Keeping our wits about us and staying with the one day at a time approach to the new life is a real good idea. If we move too fast, we make it easy to take a fall.

51, 27 We make our list, or take it from our Fourth Step and add to it any more people we can think of and we face that list honestly and openly and examine our fault.

There is a simple way to look at this Step. There are stories like the one about a princess who could feel a stone beneath a bunch of mattresses. Another phrase refers to a burr under the saddle. If they didn't bother us, they probably wouldn't be on our Eighth Step list! When we reach way down and wiggle them loose, we have settled old issues and are free to find different ways to spend our time and energy. Putting closure on things from the past frees up our future. Clean is not only time, it is the freed up energy to find new ways to live without endlessly repeating what doesn't work for us!

52, 6 A problem many of us seem to have with the Eighth Step and the admission of the harm we did is the belief we were victims, not victimizers, in our addiction.

The endless quest to look good and sound innocent avails us nothing here. Getting real and finding the source of our pain is worth the tiny jet of honesty it takes to really look at what we have been up to in active addiction and early recovery. But instead of increasing our feelings of doom, we experience elation and joy. Whatever it was, the main thing is to stop feeding the engines that produce such results. When we stagger out of a drug induced fog, we often get things backwards and fail to realize how much of a part we played in painful memories of the past.

52, 21 "The main thing this Step does for us is to build awareness that, little by little, we are gaining new attitudes about ourselves, and how we deal with other people."

Many of us find a bonus in the Ninth Step when we avoid situations where amends might be needed at a later date for what is happening in the present. It is easier to get real and be honest in the present tense than to carry bad feelings in the past tense. And it seems to be a principle that when we move one way, we free ourselves in the other. So a little relief leads to more relief and more relief frees us from the shame and guilt that has been chasing us all along.

52, 25 We want to get free of our fear, but we don't wish to do so at the price of anyone.

We do not want to create more difficulty and pain for others to push away our own embarrassment and disgust at the way we were living. That would only lead us back to feeling self-destructive about ourselves. Instead we move forward on a daily basis making amends as needed. Others see us as a different person. Without the fear, we new motivation from the good feelings that come with raising our heads and examining the roles we are playing to make sure we are not leaving damage behind us while we think we are going forward. Wherever possible we build out new lives on solid ground.

53, 5 When it gets to the point that we cannot hold the hurt any longer, amends will be made.

The Twelve Steps follow a natural sequence and move from one necessary focus to the next. The need for amends comes from inner pain, guilt and shame. Some part of us knows there is something that we and only we can straighten. Whether it involves feelings, money or things, by our amends brings order from the chaos. We feel better. Those who receive our amends feel better. Unanswered questions may produce disorder again and again for years without resolution. Putting closure on things allows everyone involved to go on with their lives. For example, at some point we took something that wasn't our. The situation requires someone who 'owned' the stolen item, a manager, who will wonder who took the items (s). Other innocent parties may be fired, accused, sanctioned even though they did nothing wrong. This could happen at work, in a family household and the same paradigm or template may fit countless scenarios. The truth we share removes tensions, allows for restoration of whatever was taken, and everybody involved is off the hook so to speak.

53, 24 Pride, fear, and procrastination often seem as impossible barrier and stand in our way of progress and growth through the Ninth Step.

A thorn in our foot will keep hurting until it is removed. We may even fear the pain of pulling out the thorn and put off removal until it begins to fester and redden to the point of blood poisoning. One thing is sure: once the source of the pain is removed, the healing process begins. The same thing happens with various kinds of disorders stemming for our past behavior. Any form of meanness and wishing ill to others comes back on us to blindside us with new problems.

54, 18 The unconditional love we experience will rejuvenate our will to live and each positive move on our part will be matched by an unexpected opportunity.

Many members get clean, stay clean and begin to work the 12 Steps of NA only to get bogged down in details and forget the larger picture recovery brings to light. Recovery is about freedom and the help comes from many sources which have common denominators like those who help us share our feelings and courage. They respect what we are doing because they have gone or are going through the same things themselves.

54, 24 We as addicts, suffer from a problem deeper than the drugs we took. Because of this, we must live by spiritual principles. Step Ten and all the Steps are to be applied to every area of our lives.

Starting with some basic touchstones of recovery, we learn about how to view the stages of recovery. While one stage blends into the next and all stages are linked up, we clearly start out as newcomers who must learn how we get along in the Fellowship. This stage is not a permanent label confining us to a less-than status. When we experience some of the pink cloud and early lessening of pressure that comes from surrender and the joy of mutual support it can make us almost manic. We all know addiction is a limiting and life threatening disease and yet the good feelings are important to our learning and growing also. As go through these processes we often enjoy helping someone else who is just beginning recovery road.

54. 28 There is no area of our lives that the disease does not affect. The truth is that fear is present in every area of our lives. So, in our experience, the program can and must be worked continuously in every area of our lives.

Just like our blood feeds and cleans our entire body as a natural part of circulation, what we learn in one area is applied in many others. And where we find fault with ourselves, we find the same need for correction in many areas. Each benefits the whole on a continuous basis.

55.4 Step 10 is a continuation of a fearless is a continuation of a fearless and searching look within ourselves in order to repair disorders that fear, pride, jealousy, and other ruinous defects can cause.

It is worth mentioning that the disorders mentioned above involved keeping people at a distance and keeping us at a distance from them. The ongoing problems brought on by addictive disease feeds on itself. Constantly justifying our actions and reactions that caused us problems with people while continually committing the same actions. Our problems beget more problems. When we tell a newcomer to stop making any avoidable decisions, they generally do pretty good. It is when they start 'deciding' again that new upsets occur. Doing nothing is doing something. We find food, shelter and clothing. We are tender in recovery. Some of our seemingly large problems seem small and so the new problems are diminished as we grow comfortable dealing with them.

55, 12 Now that we are clean, we have recognized the advantage of getting our own house in order. We can recognize ourselves as the heart of the problem.

What a relief it was to discover that our lives had become quite unmanageable as a result of our drug use, this was very clear to see. What was really an eye opener, was that after we had been clean for a while, that every attempt at trying to control, life, or to change, or attempt to manipulate a situation, we began to feel the fear and that same feeling of unmanageability that

we experienced when we were using. This is when we discover that surrender is the key, and we are the heart of the problem.

We might recall the serenity prayer at this time, knowing that we cannot change another person, we can only change ourselves and pray for the wisdom to know the difference.

Part of the miracle of recovery is knowing that we can actively participate in our own recovery and cease to be the problem and become a part of the solution.

55, 16 Any thought that we are going to be perfect has to be smashed.

The idea that perfection for humans ignores our experience. If we are willing to surrender and do the best we can, that is enough more often than not. In ourselves, or in our friends, we pray for strength and guidance when overwhelmed by a demand or situation over which we are powerless.

Constantly striving for perfection and falling short can give us fears of not being good enough.

55, 18 The smart ones who argue a lot usually die. The open-minded ones get to live.

Perfection is a fear-based idea. It is harder for more intelligent people to surrender because in our world many things give way to intelligence. There are things that require sensitivity and savvy to understand or 'get' and these are sometimes workless, or are defined by special words that go beyond objects and labels. A loving, caring person is not especially respected in certain parts of our society, yet their value is beyond price.

55. 33 We honestly chalk up our achievements. Thus we get our house in order. We feel more room to grow.

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Begin essay

56. 2 We look at our actions during the day and we practice the art of looking at where we were wrong, considering what we could have done differently, and the amends we need to make.

Essay starts.

56.13 Often ,when we get home, write out a resentment, explaining how we, and how we became angry and the part we played.We find out how we restrain ourselves later , so we don't repeat the action again.

Begin Essay

56.17 We do however , remember that God not us is responsible for our change.

If it were up to us, we would be able to have someone do it for us. In reality, we do have something else helping us change , God. When we finally decide to get clean, get involved in a homegroup, find a sponsor, and begin working the steps ,we let go of our self centered self righteous ways , let go completely and find that we are being changed and we are not doing it. We find that a power greater than ourselves is taking hold and allowing ourselves to be transformed into the person we always wanted to be and never knew how.

56 .25 In step ten we strive for genuine humility. In this humility we can better interact with others.

Begin Essay

56, 26 We are not readily angered, frightened, or maddened by greed or lust. "We remember our part in the divine partnership with God and we are more tolerant and patient with other people.

Essay starts.

56. 30 Step ten is worked while the days ups and downs are fresh in our heads.

Essay Starts

57, 1 A warning about rationalization is that it has killed more of us than anything else.

Many, many members are yet to realize that rationality alone is insufficient for the purposes of a spiritual life. Spiritual is over mentality alone.

57.8 We have defects, but a willingness to live as our Higher Power would have us is freedom.

Begin essay

57.19 It is very important to keep sharing with other people, so that when we come up with a rationalization for negative behavior, we can be told about it.

Essay: One of the things we can't forget is that we cannot be objective with ourselves.

57, 23 "Am I being drawn in by some pattern of fear and resentment?", Am I too tired " "Am I too hungry?" " Is my thinking getting cloudy?" It's a vaccination against insanity on a continuing basis.

In other words, personal, daily inventory is a vaccination against insanity.

57.27 We have discussed the preventative side of tenth step.. The love was there all the time, waiting for us to accept it.

Begin Essay: reactions which often cause regrets later.

58.5 The more often we pause when doubtful and say, "God I don't know what to do. Please teach me."

Begin essay:

58, 10 The Eleventh Step helps us, in the face of a problem, to be aware of God. The underlying principle of this Step is God consciousness. We try not asking for specific things.

Essay starts.

58, 15 A person who has realized their powerlessness and seen the vision the Higher Power has for them will see why we pray only for knowledge of his will for us and the power to carry it out.

Learning spirituality involves study, discussion and listening to what others have to say. Spiritual principles may be based in a Higher Consciousness but the nuts and bolts are learned just like we learn everything else. We hear others share or read something that strikes us in a meaningful way and we try it out to see if it will work for us. Mostly we are amazed to find simple sounding solutions have great power to heal and instruct.

58, 18 Our deepest longings and recurring images of the kind of people we'd like to be are only glimpses of God's will for us.

Later in this paragraph, we read, "It is our own real dreams that come true." To continue the idea that many people seem to know intuitively, God is in all of us. The idea that a supreme all knowing and all powerful creator lives within each of us seems overwhelming to begin with. But as a solution to all our living problems and the resolution to all our thinkings, it certainly fulfills the criteria.

58, 23 When we pray a remarkable thing happens; we find the means, the ways, and energies, to perform tasks for beyond our capabilities. By the surrender of our own power, we gain a far greater power that will see us through.

The truth of this statement bears out the efficacy of our spiritual power being 'higher.' The easy way to say this is that surrender and prayer gives us the 'luck.'

58, 28 It is easy to slip back into our old ways. We have to learn to maintain our new lives on a spiritually sound basis to insure our continued growth and recover. God will not force his goodness on us, but we will receive it if we ask.

Essay starts.

58. 34 Many times, our efforts have produced in us feelings of peace and serenity that we have never known before.

Begin essay

58, 35 We know that in doing God's will, our lives will be fulfilled.

It is one of the quietest yet strongest truths of NA what the Program takes us from insanity and futility to a spiritual awakening wherein we live by spiritual principles and look out for other people. Literally, our overflows into goodness not just for ourselves but for all who come in contact with us. There is a real basis for our sadness and despair when we come to NA seeking help. We have had plenty of failure and confusion. Gradually, as we work our Steps, go to meetings and hear others share, we are re-built into what we were meant to be. It is our dreams, yours and mine, that come true for us. The new understanding of a loving God, freedom from defects and amends with those we have harmed that come from the change inside each one of us.

59, 5 We become spiritually refreshed and are glad to be alive.

We don't sugar coat reality or promise our members that there will be no problems along recovery road. What changes is the way we are inside and the way we react to the happenings in our lives. If you are not spiritually refreshed and glad to be alive, there is usually one or more of the basics that worked for you in the beginning that you have discontinued or forgotten to observe. The spiritual life keeps us pointed in a direction that feeds us helpful information, a new attitude and people who are there for us when we need them. By not reading literature, going to meetings, calling your sponsor and, oh yeah, not using, we lay ourselves open to attack without warning. That's what a relapse is - an attack on our our new lives. Hopelessness and despair are always there, waiting around the corner, and come out when we run out of spiritual food and the opportunities that the Program brings to us.

59, 11 There are those of us who tried to stay clean without the benefit of "having had a spiritual awakening as a result of those steps," and they are no longer with us.

The Program of Narcotics Anonymous is no joke. It is a set of principles we can live by with good results. Through the years we have seen many members put their program on hold while they took care of 'more important things.' Their relationship, their job, their pasttimes and hobbies. They failed to realize for us addicts working the NA Program is a life and death matter. Now, there are those who wind up the NA who are not addicts. A little controlled using convinced and made believers of them and they got back with the program. There are others who stuck with the Program and lived on to better things. The Program is designed to help those who suffer from the disease of addiction and want a new way of life.

59, 26 The first way in which we carry the message is by staying clean with the help of God and the Fellowship. Our new way of living speaks for itself better than our words ever could.

Essay starts.

60, 2 The message is meaningless unless we live it. If we do live it, we give it more meaning with our lives than any words can express.

Essay starts.

60, 5 Learning the art of helping others when it is appropriate, without creating resentments, is a marvelous benefit of the N.A. program.

Essay starts.

60, 7 Remarkably, the Twelve Steps guide us from a state of humiliation and despair to a state wherein we are able to act as instruments of God's will.

Essay starts.

60, 16 We give freely and gratefully of our time, our services and our experiences to our fellow addicts.

Essay starts.

60, 19 We know that the more eagerly we wade in and work to stay clean, ...(the higher we're going to get and) the richer our spiritual awakening will be!

Essay starts.

60.24 \In the twelfth step, we practice the spiritual principle of giving away the N.A. message of recovery in order to keep it.

Begin essay

60, 35 We don't set ourselves up as God. That is why it is spiritual. We get to be an instrument of God's grace in action.

Essay starts.

61, 2 Those of us who do service work are the luckiest people on God's earth! Those who have been in the pits of despair, now strive to help other people to find a new and better way to live.

Essay starts.

61, 25 We no longer wish to participate in the problem. We now serve God. In this manner of service, we renew our vow to turn our will and lives over to the care of God

The brightness and pain of active addiction does more than make us say, "Ouch." Hey, it really hurts. With the pain comes the willingness. Most people realize there are ups and downs in life. If you have drifted away from the things that brought you freedom and relief in the beginning of recovery, you do not have to take a fall to get back with the program, just do what it says here: "Renew your vow to turn your will and live over to the care of God." That's all it takes. Just say the words to yourself a few times.

62, 20 Trusting others doesn't come naturally to us, but we must learn to trust because an addict alone is in bad company. The needed strength wasn't there until we found N.A., which showed us how to make faith work for us.

What a statement! Faith does work for us but we have to learn a little to get it right. Faith is evidence of things unseen. But the difference shows in how we make new choices and how we react to events and circumstances. Positive expectation may be a big part of it. Keeps our minds open to positive outcomes. If we let ourselves believe our situation is hopeless, it is hard to see good opportunities.

62, 30 Remember, we didn't become addicted in one day. We can't possibly solve all our problems at once, no matter how much energy we have. Take it easy! The only way we recover is to apply what we learn from each other, on a daily basis.

When we get away from the simple, true, proven program of NA, we can drift into endless complication. Keep it simple is more than just a neat phrase! The NA Program is assembled out of the combined experiences of men and women who found answers in the 12 Steps and work within the boundaries and principles of the 12 Traditions. To let our minds get fuzzy and drift away from what works for us, oftentimes the only thing that works for us, is insanity rejoined!

61, 2 Those of us who do service work are the luckiest people on God's earth!

Service is an expression of gratitude. We are truly grateful for the wonderful gift of recovery. We consider it a privilege to give nameless selfless service to Narcotics Anonymous. Whether we help a newcomer, make coffee, sponsor someone, bring a meeting to a shut-in, serve as chairperson for a meeting, become a trusted servant for area, region, H&I, phone lines or other positions, we consider ourselves lucky. By working the Steps we have learned the joys of living in the present in accordance with spiritual principles.

61, 34 Living just for today relieves the burden of the past and alleviates fear of the future.

We find guilt is a large part of the burden of our past. Working Steps 8 and 9 teaches us forgiveness and relieves us of this load. We have fears about the future and worry about things that have not yet happened. This tends to ruin our present. By living here now in the present, we can make the absolute most of this moment. We learn to live in the solution. When we live by spiritual principles, continually doing the right thing now, our past becomes pleasurable memories and the future looks golden. [used May 26]

62, 20 Trusting others doesn't come naturally to us, but we must learn to trust because an addict alone is in bad company.

Essay starts.

62, 23 We had a lot of energy, but we channeled it into self-destruction.

We now have a choice and can choose to channel our energy into things that bring us ongoing happiness and joy. The more we do this, the more we feel good about our recovery. If we are not busy making these choices, probably get ungrateful and begin the old whining and ingratitude that characterized our active addiction. Eventually we will say, "I am clean but I haven't changed any." Start over today! Freedom means we don't have to languish in our pain and misery. We do the best we can on a daily basis and that leads us into a happy destiny!

62, 32 The only way we recover is to apply what we learn from each other, on a daily basis. Our growth is a lifetime process.

The more we learn the more we are capable of learning. Generally, our next best move is right in front of us and we don't recognize it because we dislike and distrust openness and honesty. When we try something new and it works for us, we become curious about checking out some other scary changes!

63.1 Addiction is physical, mental, and spiritual . Therefore, we believe that we must develop faith in a higher Power Before we can hope to recover from its destruction.

Begin essay

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63, 3 When we have a strong faith in a Power greater than ourselves, and use that faith in our daily lives, that Power will be able to reach us and supply us with the strength and guidance that we need to recover.

Faith is visible in the changes we can see in our lives. Staying open to what other members share is a good practice because it gives us dozens of windows into the recovery experience of others. There is no end to what we can learn and practice. Sometimes it takes a few tries to get it right. Nobody recovers overnight. We practice what we learn and may have to wait a while to see the results. Hey, we waited for the dope man! Don't give up before the miracle.

63, 29 Spiritual and religious is one of our most basic principles. Each of us are free to work out our own concept of God, or reject the concept of a God.

Like many other freedom, the power is in the right of choice. If our old ideas of a higher power did not produce the results we wanted, that is encouragement to go looking for a new understanding!

64, 9 Three "musts" are honesty, open-mindedness, and willingness to try. Agnostics and atheists generally start out by just talking to "Whatever's there."

This daily meditation stresses the importance of being open and experimental. There are ways of learning positive ways to investigate and learn more before committing ourselves. Because of our societal limitations, we may not know we are free to really take a look around, read books, ask others to share their experience before adopting or committing themselves to their own personal understanding of a higher power. When you have your own belief, you begin to capitalize higher power. A Higher Power of your own understanding is the key to ongoing recovery and spiritual growth.

64, 13 There is a spirit or an energy that can be felt in the meetings, and it is sometimes the newcomer's first perception of God.

Recalling our feelings and impressions from our initial contact with NA helps us keep our minds open to new ideas and target what we really want and expect from recovery. That little lift in the chest and sitting up straight expresses the openness and attention to learn more about the NA 12 Steps and Traditions. We may not even have words for it yet, but it is this desire for self-betterment that drives all our recovery.

64.19 We no longer blame God and others for our own problems, and see that our problems have been of our own making.

Begin Essay

64.22 After we accept that we created our own hell and that there is a God that wants to help us, we begin to make progress in solving our problems.

Begin Essay:

64, 28 One way to develop our conscious contact with God is to make up a “gratitude list,” count our blessings and thank our Higher Power for them.

This kind of applied spirituality may be new to us. Our discomfort and disease has blotted out our view of reality, selecting only for the negative and unpleasant. That’s why our newfound hope is surprising. Active addiction removed our hope, bit by bit until there was nothing left.

65, 9 Rigorous honesty is the most important tool we have in learning to deal with the past and to live today.

Like sharpening a knife on a wet-stone, we ‘hone’ our daily habit patterns to re-route our lives into a form that we can live with without having to make amends later on. Honesty appears to have the same root word.

65.13 Our lack of fear and our new found faith serves as a firm foundation for courage in the future .

begin essay

65, 23 We have never before experienced gut-level honesty because we covered up our feelings by using.

Most often we were unaware of avoiding our true feelings because using distorted our feelings with our using. Adapting to this bizarre mish-mash of feeling became our daily view of the world. Recovery is re-adapting to the world as it is, so there is no need to run and hide they way we used to.

65, 33 Managing our own lives got us to the program of Narcotics Anonymous. What we knew about living when we got here had almost killed us.

Our ‘shared’ existence in NA factors in what has been learned and found workable in recovery by our fellow members. Human beings are programed to mimic the behavior of the crowd they spend their time with in everyday life. Living clean and practicing our spiritual principles opens doors and modify our addictive conditioning in ways we may have trouble seeing on a daily basis - but we can see and feel the results of the changes.

66, 2 Being open-minded allows us to hear something that might save our lives.

If this sounds pretty dramatic, it is. Most of us have developed defense mechanisms that keep us locked up in a narrow, defensive and lonely point of view. Our new found hope opens many doors for us, starting with believing change is possible. Hope is like a flame that warms us. Even if it is small in the beginning, the warmth makes a difference and feels good so we learned to trust our feelings and go with them as our life steadily improves. Sometimes it is hard for us to

see the old ways creeping in and don't accurately notice we can begin to work our program in reverse - using our tools to justify and condone behaviour of self-righteousness and isolation.

66, 9 We no longer have to make fools of ourselves by standing up for some non-existent values.

Pretending to be more than we are is a fear-based behavior that seemed to protect us from negative judgements by others as to our conduct or behavior. Hiding from the truth is not necessary if our house is in order.

66, 18 Honesty, open-mindedness, and willingness to try, work hand in hand. The lack of one of these principles in our programs can kill us.

Many people who call themselves members may be under a false impression that addiction is not a disease that can kill us. Rocking chair recovery can appear to work for a while, but it may leave us without the tools and principles that comprise the NA Program. Many members rest on the wide-spread meetings and body of literature as if there is nothing left to do for the growth and continuance of NA. Nothing could be further from the truth. When we stop working the Program, the Program stops working! Without knowledge of who we are and where we come from we remain children.

66, 23 Remember too that H.O.W. are spiritual principles which mean that they can be relied on to get us out of trouble that dishonesty, closed-mindedness and unwillingness go us into.

Essay starts.

67, 7 We were in the depths of despair, degradation and lost in a destructive chaos. WE came in puking, sweating and shaking. Some of us stayed. Was it through our own merit? Wh think not! Our way got us here. Recovery was done through the help of others, the tools they shared with us, and a Higher Power.

It is oh so easy to forget just how bad it was and what it felt like to have no hope, no way out and no one to turn to. Almost all humans select for a softer, easier, way. The difference for us is that that way offers only the illusion of security because we put only a coat of paint over our old behavior and call it clean! A softer, easier, way can kill us because it offers no change in how we live our lives.

67, 20 We react angrily as recovering addicts if anyone tells us what to do. In N.A. meetings, We share what it was like in our practicing addiction, our suffering that brought us to the turning point and how we stay clean today.

One of the unspoken facts of our clean life and recovery is there are people in the rooms who do not share our enthusiasm, energy and willingness to commit to our Program. They may go further with their program and realize the stakes are their lives, their happiness and their dreams or lose all three. One general statement stands out clearly and that is the Program as we know it was built by people who lived it and wrote it down in the Basic Text. Those who have attempted to 'own' and take credit for our literature are almost completely in the dark as to how it was written and the spirituality involved! So, in our daily recovery we are free to embrace, learn and apply the deepest and most loving NA light we can find and apply to our lives.

68, 2 This force in the meetings isn't just the people there, but also something within the people. We return to these meetings and use them like medicine in the form of unconditional love.

There is a strong spirituality in the love we share at our NA meetings. We express as best we can what we are doing in our day to day lives and the way we use the principles of NA to deal with things that used to have us on the run. Hearing some of the hair-raising episodes that occur in the lives of our friends will automatically encourage us and change the way we do things. Sometimes it helps us in our daily living just to stop and get in that "NA state of mind" in the midst of whatever is going on. We focus better, we recall things we need to deal with life and we are more honest and considerate of others. As we succeed using NA principles, they become woven into the fabric of our lives.

68, 13 Finally, throughout our lives, we surround ourselves with fellow members who continue to let us know we can count on them. One of the advantages of the N.A. program is that it places us in an intimate, regular contact with recovering addicts who can most understand and help us in our recovery.

As newcomers we, sometimes fearfully, share our problems and feel a deep kinship with our predecessors as they share their actual experience and solutions to our problems.

68, 31 To us, at first, it feels like insanity to give another person knowledge of our pain. As we become more closely involved with others we will learn to share our pain and it will lessen. Part of the horror of addiction is being cut off from this human experience. Our fears and guilt kept us from receiving the benefits afforded to every day people.

Essay starts.

69, 7 Being able to serve as an instrument of a loving God and participation in the recovery of others keeps a sense of wonder and gratitude in our lives. Giving comfort and encouragement to others encourages and comforts us.

Essay starts.

69, 18 If you want to change your life -- risk sharing! It is by taking risks we have almost lost our lives, by asking for help in the same way, we can change.

Essay starts.

69, 29 It is a way of life for the addicts who want to learn to live clean and have discovered one another. We share our mental and spiritual resources for the good of everyone.

Essay starts.

69, 33 Recovering addicts take great pleasure in helping other suffering addicts recover. Recovery as found in Narcotics Anonymous must come from within and no one can get clean for anyone else.

Essay starts.

70, 5 The Steps guide us into our place in society. We begin by straightening our internal disorder and obtaining release from the defects that prevent us from being all we should be.

Essay starts.

70, 11 We emphasize setting our own house in order and trying to do more than our part. We trust in our Higher Power to give us strength and to meet our needs.

Essay starts.

70, 16 If we're not grateful for the things we've got, we won't be grateful for the things we are yet to receive.

Essay starts.

70, 26 In the past we have relied on desperation to give us the strength to periodically re-order our lives. There is another way.

Essay starts.

70, 29 When we accept that we are responsible for our problems, we realize that we can be equally responsible for our solutions.

True freedom starts when we take full responsibility for our actions, the consequences of our actions, our feelings and our attitudes. We no longer are victims, either of others or of circumstances. We become free to "be here now" finding the solution to our problems without wasting time or effort on how we got here. Having the ability to live in the solution is a result of incorporating spiritual principles in every aspect of our lives.

70, 33 Being clean is abnormal to us, and we must learn how to live in an on-going manner. A great magic is found when we help others. As clean addicts in the Fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous, we help ourselves by helping others.

Essay starts.

71, 1 Our attention focuses on the solutions, and our old ideas break up and dissolve like icebergs in the tropics. When the compulsion to use is lifted from us, and we begin to think of others before ourselves, a true miracle begins. Working the steps, practicing the principles and using the tools, we begin to see ourselves in a new light.

Essay starts.

71, 9 We put spiritual living first and exercise patience, tolerance and humility in our daily lives. The further we get from the last pill, fix, drink or take, the more we see of our past and more we realize the miracle of the release from our disease of addiction.

Essay starts.

71, 18 Many of our dreams, forgotten and obscured by our addiction, return and help us regain the sense of wonder and excitement at the miracle of living clean. The old compulsions fade and the habits of mind associated with addiction weaken and are broken. A great many things become possible for us. Since we live clean and grow, we are able to take our place in the world.

Essay starts.

71, 21 In dealing with the other people in our lives, we develop a loving attitude. We forgive more easily, anger more slowly, expect less, and give more....

Essay starts.

71, 26 If we want to reap the benefits of staying clean, we find it necessary to take continual inventories of ourselves. Hidden fears and needs are still potential driving forces. Just because we don't recognize fear or anger doesn't mean that it isn't influencing our lives. We found it important to examine places where we grew angry or our beliefs were tested.

In the spirit of reciprocity we must continually look inside to receive the benefits we are seeking for our lives. For so long we were living in darkness. In order to place love in our lives we need to objectively see the darkness that covers our spirit. This takes continual surveying and plotting new courses to steer our way to a more healthy lifestyle. Once seeing the darkness does not serve us, we replace it with with a loving attribute. If we desire different results, we learn to vary our approach to get different results.

We can do this as often as needed to find what works best for us in our creative freedom. When something we are experimenting with does not serve us well, we inventory again seeking another idea that may serve us better. Each avenue finds something else we may use for finding our freedom.

We also may take each perspective we have found, mix and match to find what works best for us in the moment.

We find that it is important to remain flexible, remembering that the only constant is change and that nothing should ever be perceived as being set in stone

It takes continual searching and fearless inventory to replace the unhealthy attributes with the light we seek. To find light we needed to seek the light we had covered in darkness.

An inventory is a tool to take stock of our assets and liabilities. Seeing and hearing clearly gives us a chance to take a reading on where we are and what we are doing.

71, 35 Truth seems to be something that is impossible to understand until it becomes obvious. Truth is something we never suspected until we knew it. There are no exceptions--only incomplete truths. Everything we know about truth is subject to revision, especially what we know about truth.

Essay starts.

When we close our eyes to the truth , we deny ourselves the new possibilities that come with our new way of life. Freedom comes from not just staying clean , but in our ability to surrender unconditionally. When we learn to just let go, we experience a freedom , many of us have never experienced. The only way to do this is not just for the day , but right now in the moment. It takes practice , but is attainable.

72, 5 Another desirable quality is love. We love the ambitious for they can inspire us; we love the failures for they can teach us; we love the the kings for they are but human; we love the meek for they are divine. We love the poor for they are so many. We love the rich for they are lonely. We love the young for the faith they hold; we love the old for the wisdom they share. We love the beautiful for their eyes of sadness' we love the ugly for their souls of peace.

Essay starts.

72, 13 We think of love as a shield against the attacks of other people, and as a weapon to blast through walls of hate, and to open closed hearts and closed minds. We feel protected by our love, through adversity, discouragement, anger, and insecurity.

Essay starts.

72, 22 We forgive more easily, anger more slowly, expect less, and give more to our brothers and sisters.

These aspects of recovery are not to be forgotten or pushed aside. They are a few of the aspects of recovering addicts different from the way we were before.

72, 34 In the old days we knew, deep down inside, that we were faking it whenever we indulged in our delusions of grandeur and self-importance. Now, because we were beginning to love ourselves unashamedly, we can love other people more completely, because we no longer feel like we have anything to hide from anyone.

These are priceless blessings that money cannot buy. Many people live out their lifetimes without activating these aspects from the list of available potentials.

73, 4 Our egos used to control us in all kinds of subtle ways. For one thing, it seemed important for us to compete with others in almost all of our endeavors. Some of us even refused to try something that we might not be the best at. We watched other people closely, not with any concern for their wellbeing, but to check and see if we were measuring up to their standards.

With all this negative expectation, when we did well, we were only confused. Everyone we met was sized up in terms of how they could be useful to us or a threat to our self-esteem.

73, 11 Some of us had no idea who we were, or who we wanted to be. We only knew we didn't want to be ourselves.

Essay starts.

73, 15 The Twelve Steps to recovery, that N.A. outlines for us, hold the answer for all of our ego-trips and insecurities. they seem to hold the only answers for us that we can really use. In living these Steps, we first begin to let go of old egotism. We then open up to a Higher Power, so that we will lose all fear of facing ourselves and of facing other people.

Essay starts.

73, 30 The Twelve Steps led us to a point of recovery that seemed to make the world change before our eyes, for the better.

Essay starts.

74, 4 We place our recovery first and our own petty desires and egos last.

Essay starts.

74, 10 In our past, we were usually irresponsible. After we face ourselves in the inventory Steps, and make amends to others in our amends steps, we can no longer allow other people the “pay our way” for us. We want to serve.

It is important to remind ourselves that we are making progress. We have been down so long we have to re-conditions ourselves to

74, 15 In our groups, we all need to open up first, selfishly, for our own recovery, and later candidly, for the inspiration of the newer members.

Essay starts.

74, 21 It isn't easy, but, if we want to live happily, we have to learn to live ethically, and within our means, facing what we have and what we have not, with honest acceptance and gratitude.

Essay starts.

74, 23 Those of us who are consciously working and using the Twelve Steps to recovery in our lives are seldom bothered by gossip. Our lives are lived like “open books,” and really don't feel like hiding anything, or judging anyone. WE no longer feel a need to put up a front, because we are doing the best we can.

Essay starts.

74, 32 We apply what we learn in the meetings to all our affairs, using these teachings as a basis for living, but returning, again and again to our groups, both to help and to be helped in our recovery from addictions.

Essay starts.

200

75, 1 One of the simplest and most important parts of our whole recovery process is the concept of “live a day at a time.”

By living in the present, fully focused on what is happening now, we can be mindful of our actions and not simply react. We can take the time to figure out an appropriate response in accordance with spiritual principles. We are also going to notice how beautiful our world has become and take pleasure in it.

“A day at a time” is one of the great liberators for addicts in recovery because it removes the brick wall that confines us to things which do not work out. We can change and change back if we need to.

75, 7 We are experts at making ourselves so frustrated that we lose perspective completely.

Losing perspective means our thinking is off and we need to take a break.

75, 17 During our active using, we often lived way beyond our means, out of necessity. Unfortunately, not all of us lose our extravagance and greed easily, ever after we stop using.

Living within our means and practicing a little restraint just means we'll pay the rent on time and our lights won't be cut off next month. Later, it means more, much more. It means we will be free of financial worries that we had become accustomed to enduring. Many of us were addicted to a painful way of living.

76, 2 Humility is an honest self-acceptance, which leads to further acceptance of the conditions around us.

Essay starts.

76, 9 One of our greatest enemies is resentment. It has the power to kill. The only way to be rid of resentment is to develop humility, in the form of forgiveness. .

Essay starts

76, 25 Sometimes, the best revenge we can have over a manipulative or unpleasant person is in not allowing them to “pull our strings” by making us react unkindly to them.

Essay starts.

76, 31 Remember, we can't change other people. We can, through the program of Narcotics Anonymous, change ourselves.

Essay starts

77, 4 Alienation and isolation are symptoms of the mental part of our disease. To the practicing Addict, life is just a movement between connections and oblivion. Normal concerns are pushed aside, as the disease progresses.

Essay starts.

78, 1-5 It all begins with our first admission and surrender. From that point, each addict is reminded that a day clean is a day won. At first we can little more than go to meetings. Probably we cannot even remember a single name, word or thought from our first meeting. What we do remember is the feeling we got.

Essay starts.

79.1 That no matter what we have done or what course our addiction has taken, we can relax and enjoy the love that fills the room at every meeting which follows the Twelve Traditions.

Begin Essay;

79, 6 Having begun attending meetings regularly, we were introduced to the 12 steps. Working the Steps got us out of our old attitudes.

Just hearing "How It Works" in meetings seems overwhelming. This may be because we have not had a clear enough mind to ask questions. After a few meetings and our minds begin to clear, we may speak up in a meeting for the first time. This is a good time to ask questions in meetings and begin seeking a sponsor.

Asking one to sponsor us can also seem insurmountable.

Because of fear and a lack of understanding, we go to more meetings to find if we really desire this lifestyle.

79, 18 Freedom to change seems to come mainly after our acceptance of ourselves.

Essay starts.

79, 22 By recognizing the defects in our characters, and letting go of them spiritually, we were ready to have sanity restored to us.

Essay starts

80, 5 If we keep what we have to share, we lose the meaning.

80.6 Words mean nothing until we put them into action.

Begin essay

80.14 Facing problems is a necessary ability to stay clean

Essay Begins:

80.24 Not preaching or judging but sharing the experience strength, and hope that comes to anyone who accepts our way of life.

Essay Begins.

80, 8 We often miss what we are looking for because it isn't hidden.

It may take us a while to surrender enough to get this, but lots of things in life are not hard. We make them hard by trying too hard. Relaxing and calming ourselves changes dramatically the way others see us. If we exhibit tension and fear of things going wrong, others pick up on that. They would much rather interact with someone who is straight up and carries no air of negative anticipation.

80, 34 The program doesn't work when we adapt it to our life, we have to adapt our life to the program.

80, 26 The willingness to try new ideas and possible solutions will help open the door to our recovery.

Essay starts.

81, 4 Personality change is a natural progression set in motion by our surrender to the program.

Essay starts.

81, 13 We may still, however, feel that we cannot have a happy life without drugs. WE may suffer from the fear of insanity and feel we have no escape from using others than an insane and depresses existence.

By staying clean and going to meetings, we stop many of the things that set us up for failure and confusion. Right away, we are able to do simple things, find a place to stay and something to eat. That mean old world out there does provide some niceties when the parallel behaviors that go with using drugs disappear because we are not crazy out of our minds so much.

81, 34 The essence of addiction is that it is easier to change our perception of reality than the reality we perceive.

Living clean switches all that around. Changing reality means the changes stay put and need less correction as we go along in our new lives. We may have some amends to make but that is infinitely better than endless feelings of guilt and shame and all the avoidance patterns that go with unmade amends.

82, 4 As the benefits of basic honesty in the world begin to roll in, we are ready to consider honesty at a deeper level. Self-honesty is being in touch with the way we really feel and the way we spend our time.

82, 11 The ego of the addict must be busted for him to have a chance at recovery. "Terminal hipness" and "fatal cool" are symptoms of the addictive personality.

82, 21 At least one meeting a day for ninety days seems to be a good guide for those who are going to any lengths.

Going to meetings, reading literature, calling your sponsor, asking for God's help, don't pick up - these are five recommendations that seem to work for all members regardless of age, sex, etc. It is astonishing how helpful these simple things give us a daily reprieve from the hell of active addiction! Only a sincere member of NA gets to participate in this wonderful thing we call simply "recovery." The price of membership is high - it costs our self-will and ego. The idea we can handle it on our own can kill us. You are the one who decides if you are sincere or not. Identification with other NA members brings a special calm and new self appraisal since we begin to compare our feelings with others in the same boat we are.

83, 2. Guilt and worry keep us from living in the here and now. The denial of our disease, or reservations, keep us sick. We lack humility, clinging to our old ways.

Gaining humility takes time and a thorough working of Steps 6 and 7. Humility is a total acceptance of ourselves, both our good points and our character defects. We need to achieve such a total acceptance of ourselves that we don't feel the need to justify ourselves, explain ourselves, defend ourselves or promote ourselves. We can just calmly state our truth and move on without further discussion or argument.

83, 13 Life then becomes for us what we always wished it to be -- a constant state of awakening.

Many of us used drugs to intensify our minds and this helped drive us crazy!

83, 20 Living clean each day at a time will reveal to us the things that truly come from within and give us better understanding over things that would interrupt our flow.

Without the drugs and addictive distractions, what we go through reconnects to reality and if we want to add or take away something, we have that power. Many members forget their power to 'change gears.' If something is bothering us, we can do something about it!

84, 1 Letting go of character defects should be done with love. It is important we think, to be gentle with ourselves when putting our ego to rest.

It is easy to get all worked up and create new problems by lashing out in anger, even if our intent is to change our ways for the better. We can attack others and do damage to ourselves without realizing. We need always to bear in mind our program works a day at a time and going slow and deep is better than quick and superficial.

84, 10 We had to reach out and to accept the love and understanding that the Fellowship had to offer.

Essay starts.

84, 32 It has been our experience that personal problems will be resolved when we are willing to accept responsibility for them.

Personality change used to be rare among addicts. Once an addict, always an addict used to be the way it was. Not, through the 12 Steps of NA, we have a new way to deal with our disease of addiction. We can follow a certain order and take our self-will and ego at its roots.

85, 19 N.A. reawakened old memories of what it felt like to be a member of the human family. Slowly, we opened up, reached out, warmed up, and let ourselves love and be loved. The original desire to be clean leads us to a desire to help others.

85, 25 The only way we keep from continuing a habit is not to take that first fix, pill, drink or toke.

This line was taken out of the material reviewed for the Basic Text, *Narcotics Anonymous*. The idea was to focus on the disease and not the venue. While this is still a good and valid idea, there is power in breaking habits what makes it important to avoid the context as well as the content. When we avoid the specific drugs we took, it may help us make it. The whole program revolves around changing our personalities and getting away from escape from reality.

Newcomers are still told to avoid people, places and things associated with their personal using patterns and that does include drugs in various forms.

85, 31 Abstinence is the basis of our program. Any mood or mind-altering chemical, prescription or not, is poison to our bodies.

There is literature available outside our approved material that goes right to the heart of the thinking behind taking drugs to 'feel better' or adjust our moods without changing the things that produce stress or bad feelings in our day to day lives. This is hardly an outside issue. There are plenty of people who may benefit from various treatments that usually include meds. They don't have to call themselves NA members or follow our 12 Steps. There are also many members in good standing who both work our program and get the relief they seek from doing so. Folks have to find what works for them. Our role is supportive, not directive.

86, 3 If we clean our bodies by daily abstinence we should clean our minds of preconceptions based on past experience. It is those who stay clean when it seems like it isn't worth it who make it.

86, 9 The bottom line of Narcotics Anonymous is staying clean. When we realize that we can't use drugs in any form and live, we are ready to admit our powerlessness.

Relapse is not a subtle state to be in! The effects are immediate and devastating. If we are a little quieter and go to work on time, that may be a misleading benefit. Like the prohibition against taking the first drug in any form, the visible relapse comes later when we imagine we are using successfully. This vicious cycle must be avoided at all costs.

86, 22 We believe the solutions for the problem of having drug-fogged minds, sick bodies and tormented emotions is in a spiritual way of life.

Spiritual means learning about the things that affect how we feel, for better or worse. Anger, resentment, judgemental attitudes, allowing ourselves to focus on what is bothering us rather than looking for new ways of looking at things will generally put us in a bad mood to say the least. Focusing on what we have to be grateful for, seeking help from our sponsor or another member we trust, making a gratitude list and a whole lot of other different ways to process our feelings improve our spiritual condition and open the many doors that will lead us out of our misery and ingratitude. Many members are addicted to their powerlessness. Reading material on prayer and meditation can put us in touch with others seeking to improve their lives by following a spiritual path. Old experiences with religion and hokey non-sense may bar the door to new ideas and ways to improve our condition. Spiritual involves the quality of our life.

86, 12. It takes some of us a while to realize how unmanageable we were and are still. For others this is the only thing we can be sure.

The first step lets us know that we are powerless and our lives were unmanageable. It was easily evident that the lives that we had led brought us to places we hadn't planned on going to: jails, institutions, near death, as well as witnessing our friends die. After getting and remaining clean, we experience the care, concern, and love from other addicts, that lived in just as an unmanageable life as we had. (love from other addicts whose lives had been as unmanageable as ours.) Our stories and experiences may have been different, however, the pain, shame, and woundedness that we lived with all feel the same .

88, 6 We came to this program for many different reasons. Those of us who stay, do so for the same reason--to stop using and stay clean.

Essay starts.

88, 19 Usually one of the first things we try to do when we're working with a newcomer is to get them to a meeting. After all, that's what worked for us.

An NA group has one primary purpose, and that is to carry this message to the addict who still suffers. This can only be done through *our* members sharing their honest experience, strength and hope. By watching newcomers who have raised their hands, or when we notice the scared addict sitting by him or herself in the back of the room. In a loving way , remembering their name or just simply introducing ourselves, "Hi, I am an addict named ____.

Meeting attendance helps the new member to identify with other recovering addicts and provides a sense of hope in the experience, strength and hope shared. It also provides an opportunity to be of service for our more experienced members when we "12th Step" newcomers by taking them to meetings.

This approach also helps our oldtimers to remain humble, putting ego aside and remembering that it is the group that is our most powerful vehicle for carrying the message and fosters the spirit of the therapeutic value of one addict helping another.

89, 1 What is it about our meetings that's so special? Usually, about all we can say is that there is a feeling there, a feeling of strength and hope and love; an atmosphere of recovery. Our meetings are very special to most of us. They're a place where we feel safe; a place where we fit in.

For many of us this is the first time we have felt that we fit in. Many addicts have felt different from everyone else all their lives and to finally feel we belong is an incredible feeling. We love it. We are greeted, told we will be loved until we learn to love ourselves and accepted just as we are. Later, we want to help the newcomer feel this way too.

89, 8 Groups of self-centered, self-willed, isolated individuals just can't meet together peacefully and safely' but we do. The reason that we can is that we have Twelve Traditions that help to keep our groups "safe" and free.

Often we forget how essential our Traditions are when it comes to basic stuff like the atmosphere of recovery in our meetings. Study and open discussion give us insight and a deeper understanding of how our freedom has to mesh with the freedoms of others. There is no doubt that our members go on binges of obsession on a single point or two and for the time can't see a broader picture, even if others are trying to help them. Fortunately we have extensive training in dealing with nuts. Patience, humility and tolerance come easily to some of us. Loving and caring for others is not seen as an ongoing affair. Mostly, our members come out from obsession to gain information or the get to the bottom of something that bothers them.

90, 28 Most of us had never experienced the kind of attention and personal care that we found in the program. We are accepted and loved for what we are' instead of "in spite" of what we are.

Because we have adapted our Steps and Traditions from another program, we have to remind ourselves we have taken a receipt from another program but also we have baked our own cake. We have expanded our program of recovery to include the many forms addictive disease can take. Once you take away the drugs, you just have a more efficient maniac. Addiction comes out in many ways. We get addicted to ideas, places, people, moods, activities: anything that qualifies for obsession or compulsion. Recovery is regaining our choice. Addiction is not having a say in what we do, when we do it or why we do it. We lose our rights to freedom when the addictive process is begun.

91, 8 In our addiction we consistently placed our personal welfare before anything else. Here we found that in the long run what's best for the group was usually good for us. We chose to conform to the common good because that's what worked for us.

We learned to put group purpose ahead of personal preference. Where there were conflicts, it was understood that we are free to re-consider our stand on issues. No one can make us do much of anything. We'll leave the group if we are not happy there. We can even reconsider and go back later if we like. But for purposes of recovery, we all have to pull together if we are going to enjoy the miracle of recovery.

89, 22 The Twelve Traditions of N.A. are not suggested, and they are not negotiable. There are the rules that keep our fellowship alive and free.

Essay starts.

90, 6 It is only through understanding and application that they have power.

We have all heard this line read at each NA meeting we attend. You can become a members when you say you are. You become a member in good standing when you stop using, go to meetings and work the NA 12 Steps. Members in good standing also become familiar with our NA 12 Traditions. Pulling together, learning about our group purpose and dealing with powerful personalities are extremely important as a floor plan for recovery to take place. All the Traditions interlock. You can consider a Tradition violation and with a little thought and study you can see where it affects the other eleven Traditions as well. The spirit of the Traditions brings us together with plenty of individual freedom along with the loving support of the group to pull on for what we need.

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90, 9 One of the most important parts of our new way of life is being a part of a group of addicts also seeking recovery.

Essay starts.

90, 17 This program can do for us what we could not do for ourselves. We came and saw this program work in the lives of other addicts.

Essay starts.

250

90, 21 This surrender was the starting point of our recovery, and is a primary point of unity for the Fellowship.

Essay starts.

90, 26 Each of us has learned to depend upon a Power greater than ourselves, which is our source of strength.

Essay starts.

91, 3 The individual is precious to the group, and the group is precious to the individual. No one can revoke our membership or punish us, or make us do anything that we don't choose to do.

Balance and focus are two very important points to keep in mind. We are all important and contribute something to the people we are with at any given point. Likewise, we are not in the group by accident. We give and receive and need both for health. While the combination of personal views strengthens the whole, the whole is dependent on accurate information from each group member. On just the feeling level, we need the presence of other people in our lives. Isolation deprives us of this and we find ourselves substituting fantasy for reality with no one to help catch our errors.

91. 8 In our addiction we consistently placed our personal welfare before anything else. Here we found that in the long run what's best for the group was usually good for us.

Essay here.

91, 16 We convinced ourselves that we could make it alone and proceeded to live life on that basis. The results were disastrous, and, in the end, each of us had to admit that our self-sufficiency was a lie.

Essay starts.

91, 20 We found that we could no longer control our using, nor could we manage our own lives. This surrender was the starting point of our recovery, and is a primary point of unity for the Fellowship.

Without surrender we find it hard or impossible to admit our need for help or express our need to those who might have our answers.

92, 12 Without N.A. few of us would have survived, and fewer still would have found recovery.

We are still constructing NA as we know it. Our experienced members are often appalled at the members who seem to think we just make up things and do not realize we learned from those who have gone before. Our written literature helps our members get in touch with the reality of passing on experience that has proven itself in the lives of many addicts. Those who have a vested interest in NA want to continue growing and better carry a message of recovery based on the actual experience of our members. The scars of our addiction and the host of ideas carried in the minds and hearts of our members in different stages of recovery make an interesting mix. Keeping up appearances has to be balanced with the truth of inner experience. Financial issues and concerns need to balance with the love and concern we have for others. The things we gather in recovery should never take precedence over our need for our meetings and the others who walk our path.

92, 16 By nature we seem to be strong-willed, self-centered people, seeking self-gratification in the realms of money, power, and sex. As important part of our recovery is learning how to live

with these drives; how to realign our misguided instincts, how to stop acting out our insanities, how to disarm our self-destruct mechanisms, and how to rechannel our energies toward constructive ends.

As human beings we want to be productive, effective and well liked by the people we come in contact with. The problems come in when we are willing to use lies, deceit and thievery to achieve these ends. Honesty, openmindedness and the willingness to try seem impractical and sometimes, unworkable principles to apply to life on life's terms.

92, 25 One of our sayings is "Our best ideas got us here." This seems apt as we look back and see how many times our schemes and plans got us into trouble despite their original intent.

essay

93, 5 When we realized this had relates to our new group oriented way of life we often experienced a sort of gut-level panicky feeling.

Depending on people we are just getting to know can feel like risky business. in 'real' NA, we come to know down deep that those who are really working their 12 Steps have a vested interest in recovery and live the program like their very lives depended on their words and actions. Not everyone is able to jump into recovery this way. They hold back from habitual fear based on their experiences before recovery. NA recovery is not an everyday miracle. It is the result of faith, experience and positive intention.

93, 14 In working the Steps we need to come to depend on a Power greater than ourselves. WE We continue this relationship and utilize it for our Group purposes. If we each turned our will and our lives over to His care and seek to do his will, he will express Himself on a group level.

Sometimes things just go wrong. Maybe somebody thought they were praying for strength and guidance but had a belief system that made reliance on God a risky business. How could we know. We can only to the best we can on an individual basis with the understanding that we will honor our commitment to serve and cover the shortfall if anything goes wrong. This is what it means to say "Our Program" and mean it!

94, 14 We've made a lot of bad decisions and pawned them off as Group conscience. This worries many of us. How can we really tell if our decisions are really Goup conscience or not, and how do we prevent painful mistakes?

Easy answer: we can't! All we can do is work our program to the best of our ability. There are many choices involved with NA membership. We chose our friends and sponsors. We choose our home group. These choices sort out where we go and who we spend time with. This takes care of many problems in a quiet and natural manner. Egos, personal preferences, and honest mistakes insure we will have some problems. Hey, when we are clean, we can handle most

things that come up in a group so long as we follow our Traditions. One trouble is many of us don't know when we are violating the letter or spirit of a Tradition. We stay away from the law of the land because outsiders, however well intended, cannot be expected to know our Program or understand our ways. We avoid affiliation for the same reason. When we are really focused on recovery and helping others, it takes up enough time and energy to keep us out of trouble.

94, 31 We have seen that we try to rest authority in the spiritual conscience of the group. In keeping with this, we make a special point of trying to prevent authoritarian leadership. We have learned that for our Fellowship, leadership by example and by self-less service works, and that direction and manipulation fails.

This is where clean time and experience comes into play. Without clean or experience, all we can offer is opinion and hopeful projections. There is a need to have those who have gone before us to share what they have seen work in practice and what leads to trouble..

95, 3 We choose not to have presidents, masters, chairmen or directors. Instead we have secretaries, treasurers, and representatives .These titles in themselves imply service rather than control.

Jailhouse lawyers, inexperienced persons and those who speak without thinking or praying, may miss the point here. Start with personal powerlessness. A surrendered person would want help and listen to what other members involved have to say. Someone with a tender ego may see everything in terms of what will make them important or look good. This is a distorted misperception. Egotistical perceptions make problems from the get-go. This is because we care about all our members and know that practice in decision making and group activities build up a person's confidence and interpersonal exchanges. They move from attending a meeting to being a part of a group. None of this is by accident. Many of our group conscience processes do double duty by informing members at large while establishing and maintaining principled processes as well as spiritual principles. Good ideas that don't work in real life and dismissed in favor of practical solutions. That is why so much of our literature is based on successful actions instead of great ideas.

95, 13 An atmosphere of recovery in our groups is one of our most precious assets; and we must guard it carefully lest we lose it to politics and personalities.

If each one of us prays to relinquish their ego and self-will, the atmosphere will resolve. Honest sharing and personal disclosure set the tone for other members to also follow suit.

95, 17 Those of us who have been involved in service for a long time or in getting a group started and keeping the doors open through the hard early days sometimes have a hard time letting go of the reins. Sometimes our egos get in the way, sometimes ungrounded fears get in the way, and sometimes the group gets in the way.

No one claims to completely understand the miracle of our our message and our recovery. Therefore there is no safe and sure way to make rules for members to obey blindly. We all need

to look up now and then to see how we are doing. Paying attention to the facial expressions of other members gives us the best way to determine when to pass the baton to someone else. If the moment passes, it can break the spirit of inter-personal sharing. The optimum is usually brief, genuine shares about what is happening in one's life or a current concern, then sit back for others to share. Cross talk and a few members swapping comments leaves out the rest of the group and that too can interrupt the sharing. If you and I share our personal truth and experience, we leave it at that and pay attention to what others are sharing.

Someone observed that people generally share with other people who are at or near the same level of growth and development. This may be true. If it is, it might partly explain why people hold back or leave the room if someone is talking down to them or gives an unscheduled lecture. It disadvantages others and stops the open sharing of personal truth.

97, 2 Along with this they also accept that they do have special and valuable experiences which can benefit the group. They become a resource for the group; seeking neither to control the group nor to set themselves apart. It is at this time that their long service truly contributes the most. They encourage us, inspire us, and teach us by example.

The material in the Grey Book leads up to this sentence enumerating the things that a person can go through as they progress in service. The 'resource' idea is crucially important. A group without someone to turn to in the advent of a log-jam is in trouble. This happens when everyone is getting confused and ready to set aside spiritual principles to get their way. Having a resource to get them back on the same page is a non-toxic exit to the disagreements.

97, 30 The newcomer is our lifeblood of N.A. and when one comes to us seeking help we welcome them with open arms.

The principle here is obvious. Evaluating the situation requires some common sense. Sometimes 'qualified' newcomers exhibit symptoms of mental disturbance that make it hard to determine if they are serious about recovery or dancing on air mentally. We actually are qualified to determine which is the case and we have always seen people transit into NA members if the disease and desire are there. Some people with mental illness benefit from the 12 Step process. Surrender, belief and capitulation open them to help in various forms. Sometimes it just takes time. Perhaps the important thing here is to remind us everyone in NA is a miracle and we were all in bad shape when we got here!

98, 11 Many of us could not visualize a life without drugs, let alone want it. Many of us had reached the point in our addiction where we felt there was no hope for us, we only wanted a little relief.

The information we gain about addiction helps us stay clean as long as we are focused on adding to that information with our own personal experience. If we let ourselves drift into distraction and forget the basics of recovery, we can pave the way to relapse by dropping the new attitudes and living habits that helped us get clean in the first place.

99, 15 WE have also met members who are uncertain about where they really belong. We suggest that they ask themselves three questions: 1. What message do you carry? (What is the nature of your recovery and what have you recovered from?) 2. Who are you trying to carry this message to? 3, Where are you trying to carry this message?

Reviewing basic ideas gives us a chance to make sure we are on common ground with reality. We are great ones for charging off in directions composed of our own projections and negative expectations. Just because we run a definite risk of running off the road does not mean we have to run through a catalog of fear every time we get behind a wheel! Obsession can really mess up your perception of reality. The clean life requires a few adjustments!

99. 25 The choice of membership rests with the individual.. WE feel the ideal state for our fellowship exists when as addict can openly and freely come to an N.A. meeting; wherever and whenever they choose and leave just as freely if they want to. We realize that there is nothing we can do to make an addict stop using.

Without understanding and acceptance of this basic idea, the rest of our recovery process fails to ring true.

100, 2 The autonomy of our groups is one of our most precious possessions. This sounds great but what does it mean? What is it to be autonomous? Webster's defines autonomous as "having the right or power of self government," "undertaken or carried on without outside control," "existing or capable of existing independently," "responding, reacting or developing independently of the whole."

There is a spirit that exists among individuals dedicated to a common cause or purpose. Common understanding and agreement results in unison of action and purpose that works to get the desired result. It takes freedom of belief and action to achieve this. Addicts who want to stay clean and enjoy a life in recovery should by all means be free to do so. A classical example of our God given ability to find ways to disagree is over where we say, "a half dozen or six." Of course, it makes no real difference and with a little effort most people can see this but there of those who insist on their terminology and reject any variation out of hand. If getting clean, staying clean, and helping others is why we go to meetings, we stand on common group and are likely to be effective. Needless conflicts should not ruin our efforts to achieve our primary purpose.

100, 15 The answer, of course, is that these things are not N.A. They are services that we can utilize to help us in our recovery and further the primary purpose of our groups.

100, 18 Narcotics Anonymous is a Fellowship of men and women, addicts, meeting together in groups, and using a given set of spiritual principles to find freedom from addiction and a new way to live. All else is not N.A.

This simple statement has been made to appear disunifying and obscure enough to be removed by three members before the first publication of our Basic Text, *Narcotics Anonymous*. We hope through time and personal growth we will come to a high level of basic agreement. The importance of limiting perceived power in our service bodies is great. The huge majority need not be restricted to the level of a very few members. Even if they are gifted or full of noble sentiments, they do violence to the individual members and groups. If they have trouble seeing this simple point, it illustrates the importance of having a general and agreeable basic understanding in our written recovery material. Else readers will sooner or later take issue with offending items and some will leave NA. It is simple enough to write in an inclusive manner. Giving undue and excessive to trusted servants who surely may have problems understanding and maintaining proper boundaries for the sake of our common welfare. After all, most trusted servants have leeway to do their job and ask for help as needed. Whereas who takes up for the members if excesses occur or accumulate? Irreparable harm may go for years without correction. All because a few 'powerful' members took it upon themselves to disregard the deep consideration that went into the original they don't quite understand.

100, 31 Once a group registers they are sent a starter kit. This contains many suggestions and is one of the way we share our experience to help the group. Whether or not they take our suggestion is their decision. In this starter kit it says that we must abide by the Twelve Traditions in order to call ourselves Narcotics Anonymous. This is also true, but these Traditions are part of the set of spiritual principles that are N.A. Without the Traditions, N.A. does not exist.

Just as a surveyor can get careless and mark his charts quarter of an inch off, it may make him a mile off down the line. Where great numbers of persons are concerned, great care must be exerted. For a few people to come in and re-write the work of very intense effort and review is a tremendous liability. Everyone today knows well the power of finance and corporate impropriety to degrade and destroy human considerations and values. Recover teaches us to take care and proper concern in all areas of our lives. Members who have a vested interest in the growth and continuance have only three ways of dealing with bureaucratic problems: correction, relapse or death. In time we hope for restitution of our original, attractive and edifying literature. We cannot permit statements and treatments of subjects in our approved literature that go against our Steps or Traditions. For instance, total abstinence and DRT or no surveillance and drug slip attendance. We have to be very careful and able to state the truth of our experience regardless of corporate or medical pressure to serve the views or issues of outside enterprises.

101, 12 For us in Narcotics Anonymous autonomy is also creative freedom. It gives our groups the freedom to act on their own to establish their atmosphere of recovery, to serve their members, and to fulfill their primary purpose. It is this aspect of autonomy that makes it one of our most precious principles.

This does not give a group the license to violate the principles of the 12 Steps or Traditions. Among the important items of spiritual growth is the ability to sort out common sense. Almost all members visit other areas and travel to distant conventions or gatherings to see if members elsewhere work their Steps and practice the principles of NA the same way their members back home practice them.

102, 3 If we check to make sure that our actions are clearly within the bounds of our Traditions, if we don't represent anyone but ourselves, if we don't dictate to other groups or force anything upon them, and if we take the time to consider the consequences of our actions ahead of time, then I will be well.

Not one of us is perfect and the ability to make amends frees us to step out on faith and try something new or different. Still, anything new or untried. may or may not work out. In our daily lives, we make changes all the time. Before they put the curves at the end of aircraft wings, an airplane was said to be 'off course' over 90% of the time due to wind and turbulence! Self-correction is a real bonus that comes with our new freedom from the insanity of active addiction. Our lives find benefits from the principles of our 12 Steps and Traditions because principles are spiritual and universal. It takes time for all this to become a working part of our lives. When problems come up in our daily lives, we can think about our Program and sometimes find things we can do to help correct some situation that has gone wrong. There is no way to get 'recovery' without making mistakes and learning to apply the new tools in our lives.

102, 15 All Our groups can do is plant the seed for recovery and bring addicts together so that the magic of empathy, honesty, caring, sharing and service can do its thing.

This quote reminds us that our recovery is a God-given blessing far beyond what the mind of mankind can do. Recovery is a miraculous event. Those who work their Steps like their lives depend on it know what is meant by these words. The disease of addiction affects three levels: the physical, mental and spiritual. The physical is easy, we can feel it. We can feel the mental also but the idea that we are in control can become a serious roadblock. Spiritual knowledge is what grants us real recovery. Many, many members who work their program, go to meetings, read the literature and follow the proven NA Program in all ways but one miss out on the biggest blessing of all: relinquishment, freedom from our human frailty through a supernatural agency called God or Higher Power.

102, 26 The 12 Step of our personal program also says that we should carry the message to the addict who still suffers. This is no coincidence.

As we progress to the benefits of recovery, we recall how our surrender make such a big difference. Through helping others, we become a human plus sign. We offer a life giving solution to our situation of pain and endless suffering. Helping others gives us a mental, spiritual and even physical lift right away. We can see ourselves in others. We realize that those who help us do not feel grandiose or .better than us. It is actually the other way around. We are comforted because some of the words we use apply to us as well.

102, 30 For the newcomer this is how they find out about NA and how they stay clean; and for the members this reaffirms and clarifies what they have learned.

Sharing and caring are both active and positive expressions of our love for others.

103, 10 What would happen if our groups had other primary purposes? We feel our message would be diluted and then lost.

103, 19 In our groups we share our experience, strength and I hope and this is our message – that an addict, any addict, can stop using drugs; lose the desire to use again; and find a new way to live. Their message is hope and the promise of freedom.

103, 26 Our Fifth Tradition defines our primary purpose and our Sixth Tradition tells us some of the things we must do to preserve and protect this spiritual aim. This Tradition tells us that we ought never endorse, finance or lend the N.A. name to any outside enterprise. And then we are warned exactly what can happen if we ignore this advice.

104, 3 This Tradition is the basis for our policy of non affiliation and is extremely important to the continuation and growth of N.A. Unfortunately, this Tradition has also been a point of controversy within our Fellowship.

104.14 A direct endorsement is often used to try and persuade someone to do something.

Begin essay: Isn't persuading someone to do something the same as manipulation. And isn't manipulation a primary symptom of our disease of addiction. This is part of what Tradition six is about.

104, 21 The third thing warned against is lending N.A. name. This means letting someone use the name, Narcotics Anonymous, for something that is not Narcotics Anonymous. It also means letting an outsider mention or utilize our name for their own purposes.

106, 21 We who were unable to function as human beings now find anything is possible for us. Those dreams we gave up long ago can now become realities with God's help.

109, 9 Spiritual principles are basic truths that do not change with time or place; they simply work in all cases.

109, 33 Our motivation is simple; this program was given freely to us by addicts who cared. We only do the same.

110, 4 These are the things we are and how our program works. They are a reality for us. We have our Steps; we have mobility; we really understand and care; and we are motivated by survival. All these things are a contradiction to traditional recovery approaches and to professionalism. The professional has no place in our fellowship; very nature prohibits this.

111, 1 This Tradition defines the way we run our Fellowship. A lot of confusion has occurred because of misinterpretations of our Ninth Tradition. Our members are addicts who have the desire to stop using, who want what we have to offer, and who have chosen to join us. Our meetings are a gathering of members for the purpose of staying clean.

111, 9 our steps in traditions are uniform and set in a specific order. They are numbered; they are not random and unstructured. Certainly they are organized, but this is not the organization of earned a tradition. For the purpose of this tradition, organize means having an administrative structure, and this implies management and control.

111, 16 N.A. should never be run by bureaucracy or management nor controlled by individuals within administrative structure. If we were to allow this, N.A. this would surely lose the best it has to offer and choke to death on our insanities.

111, 21 Even without this Tradition (9), organization such as this would be in opposition to our spiritual principles. A loving God as He may express himself in our group conscience would find no place within an administrative structure.

111, 28 Specialization and professionalism are the basis of any management scheme. Any administrative structure, but is very nature, eliminated the possibility of autonomy. An organized N.A. is a contradiction in terms and any attempt to force organization on us would destroy us.

111, 34 The Ninth Tradition goes on to define the nature of the things that we can do, outside N.A., to help N.A. It says that we may create service boards or committees directly responsible to those they serve.

7.24.15

112, 14 In order to achieve our spiritual aim, Narcotics Anonymous must be known and respected. No where is this more obvious than our history. N.A. I was founded 1953. For 20 years of Fellowship remain small and obscure. In the 1970s, society realized that addiction had become a worldwide condition and began to look for answers.

In making spiritual growth and active part of our lives, we too must be looking for answers on a daily basis. We need to repeat what works and discard what fails.

113, 23 We have learned the value of teaching bad example rather than direction. This is work for us and will utilize this principle while we work with other addicts. Are messages most obvious in our lives.

114, 17 Promotion is representing our sales is something we are not. In order to accomplish something we want, we don't use promotion to encourage Alex to come to us and we don't use promotions to make ourselves more acceptable. Our successes speak for themselves.

114, 32 Personal anonymity is really much more. It is a corner of freedom, and personal recovery.

115, 3 Each of us has her story, and around recovered. Individually, we're powerless but as the fellowship we can achieve great things.

300

115, 6 The 12 Traditions of Narcotics Anonymous are even more inter-related than our Steps. They complement each other and are bound together by the principle of anonymity.

"Anonymity is the whole basis of the program; it is truly the foundation. In order to survive, we must set aside the differences we live by and become a part of a greater whole." Recovery leads us back into the fabric of lot. To enjoy this new way of life we have to drop a lot of the personal preferences that in the end don't mean much to us and they blocked the way to a happy destiny.

115, 11 Many of us have nowhere else to go if we could not trust our N.A. groups and members. We were no longer afraid to ask for help. How then did we lose our fear?

115, 16 The awakening of anonymity in each of us occurs when we've family give up trying to manager allies and begin to depend on a power greater than ourselves.

Thinking we are different from others, insisting on having our way, needless conflicts with others: all these are the prison bars of our active addiction. They keep us more or less in conflict with all the people we come in contact with in our day to day lives.

115, 25 Unity is the direct result of application of the principle of anonymity within the group and the fellowship.

116, 1 No single person (no personality) has authority. This is vested in a loving God to whom we have turned over our will and lives.

116, 7 We do not define our members. We only insist they have a desire to stop using. Nothing else should matter. This desire is the one crucial must of our program.

117, 26 Anonymity is everywhere in our Traditions and in our Fellowship. It is one of the basics of recovery. The principle of anonymity protects us from our defects of personality and character. Where anonymity exists, personalities and differences have no power. Anonymity in action makes it impossible for personalities to come before principals.

119, 1 For us, to use is to die. We have seen addicts come to our Fellowship, try our program, say clean for a period of time, only to drift gradually away.

120, 1 Basically, we lost our fear through the experience of sharing. You Share our fears with other addicts. The more we do this, the more our fear slips away.

Just one more just one more okay don't do it don't do it just

119, 1 For us to use is to die. We have seen addicts come to our fellowship, try our program, stay clean for a period of time only to drift away.

It is important to remember that the disease will undercut and derail our efforts to get with the NA program. Saying, "I'm clean but I haven't changed." is a really sad statement because it is up to each individual member to surrender, admit unmanageability and begin to learn what has worked for others. We go looking for a Higher Power and find ways to go on from there. Strong egos can stop the recovery process before it has a chance. Surrender is the cure for egotism!

We attend funerals of fellow members and this brings home the importance of working a strong program and carrying a clear message of recovery. Anyone who has been in the program a while has seen a person nurse a futile resentment until it drives them out of the rooms.

What has changed besides not using? Are we collecting resentments or forgiveness where others seem to conflict with us?

This does not have to happen when we do the things that work for us, not just staying clean, but to use our sponsor, go to meetings regularly, find a homegroup that we attend and support, where we can feel safe and comfortable. By simple prayer, and discovering that we are experiencing true miracles, in our lives, we are becoming more comfortable in our own skin. We see that our obsessions have left us. Now we can believe and see that maybe this thing, called Narcotics Anonymous can, and is working for us.

119, 14 No longer comfortable with our using friends, we were not yet at home in meetings. Basically, we lost our fear through the experience of sharing. We share our fears with other addicts.

Essay starts.

120, 31 Addicts must patiently re- learn things forgotten and learn how to live. This is what Narcotics Anonymous is about.

Essay starts.

121, 11 If we are to continue abstinence we must be responsible and productive, not necessarily in terms of normal definitions, but in terms of spiritual principles. We must grow.

Each one of us is different and we have different requirements. The freedom NA offers allows us to take in and concentrate on the subject we need most. As we grow a divine hand guides us to exactly what we need to be happier and more effective. We cannot always understand what is happening at the time, but clean time gives us a chance to review what happens and the results of our growth.

121, 26 Spirituality as a way of life for an addict seems a total contradiction. Many feel that they have found what they were searching for in drugs through spirituality. By working the Steps we are relieved of our obsession to use and many gratefully serve the Fellowship for this reason. Growth means change and we feel we must live on a spiritual basis in order to change.

121, 35 From self-centered, angry, frightened isolated people, we become loving, sharing, self-assured spiritual parts of a greater whole. We changed from hopelessly helpless to hopefully helping.

Our daily recovery offsets the gravity of our addictive disease to draw us into the same selfish and benighted condition we were before recovery with a suitable coat of paint to protect us from the notice of our fellow NA members. We want to look good. This is not a badness in us, it is simply our disease and all members admit they have it! Rationalization, justification and projection are tools we use to stay sick and avoid recovery.

122, 6 We remain honest to free ourselves from guilt. As we begin to function in society, our creative freedom helps us sort out priorities and do the most basic things first. Daily practice of the Twelve Step program enables us to change from what we were to what our Higher Power would have us become.

essay

122, 13 We cry easily and find it safe to cry and express love and share all our emotions in the atmosphere of recovery found at N.A. meetings. The steps become our framework of daily change. Continuous abstinence requires spiritual growth which leads to emotional recovery in our lives.

essay

122, 19 Each day we stay clean by practicing the Steps in our lives, our chances of relapse decrease. Each of us is only one drug away from a painful active addiction, but living our program through regular honest sharing in the Fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous increases our chances for uninterrupted clean time.

essay

122, 29 Complacency is the enemy of members with substantial clean time. We never fully recover. Guilt, remorse, fear, lust and pride may all become unbearable if we fail to invest ourselves totally in the program, no matter how much clean time we have.

Write it on the wall! The idea that our good time drug use was fun will be like the call of the wild and at some point we will confuse ourselves enough to the point using seems like an option. This is amazing considering all we've been through. All we have to do is just remember what the last one did for us and after a few moments a miracle happens and we are restored to sanity!

123, 1 Meetings provide a safe place to share with others during this time. Many members who recoveries have blessed them tell us that they continue to attend meetings on a daily basis even after several years of clean time.

We never get so much clean time we lose our need for recovery meetings. Some of us are blessed with lives where we continuously talk, visit, host and travel within NA. Some of us can recall thinking, "This disease can kill me and all my dreams with it. I better get to more meetings!" only to look up from the highway and realize we are driving in the middle of the night to a three day NA convention in a favorite recovery community. Back home, we still get to meetings if we want to stay clean. Recovery is the shore and the meetings are our life boats.

123, 13 The experience gained with time insures our ongoing recovery. WE must use what we learn or we will lose it and probably relapse, no matter how long we have been clean.

essay

123, 25 The group we choose to be our home group will be like a spiritual savings account. The more we can invest in it through our care and sharing, the greater the dividends it will pay.

essay

123, 31 As we grow, we learn to overcome our tendency to run and hide our feelings. Learning to be totally honest about our feelings helps other people take us seriously.

Facts and personal self-disclosure ring true to the listener and when they see us let our guard down, they are better able to share honestly with us. All this honesty is good for us.

124, 1 Sharing our lives with others seems to keep us from feeling lonely. The Steps lead to the kind of honesty that can help us let others know and accept us.

essay

124, 5 We seek creativity through the Spirit. This spirit dwells within all of us. We need to understand that the spirit within each individual is the same. The action being that we tap the available resources of the spirit within ourselves. Some have tapped more than others. We need to create more soul searching within one another. This process is the creative action of the spirit. We listen to ourselves and others in order to recover and to stay on that path.

It is this sameness of spirit that makes NA a universal program. Our Steps and Principles have been applied and utilized in every part of the globe. Our original literature was written to include all people who might seek recovery in NA, regardless of their national language, history, religion or other factors that might hinder their approach to NA recovery.

124, 13 Lack of spiritual quality within our lives leads us down the path to relapse. This part of our recovery is the essence of the program. Spiritual maintenance is indispensable if recovery is what we're after.

124, 15 . Diverting from the spirit in ourselves we utilize the negative consciousness that comes from within. Our life is the constant efforts of progressing in our spiritual consciousness.

Our attitudes to ourselves and others, learning, open mindedness, remaining teachable - all these and more affect our spiritual condition. Maintaining that condition is called recovery. Whenever and wherever we find ourselves being negative or critical of others, we have stepped back from that state of mind and soul that allows us to see past surfaces into what is really happening in the people and world around us. [we decided to drop this out of the quotes due to misspoken sentence.]

124, 19 Stagnation or just plain old character defects which we re-cultivate rather than let go of sends us back to where these defects were conceived.

124, 27 In our daily lives, we are subject to emotional, environmental, intellectual, mental and spiritual relapses, causing us to become defenseless against the physical relapse of addiction.

If we have worked our First Step, we know the connection between our using and our pain. Using will hurt like hell if we fall into one of the many traps it lays for us, all pretty and tasty

looking on top and steel jaws below. Want to feel lower than the sidewalk? You know the way. Want to feel joy and hopeful? These is a way called NA! **Moved to May 31st**

124, 31 As a disease, addictions is subject to relapse. Reverting to using is a physical relapse. Physical relapse is on a symptom. We are never forced into relapse. We are given a choice.

Many - if not every single one - of us have to get into the habit of praying and meditating, whatever level we are on. Contact with other members inside and outside our meetings keeps us on our toes recovery-wise. Honest sharing keeps us aware of the dangers of thinking we have it made. .

125, 1 When we were told in meetings we were flirting with relapse, we had to make a decision. We had reservations about anything which did not describe us to a tee and built these up until we thought we could use again.

What a disease! The stupid stuff we use to build long standing resentments against other members is incredible. We don't have to worry about outside issues disrupting NA as long as the ties that bind us together remain strong enough. Most all of us have sponsors with much more clean time and recovery than we do and they all tell us of the painful times they have seen otherwise good members fight and carefully build resentments based on rumor and gossip that last for decades. Maybe someday we will be able to address all these issues but until then we have to pray for strength and guidance to not fall into the same traps ourselves!

How clear can you get? Unless we connect our using with our pain, we cannot work the First Step. The admission of our powerlessness is the basis for all recovery. The person who cannot ask for help is helpless. Those who ask for help get help. When we are learning about NA, we also learn to monitor our progress.

125, 5 Relapse is a sign we have had reservations in our program. We slighted our program and left loopholes in our daily lives. Aware of the pitfalls ahead, we trod blindly on in the belief we could make it on our own.

Although our addictive disease expresses itself in so many ways, it is surprising how much has to do with honesty, open-mindedness and the willingness to try. Perhaps it is the built-in memory of a painful past that continues to build up protective walls long after the need for them is gone.

125, 8 If we continue to fall back into the illusion that drugs would make life easier, we must not be ready yet. We believed that drugs would change us and forgot the changes would be fatal. Unless the illusion is shattered that we, in any way, can stop using on our own, we will use again.

Many people do not ever reach an understanding of why and how the NA program works. Try paying more attention to what others are saying with their words and their faces or body

language. Some will be attending every word spoken by a newcomer to our rooms because they came to the meeting to help others. What they share can tell you where they are at. After the meeting, crosstalk breaks the atmosphere of recovery, they get with the person and interact.

125, 14 We took the opportunity to avoid several of our responsibilities, missing meetings, skipping work, neglecting Twelve Step work, and most important, we stopped asking for help. Growth in the program stopped.

Other good stuff in this paragraph. The idea is that certain things we do in recovery can be written out and listed work together to help us stay clean and grow spiritually. If we stop doing one or more of these things, we put our whole recovery at risk.

Yes, we could coast forward for a little ways. But our spiritual deposits were soon matched by our spiritual withdrawals. The flow of miracles stopped coming. We need these miracles and it is sometimes hard for us to see where the prayers make a difference. Spiritual things are not of this world and so are difficult to quantify in terms like sight, sound, taste, color, etc. They are spiritual and beyond things of this world. Does someone need to spell this out for you? Is this not your experience? We see the difference in the way things work out for us. And the way others react to us when we are working the Program.

125, 22 When a resentment or any other emotional relapse occurs, failure to practice the Steps and result in physical relapse. Many of our newcomers have difficulty coming into the Fellowship because they do not understand we have a disease called "addiction." We are doomed (spelling corrected) to see our past behavior as part of ourselves and not part of our disease.

essay

125, 28 As long as we preserve our clean time we enjoy the greatest possible advantage over our disease. For this we are grateful. The first thing to do is get clean. This makes the other stages of recovery possible. Learn that addiction is a disease. Try to forgive past behavior and realize it was caused by our disease. Go to meetings and study the program for your own personal growth.

This amazing paragraph is supremely important for it contains basic information that has worked for literally countless addicts all over the planet Earth. All faiths are welcome to NA! All nationalities, languages, national historical settings fit in with us. Addicts are the same wherever they come from and so is recovery!

125, 35 Obsessiveness is really common to all the addicts we have met or heard of. Our ego tells us we can do it on our own, then loneliness and paranoia return.

126, 3 There will be times, however, when we feel like getting off. We want to run, we feel lousy, we need to be reminded of where we came from and that it will be worse this time. This is when we need to Fellowship most.

Next

126, 11 We hate to be wrong. It is hard to believe that now in our recovery somehow self-will leads us to make decisions based on manipulation, ego, lust or false pride but it happens . . . often.

126, 14 Remember we've don't recover overnight. When we realize that we have made a bad decision or bad judgment, we make an attempt to rationalize it. We become extreme in our self-righteous attempts to cover our tracks.

126, 27 We pray for willingness and humility and finally get honest about our mistake in judgment or bad decision. We tell those who were hurt that we were to blame, ask them to forgive us and make whatever amends necessary. Now we're in the solution again.

126, 32 We think that the Tenth Step helps prevent relapse.

126, 34

There is something in our self-destructive personalities big cries for failure. It permeates our total being – “You do not deserve to succeed.” We have all experienced this and without the knowledge that we finally have earned the right to be responsible, respectable members of society. The manner in which we returned to our addiction hello is not important. What is essential to each of us is that we have the choice not to continue.

Next

127, 10 Those of us who have relapsed found the true progression the disease that plagues us. To know and come to understand that there is a Power greater than ourselves desiring to have a relationship with us, in spite of our faults, comforts us all.

127, 22 Some of us reach a point of complacency in recovery. If we stay at this level for long, the recovery process ceases and we begin to backslide. Clean tab in the program access insurance. If complacency is not acted upon the disease begins to manifest the parent symptoms in us. Denial returns along with obsession and compulsion.

128, 7 Meetings are a healing source. Writing about what we want, what we are asking for and what we get and sharing this with our sponsor or another trusted person helps us to work through those feelings, and letting other share with us about their experience gives us hope that it does get better.

128, 15 Attending meetings daily, living a day at a time, and reading the literature seems to send our mental attitude towards the positive. Willingness to try what has worked for others is vital.

128, 30 Progression of recovery is a continuous journey uphill with loving effort. Without love or effort we start the downhill run. The progression of the disease is an ongoing process, even during abstinence, no matter how long.

129, 4 Spirituality and sharing is the essence of their recovery . Keeping our illusion of reality rather than using the tools of the program and the people in the Fellowship will return us to isolation.

129, 15 To use is to die, often in more ways than one. We have found this program at the right time or we wouldn't have found it at all. N.A. and its principles are here to help us achieve quality in our lives. If we were worthless we wouldn't be alive.

129, 22 Left with a shadow of doubt, the mind of a newcomer and even the old-timer can prove to be this spark needed to set off the return of insanity and that first pill, fix, drink or toke.

130, 13 Life's flow takes place in this manner: we come here powerless and the power we seek comes to us through other people in the Fellowship if we can only reach out for it.

350

130, 30 Slow down and lived life. A cynic is someone who has been very disappointed. He does not hear until the heart decides to listen, then he can accept help. It is not shameful to relapse. The real shame is in not coming back.

Next

131, 9 When someone returns the Fellowship after relapse, ways stress the importance of living just for today. The past is the past. We cannot change what is happening. What is important is to stay clean today.

131, 20 We all find the feeling we get from helping others motivates us to do better at around lives. If we are hurting, and most of us do from time to time, we learned asked for help.

131, 26 Recovery found the narcotics anonymous must come from within and no one gets clean for anyone but themselves.

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143.3When we came to our first meeting it was though a big weight was lifted from our shoulders, guilt feelings rolled off, and a feeling and a feeling of peace came over us,as we realized that with our surrender to our higher power, would come the help we so desperately needed.

Begin Essay:

143.9 We also felt the great feeling of warmth and love that came from the group.

Begin essay:

144..3 A great many addicts have a hard time with acceptance in recovery. For so long we wanted and demanded that things go our way .When we came into the program of Narcotics Anonymous we were asked to be more patient and accepting. This is a critical part of our recovery.

Begin Essay:

144.14 Any addict clean, without the compulsion to use, is a miracle.We keep this miracle alive in ongoing recovery with positive attitudes and awareness involving personal growth.

Begin essay:

144.22 As our lives become more comfortable , many of us lapse into spiritual complacency, and we find ourselves in the same horror and loss of purpose from which we came.

Begin essay:

144.34 The enemy we have to fight is our own self destructiveness. When we begin to work our program we will like ourselves better.

Begin essay

144.2 Much of the loneliness and fear will have been replaced by the love of the Fellowship and the security of being a part of a new way of life.

Begin Essay: